LUKMAAN IAS

Lead with Edge

UPSC MAINS CORE GROUP 2026



DAF DECODED • HOBBY QUESTION BANK

Hobbies

33 hobbies + 5 activities: content, real questions, model answers

742	98	33
real board questions	model answers	hobbies covered

CSE 2019–2025 • Systematic Content • Asked + Expected Questions • Model Answers

"Your hobby is the one subject where the board expects you to be the expert."

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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Hobbies are the one part of the DAF that you chose freely, so the board treats them as your **zone of expertise**. This book covers the 33 hobbies that candidates list most often. For each hobby it gives **systematic content** (basics, India story, institutions and policy, 2025–26 developments, science and social angles, administrative linkages), the **questions boards actually asked** in CSE 2019–2025 interviews, **expected questions**, **two model answers**, common **traps** and a **preparation checklist**. Part V does the same for **extra-curricular activities** (NCC, NSS, sports medals, leadership roles, awards). Part VI shows how boards **combine a hobby with the rest of your DAF**, and Part VII gives a **one-page revision sheet** for every hobby and activity for the night before the interview.

How the questions were collected

742 real hobby questions from candidate-shared Personality Test transcripts (ForumIAS, Insights IAS, PW OnlyIAS, Reddit and toppers' blogs), CSE 2019–2025. Each carries the CSE year in square brackets.

Transcripts are recollections, so wording is approximate. Expected questions and model answers are Lukmaan IAS additions.

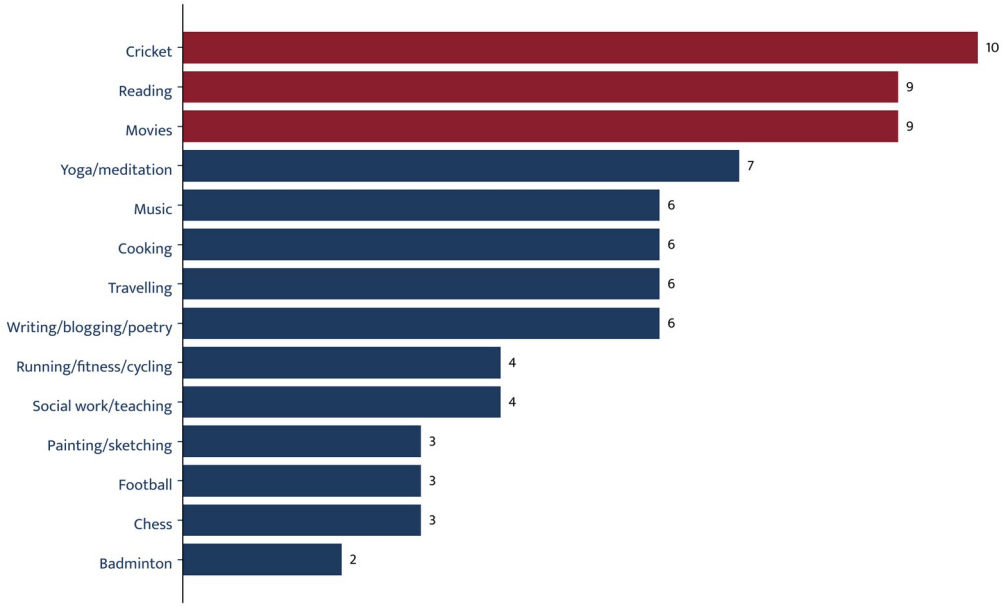


Figure 1. Hobbies in 68 transcripts studied (number of candidates)

How boards question hobbies

- **Many listed hobbies are never touched.** In about a quarter of the transcripts opened, the board skipped the hobby entirely; a 2025 Raj Shukla board candidate wrote 'Nothing asked from Hobbies', and a 2022 RN Choubey candidate's football, tennis and movies drew 'No questions asked'.
- **Proof-of-practice questions.** Boards check whether the hobby is actually practised: 'What level of cricket have you played?' (2022), 'Position I played' in football (2022), 'How much time do you take to solve sudoku? What about hard level?' (2023), 'Chess.. your rating?' (2024).
- **Technical depth tests.** Members drill into the craft's specifics: 'Which camera and lens do you have? Which lens is preferred for bird photography?' (2021), 'what is the actual physiological

function... while doing pranayaam?' (2021), 'Why are badminton courts wooden, not cemented?' (2024).

- **Definitions and fine distinctions.** A favourite move is to ask the candidate to separate near-synonyms: 'Journal vs diary writing' (2021), 'difference between bibliophile, bookworm and wordsmith' (2024), budget traveller vs backpacker (2022), 'How is mindfulness different from other forms of meditation?' (2025).
- **Recency checks.** Boards ask what you did with the hobby lately: 'What did you write about recently?' (2021), 'Recent movie watched?' (2021), 'which books did u read recently. Why?' (2021), 'What was the last sketch you made... why choose [a lion]?' (2025).
- **Hobby turned into a policy question.** A sport or pastime becomes a governance question about the sector: 'Why are we lagging so behind in swimming?' (2020), 'India not favourable to cycling, why? What needs to be done?' (2021), 'What will you do to attract children to play badminton?' (2024), 'Why did the Formula 1 race stop in India?' (2024).
- **Link to administration and life lessons.** Candidates are asked what the hobby taught them or how it transfers to the job: doodling 'how can this be used in administration?' (2022), 'What do you learn from chess in life?' (2024), 'How kabaddi contributes to character development' (2024), 'Football tactic that can be used by lawyers in arguing a case' (2022).
- **Favourites with justification.** A favourite is asked and then the reason is probed: 'Which cricketer inspires you the most... calm and that too Virat Kohli?' (2025), 'Favourite Agatha Christie detective... what do you like about his character?' (2024), 'Favourite book and why?' (2023).
- **Regional and cultural anchoring.** Hobbies are tied to the home state or to Indian culture: Malwa cuisine and daal bafla for a cooking candidate from MP (2024), Pichwai vs Tanjore painting and Sanganeri vs Bagru print (2023), features of Bundelkhandi music (2020), famous Indian flautists (2025).
- **Hobby as a hook for current affairs or GK.** The hobby only opens a factual question: 'Your hobby is quizzing.. then tell me the name of rail corridors announced in budget?' (2025), 'Why 2nd November 2025 is known as the red day of Indian cricket' (2025), 'U mentioned quizzing... 2 American states which are perfectly rectangular' (2021).
- **Odd combinations questioned.** Unusual or mismatched profiles draw a 'how come' question: 'Its interesting that a student of Physics also likes to sing. Amateur or trained?' (2021), 'You have covered different unrelated fields... cooking, Aircraft, Formula 1. How and why?' (2021), 'unique combination of Pichwai and Tanjore painting, how come?' (2023).
- **Wording and padding get exposed.** Coaching commentary (Onmanorama 'ABC of Civil Service', 2020) gives examples of padded entries being mocked: 'following wildlife' drew 'Whom do you follow; a bear or an elephant?', and 'crooning' or 'cherishing Bharatanatyam' showed the candidate did not know what the words mean. The same column says boards may ask about books, movies or music even when they are not listed.

General hobby questions asked in real boards

1. Where all have you travelled? / Which places have you travelled to? **[2020, 2022]**
2. Which books did you read recently? Why? **[2021]**
3. Recent movie watched? What is it about? **[2021]**
4. What did you write about recently? **[2021]**
5. How can this [hobby] be used in administration? **[2022]**
6. What do you learn from [chess] in life? / What have you learnt [from volleyball]? **[2019, 2024]**

7. What level have you played at? What was your parents' reaction when you started playing? **[2022]**
8. At what position do you play? **[2022, 2024, 2025]**
9. Who is your favourite player / who inspires you most, and why? **[2022, 2025]**
10. How is [cooking] your hobby? **[2021]**
11. Why do you meditate? What would you tell school children to convince them? **[2021]**
12. How long have you been doing/watching this? **[2021]**
13. Favourite book and why? **[2023]**
14. What was the last [sketch] you made, and why that subject? **[2025]**
15. Why is India lagging in [your sport], and what can be done? **[2020, 2021, 2025]**

The four-layer method for any hobby

Step 1. **Personal layer.** Why you took it up, what you do, how often, your best moment. Be specific: titles, matches, routes, recipes.

Step 2. **Knowledge layer.** History, rules, techniques, Indian icons, records and the vocabulary an enthusiast would use.

Step 3. **Governance layer.** Ministries, bodies, schemes, laws, court cases and current controversies linked to the hobby.

Step 4. **Officer layer.** How the hobby makes you a better administrator, and how you would use it in a district or ministry.

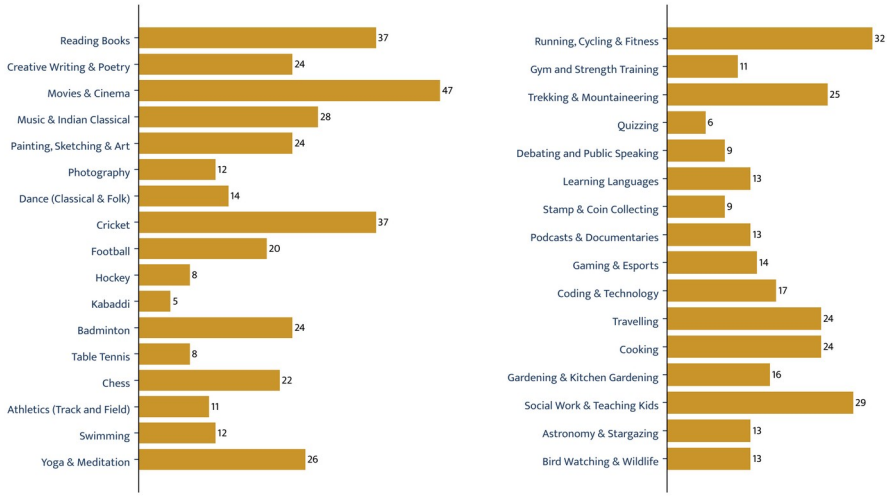


Figure 2. Real board questions found per hobby in this compilation (CSE 2019–2025)

PART I
Mind, Arts and Expression

Reading, writing, cinema, music, art, photography, dance

HOBBY 1
Reading Books

Appears in DAFs as: reading fiction, non-fiction, biographies, novels, spy thrillers, classics, collecting books, book clubs, Kindle reading. Reading is the most common DAF hobby, so boards use it to

separate genuine readers, who can discuss authors, ideas and their own takeaways, from candidates who listed it as filler.

> **What the board is really testing**
>
> • Is the hobby real: can you name recent reads, authors and the central argument of each book without hesitation?
>
> • Depth of thought: can you turn a book's idea into a view on governance, ethics or society?
>
> • Breadth and openness: do you read beyond your comfort genre, including Indian-language and contemporary writers?
>
> • Honesty under pressure: do you admit 'I have not read that' instead of bluffing?
>
> • Officer-like use: how reading shapes empathy, judgement and communication in administration

Basics, genres and reading culture

- Know the vocabulary: a **bibliophile** loves and collects books, a bookworm reads compulsively, a wordsmith is skilled at using words; boards have asked this distinction directly.
- Main genres: literary fiction, genre fiction (crime, spy, fantasy, sci-fi), biography/memoir, history, popular science, philosophy, self-help; be ready to defend your genre choice.
- Classic versus contemporary: classics have survived generations (Dostoevsky, Tolstoy, Premchand); contemporary means recent living writers; boards ask which you prefer and why.
- Formats: print, e-reader and **audiobooks**; be ready for a print-versus-Kindle question covering retention, cost, eye strain, access and environmental footprint.
- Crime fiction pairs boards like: Agatha Christie's Hercule Poirot (psychology, 'little grey cells') versus Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes (forensic observation and deduction).
- Keep a reading log: title, author, year, central thesis, one quote, one disagreement and one administrative lesson for every book listed in your DAF.

India story and literary icons

- Non-fiction staples boards cite: Amartya Sen's The Argumentative Indian, Huntington's The Clash of Civilizations, Sanjaya Baru's The Accidental Prime Minister, Kalam's Wings of Fire.
- Indian-language greats: Premchand, Rabindranath Tagore (Nobel 1913, Gitanjali), Girish Karnad (plays Tughlaq, Hayavadana), Mahasweta Devi, U.R. Ananthamurthy, Basheer, Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay.
- **Jnanpith**: 58th went jointly to Gulzar and Jagadguru Rambhadracharya; 59th to Hindi writer Vinod Kumar Shukla, first from Chhattisgarh, who died in Raipur on 23 December 2025.
- **International Booker 2025**: Banu Mushtaq's Kannada story collection Heart Lamp, translated by Deepa Bhasthi, the first Kannada book and first short-story collection to win.
- Booker Prize 2025 went to David Szalay's Flesh; International Booker 2026 went to Taiwan Travelogue by Yang Shuang-zi, translated by Lin King.
- Spy-fiction context: Eli Cohen was an Israeli Mossad agent who penetrated Syria's elite in the 1960s and was hanged in Damascus in 1965; Vienna was the Cold War 'spy capital'.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Sahitya Akademi** (1954, Ministry of Culture) gives awards in 24 languages; **National Book Trust** (1957, Ministry of Education) runs the New Delhi World Book Fair and PM-YUVA author mentorship.
- Libraries are a **State List** subject (Entry 12); the Delivery of Books and Newspapers (Public Libraries) Act, 1954 mandates copies to national libraries; Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation (1972) supports public libraries.
- **Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya**, run by NBT, is a free national digital library for children and adolescents with thousands of e-books across Indian languages, accessible on phones and tablets.
- **Gyan Bharatam Mission** (Ministry of Culture, 2024–31, Rs 482.85 crore) aims to survey, conserve and digitise India's estimated five million-plus manuscripts.
- Copyright Act, 1957 protects literary works for the author's life plus 60 years; DU photocopy case (2016) treated course-pack copying as fair educational use.
- NEP 2020 and NIPUN Bharat prioritise foundational literacy, reading corners and school libraries; ASER 2024 found 27.1% of Std III children could read a Std II text.

Current developments 2025–26

- New Delhi World Book Fair (10–18 January 2026, Bharat Mandapam) made entry free for the first time, took Indian military history as its theme, and reported over 20% higher footfall.
- Sahitya Akademi's December 2025 award announcement was cancelled on Ministry of Culture instructions; the 2025 awards were finally announced on 16 March 2026, raising **autonomy** debates.
- 2025 Sahitya Akademi winners include Navtej Sarna (English, Crimson Spring, on Jallianwala Bagh) and Mamta Kalia (Hindi, Jeete Jee Allahabad).
- Tamil Nadu announced its own literary awards in several languages after the Akademi episode, framed as a federalism and cultural-autonomy issue.
- Translation is driving Indian literature abroad: Heart Lamp (2025) followed Geetanjali Shree's Tomb of Sand (2022) as Indian-language International Booker winners.

Science, economics and social angle

- Neuroscience: deep reading builds sustained attention and **theory of mind**; Matthew Walker's Why We Sleep (asked by a board) links sleep to memory consolidation.
- Screen reading tends toward skimming; studies on the 'screen inferiority effect' suggest lower comprehension of complex text on screens than on paper.
- Publishing economy: India is among the world's largest book markets, with a large Hindi and regional-language segment, plus piracy, high GST on paper and thin distribution as constraints.
- Social role: community libraries in villages, mobile libraries and reading rooms widen access for first-generation learners and competitive-exam aspirants from poor households.
- Censorship and book bans test Article 19: Rushdie's The Satanic Verses (import ban 1988) and periodic state-level bans illustrate the tension with public order.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A district officer can revive panchayat libraries, use DMF or CSR funds for reading rooms, and link them with Samagra Shiksha school libraries.

- Literature builds **empathy**: Premchand's peasants or Mahasweta Devi's tribals show realities that files reduce to statistics.
- Biographies of administrators and leaders model integrity, crisis decisions and the courage to dissent within rules.
- Reading habits help in drafting clear notes, judgements and public communication, and keep an officer updated in a fast-changing policy environment.
- Ethical caution: do not quote a book you have not read; intellectual honesty is itself an integrity signal to the board.

Asked in real interviews

1. You list reading and collecting books. How many books are in your collection? What is the difference between a bibliophile, a bookworm and a wordsmith? **[2024]**
2. Which fiction have you read? Favourite Agatha Christie book and detective, Poirot or Miss Marple? What is Poirot's speciality and how does his deduction differ from Sherlock Holmes? **[2024]**
3. Do you read non-fiction? Which genre and which specific books apart from the Constitution? Do you know any plays by Girish Karnad? **[2024]**
4. You read spycraft novels: who was Eli Cohen and what happened to him? Why was Vienna the Cold War spy capital? What could make New Delhi the new one? **[2024]**
5. What is the last book you read and what did you learn from it? What is your favourite book? **[2024]**
6. What is the last book you have read? **[2023]**
7. Which book did you read recently and what is it about? Have you read 'Why We Sleep'? **[2021]**
8. Who wrote The Clash of Civilizations, The Argumentative Indian and The Accidental Prime Minister? **[2021]**
9. What kind of books do you read? Do you buy them in print or read them on Kindle? **[2021]**
10. You write and read poems; don't you read any books? Name your favourite authors. **[2023]**
11. Since you like to sing and read, are you aware of Romanticism? **[2021]**
12. Why did you read Dostoevsky's work and not that of other writers? **[2025]**
13. You read fiction: classical or contemporary? Which contemporary writers? **[2023]**
14. From your reading on Gandhi: is Gandhi and his non-violence relevant today? Gandhi or Kissinger, who is better? **[2023]**
15. Which book has Abdul Kalam written? In Wings of Fire, what is 'wings' and what is 'fire'? **[2021]**
16. Name some Hindustani poets. Isn't Ghalib an Urdu shayar? Recite a Ghalib couplet and explain it. **[2024]**
17. Have you read Madhushala? What does Bachchan mean by 'Madhushala'? Your interpretation? **[2024]**
18. Difference between novel and novella? Central theme of Animal Farm? Any other novel? **[2024]**
19. Non-fiction books vs podcasts: your preference and why? **[2024]**
20. Three Indian authors of magical realism other than Salman Rushdie. **[2024]**
21. Have you read Nancy Drew in childhood? What other novels have you read? **[2024]**
22. Name five non-fiction books you would revisit; who wrote them and what are they about? **[2024]**

23. You love spycraft novels: do you know Eli Cohen? Last book you read and its lesson? Favourite book? **[2024]**
24. Which self-help books have you read, and are they helping? What is meant by 'Man's Search for Meaning' and logotherapy? **[2024]**
25. You read military biographies and non-fiction: why not fiction? Should literature be taught in schools? **[2024]**
26. Your favourite Agatha Christie detective: Poirot or Marple? Read Sherlock Holmes? How many books are in your collection? **[2024]**
27. Which book did you last read? Two things you liked and two you disliked in it. **[2024]**
28. You read biographies: why not autobiographies? What is the difference? **[2024]**
29. How did reading about defence become your hobby? Where do you read defence news? **[2024]**
30. Recommend a book. Name three overrated books. **[2024]**
31. What are high-fantasy novels and which would you suggest? Last non-fantasy novel you read? **[2019]**
32. Shayari is your interest: which classics and which shayars do you read? **[2021]**
33. Why read Dostoevsky and not others? Was Prince Myshkin really an idiot? Compare Dostoevsky, Pushkin and Tolstoy. **[2025]**
34. Do you read essays? Which essayists have you read? **[2025]**
35. Have you read 'Usne Kaha Tha' and 'Ashadh Ka Ek Din'? Is there an ideology in Premchand's writings? **[2025]**
36. You read Marathi literature: have you read Mrityunjay? Which self-help books do you read? **[2025]**
37. Do you read Ghalib? What does 'Rekhta' mean? Explain 'bazicha-e-atfal'. **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Name three books you read in the last six months and the one idea from each that changed your thinking.
2. Who won the 59th Jnanpith Award and what is distinctive about his writing?
3. Should the Sahitya Akademi be fully autonomous of the Ministry of Culture? What happened with the 2025 awards?
4. As a District Collector, how would you build a reading culture among rural youth?
5. Is reading on screens destroying deep reading? Should schools move to e-books?
6. Which book would you recommend every civil servant read, and why?
7. Your favourite author faces a ban on a book in your district due to protests. What will you do?
8. Translations won the International Booker in 2022 and 2025. What does this say about Indian-language literature?

Model answer: In the age of reels and AI summaries, is book reading becoming irrelevant?

I do not think so, though the format is changing. Short content gives information, but long-form reading builds sustained attention and the ability to hold competing arguments, which an administrator needs. ASER 2024 found only 27.1% of Std III children could read a Std II-level text, so the real challenge is foundational reading, not books versus screens. As an officer, I would combine both: revive panchayat and school libraries, promote the free Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya on phones, and run reading campaigns through anganwadis and SHGs, so that technology becomes a gateway to deeper reading rather than a substitute.

Model answer: A book by a well-known author is facing violent protests in your district and groups demand a ban. As DM, what would you do?

My first duty is to protect both public order and the constitutional right under Article 19(1)(a). Courts have repeatedly held that the state cannot surrender to a heckler's veto; in S. Rangarajan the Supreme Court said threats of violence cannot justify suppressing expression. Book bans are a decision for the state government under law, not for a mob or for me. I would provide security to bookshops and the author's events, talk to community leaders, counter rumours on social media, and act firmly against anyone inciting violence. If any passage genuinely attracts a legal offence, I would refer it for a legal opinion rather than act on pressure.

Common traps

- Listing 'reading' but naming only exam books or one bestseller read years ago; boards immediately ask for the last book and its argument.
- Bluffing about books or authors you have not read; follow-ups on plot, characters or thesis expose it within seconds.
- Ignoring Indian and regional-language literature, or not knowing major current literary awards and controversies.

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare one-page notes on 8–10 books you have actually read: author, year, thesis, characters, a quote, a critique and an administrative lesson.

☐ Memorise current literary facts: Jnanpith 58th and 59th, Booker and International Booker 2025 and 2026, Sahitya Akademi 2025 episode.

☐ Read at least one Indian-language classic in translation and one book by an author from your home state.

☐ Revise institutions and schemes: Sahitya Akademi, NBT, RRRLF, Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya, Gyan Bharatam, NEP 2020 reading goals, ASER findings.

☐ Practise answering 'last book you read' and 'favourite author, why' in under 60 seconds, ending with a governance link.

HOBBY 2

Creative Writing & Poetry

Appears in DAFs as: writing poems, Hindi/Urdu poetry and shayari, free verse, short stories, blogging, journaling, Quora writing, publishing. Writing reveals how a candidate thinks and feels, so boards test whether the candidate knows the poetic tradition behind the hobby and can link self-expression with free-speech law and public communication.

What the board is really testing

- Authenticity: can you describe, or even recite, your own work and explain what drives it?
- Literary grounding: do you know the poets, movements and forms of the language you write

in?

• Observation and empathy: do you write about people and society around you, and what did that teach you?

• Constitutional sense: limits of free expression, online speech regulation and creative freedom

• Communication skill: can a writer draft crisp, humane official communication and handle public messaging?

Forms, techniques and traditions

- Forms: sonnet, ghazal (sher, matla, maqta, radif, qafiya), haiku, doha, nazm, free verse, prose poem, short story, flash fiction, personal essay, blog post.
- **Free verse** abandons fixed metre and rhyme (Walt Whitman, T.S. Eliot); Vikram Seth's The Golden Gate (1986) is the opposite, a novel in rhymed tetrameter sonnets.
- Hindi poetry movements: Bhakti and Riti kaal, **Chhayavad** (Prasad, Pant, Nirala, Mahadevi Verma), Pragativad, Prayogvad (Agyeya's Tar Saptak, 1943) and Nayi Kavita.
- Dinkar's **Rashmirathi** (1952) retells Karna's life; the title means 'charioteer of the sun's rays', pointing to Karna as son of Surya. Dinkar won Jnanpith for Urvashi.
- Tamil classics boards use: Thiruvalluvar's Thirukkural (1,330 couplets on virtue, wealth and love) and Andal's Thiruppavai (30 verses sung in Margazhi month).
- Urdu tradition: Mir, Ghalib, Iqbal, Faiz, Sahir, Bashir Badr, Rahat Indori; be ready to explain one couplet's meaning if you list shayari.

India story and literary icons

- Tagore remains the only Indian Nobel laureate in Literature (1913); boards expect respect in naming, such as 'Gurudev'.
- Mahadevi Verma, called the 'modern Meera', won Jnanpith (1982) and wrote poetry of longing and essays on women's condition (Shrinkhala ki Kadiyan).
- Kabir, Tulsidas, Meera, Basavanna and Lal Ded show how vernacular poetry carried social reform and devotion to ordinary people.
- Protest and nationalist poetry: Bankim's Vande Mataram, Iqbal's Saare Jahan Se Achha, Subramania Bharati, Faiz's Hum Dekhenge, Dinkar's Samar Shesh Hai.
- Contemporary voices: Gulzar (Jnanpith, 58th, jointly), Vinod Kumar Shukla (59th Jnanpith, poet-novelist, died December 2025), Javed Akhtar, Arundhathi Subramaniam, Jeet Thayil.

Institutions, policy and law

- Article 19(1)(a) protects expression; Article 19(2) permits reasonable restrictions for sovereignty, security, public order, decency, morality, defamation, contempt and incitement.
- **Shreya Singhal (2015)** struck down Section 66A of the IT Act for vagueness but upheld Section 69A blocking powers with safeguards.
- IT Rules, 2021 govern intermediaries and digital publishers; Section 79 safe harbour depends on due diligence and takedown on lawful orders.
- Copyright Act, 1957 protects literary works automatically from creation, for life plus 60 years; registration is optional but useful evidence in disputes.
- BNS 2023 provisions writers must know: Section 196 (promoting enmity), 299 (outraging religious feelings, old 295A), 356 (defamation, old 499).

- Press and Registration of Periodicals Act, 2023 replaced the colonial 1867 Press and Registration of Books Act for periodicals.

Current developments 2025–26

- **Imran Pratapgadhi v. State of Gujarat** (March 2025): Supreme Court quashed an FIR over the poem 'Ae khoon ke pyase', holding police must read speech as a reasonable person would.
- Sahitya Akademi's 18 December 2025 award announcement was cancelled at the Culture Ministry's direction under a July 2025 MoU; the awards were announced on 16 March 2026.
- Karnataka High Court (September 2025) dismissed X Corp's challenge to the **Sahyog portal** for takedown notices under Section 79(3)(b); X has appealed.
- In the India's Got Latent case (2025), the Supreme Court said self-regulation of online content is ineffective and asked the Centre for a neutral, autonomous regulatory mechanism.
- The Digital Personal Data Protection Rules were notified in November 2025, relevant to bloggers and newsletters that collect reader data.

Science, economics and social angle

- Expressive writing research (James Pennebaker) links journaling about difficult experiences with lower stress and better health; reflective writing is used in medical and teacher training.
- The **creator economy** lets bloggers and poets earn via newsletters, Instagram poetry and open-mic platforms, but income is uneven and platform-dependent.
- AI text generators raise authorship, copyright and plagiarism questions; Indian law currently assumes a human author for copyright.
- Open mics and slam poetry have revived spoken word in Indian cities, often bilingual (Hinglish), and in regional languages through YouTube.
- Translation is the bridge for Indian literature; shortages of skilled translators, including into Hindi, limit cross-language reach and official communication.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Writing trains clarity: a well-drafted note, order or press release prevents litigation and confusion; officers write constantly.
- Observational writing about everyday people, like a blog on a local vendor, trains the **empathy** and field sense a district officer needs.
- Officers can use poetry and storytelling in campaigns, such as Swachh Bharat jingles, Beti Bachao slogans and election awareness, in local dialects.
- Conduct Rules: All India Services (Conduct) Rules allow literary and artistic writing but bar criticism of government policy and unauthorised disclosure; officers must stay politically neutral.
- Ethical issues: plagiarism, AI-written work passed off as one's own, and respecting dignity of real people portrayed in stories.

Asked in real interviews

1. You write free verse poetry. Can you name some poets? Have you read any contemporary poets? **[2025]**
2. Have you heard of The Golden Gate? Does Vikram Seth write free verse? **[2025]**
3. Name one writer who talks about issues at the district level. **[2025]**
4. Do you like Thiruppavai or Thirukkural? You must choose one. **[2024]**

5. What types of blogs do you write? How many people read them? **[2024]**
6. Why is Rashmirathi named so? **[2023]**
7. What is the name of your blog and why that name? Do you observe people closely? Why do you write about human lives? **[2022]**
8. Tell us three things you learned from the story you wrote on your blog. **[2022]**
9. What do you mean by illustrating poetry? Have you read a particular Hindi poem? **[2021]**
10. Why is there so much difficulty in Hindi translation? Any suggestions? **[2021]**
11. Who are your favourite Hindi poets? What is the opening line of Dinkar's Rashmirathi? **[2020]**
12. Tell us something special about Mahadevi Verma. What is Chhayavaad? **[2020]**
13. The member recited shayari by Bashir Badr and Rahat Indori and asked the candidate to interpret it. **[2020]**
14. You write poetry or recite? Recite a poem. **[2024]**
15. Do you journal? Would you share it with a friend? Why share on social media but not a journal? **[2024]**
16. Would you write science fiction? On what concept, and wouldn't it risk plagiarism? **[2024]**
17. Do hobbies like writing poems and philosophical notes emanate from being heartbroken? **[2024]**
18. You write micro-tales: isn't nuance lost in them? **[2024]**
19. What did you write in your college magazine? Any memorable piece? **[2024]**
20. As writers' head, on what issues did you write the play? **[2021]**
21. What would you write on your blog about the Russia-Ukraine war? **[2021]**
22. What is reflective journaling? **[2025]**
23. You write short stories: difference between novel and novella? On which issues do you write? **[2025]**
24. Why do you write a diary? When did you last receive a letter? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Recite two lines of your own poem and explain what inspired it.
2. What is the difference between free verse and a ghazal? Which suits your writing and why?
3. Can a poem be a crime? Where should the line be drawn between creative freedom and public order?
4. The Supreme Court quashed an FIR over a poem in 2025. What principle did it lay down?
5. Should civil servants publish poetry or blogs? What limits do the Conduct Rules impose?
6. Will AI tools make poets and writers irrelevant? Who owns an AI-written poem?
7. How would you use storytelling or poetry in a public campaign in your district?
8. Was the cancellation of the Sahitya Akademi announcement in December 2025 justified?

Model answer: Can poetry be a crime? Where would you draw the line?

Poetry can be provocative, and that is often its social value. I would draw the line only where the Constitution does, under Article 19(2): incitement to violence, defamation or threat to public order. In March 2025, in Imran Pratapgadhi's case, the Supreme Court quashed an FIR over a poem and said police must judge speech by the standard of reasonable, strong-minded people, not the most sensitive reader. As an officer, before registering such cases I would seek legal scrutiny of the actual text, protect the writer's events from mobs, and act firmly only against genuine incitement, not mere offence.

Model answer: As a civil servant, will you continue to write and publish? Is it compatible with service neutrality?

Yes, I would like to continue, within the rules. The All India Services (Conduct) Rules permit literary and artistic work, but bar criticism of government policy, disclosure of official information and political commentary. Many officers have been noted writers, which shows the two can coexist. I would keep my creative writing separate from official matters, avoid themes that use confidential information, and seek permission where required. My writing habit would also help in my work: clear notes, empathetic letters to citizens and campaign messages in local language. The test is simple: my writing should never compromise impartiality or public trust.

Common traps

- Writing in a language but not knowing its major poets, movements or forms; boards ask about Chhayavad, Dinkar or Ghalib immediately.
- Being unable to recite or explain even a few lines of one's own work, or claiming a blog with no real content.
- Taking extreme positions on free speech, either absolutist or censorious, without citing Article 19(2) and key judgments.

Preparation checklist

☐ Keep 3–4 of your own poems or pieces ready to recite in 30 seconds each, with the context and message.

☐ Revise the literary history of your writing language: movements, five key poets, two famous works each and one line you can quote.

☐ Know the free-speech law kit: Article 19(1)(a) and 19(2), Shreya Singhal, Imran Pratapgadhi 2025, IT Rules 2021, Sahyog portal ruling, BNS sections.

☐ Read the All India Services (Conduct) Rules on publications and media participation.

☐ Prepare one example of how storytelling or writing could improve a government campaign in your home district.

HOBBY 3

Movies & Cinema

Appears in DAFs as: watching movies, world cinema, Hollywood, regional films, OTT series, documentaries, film appreciation, film reviewing. Cinema is both mass culture and a policy domain spanning censorship, OTT regulation, the creative economy and soft power, so boards use it to test whether a casual hobby carries social and governance insight.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you watch critically: themes, direction, social message, not just stars and box office
- Your view on cinema's influence on society, from violence and stereotypes to social reform films
- Knowledge of regulation: CBFC, the Cinematograph Act, OTT rules and free speech

• Awareness of the industry: National Awards, Oscars and Cannes, soft power and the creative economy

• Balance and maturity on controversial films, bans and the heckler's veto

Basics, history and milestones

- Dadasaheb Phalke's Raja Harishchandra (1913) was India's first full-length feature; Ardeshir Irani's Alam Ara (1931) was the first talkie.
- Golden age and parallel cinema: Satyajit Ray (Pather Panchali 1955, honorary Oscar 1992), Ritwik Ghatak, Mrinal Sen, Shyam Benegal, Adoor Gopalakrishnan.
- Evolution of Hindi cinema: social and nation-building films (1950s), angry-young-man era (1970s), liberalisation-era romance (1990s), multiplex and content-driven cinema (2010s), OTT era (2020s).
- Regional cinema's rise: Malayalam realism, Tamil and Telugu pan-India spectacles (Baahubali, RRR), Kannada's Kantara (2022) built on Bhuta Kola folk ritual of coastal Karnataka.
- Oscars: RRR's Naatu Naatu (Best Original Song) and The Elephant Whisperers (Documentary Short) won in 2023; Payal Kapadia's All We Imagine As Light won Cannes Grand Prix 2024.

Awards, icons and recent films

- **71st National Film Awards** (films of 2023): 12th Fail best feature; Shah Rukh Khan (Jawan) and Vikrant Massey shared best actor; Rani Mukerji best actress; Mohanlal got Dadasaheb Phalke Award.
- **72nd National Film Awards** (films of 2024, announced 18 July 2026): Article 370 best feature; Kartik Aaryan and Mammootty shared best actor; Yami Gautam best actress; Rajkumar Periasamy best director (Amaran).
- The 72nd awards ceremony was held at Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, on 22 September 2026, the first outside New Delhi in decades.
- Veteran Kannada actor Anant Nag was named for the **Dadasaheb Phalke Award** for 2024 in September 2026.
- 12th Fail, based on IPS officer Manoj Kumar Sharma's struggle, is a board favourite for discussing coaching culture, poverty and the dignity of failure.

Institutions, policy and law

- **CBFC** certifies films under the Cinematograph Act, 1952 (Ministry of I&B); the Film Certification Appellate Tribunal was abolished in 2021, so appeals now go to High Courts.
- Cinematograph (Amendment) Act, 2023: UA 7+, UA 13+, UA 16+ sub-categories; perpetual certificates; piracy jail of three months to three years and fine up to 5% of production cost.
- OTT platforms are governed by Part III of the IT Rules, 2021: a code of ethics, self-classification (U, U/A 7+, 13+, 16+, A) and a three-tier grievance system.
- Key judgments: K.A. Abbas (1970) upheld pre-censorship; S. Rangarajan (1989) rejected the heckler's veto; courts cleared Padmaavat (2018) despite state bans.
- NFDC now absorbs Films Division, the Children's Film Society and the National Film Archive (merged 2022); IFFI Goa is India's premier FIAPF-accredited festival.

Current developments 2025–26

- Neeraj Ghaywan's **Homebound**, India's official Oscar entry, made the 15-film International Feature shortlist in December 2025 but missed the final nomination in January 2026.
- **WAVES 2025** (World Audio Visual and Entertainment Summit), Mumbai, from 1 May 2025: Rs 391 crore Indian Institute of Creative Technology and a USD 1 billion creator-economy fund.
- 56th IFFI Goa (20–28 November 2025): Vietnamese film Skin of Youth won the Golden Peacock.
- US President Trump announced, in May and again in September 2025, a 100% tariff on films made outside the US, alarming Indian producers who depend on diaspora box office.
- In the India's Got Latent case (2025) the Supreme Court said self-regulation of online content had failed and asked the Centre to devise a neutral, autonomous mechanism.

Science, economics and social angle

- India produces the most films in the world, in over 20 languages; the M&E sector was valued at about USD 28 billion around WAVES 2025.
- **Soft power**: Indian films are popular in the Gulf, Africa, Russia, Central Asia and China (Dangal); the government offers incentives for foreign film shoots in India.
- Social influence: films shaped attitudes on toilets (Toilet: Ek Prem Katha), menstrual hygiene (Pad Man), sports and girls (Dangal), but can also glamorise violence and misogyny (debate over Animal).
- The 2023 Hollywood strikes by writers (WGA) and actors (SAG-AFTRA) were over streaming residuals and protection from **AI** replicas and AI-written scripts.
- Why National Award films struggle commercially: weak distribution, few screens per capita, star-driven marketing and limited exhibition for regional and independent cinema.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District administration manages film-related law and order, cinema licensing and single-screen safety; the Uphaar fire (1997) remains the reference case for fire safety.
- Officers can use films and short videos for IEC campaigns, and film societies in schools to build critical thinking and media literacy.
- Film-shooting facilitation through single-window clearances and state film policies brings tourism and jobs; states compete through subsidies.
- Ethical issues: piracy as theft, stereotyping of communities and women, glamorising violence, and the officer's duty to protect lawful screenings against mobs.
- Biopics of officers and real crimes raise fairness questions: trial by cinema, privacy and portrayal of victims.

Asked in real interviews

1. How is society influenced by social movies? **[2025]**
2. A year or more ago there was a strike in Hollywood. What was it about? **[2024]**
3. Which recent Tamil movie have you watched? Describe the movie. **[2024]**
4. The board asked about Kannada movies, including Kantara, and older Kannada films. **[2022]**
5. How has Hindi cinema evolved? Which actor depicts social reality, and which movies deal with social issues? **[2023]**
6. Have you watched 12th Fail? What do you say about it? Doesn't it also show the lack of resources? **[2023]**

7. Are the violence and box-office success of Animal a concern? Would you censor such films? **[2023]**
8. You have a unique hobby with respect to cinema. What have you learnt from it? **[2023]**
9. National Award-winning movies are not doing well at the box office. Why? **[2023]**
10. You watch OTT: what is the difference between viewing it on phone, TV and in a cinema hall? **[2024]**
11. How do you deal with sex scenes in OTT shows? Are any filters used? **[2024]**
12. Who calls it 'new wave Hindi cinema' now? When did the wave start and end? **[2024]**
13. What was the main theme of Laapataa Ladies? **[2024]**
14. If a Rajinikanth movie and a Kamal Haasan movie released together, which would you watch first? **[2024]**
15. Which was the last movie you watched recently? **[2024]**
16. Any recent movie you watched? Analyse the character of the police officer in Laapataa Ladies. **[2024]**
17. How should the police officer in Laapataa Ladies have behaved with the woman? **[2024]**
18. You like sci-fi movies: what is science fiction, and do you really consider Indian sci-fi movies to be sci-fi? **[2024]**
19. Can horror movies be thrillers? Why do people watch horror movies? **[2024]**
20. Police in action-thriller movies always arrive late. Why, and what does it portray? **[2024]**
21. What are your learnings from action-thriller movies? Is watching them your interest or hobby, and how do the two differ? **[2024]**
22. Latest sci-fi movie or web series you watched (Severance): what is its main idea, and what is controversial about the severance procedure? **[2024]**
23. What other science-fiction series have you watched (3 Body Problem), and which book is it based on? **[2024]**
24. Why are 60-70% of movies and shows nowadays in the thriller category? Shouldn't they make more comedies? **[2024]**
25. Does watching crime thrillers with gore and violence make one violent? Can this hobby help you in service? **[2024]**
26. What is your favourite inspirational movie and why? Any Bollywood one? **[2024]**
27. What was the recent Hollywood strike about? **[2024]**
28. What is the artistic expression of critically acclaimed films? Which film is best in sound mixing, including Hindi films? **[2024]**
29. From where was the music of 12th Fail borrowed? Who gave the music of Pather Panchali? **[2024]**
30. Have you watched Oppenheimer? What do you think of his character? **[2024]**
31. Any documentary on physics that you have watched? **[2024]**
32. Documentaries you saw recently? Name a few documentaries with social underpinnings. **[2024]**
33. You play chess: have you watched The Queen's Gambit? **[2024]**
34. There was a chess movie 2-3 years ago with a female lead. Name it. **[2024]**
35. You like sitcoms: narrate a joke and make us laugh. **[2025]**
36. You watch thriller web series: what did you learn from the last one you saw? **[2025]**
37. Which science movie did you last watch? Who is the most successful filmmaker of India? **[2025]**

38. Which type of regional cinema do you watch? What is different about southern cinema? How has Bollywood helped spread Hindi? **[2025]**
39. Discussion on Christopher Nolan and Interstellar. **[2025]**
40. Major difference between North Indian and South Indian movies? Favourite Kannada actor? **[2025]**
41. What are classical cult movies? Give three names. **[2025]**
42. Why do animated movies carry social messages? Have you watched Terminator? **[2025]**
43. Which movie did you watch recently? What is the impact of larger-than-life films? Best movies on sports? **[2025]**
44. Why do you only watch Ramanand Sagar's Ramayana? **[2025]**
45. You like Hindi web series: which did you watch recently, what was the plot and its message? **[2025]**
46. You like movies on social issues: which ones have you watched? **[2025]**
47. What are the famous blockbusters from Karnataka? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Which film did you watch most recently, and what was its social message?
2. Should the CBFC certify films or censor them? Is pre-censorship compatible with Article 19?
3. OTT content is uncensored. Should it be brought under CBFC-type control?
4. What were the major outcomes of the WAVES summit, and what is the orange economy?
5. Why did Homebound get attention internationally, and what does it say about Indian cinema?
6. A film is facing protests and threats in your district on release day. As SP or DM, what will you do?
7. Does cinema glorify or criticise the bureaucracy? Name a film that portrays officers realistically.
8. Who won the latest Dadasaheb Phalke Award and best feature film at the National Awards?

Model answer: Should violent films like Animal be censored, given their huge box-office success?

I would not support banning a film merely for its violence or ideas, because adult viewers have the right to choose, and the CBFC already has an A certificate for this. The 2023 amendment added age-based UA 7+, 13+ and 16+ categories, which is the better tool: informed choice rather than prohibition. Concern is legitimate when films normalise misogyny for young viewers, so enforcement of age ratings, media literacy in schools and responsible marketing matter. As an administrator, I would ensure ratings are respected in theatres and protect lawful screenings, while encouraging public debate rather than mob-driven censorship.

Model answer: Should OTT platforms be regulated like films in theatres?

OTT needs regulation, but not a copy of theatrical pre-censorship. OTT viewing is on demand and private, so the IT Rules, 2021 use self-classification by age, parental locks and a three-tier grievance system. In the 2025 India's Got Latent case, the Supreme Court observed that self-regulation has not worked well and asked for a neutral, autonomous mechanism. I would favour an independent co-regulatory body with industry, child-rights and legal experts, clear statutory standards, and quick grievance redress, avoiding direct executive control over content, which could chill creative freedom.

Common traps

- Naming only blockbusters and stars without discussing direction, themes or social message.
- Not knowing basics of regulation: CBFC, certificate categories, OTT rules, and the 2023 amendment.
- Taking a moralistic 'ban it' stand on controversial films, or the opposite extreme, ignoring Article 19(2).

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare 5–6 films (including one regional, one world cinema and one documentary) with director, year, theme and a governance takeaway.

☐ Memorise 2025–26 facts: 71st and 72nd National Awards, Phalke awardees, Homebound's Oscar run, IFFI 2025, WAVES outcomes.

☐ Revise the law: Cinematograph Act 1952 and 2023 amendment, IT Rules 2021 Part III, K.A. Abbas, S. Rangarajan, FCAT abolition.

☐ Prepare a situational answer on protests against a film release, covering law and order, dialogue and court orders.

☐ Watch 12th Fail and one film on your home state's society, and be ready to critique both, positive and negative.

HOBBY 4

Music & Indian Classical

Appears in DAFs as: listening to music, singing, Hindustani/Carnatic classical, ghazals, sugam sangeet, bhajans, playing harmonium, guitar, tabla, violin, piano, flute. Music lets boards test technical depth (swara, raga, gharana), cultural knowledge and personality in one go, often by asking the candidate to sing or explain a classical concept on the spot.

What the board is really testing

- Genuineness and training: amateur or trained, which guru or gharana, how long?
- Technical grasp: swaras, ragas, taal, Hindustani versus Carnatic, instrument families
- Cultural literacy: icons, folk traditions of your home state, history and controversies such as the AIR harmonium ban
- Confidence and composure: willingness to sing or play a few lines when asked
- Linkage to society and administration: music therapy, livelihoods of folk artists, copyright and cultural policy

Basics, theory and history

- Seven **swaras**: Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Dha Ni; with komal and tivra variants there are 12 semitones; Sa and Pa are fixed (achal).
- Raga needs at least five notes, aroha-avaroha, vadi-samvadi and characteristic phrases; taal is the rhythmic cycle, such as teentaal of 16 beats.

- Texts: Bharata's Natya Shastra, Matanga's Brihaddeshi (first defines raga), Sarngadeva's Sangita Ratnakara (13th century), the last text common to both systems.
- Natya Shastra classes instruments as tata (string), sushira (wind), avanaddha (membrane) and ghana (solid); harmonium is a free-reed wind instrument of European origin.
- Bollywood songs generally use tempered, fixed pitches and mixed scales, while classical music uses microtonal shading (shruti), meend and gamaka.

Hindustani, Carnatic and icons

- Hindustani: north, Persian influence, 10 **thaats** (Bhatkhande), improvisation-heavy, forms dhrupad, khayal, thumri, tappa; Carnatic: south, 72 melakarta ragas (Venkatamakhin), composition-centric, kriti form.
- Carnatic Trinity: Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar, Syama Sastri; Purandara Dasa is the 'Pitamaha'; modern proponents include M.S. Subbulakshmi, Balamuralikrishna and T.M. Krishna.
- Hindustani gharanas: Gwalior (oldest khayal), Agra, Kirana, Jaipur-Atrauli, Patiala, Mewati; tabla gharanas: Delhi, Lucknow, Ajrara, Farrukhabad, Benares, Punjab.
- Musician Bharat Ratnas: M.S. Subbulakshmi (1998), Ravi Shankar (1999), Lata Mangeshkar and Bismillah Khan (2001), Bhimsen Joshi (2009), Bhupen Hazarika (2019, posthumous).
- Light music: ghazal (Mehdi Hassan, Ghulam Ali, Jagjit Singh), abhang popularised by Bhimsen Joshi, Haryanvi ragini, Garhwali jagar; Kishore Kumar was born in Khandwa, Madhya Pradesh.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Sangeet Natak Akademi** (1952–53, Ministry of Culture) gives Akademi Ratna fellowships, Akademi Puraskar and the Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar.
- All India Radio banned the harmonium from 1940 to 1971; John Foulds and Lionel Fielden pushed it, and Tagore backed it. As I&B minister, B.V. Keskar also barred film songs in the 1950s.
- Copyright (Amendment) Act, 2012 gave lyricists and composers a non-waivable right to royalties; IPRS and PPL license public performance of music.
- Schemes: Guru-Shishya Parampara, Scheme for Pension and Medical Aid to Artistes, Zonal Cultural Centres, Kala Utsav in schools.
- UNESCO lists of Intangible Cultural Heritage include Vedic chanting, Kutiyattam, Ramlila and Sankirtana of Manipur; several instruments carry GI tags, such as Thanjavur veena.

Current developments 2025–26

- **Grammys 2026**: Ustad Amjad Ali Khan with sons Amaan and Ayaan won as composers on the Dalai Lama's album Meditations; Anoushka Shankar and Shakti were nominated but did not win.
- Sangeet Natak Akademi fellowships and awards for 2024 and 2025 (7 fellows, 115 artists) were conferred by the President on 13 August 2026.
- Deaths: Assamese singer **Zubeen Garg** (Singapore, September 2025), Padma Vibhushan thumri maestro Pt. Chhannulal Mishra (Mirzapur, October 2025); tabla legend Zakir Hussain died in December 2024.
- In December 2024 the Supreme Court restrained T.M. Krishna from being projected as recipient of the Music Academy's M.S. Subbulakshmi award, after objections by Subbulakshmi's grandson.

- WAVES 2025 and the creator-economy fund include music; streaming now dominates recorded-music revenue in India.

Science, economics and social angle

- Music engages reward circuits: listening and playing release **dopamine**, and group singing is linked to oxytocin and lower cortisol; music therapy helps in dementia, autism and stroke rehabilitation.
- Traditional raga-chikitsa claims need caution; evidence supports music's effect on mood and stress more than raga-specific cures.
- Old versus new songs: older film music had melody-led orchestration and poetic lyrics; digital production, Auto-Tune and short-video virality favour hooks and remixes.
- Folk musicians such as Langas and Manganiyars, Bauls and Pandavani singers face income insecurity; festivals, tourism circuits and digital platforms offer partial support.
- India is a large music-streaming market dominated by film music; independent and regional artists are growing via YouTube and streaming.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers can use folk music for public messaging, as in election awareness, Swachh Bharat and nutrition campaigns, using local forms for trust and reach.
- District festivals and cultural mapping can document dying traditions and connect artists to pensions, Guru-Shishya grants and tourism.
- Noise pollution rules (2000) and the Supreme Court's 2005 loudspeaker order (no loudspeakers 10 pm–6 am, with limited exceptions) require balancing religion, celebration and public health.
- Music teaches **discipline** (riyaz), patience and listening, qualities useful in grievance hearings and teamwork.
- Ethical issues: royalty theft, plagiarism in film music, exploitation of folk artists by intermediaries, and gender barriers in gharana traditions.

Asked in real interviews

1. You mention sugam sangeet. What do you listen to, which singers? Sing a ghazal of Ghulam Ali. **[2025]**
2. What is the difference between Hindustani and Carnatic music? Name two proponents of Carnatic music. **[2025]**
3. Your life seems to be about music. Do you want to become a singer? **[2025]**
4. Your hobby is singing: who is your favourite singer? Are old songs better than new ones, and is technology the reason? **[2025]**
5. Where was Kishore Kumar born? What was the name of his wife? **[2025]**
6. Who in the music industry popularised abhangs? Why is Haryanvi ragini famous and what is its purpose? **[2023]**
7. What does your multilingual music appreciation hobby mean? How is Garhwali jagar different from Punjabi folk songs? **[2023]**
8. Asked about the controversy over the harmonium, and the minister related to it. **[2022]**
9. Which instruments do you play? **[2022]**
10. A Physics student who sings: are you an amateur singer or trained in Hindustani classical? **[2021]**

11. What is the difference between piano and harmonium? Which hormones are released when you play, and what physical changes do you feel? **[2021]**
12. Tell me about sur. How many surs? How do Bollywood and classical sur differ? Name some high-pitch Bollywood songs. **[2021]**
13. Asked about violin-manufacturing companies. **[2021]**
14. Who is your favourite singer? **[2019]**
15. Is your favourite singer Arijit Singh? Which era of Bollywood songs attracts you? Sing a Mohammed Rafi song. **[2024]**
16. What kind of songs do you sing; any accompaniment? Sing a few lines of your favourite. **[2024]**
17. What is EDM and deep house? Chicago house, 4x4, and jazz or waltz in deep house? **[2024]**
18. Do you sing bhakti sangeet on classical basics? Which ragas do you know; speciality of Raag Yaman? **[2024]**
19. What music do you listen to? Is music art or spiritual? Hindustani vs Carnatic, Indian vs Western? **[2024]**
20. How many types of guitars are there? **[2019]**
21. Do you play flute, with training? Tell us a few raags and name some flautists. **[2022]**
22. You listen to qawwali and ghazals: who was the last Mughal emperor's court poet, and Ghalib's relation to him? **[2023]**
23. You mention sugam sangeet: what do you listen to? Hindustani vs Carnatic? Do you want to become a singer? **[2025]**
24. Isn't tabla backward-looking? How can your music skills help in service? **[2025]**
25. Define folk music; how does it differ from mainstream and Western country music? **[2025]**
26. What form of music do you sing? Importance of guru-shishya parampara? **[2025]**
27. Sing a song. Punjabi folk songs adapted by Bollywood? **[2025]**
28. You play flute: name a famous Indian flautist and his film-music collaboration. **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Sing or hum two lines of your favourite song or raga, and tell us its raga or mood.
2. What is a gharana? Name two gharanas and how they differ.
3. Why was the harmonium banned on All India Radio, and was it justified?
4. Which Indian musicians won at the 2026 Grammys, and for what?
5. How can music be used in public health or education programmes in your district?
6. Folk artists of your home state are struggling. What would you do as Collector?
7. Is copyright law fair to lyricists and composers? What changed in 2012?
8. Loudspeakers at a religious event exceed noise limits at night and locals complain. What do you do?

Model answer: Was the AIR ban on harmonium (1940–71) justified?

I find it understandable but excessive. The objection was technical: as a fixed-pitch, tempered instrument, the harmonium cannot produce meend, gamaka or microtonal shruti, which define Indian classical music. John Foulds and Tagore argued this, and AIR banned it in 1940 until 1971. But the instrument had already become integral to khayal, thumri, qawwali, Gurbani kirtan and theatre, and masters showed it could accompany sensitively. A public broadcaster should promote quality and authenticity, but through standards and diversity rather than prohibitions. As an administrator, I take the lesson that cultural policy should support traditions without imposing a single idea of purity.

Model answer: How would you use music in administration as a District Collector?

Music builds trust faster than circulars. I would use local folk forms in campaigns, as states have done with nukkad songs for immunisation, nutrition and voter awareness, because people respond to their own idiom. Research shows group singing lowers stress, so music therapy could be added in district hospitals, de-addiction centres and old-age homes. I would map folk artists in the district, link them to Sangeet Natak Akademi programmes, artist pensions and tourism circuits, and showcase them in district festivals. Finally, I would ensure noise rules are enforced sensitively, balancing celebration with citizens' right to rest.

Common traps

- Claiming 'Indian classical music' as a hobby without knowing swara, raga, thaat or a single gharana; boards probe theory instantly.
- Freezing or refusing when asked to sing or play; a short, confident rendition is better than an apology.
- Knowing only film music and nothing of the folk music of one's home state or current music news.

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare two short pieces, a song and a raga or bandish, that you can sing or hum confidently in 20–30 seconds.

☐ Revise theory: seven swaras, shruti, thaat versus melakarta, five ragas with their time and mood, taals such as teentaal and adi taal.

☐ Make notes on icons and history: Carnatic Trinity, major gharanas, musician Bharat Ratnas, AIR harmonium ban, B.V. Keskar.

☐ Update current affairs: Grammys 2026, Sangeet Natak Akademi 2024–25 awards, deaths of Zubeen Garg and Chhannulal Mishra, the T.M. Krishna case.

☐ Study your home state's folk music forms and one scheme for artists, and prepare one administrative idea using music.

HOBBY 5

Painting, Sketching & Art

Appears in DAFs as: painting (oil, acrylic, watercolour), pencil sketching, fabric/folk painting, doodling, Madhubani. Art lets the board test cultural literacy, aesthetic sensibility and creativity, and probe whether a candidate can turn heritage and folk art into livelihood and governance ideas.

What the board is really testing

- Genuineness: medium, themes, technique and whether you can discuss your own work
- Knowledge of Indian art history, movements, masters and folk or tribal traditions
- Ability to answer conceptual questions, such as whether sketching is copying, or art versus science
- Awareness of the art economy: artisans, middlemen, GI, auctions and cultural policy
- Use of creativity, visual thinking and communication in administration

Basics, media and movements

- Media: **oil** (slow-drying, rich blending), **acrylic** (water-based, fast-drying, plastic sheen), watercolour (transparent), tempera, gouache; pencil grades run from hard H to soft B.
- Classical Indian theory lists six limbs of painting (**Shadanga**): form, proportion, emotion, grace, likeness and colour, cited in Yashodhara's commentary on the Kamasutra.
- **Cubism** (Picasso and Braque, c. 1907-14) broke objects into geometric planes and multiple viewpoints; Gaganendranath Tagore experimented with it in India.
- Other movements: Impressionism (light and moment), Expressionism, Surrealism, Abstract art; doodling and sketching build observation and are basic tools of design thinking.
- Copying from a reference is a classic training method; originality comes from interpretation, composition and style rather than subject alone.

India story and icons

- **Bhimbetka** rock shelters (MP, UNESCO 2003) hold prehistoric paintings; archaeologist V.S. Wakankar identified them in 1957.
- Ajanta murals, Mughal and Rajput miniatures, Pahari schools (Kangra, Basohli), Company painting and Tanjore art form the classical arc.
- **Raja Ravi Varma** popularised oil painting and mass lithographs; Abanindranath Tagore founded the Bengal School ('Bharat Mata'); Nandalal Bose illustrated the Constitution.
- Amrita Sher-Gil fused Western and Indian idioms; the Progressive Artists' Group (Bombay, 1947) included Souza, Raza, Husain, Ara, Bakre and Gade.
- Folk and tribal traditions: Madhubani/Mithila (Bihar), Warli (Maharashtra), Pattachitra (Odisha), Gond (MP), Kalamkari (Andhra), Pithora, Phad and Cheriyal scrolls.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Lalit Kala Akademi** (1954) and the National Gallery of Modern Art (1954, Jaipur House, Delhi) are the national institutions for visual arts.
- The Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972 declared works of nine artists, including Ravi Varma, Sher-Gil and Rabindranath Tagore, as **national art treasures** that cannot be exported.

- Copyright Act, 1957 protects artistic works for life plus 60 years; Section 57 moral rights were upheld in Amar Nath Sehgal v. Union of India (Delhi HC, 2005).
- Kalamkari has two styles: Srikalahasti (freehand pen) and Machilipatnam/Pedana (block-printed, GI-tagged); Madhubani painting also has a GI.
- Schemes such as PM Vishwakarma, Hunar Haat-style melas and ODOP help artisans; Padma awards have honoured folk artists like Dulari Devi.

Current developments 2025-26

- In March 2025, M.F. Husain's 1954 mural **Gram Yatra** sold for about USD 13.8 million at Christie's New York, then a record for Indian modern art.
- In April 2026 Raja Ravi Varma's **Yashoda and Krishna** sold for Rs 167.2 crore at Saffronart, Mumbai, to Cyrus Poonawalla, setting a new Indian auction record.
- On Budget day, 1 February 2025, the Finance Minister wore a saree with Madhubani art gifted by Padma Shri artist **Dulari Devi**, spotlighting Mithila painting.
- Deepavali's December 2025 UNESCO inscription, India's 16th intangible heritage element, renewed attention on festival arts such as rangoli and diyas.
- Repatriation of stolen antiquities and artworks from the US, UK and Australia continues to be a priority for the Ministry of Culture and ASI.

Science, economics and social angle

- Art and science both rely on observation and experiment; perspective drawing uses geometry, and pigments involve chemistry, from natural ochres to synthetic acrylics.
- Folk artists often earn little because **middlemen** capture value; direct e-commerce, GI branding, cooperatives and design training raise their share.
- India's art auction market boomed after 2023, but it remains concentrated in a few modern masters while living folk artists stay poor.
- Art therapy helps mental health, children with special needs and trauma survivors; art education is encouraged by NEP 2020's emphasis on arts integration.
- Women dominate many folk traditions such as Madhubani, so art livelihoods double as women's economic empowerment.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Collectors use wall art and murals for **IEC campaigns** on sanitation, voting (SVEEP), vaccination and girl-child education.
- Drawing and visual mapping help in planning, presenting data and simplifying complex schemes for citizens.
- District branding through ODOP and GI-tagged crafts can link artists with markets, exhibitions and export portals.
- Cultural heritage protection: preventing vandalism of rock art, checking idol and art theft, and supporting museums.
- Ethically, officers should respect artistic freedom and avoid censorship while handling sensitive content under the law.

Asked in real interviews

1. Have you visited art galleries or exhibitions? Have you bought or sold any paintings? **[2024]**
2. Pointing to a painting in the room: is it acrylic or oil? What themes do you paint? **[2024]**

3. What is cubism in art, and whom did cubism inspire? **[2024]**
4. How can traditional fabric arts like Madhubani and Kalamkari be promoted among children? How did you start fabric painting? **[2025]**
5. Which state does Kalamkari belong to? Which region of Andhra is famous for it, and why? **[2025]**
6. Which painter do you like? What is creative journaling? **[2025]**
7. Middlemen take most of the profit in Madhubani painting. What is the situation now and what is the government doing? **[2023]**
8. You do pencil sketching; isn't it just copying? **[2022]**
9. What is the difference between art and science? Is history a science or an art? **[2022]**
10. What is doodling of abstract emotional constructs? Describe a doodle you have done. How can this be used in administration? **[2022]**
11. Who was V.S. Wakankar? Have you visited Bhimbetka? What was the theme of the painting you made? **[2022]**
12. Art is fairly analog: what is the impact of digital media and technology on art? **[2024]**
13. Can you name some of the highest-selling artists from India? **[2024]**
14. Sketching vs drawing? **[2023]**
15. What do you sketch? Major pencils available in India? Any famous cartoonists? **[2024]**
16. Sketch a person who has no description (task by Chairman). **[2024]**
17. Where are contemporary mural arts found? Famous mural art of Delhi? **[2024]**
18. Favourite cartoon? How did you develop cartoon-making as a hobby? Draw us a cartoon; cartoon vs caricature? **[2024]**
19. What is Zentangle art? **[2024]**
20. How did you start fabric painting, at school or later? How can fabric painting and such traditional arts be promoted? **[2025]**
21. What is stipple art? Is it done with a stapler? **[2025]**
22. What is meditative mandala doodling? **[2025]**
23. What is hand lettering? Where did you learn it, and do you still do it? **[2025]**
24. Mandala art: do you do it or are you just interested in it? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Who are the members of the Progressive Artists' Group and what did they change in Indian art?
2. What is the difference between Bengal School and Company School painting?
3. Why do folk artists remain poor even when Indian art fetches record prices at auctions?
4. Can art be taught, or is it innate?
5. Should the State fund art that some people find offensive?
6. As collector, how would you use art to promote a public campaign like voter awareness?
7. Which folk art of your home state would you promote and how?
8. What is the Antiquities and Art Treasures Act and why can't some paintings be exported?

Model answer: Isn't pencil sketching from a photograph just copying?

In part it is practice, and every tradition, from guru-shishya painting to European academies, trained artists by copying masters. But a sketch is never a mechanical copy: the artist chooses what to emphasise, how to shade and what to leave out, which makes it interpretation. Copyright law also recognises an artistic work by its original expression. For me, sketching sharpens observation. As an administrator, the same skill helps me read a site, map a problem visually and communicate schemes through simple drawings, which matters when many citizens respond better to images than to dense text.

Model answer: Madhubani paintings sell for high prices in cities, yet artists earn little. What would you do?

The gap comes from middlemen, weak branding and artists' limited market access. Madhubani has a GI tag and public visibility, such as the saree Padma Shri Dulari Devi gifted the Finance Minister for Budget 2025, but most value is captured downstream. As a district officer I would register artists as authorised GI users, organise them into cooperatives or producer companies, onboard them to GeM and e-commerce, and link them with PM Vishwakarma training and credit. I would also commission local artists for public murals, giving them income and pride while keeping the tradition alive.

Common traps

- Not being able to name the medium, technique or theme of your own work, or to identify oil versus acrylic
- Knowing only Western artists, or only famous names, without Indian movements, folk forms and their regions
- Giving purely aesthetic answers with no link to artisans' livelihoods, heritage law or administration

Preparation checklist

- ☐ Prepare a short portfolio narrative: your medium, five works, themes and influences
- ☐ Revise Indian art history: Bhimbetka, Ajanta, miniatures, Ravi Varma, Bengal School, PAG, Sher-Gil
- ☐ Learn your state's folk art, its GI status, and artisan schemes like PM Vishwakarma and ODOP
- ☐ Know current events: the 2025 Husain and 2026 Ravi Varma auction records, and the Dulari Devi saree
- ☐ Prepare conceptual answers: art versus science, copying versus creativity, art and censorship

HOBBY 6

Photography

Appears in DAFs as: nature/wildlife/bird photography, *street photography*, *mobile photography*, *travel and food photography*. Photography lets the board test technical knowledge, visual storytelling and ethics, and it links naturally to wildlife, privacy, media freedom and deepfakes.

What the board is really testing

- Genuineness: your camera, lenses, settings and the kind of photographs you take
- Knowledge of famous photographers, Indian and global, and their genres
- Grasp of the technical vocabulary: exposure, aperture, bokeh, composition, editing
- Ethical sense on consent, privacy, manipulation and photojournalism
- How visual storytelling and imagery can serve governance and communication

Basics, history and technique

- Joseph Nicéphore Niépce made the earliest surviving photograph (c. 1826-27); the **daguerreotype** was announced in 1839, and 19 August is World Photography Day.
- The **exposure triangle**: aperture (f-number, controls depth of field), shutter speed (motion), and ISO (sensor sensitivity and noise).
- **Bokeh** is the aesthetic quality of out-of-focus blur, produced by wide apertures like f/1.8 and longer focal lengths.
- Bird and wildlife work needs telephoto lenses of about 400-600 mm, fast shutter speeds and continuous autofocus; macro lenses suit insects and flowers.
- Composition rules: rule of thirds, leading lines, framing, golden hour light; RAW files preserve more data for editing than JPEG.

India story and icons

- Lala **Deen Dayal** was court photographer to the Nizam of Hyderabad; **Homai Vyarawalla**, India's first woman photojournalist, received the Padma Vibhushan in 2011.
- **Raghu Rai** (Padma Shri 1972), famed for Bangladesh war and Bhopal gas tragedy images, died on 26 April 2026 aged 83.
- Danish Siddiqui and the Reuters team won Pulitzers (2018, 2022); Siddiqui was killed covering Afghanistan in 2021.
- Other names: Dayanita Singh, Sudharak Olwe (Padma Shri), Raghubir Singh; nature photographers include Sudhir Shivaram, Dhritiman Mukherjee and Sandesh Kadur.
- Global masters: Henri Cartier-Bresson (decisive moment, Magnum founder), Ansel Adams (landscapes), Steve McCurry (Afghan Girl), Sebastião Salgado.

Institutions, policy and law

- Copyright Act, 1957 makes the person taking a photograph its author; protection lasts 60 years from publication.
- Privacy: **Puttaswamy (2017)** recognised privacy as a fundamental right; the DPDP Act, 2023 governs digital personal data, including images.
- Voyeurism is punishable under BNS Section 77 and IT Act Section 66E; photographing prohibited places can attract the Official Secrets Act, 1923.
- Drone Rules, 2021 use the Digital Sky platform with green, yellow and red airspace zones; nano drones under 250 g face lighter rules.
- ASI allows still photography at most protected monuments, with exceptions such as inside the Taj Mahal mausoleum; MIB's Photo Division runs National Photography Awards.

Current developments 2025-26

- MeitY notified **IT Amendment Rules, 2026** on 10 February 2026, effective 20 February, requiring labels and provenance metadata for AI-generated images and faster takedowns.
- Some lawful takedown orders must now be actioned within three hours instead of 36, a big change for viral morphed photos.
- Pune's Rahul Sachdev won a Highly Commended title at the Natural History Museum's **Wildlife Photographer of the Year 2025**.
- The death of Raghu Rai in April 2026 prompted national tributes and renewed discussion of documentary photography's role in democracy.
- Smartphone computational photography and AI editing blur the line between capture and creation, raising authenticity questions for journalism.

Science, economics and social angle

- A camera works like the eye: the lens focuses light on a sensor (CMOS) much as the retina; aperture equals pupil, and dynamic range equals contrast perception.
- **Citizen science** platforms like eBird and iNaturalist use amateurs' photographs to track species distribution and migration.
- Camera traps underpin India's tiger census; the 2022 estimate put India's tigers at about 3,682, around 75% of the world's wild tigers.
- Photography drives tourism, social media and the creator economy, but image manipulation and deepfakes fuel misinformation.
- Street photography raises consent questions: public-space photography is generally legal, but dignity, children and vulnerable people need care.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- **Geo-tagged photographs** verify works under MGNREGA, PMAY-G and Swachh Bharat; officers must also check for reused or fake images.
- Photographic documentation helps in disaster damage assessment, crop-loss surveys, encroachment cases and evidence under BNSS e-procedures.
- Visual storytelling makes campaigns effective; before-and-after images build public trust in development projects.
- Officers must respect privacy of victims, children and patients when sharing images on official handles.
- Ethical rule: do not stage or manipulate images; distinguish documentation from publicity and avoid photo-ops at disaster sites.

Asked in real interviews

1. Explain nature photography. Which camera and lens do you have? Which lens is preferred for bird photography? **[2021]**
2. Tell us about nature photography. Who are some famous nature photographers in India? **[2023]**
3. What type of camera and lens do you use? Is the picture quality good? Do you travel to different places to photograph? **[2023]**
4. Name two famous photographers. Any Indian photographer? What type of photography do they do? **[2020]**
5. Name a famous book on photography. **[2022]**

6. You mention food photography, which does not involve cooking. How do you choose the images to capture? **[2020]**
7. What kind of photography do you like? Questions on Photoshop and editing. **[2019]**
8. You are interested in mobile photography; what is bokeh? **[2019]**
9. What is street photography? **[2019]**
10. You said street photography can tell a story. How can storytelling benefit administration? **[2019]**
11. What is night photography? Do you upload your photos on any platform? **[2024]**
12. What do you think about travelling: is it only for photos, videos and show-off? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. What is the exposure triangle? Explain with an example from your own photographs.
2. Should AI-generated or edited photographs be labelled? What do the 2026 IT Rules say?
3. Is it ethical to photograph people on the street without consent?
4. Who was Raghu Rai and why is he important for Indian photojournalism?
5. How can photography help in wildlife conservation?
6. As collector, how will you stop fake geo-tagged photographs being used to claim scheme payments?
7. What is the difference between a DSLR and a mirrorless camera?
8. Which is your best photograph and what story does it tell?

Model answer: Is it ethical to photograph people in public without their consent?

Legally, photographing people in public is generally allowed, but ethics goes beyond legality. After Puttaswamy, privacy is a fundamental right, and the DPDP Act, 2023 governs digital personal data. In my street photography I avoid capturing people in distress, children or intimate moments without permission, and I ask when a face is the subject. As an administrator I would apply the same principle: official social media must not show victims, patients or children in ways that harm their dignity, and departments should have a clear consent protocol before publishing photographs of beneficiaries.

Model answer: With AI editing and deepfakes, does photography still have documentary value?

It does, but trust must now be earned through verification. Morphed and AI-generated images spread fast, which is why MeitY's IT Amendment Rules, 2026 require labelling and provenance metadata for synthetic content and faster takedowns. A photographer's credibility rests on disclosure: minor corrections are acceptable, adding or removing elements is not. In administration, geo-tagged photographs are used to verify works under MGNREGA and PMAY-G; I would add metadata checks, random field inspections and AI tools to detect reused or manipulated images, so that evidence remains reliable.

Common traps

- Not knowing the make, lens and settings of your own camera, or basic terms like aperture, ISO and bokeh
- Being unable to name Indian photographers beyond one name, or missing major news like

Raghu Rai's death in 2026

• Ignoring ethics and law: consent, privacy, drone rules, protected sites and image manipulation

Preparation checklist

☐ Know your equipment and settings, and be ready to describe three of your best photographs

☐ Revise photography history and key Indian and global photographers with their signature works

☐ Learn the legal framework: Copyright Act, Puttaswamy, DPDP Act, BNS 77, Drone Rules 2021, IT Rules 2026

☐ Follow current news: Wildlife Photographer of the Year, Pulitzer winners and Indian photography awards

☐ Prepare governance links: geo-tagging, citizen science, camera traps and visual IEC campaigns

HOBBY 7

Dance (Classical & Folk)

Appears in DAFs as: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Odissi, Kuchipudi, Mohiniyattam; folk forms such as Ghoomar, Bhangra, Garba, Karakattam. Dance opens questions on Indian culture, gender, caste and heritage policy, so it is a natural bridge from the DAF to GS-I and to ethics.

What the board is really testing

• Training depth: guru, years, repertoire, arangetram or performances, and core grammar (nritta, nritya, natya)

• Cultural literacy: Natyashastra, classical versus folk forms, regional origins and exponents

• Social sensitivity: devadasi history, caste and gender in art, appropriation and inclusion

• Heritage policy: Sangeet Natak Akademi, UNESCO lists, copyright and support schemes for artists

• Discipline and soft power: what dance taught you, and how culture can serve diplomacy and administration

Basics, history and rules

- Bharata Muni's **Natyashastra** codifies rasa, bhava and abhinaya; four abhinayas are angika (body), vachika (speech), aharya (costume) and sattvika (inner state).
- Three elements: **nritta** (pure rhythmic dance), nritya (expressive, with bhava) and natya (drama). Questions often test whether a dancer can succeed with only two.
- Sangeet Natak Akademi recognises eight classical forms: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kathakali, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Sattriya, Manipuri and Mohiniyattam; the Culture Ministry also lists Chhau.
- Kathak gharanas: Lucknow (expressive), Jaipur (rhythmic footwork) and Banaras; Raigarh developed under royal patronage in Chhattisgarh.

- Folk dances are community, seasonal and ritual based (Ghoomar, Bhangra, Garba, Bihu, Lavani, Karakattam) and less codified than classical forms.

India story and icons

- **Rukmini Devi Arundale** founded Kalakshetra (1936) and helped reframe Sadir as Bharatanatyam; E. Krishna Iyer campaigned for its revival.
- Vallathol founded Kerala Kalamandalam (1930) to revive Kathakali and Mohiniyattam; Sattriya, from Srimanta Sankardeva's sattras, gained classical status in 2000.
- Icons: Pandit Birju Maharaj (Kathak, d. 2022), Kelucharan Mohapatra (Odissi), Vempati Chinna Satyam (Kuchipudi), Balasaraswati, Yamini Krishnamurti, Sonal Mansingh, Mallika Sarabhai.
- Uday Shankar fused Indian and Western staging and took Indian dance worldwide in the 1930s.
- Mohiniyattam guru **Kalamandalam Vimala Menon** received the Padma Shri in 2026.

Institutions, policy and law

- Sangeet Natak Akademi (1952) is the national academy; Zonal Cultural Centres promote folk arts; SPIC MACAY takes classical arts to schools.
- Madras Devadasis (Prevention of Dedication) Act 1947 ended temple dedication; Karnataka (1982) and Andhra Pradesh (1988) passed similar laws.
- Copyright Act 1957 treats **choreographic works** as dramatic works, so original choreography can be protected; traditional forms themselves are in the public domain.
- Culture Ministry schemes include the Guru–Shishya Parampara and repertory grants, fellowships for artists, and pension support for veteran artists.
- UNESCO Intangible Heritage entries from India include Chhau, Kalbelia and Mudiyettu (2010), Manipuri Sankirtana (2013), Garba (2023) and Deepavali (2025).

Current developments 2025–26

- In April 2025 the **Natyashastra** and Bhagavad Gita manuscripts were inscribed on UNESCO's Memory of the World Register.
- India hosted UNESCO's 20th Intergovernmental Committee session on intangible heritage at the Red Fort, Delhi (8–13 December 2025).
- **Deepavali** was inscribed at that session, India's 16th element on the UNESCO intangible heritage list.
- Garba of Gujarat, inscribed in December 2023, remains the most recent dance-specific Indian inscription and is often asked in folk-dance contexts.

Science, economics or social angle

- Classical revival had a **caste and gender** cost: hereditary devadasi and isai vellalar artists were displaced as dance moved to upper-caste urban stages.
- Folk forms such as Karakattam carry stigma and low pay, while classical forms gain prestige; this shows how art can reproduce social stratification.
- Dance improves cardiovascular fitness, balance and mental health; dance movement therapy is used for autism, Parkinson's and trauma recovery.
- The cultural and creative economy (festivals, tourism, digital content) offers livelihoods, but most folk artists remain informal workers without social security.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers use folk dance and street theatre for behaviour change: SBM, Beti Bachao, voter awareness (SVEEP) and anti-trafficking campaigns.
- District festivals (Hornbill, Konark, Khajuraho) promote tourism; officers must ensure artists are paid fairly and not reduced to props.
- Ethics: guard against harassment in guru–shishya settings (Kalakshetra case, 2023) by applying POSH Act committees to cultural institutions.
- Cultural diplomacy: ICCR uses dance for soft power; Indian diaspora schools keep forms alive abroad.

Asked in real interviews

1. Bharatanatyam needs three elements. Can a dancer do well with only two of them? **[2021]**
2. Who are the main proponents of Bharatanatyam? **[2021]**
3. Apart from Ghoomar, which dance do you do? When is Ghoomar performed? **[2022]**
4. How is Bhangra different from other classical and folk dances? **[2023]**
5. What type of dance is Bhangra, and what is its history? **[2023]**
6. Why do South Indian states have more classical dance forms? **[2023]**
7. Which form of intellectual property right applies to Kathak? **[2024]**
8. Name some foreign dance forms and their places of origin. **[2024]**
9. What is the social significance of Bharatanatyam and Karakattam? **[2025]**
10. Do these traditional art forms inadvertently reinforce social stratification? **[2025]**
11. You learnt Kathak in school: should it be made compulsory? **[2025]**
12. What is Lasya? Which Kathak gharana do you belong to, and how is Lucknow gharana different from Jaipur? **[2025]**
13. How does dance shape a civil servant? Can you learn empathy through dance? **[2025]**
14. Relevance of Mohiniyattam, Kalaripayattu and Kathakali. **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. What is the difference between nritta, nritya and natya? Demonstrate a mudra.
2. Did the twentieth-century revival of Bharatanatyam erase its devadasi roots?
3. Why is Chhau sometimes called classical and sometimes folk? Who decides classical status?
4. Should the government fund classical arts when folk artists are poorer?
5. What did Natyashastra's inscription on UNESCO's Memory of the World Register mean for India?
6. Is fusion and Bollywood-style dance diluting tradition, or keeping it alive?
7. As DM, how would you use folk dance to promote a welfare scheme in a tribal district?
8. Female students at a dance institution in your district allege harassment by a guru. What will you do?

Model answer: Do classical dance forms reinforce caste hierarchy?

Historically, partly yes. Bharatanatyam came from Sadir, performed by devadasi communities. After the Madras Devadasis Act of 1947, the form was reframed by largely upper-caste practitioners, and many hereditary artists lost both livelihood and credit. Folk forms such as Karakattam still carry stigma. But art also democratises: today dancers from every background train and perform. As an officer I would make cultural funding inclusive, document hereditary artists' contributions, and include folk and Dalit art forms in district festivals on equal terms, so heritage honours all its makers.

Model answer: What has dance taught you that will help you as a civil servant?

Dance taught me discipline and patience: years of practising adavus before I could perform a full item. It also taught me empathy, because abhinaya means expressing someone else's emotion convincingly, which is close to understanding citizens' problems from their side. The Natyashastra speaks of rasa, the shared experience between performer and audience, and governance also depends on that connection. Practically, I would use folk dance and street theatre for awareness campaigns, as has been done for sanitation and voter turnout, because people respond to their own cultural idiom far more than to pamphlets.

Common traps

- Naming a classical form without being able to explain its grammar, gharana or bani, guru, or a basic item from its repertoire.
- Romanticising tradition while ignoring devadasi history, caste and gender questions, which boards often raise.
- Getting counts wrong (eight SNA classical forms versus nine with Chhau, India's UNESCO intangible heritage elements) or confusing folk and classical forms.

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare a two-minute self-introduction on your training: guru, years, repertoire, performances and the item you would demonstrate.

☐ Revise Natyashastra concepts: rasa, bhava, abhinaya types, nritta/nritya/natya, tandava and lasya, key mudras.

☐ Make a state-wise table of eight classical forms and twenty folk dances, with origins, exponents and costumes.

☐ Know heritage institutions and lists: SNA, Zonal Cultural Centres, UNESCO intangible heritage (including Garba 2023 and Deepavali 2025) and Memory of the World 2025.

☐ Prepare balanced views on devadasi history, appropriation, copyright in choreography and welfare for folk artists.

PART II

Sports, Fitness and Adventure

Team sports, racket sports, chess, athletics, swimming, yoga, fitness, trekking

HOBBY 8

Cricket

Appears in DAFs as: playing cricket, watching cricket, following IPL/Test cricket, captaining college team. Cricket is India's most-followed sport, so boards use it to test whether a candidate can move from scores and stars to money, law, gender, diplomacy and governance.

What the board is really testing

- Whether the candidate genuinely follows the game (recent results, records, roles) or listed it as filler
- Ability to extract leadership and teamwork lessons and link them to administration
- Balanced views on money, equal pay, BCCI autonomy and the cricket-versus-other-sports gap
- Awareness of legal and civic angles: liability, crowd safety, betting and gaming law
- Composure and honesty when a fact is unknown

Basics, history and rules

- Codified in England; MCC (founded 1787) remains the **custodian of the Laws of Cricket**, while the ICC (est. 1909, HQ Dubai) runs international cricket.
- Three formats: Test (5 days, red ball; pink ball for day-night Tests), ODI (50 overs, white ball) and T20 (20 overs); World Test Championship links bilateral Tests.
- Key rules: LBW, no-ball and free hit, DRS with ball-tracking, impact-player rule in IPL; an illegal bowling action ('chucking') means straightening the elbow beyond **15 degrees**.
- Team roles: openers, middle order, finisher, all-rounders, wicketkeeper; sides usually carry 2-3 all-rounders in white-ball cricket to balance batting depth and bowling options.
- Adaptive forms: blind cricket (B1-B3 sight categories, audible ball), wheelchair and deaf cricket; India's blind men's team has won multiple T20 World Cups.

India story and icons

- **1983 World Cup win** under Kapil Dev at Lord's was the watershed that turned cricket into a mass passion; 2011 ODI and 2007 T20 titles under Dhoni consolidated it.
- India women won their **maiden ODI World Cup** on 2 November 2025, beating South Africa by 52 runs at DY Patil Stadium, Navi Mumbai, under Harmanpreet Kaur.
- India men won the T20 World Cup 2026 on home soil, beating New Zealand by 96 runs in the final (8 March 2026), retaining the 2024 title.
- Records boards like: Tendulkar's 100 international centuries, Kohli's 50+ ODI centuries, Rohit's ODI 264; Vaibhav Suryavanshi became the youngest IPL centurion at 14 in 2025.
- Captaincy styles: Ganguly built an aggressive overseas-winning side, Dhoni was calm and process-driven, Kohli fitness- and intensity-driven; compare by context, not ranking alone.

Institutions, policy and law

- BCCI is a society registered under the Tamil Nadu Societies Registration Act; **Zee Telefilms v Union of India (2005)**: not 'State' under Article 12 but amenable to writs under Article 226.
- BCCI v Cricket Association of Bihar (2015) and the **Lodha Committee** reforms (2016) brought tenure limits, cooling-off, one-state-one-vote and conflict-of-interest rules, later diluted in 2022.
- National Sports Governance Act 2025 (assent 18 August 2025) creates a National Sports Board and National Sports Tribunal; RTI applies only to bodies receiving government aid, so BCCI stays outside RTI.
- Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act 2025 banned real-money games; Dream11 exited the jersey deal and **Apollo Tyres** became Team India's lead sponsor till 2027; challenges are pending in the Supreme Court.
- Spot-fixing and betting: no dedicated central anti-match-fixing law; the Law Commission (2018) recommended regulating betting; BCCI has an Anti-Corruption Unit.
- Liability if a struck ball kills a spectator: civil negligence turns on foreseeability (Bolton v Stone, 1951); criminally, causing death by negligence is Section 106 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Current developments 2025–26

- India won the 2025 Champions Trophy, the 2025 women's ODI World Cup and the 2026 men's T20 World Cup, co-hosted by India and Sri Lanka.
- Bangladesh refused to play its T20 World Cup 2026 games in India and sought Sri Lankan venues; the ICC refused and replaced Bangladesh with **Scotland** (January 2026).
- Royal Challengers Bengaluru won IPL 2026, beating Gujarat Titans by 5 wickets at Ahmedabad on 31 May 2026, a second straight title after 2025.
- Cricket returns to the Olympics at **LA28**: six-team men's and women's T20 events at a purpose-built venue in Pomona; qualification pathway confirmed 29 June 2026.
- Australia won the Women's T20 World Cup 2026, beating hosts England by 7 wickets at Lord's on 5 July 2026.
- Mithun Manhas was elected BCCI president in September 2025; BCCI's Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru (opened 2024) replaced the old National Cricket Academy.

Science, economics or social angle

- IPL media rights for 2023–27 sold for about **Rs 48,390 crore**, making the IPL one of the costliest leagues per match in the world.
- Equal match fees for India men and women were announced in October 2022; retainers and central contracts still differ sharply, so pay equity remains partial.
- Science: swing depends on seam position and air flow, reverse swing on an old, rough ball; ball-tracking and Snickometer have reshaped umpiring.
- Social reach: the Women's Premier League (from 2023) and the 2025 World Cup win changed girls' participation; but cricket's dominance crowds out funding and sponsors for other sports.
- Associates' rise (Afghanistan, USA, Nepal) shows cricket as soft power and a social glue in conflict-hit societies.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District officers use cricket tournaments for drug-awareness, voter-awareness (SVEEP) and community policing; inclusive formats such as blind and women's cricket build social capital.

- Crowd management lessons: the June 2025 Bengaluru stampede at RCB's victory celebration showed the need for SOPs, permissions, ticketing control and inter-agency coordination.
- **Team versus group**: a team shares a common goal and complementary roles; this maps directly onto district task forces and inter-departmental convergence.
- Ethical issues: fixing, conflict of interest, surrogate advertising, gaming sponsorships, and overcrowded schedules versus player welfare.
- India–Pakistan: government policy since 2025 allows matches only in multilateral events, not bilateral series; an officer should state this policy neutrally.

Asked in real interviews

1. Why was 2 November 2025 a notable day for Indian cricket? **[2025]**
2. Which cricketer inspires you most and why? How can an aggressive player like Kohli be called calm? **[2025]**
3. Name one past and one current player who stayed composed under pressure. **[2025]**
4. Should men and women cricketers get equal pay? **[2023, 2025]**
5. Should there be a balance between money in cricket and the game itself? What is BCCI's Centre of Excellence? **[2025]**
6. What position do you play? How many all-rounders should a side have in ODI, T20 and Tests, and how many did India play in its last ODI? **[2025]**
7. If a ball you hit leaves the ground and kills a passer-by, who is liable? **[2025]**
8. What did you learn from organising a cricket tournament for visually impaired women? **[2025]**
9. Who is the youngest Indian ODI centurion? Any other young record-setter, including domestic cricket, and roughly how old is he? **[2025]**
10. Which cricket record do you think is hardest to break? **[2025]**
11. Why did Bangladesh want its matches moved to Sri Lanka and refuse to play in India? **[2025]**
12. What is adaptive cricket? **[2025]**
13. Compare T20 cricket with Swiggy. **[2025]**
14. Why is Afghanistan a successful cricket nation despite its domestic turmoil? **[2024]**
15. What life lessons has cricket taught you, especially as a captain? **[2023]**
16. Do you watch cricket or movies during exam time? **[2023]**
17. What types of balls are used in cricket? Is the red ball no longer used, and when is the pink ball used? **[2023]**
18. Rank Kapil Dev, Ganguly, Dhoni and Kohli by impact on Indian cricket; compare captaincy of Tendulkar, Dhoni and Kohli. **[2023]**
19. BCCI is a private body and cricket thrives; should other sports bodies be privatised too? **[2023]**
20. Who is a chucker? What role do psychologists play in cricket? **[2023]**
21. What watershed moment made cricket popular in India? Why can't football be promoted the same way? **[2022]**
22. Is it justified that cricketers, footballers and film stars earn so much more than doctors and engineers? **[2022]**
23. Should India play cricket with Pakistan? Why? **[2022]**
24. Your DAF lists a cricket team: how is a team different from a group? **[2021]**
25. Why is cricket more popular than other sports in India, and what has government done to promote sports? **[2021]**

26. You watch cricket; do you play too? Is IPL a commercial business and Virat Kohli its best employee? **[2024]**
27. Do you watch cricket? T20 vs Test: three merits and demerits. Why has IPL done well? **[2024]**
28. Is women's cricket just a copy of men's cricket? **[2024]**
29. Why is Kohli weak outside the off stump? **[2024]**
30. What did captaincy teach you? Sehwag's contribution to Indian cricket? Who will win IPL? **[2024]**
31. Why red ball in Tests and white in T20? Your view on cricketers taking wives on tours? **[2024]**
32. Cricket team in DAF: difference between a team and a group? **[2021]**
33. You have played cricket: batsman or bowler? What values do sports teach? **[2019]**
34. You played for IIT Madras: which format do you like? Why do Tests end in three days now? What is Bazball? **[2025]**
35. You play cricket: what quality does a cricketer need most? **[2025]**
36. You have played cricket: why does Gujarat produce cricketers but not other athletes? **[2025]**
37. Your opinion on variable match fees for players? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Who won the 2026 IPL and the 2026 T20 World Cup, and what made those teams succeed?
2. Should BCCI be brought under RTI now that the National Sports Governance Act 2025 is law?
3. Is the ban on real-money gaming fair to fantasy-sports firms that funded Indian cricket?
4. Does cricket's inclusion in LA28 help or hurt other Indian Olympic sports?
5. As DM, a victory parade is announced at short notice in your city. How will you manage it?
6. Your district has one stadium: cricket academies want it, but athletes need a track. How will you decide?
7. What did the 2025 women's World Cup win change for girls' sport in small towns?
8. Name the Lodha Committee's key recommendations. Which ones survived?

Model answer: BCCI is rich and successful as an autonomous private body. Should other federations be privatised the same way?

I would separate autonomy from privatisation. BCCI succeeded because it built a commercial product early, but even it needed the Lodha reforms after the 2013 spot-fixing scandal, so autonomy without accountability fails. Most federations depend on public stadiums and TOPS funding, so full privatisation could neglect athletes in poorer regions. The National Sports Governance Act 2025 offers a middle path: professional, athlete-represented bodies under a National Sports Board and Tribunal. As an administrator I would push federations towards private partnerships for leagues and sponsorship, while keeping transparent elections, safeguarding policies and public audit of government money.

Model answer: If a ball you hit kills a passer-by, who is liable?

Liability depends on foreseeability and reasonable care. In Bolton v Stone (1951), the club was not held negligent because balls rarely cleared the fence, but a ground that regularly sends balls onto a road would be. Criminally, causing death by a rash or negligent act falls under Section 106 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, though a batter playing a normal shot inside a permitted ground usually lacks criminal negligence. Organisers and the ground owner share civil duty through netting, boundaries and signage. As an officer I would make safety netting and insurance conditions for permits for public grounds next to roads.

Common traps

- Quoting outdated facts: calling India 2024 T20 champions only, missing the 2026 title, or naming the wrong BCCI president
- Turning answers into fan commentary on favourite stars, with no governance, economic or ethical angle
- Taking a one-sided line on India–Pakistan matches or equal pay instead of giving policy plus a balanced view

Preparation checklist

☐ Make a one-page results sheet for 2024–26: ICC events (men and women), IPL and WPL winners, major records and current captains

☐ Read the Lodha reforms, Zee v Union of India, the National Sports Governance Act 2025 and the Online Gaming Act 2025

☐ Prepare three personal stories (captaincy, a loss, organising a match) with a clear lesson for administration

☐ Learn the rules boards like: LBW, DRS, ball types, chucking (15 degrees), the impact player and adaptive cricket categories

☐ Prepare balanced 60-second views on equal pay, cricket versus other sports, betting regulation, LA28 and India–Pakistan policy

HOBBY 9

Football

Appears in DAFs as: playing football, watching EPL/ISL, football analysis, virtual football management. Football is the world's game but India's underperformer, so boards use it to probe governance failure, sports economics and grassroots development.

What the board is really testing

- Whether the candidate can explain why Indian football lags despite mass popularity
- Awareness of AIFF governance, the ISL crisis and Supreme Court intervention
- Views on money in sport: EPL wealth, player pay, club ownership and sustainability
- Leadership and inclusion on the field, such as playing with juniors without bullying

- Ability to propose practical grassroots and district-level solutions

Basics, history and rules

- Modern rules were codified by England's Football Association in 1863; the **IFAB** (1886) still makes the Laws of the Game, while FIFA (founded 1904, Paris) governs worldwide.
- Eleven a side, 90 minutes plus stoppage time, offside law, VAR since the 2018 World Cup, and five substitutions now standard.
- Shared ground with cricket: team formation, set pieces, and data analytics on expected goals (xG) and pitch maps; differences lie in continuous play and fewer stoppages.
- Confederations: AFC for Asia (India's body), UEFA for Europe, CONMEBOL for South America; the World Cup expanded to **48 teams** from 2026.
- Women's football: FIFA Women's World Cup since 1991; India hosted the U-17 Women's World Cup in 2022 after the men's U-17 in 2017.

India story and icons

- Golden era under coach **Syed Abdul Rahim**: Asian Games golds in 1951 and 1962 and fourth place at the 1956 Melbourne Olympics.
- India qualified for the 1950 World Cup but did not travel, owing to travel costs, AIFF priorities and lack of preparation; the barefoot story is largely a myth.
- The **Durand Cup** (1888) is among the world's oldest club tournaments; Bengal, Goa, Kerala, Manipur and Mizoram are traditional football heartlands.
- Sunil Chhetri, India's record scorer with 90-plus international goals, retired in 2024 and returned in March 2025; Gurpreet Singh Sandhu is the long-serving goalkeeper.
- Khalid Jamil was appointed in August 2025 as the first Indian head coach of the men's team in 13 years.

Institutions, policy and law

- **AIFF** (founded 1937) is the national federation; FIFA suspended it in August 2022 for third-party influence, lifting the ban after about 11 days once elections were held.
- Supreme Court final judgment on the AIFF constitution (19 September 2025): eminent players on the General Body and Executive Committee, a 70-year age cap and mandatory promotion-relegation.
- The SC ruled AIFF may delegate commercial rights (as to FSDL) but not governance powers, and any constitutional amendment needs court approval.
- National Sports Governance Act 2025 and National Sports Policy 2025 (Khelo Bharat Niti) set governance norms and a grassroots-to-podium approach for federations including AIFF.
- Khelo India and the FIFA Football for Schools programme support school football; sport is a **State subject** (Entry 33, State List).

Current developments 2025–26

- **Spain won the 2026 FIFA World Cup**, beating Argentina 1-0 after extra time (Ferran Torres, 106') at New York New Jersey Stadium on 19 July 2026.
- ISL crisis: the AIFF–FSDL master rights agreement expired without a new partner; the 2025–26 season ran as a shortened single-leg league from 14 February to 21 May 2026.

- East Bengal won the 2025–26 ISL on the final day, their first top-flight league title in 22 years.
- Club distress: City Football Group sold its Mumbai City stake, Kerala Blasters were put up for sale, and Tata-owned **Jamshedpur FC** said in August 2026 it would leave the ISL.
- India fell to 142nd in the FIFA rankings after a 0-1 loss to Bangladesh, missed the 2027 AFC Asian Cup, and stood 138th in June 2026.
- Messi's 'GOAT Tour' (December 2025) ended in chaos at Kolkata's Salt Lake Stadium; the organiser was arrested, exposing gaps in event licensing and crowd control.

Science, economics or social angle

- The Premier League's global broadcast revenue makes even mid-table clubs richer than most leagues; parachute payments and squad-cost rules try to curb unequal spending.
- High player pay reflects global audiences and short careers, not social worth; a fairer comparison is with other entertainers rather than with doctors.
- Sports science: GPS vests, recovery and load management; heat stress at the 2026 World Cup revived debate over playing in high temperatures.
- Football as social inclusion: slum-soccer models, girls' leagues in Jharkhand and Manipur, and the game as an identity marker in the North-East and Kerala.
- Indian football's weak economics: low broadcast value, a short league season and few grassroots academies, so clubs depend on corporate patrons.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Districts can revive local leagues, upgrade school grounds through MGNREGA and CSR convergence, and partner with clubs for scouting under Khelo India.
- Using football for youth engagement in Left Wing Extremism and border areas, for example police-run tournaments in tribal districts.
- Ethics on the pitch: fair play, respecting referees, and inclusive play with juniors and girls rather than dominance.
- Governance issues: conflict of interest in federations, age fraud in youth football, and match-fixing in lower leagues.
- Event management: the Messi tour chaos and stadium stampedes show why ticket audits, capacity limits and SOPs are administrative duties.

Asked in real interviews

1. You say you analyse football: do you only do analysis and not watch it? **[2022]**
2. Who is the greatest footballer of all time? **[2022]**
3. Is it justified that footballers, cricketers and film stars earn huge sums? Should there be parity with doctors and engineers? **[2022]**
4. What do cricket and football have in common? Can any cricket rules be applied to football? **[2022]**
5. What is wrong with the All India Football Federation? Is its administration poor? **[2022]**
6. Why is Indian football in a poor state, why can't it be promoted like cricket, and what recent initiatives exist? **[2022]**
7. Tell us about your online virtual football management tournaments. Do you play football in real life? **[2022]**
8. The English Premier League is flush with money. What is your view, and does money matter? **[2022]**

9. Your state is famous for wrestling, so why did you take up football and badminton? **[2023]**
10. Do you follow only Indian football? **[2024]**
11. Name the top three international footballers playing today, and the most prominent current Indian footballer. **[2024]**
12. What steps would you take to improve Indian football? **[2024]**
13. Whom do you play football with? Might younger players feel bullied? **[2025]**
14. What was the recent issue involving the AIFF, and what are its implications for Indian football? **[2025]**
15. You play football: which team and player do you follow? Why has Real Madrid been so successful? **[2024]**
16. Lessons from Barcelona's economic crisis management for public administration? **[2024]**
17. Favourite football club? Status of Barcelona in Europe? **[2019]**
18. Has ISL succeeded in uplifting Indian football? Why not? **[2021]**
19. Applications of football in administration? Do you watch it for interest or something else? **[2025]**
20. You play online football-management tournaments: elaborate. Do you play football in real life? **[2022]**

Expected questions

1. Who won the 2026 World Cup? What explains Spain's success model?
2. Why did the ISL lose its commercial partner, and what is the new club-led model?
3. What did the Supreme Court change in AIFF's constitution in 2025?
4. Jamshedpur FC is quitting the ISL. Should government step in to save clubs?
5. India is 1.4 billion people yet ranked below 130. Give three structural reasons.
6. As DM of a football-loving district in Kerala or Manipur, how would you build a talent pipeline?
7. A celebrity football event in your district turns chaotic. Who is accountable, and what will you do?
8. Is the 48-team World Cup good for football or only for FIFA's revenue?

Model answer: Why has Indian football failed to grow like cricket despite huge popularity?

I think the problem is structural, not cultural. Cricket had a 1983 moment, television money and a strong BCCI; football lost its 1950s base and never built a grassroots league pyramid. AIFF's governance crises, including the 2022 FIFA suspension and the expiry of the ISL commercial deal in 2025, left clubs dependent on a few corporate patrons. India is now ranked below 130. The Supreme Court's 2025 order mandating promotion-relegation and player representation is a start. Administratively, I would build district leagues, use school grounds after hours, and link Khelo India centres to clubs for scouting.

Model answer: The Premier League is flush with money while Indian clubs shut down. What does this teach us?

Money follows audiences and good governance. The Premier League sells broadcast rights globally and shares revenue fairly evenly, so even small clubs survive; Indian clubs rely on owners because media value is low and the season was cut to a single leg in 2025–26. Jamshedpur FC's planned exit in 2026 shows how fragile this model is. The lesson is a stable calendar, transparent rights tenders and a youth-development pipeline that creates players and fans together. As an officer I would support community ownership and local sponsors so clubs become civic institutions, not corporate projects.

Common traps

- Repeating the 'India refused the 1950 World Cup for lack of boots' myth as fact
- Not knowing the 2025–26 AIFF–ISL crisis, the Supreme Court constitution ruling or India's current FIFA ranking
- Answering GOAT or club-loyalty questions with fan emotion instead of reasons and data

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare a timeline of AIFF events: 2022 FIFA suspension, the 2025 SC judgment, the FSDL deal expiry, the 2025–26 ISL and 2026 club exits

☐ Memorise the 2026 World Cup facts: hosts, format, champion, final score and award winners

☐ Know India's football history: 1951 and 1962 golds, 1956 Olympics, Rahim, Chhetri, the current coach and ranking

☐ Prepare a five-point district plan for grassroots football using Khelo India, schools, CSR and local leagues

☐ Form balanced views on player pay, EPL wealth, franchise leagues and promotion-relegation

HOBBY 10

Hockey

Appears in DAFs as: playing field hockey (school/college/state), following Indian hockey, HIL. Hockey carries India's richest Olympic legacy and a live revival story, letting boards test pride, realism about decline and revival, and sports governance in one go.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you track Indian hockey beyond nostalgia: recent Olympic, World Cup and Asian Games results
- Your ability to explain decline and revival causally (astroturf, infrastructure, Odisha model, leagues)
- Team spirit, leadership and handling defeat, drawn from your own playing experience
- Views on cricket's dominance and how a district officer can widen the sports base
- Awareness of sports governance reform: National Sports Governance Act 2025, Khelo Bharat

Niti 2025

Basics, history and rules

- Modern field hockey codified in 19th-century England; global body **FIH** (founded 1924, headquartered in Lausanne). Played 11-a-side on synthetic turf, four 15-minute quarters.
- Key rules: only flat side of stick, ball played into circle for a valid goal, penalty corners and strokes; green, yellow and red cards for suspensions.
- Shift from grass to **astroturf** (Olympics, Montreal 1976) favoured fitness, speed and well-funded European teams, eroding Indian dribbling-based advantage.
- Hockey is not officially India's 'national game': the Sports Ministry has stated in RTI replies that no sport is declared national game.
- India has 8 Olympic golds (1928–1956 six in a row, 1964, 1980) and the 1975 World Cup (Kuala Lumpur).

India story and icons

- **Major Dhyan Chand**: three Olympic golds (1928, 1932, 1936); his birthday, 29 August, is National Sports Day; India's top sports award bears his name.
- Balbir Singh Sr scored five goals in the 1952 Olympic final, still a record; Dhanraj Pillay and Dilip Tirkey anchored the lean 1990s–2000s.
- Tokyo 2020 men's bronze ended a 41-year Olympic medal drought; Paris 2024 bronze (beat Spain 2–1) gave back-to-back medals for the first time since 1968–72.
- PR Sreejesh retired after Paris 2024; Harmanpreet Singh leads the men; women's team finished 4th at Tokyo, its best Olympic finish.
- Tribal belt of Odisha and Jharkhand (Sundargarh, Simdega) is the nursery of Indian hockey, producing many internationals.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Hockey India** is the recognised federation (replaced the Indian Hockey Federation, 2009); president Dilip Tirkey. Funding via Sports Ministry TOPS and Khelo India.
- Odisha has sponsored national men's and women's teams since 2018; in June 2024 the sponsorship was extended to 2036.
- Odisha hosted the 2018 and 2023 men's World Cups; Birsa Munda stadium, Rourkela is among the largest hockey stadiums globally.
- **National Sports Governance Act 2025**: National Sports Board recognises federations, National Sports Tribunal settles disputes; key provisions in force from 1 January 2026, rules notified May 2026.
- **Khelo Bharat Niti 2025** replaced the 2001 policy with five pillars, targeting a top-five Olympic finish and a 2036 Olympic bid.

Current developments 2025–26

- Hockey India League revived (Dec 2024–Feb 2025) with a first women's edition: Rarh Bengal Tigers (men) and Odisha Warriors (women) won.
- Men won the Asia Cup at Rajgir, Bihar (beat Korea 4–1, September 2025), securing a direct 2026 World Cup berth.

- 2026 World Cup (Belgium–Netherlands, August): men finished 8th, women 5th, women's best finish in 52 years; Germany and Argentina won.
- Asian Games 2026, Aichi-Nagoya: men retained gold (beat Malaysia 5–1), women won gold beating China 1–0, ending a 44-year wait; both qualified for **LA 2028**.
- Hockey was dropped from the pared-down Glasgow 2026 Commonwealth Games programme, removing a traditional Indian medal source.

Science, economics or social angle

- Synthetic turf costs crores and needs watering; scarcity of turfs outside a few states limits rural talent pipelines.
- Sports science, video analysis and foreign coaches (e.g. Australian and Dutch) helped India's fitness-led revival after 2010.
- Hockey offers social mobility for Adivasi youth; Sundargarh model shows sport as a tool against marginalisation and Left-Wing Extremism influence.
- Leagues (HIL) create salaries, broadcast exposure and foreign-player exposure, but sustained sponsorship is the test.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A DM can use DMF and CSR funds for turfs, district academies and Khelo India centres, as Odisha's Sundargarh did.
- Selection transparency, age fraud and federation disputes are governance risks; the 2025 Act's tribunal and athlete representation aim to correct them.
- Team sport teaches collective responsibility and role clarity, directly transferable to leading a district team.
- Olympic bid for 2036 requires legacy planning so stadiums do not become white elephants, an ethical use of public money issue.

Asked in real interviews

1. Why did India do well in hockey at this (Tokyo) Olympics? **[2020]**
2. What is the future of hockey in India? **[2020]**
3. What was the Indian hockey team's performance in the recent Olympics? **[2021]**
4. Why does India lag in Olympic medals and what can be done to improve the tally? **[2021]**
5. Why should other sports be promoted instead of focusing only on cricket, where funding is better? **[2021]**
6. What is the benefit of playing a sport other than fitness? **[2021]**
7. Why the setback for India in the Hockey World Cup? **[2022]**
8. Team sport versus individual sport, followed by a discussion on hockey and cricket. **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Indian women won Asian Games gold in 2026 after 44 years. What changed?
2. Is Odisha's sponsorship of Indian hockey a model other states should copy, or a misuse of state funds?
3. Why did India finish only 8th at the 2026 World Cup despite Olympic medals?
4. Hockey is not officially the national game. Should India declare one?
5. As DM of a tribal district, how would you build a hockey pipeline?
6. How does the National Sports Governance Act 2025 change federations like Hockey India?

7. What did playing hockey teach you about leadership under pressure?
8. Glasgow 2026 dropped hockey. How should India respond while bidding for CWG 2030 and Olympics 2036?

Model answer: Why did Indian hockey decline after 1980, and is the revival sustainable?

I see the decline as structural. The move to astroturf from 1976 rewarded fitness, speed and money, and India had few turfs and outdated coaching. The revival came from fixing that: modern coaching, sports science, and Odisha's sponsorship since 2018, now extended to 2036. Results show it: Olympic bronzes in Tokyo and Paris and double Asian Games gold in 2026. But the 8th place at the 2026 World Cup shows we are not yet elite. For sustainability, administrators must spread turfs to districts beyond Odisha and Punjab, and run the revived Hockey India League consistently so youngsters see a career.

Model answer: Should the state spend scarce funds on sport when health and education need money?

I think sport is itself a public good, not a luxury. It improves health, keeps youth engaged and gives marginalised communities mobility; Sundargarh's tribal hockey players are an example. Khelo Bharat Niti 2025 recognises sport for social and economic development. Still, spending must be accountable. As an officer I would prefer many low-cost district facilities over a few showpiece stadiums, use DMF and CSR funds, and track outcomes such as participation and talent identified. The 2036 Olympic bid must avoid white elephants. Balanced this way, sport complements health and education rather than competing with them.

Common traps

- Calling hockey India's official national game without the RTI caveat
- Quoting only Dhyan Chand-era glory and missing 2024–26 results (Paris bronze, 2026 Asian Games doubles, World Cup 8th and 5th)
- Claiming to play hockey but not knowing basic rules such as quarters, penalty corners, cards or your own playing position

Preparation checklist

☐ Memorise India's Olympic hockey record: 8 golds plus 1968, 1972, 2020 and 2024 bronzes

☐ Revise 2025–26 results: HIL winners, Asia Cup Rajgir, World Cup 2026 finishes, Asian Games 2026 golds

☐ Read the National Sports Governance Act 2025 and Khelo Bharat Niti 2025 summaries

☐ Prepare a district-level plan for a hockey pipeline (turf, coaches, schools, DMF/CSR)

☐ Prepare two personal stories from your playing days on teamwork and handling defeat

HOBBY 11

Kabaddi

Appears in DAFs as: playing kabaddi (school/college/district), following Pro Kabaddi League. Kabaddi is a rural, indigenous sport turned commercial success, so boards use it to test cultural roots, character lessons and sports-federation governance.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you understand kabaddi's indigenous roots and regional variants, not just PKL
- What the sport taught you about courage, teamwork and decision-making under a single breath
- Your awareness of India's international standing and the challenge from Iran
- Understanding of federation governance problems (AKFI administrator, IKF suspension, Supreme Court)
- Ability to link traditional games to Khelo Bharat Niti, rural youth and the sports economy

Basics, history and rules

- Contact team sport of Indian origin; seven players per side on court, raider must chant 'kabaddi' (cant) in one breath while tagging defenders and returning.
- Key terms: baulk line, bonus line, **super tackle** (fewer than four defenders stop raider), all out (bonus points), do-or-die raid in PKL.
- Origins claimed in ancient Tamil Nadu (sadugudu), with legends linking it to Krishna; Abhimanyu's chakravyuha is a popular analogy.
- Variants: Sanjeevani (revival rule, basis of modern rules), Gaminee, Amar, and Punjabi circle-style kabaddi on a round pitch.
- Shown as a demonstration sport at the 1936 Berlin Olympics; part of the Asian Games since Beijing 1990.

India story and icons

- India won all seven men's Asian Games golds 1990–2014; in 2018 men took bronze after losing to Iran, ending dominance.
- India regained men's and women's gold at Hangzhou 2022 (held 2023) and retained both at Aichi-Nagoya 2026, beating Iran 40–34 and 37–34.
- Women won the Kabaddi World Cup in Dhaka (November 2025), beating Chinese Taipei 35–28 for back-to-back titles.
- Icons include Anup Kumar, Ajay Thakur, Pardeep Narwal and Pawan Sehrawat; Arjun Deshwal starred in the 2026 Asian Games final.

Institutions, policy and law

- **AKFI** (Amateur Kabaddi Federation of India, founded 1973) governs the sport; internationally the International Kabaddi Federation (IKF) and Asian Kabaddi Federation.
- Delhi High Court appointed Justice (Retd) S.P. Garg as AKFI administrator; IKF suspended AKFI in July 2024 for lacking an elected body.

- Supreme Court (February 2025) directed handover to the body elected in December 2023 so players could compete in the Asian Championship.
- AKFI elections held at Ranchi in June 2026; Punit Balan elected unopposed as president for 2026–30.
- National Sports Governance Act 2025 requires federations to be recognised by the National Sports Board and run ethical, transparent elections.

Current developments 2025–26

- **PKL Season 12** (2025): Dabang Delhi KC beat Puneri Paltan 31–28 in the final, their second title.
- Indian women retained the Kabaddi World Cup in Dhaka, November 2025.
- Asian Games 2026: India swept both kabaddi golds, beating Iran in both finals on 26 September 2026.
- Federation governance normalised with June 2026 AKFI elections after the administrator period and IKF suspension.

Science, economics or social angle

- Needs no equipment, only a mat or mud court, making it ideal for rural and low-income youth participation.
- **Pro Kabaddi League** (from July 2014, eight franchises) professionalised the sport: mats, TV-friendly rules, player salaries and celebrity owners.
- Fitness profile: explosive power, breath control, agility; high injury risk to knees and shoulders needs sports-medicine support.
- Iran's rise shows how foreign coaching and PKL exposure globalised an Indian game, an example of Indian soft power.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Traditional games revival is a pillar of Khelo Bharat Niti 2025; an officer can run village kabaddi leagues to engage youth and reduce drug use.
- AKFI dispute shows how politicised federations hurt athletes, a case for transparent governance and athlete representation.
- Kabaddi teaches tackling as a unit and knowing when to retreat, transferable to crisis management and team leadership.
- Age fraud and doping in grassroots tournaments require verification and awareness by district sports officers.

Asked in real interviews

1. What have you learnt from playing kabaddi? (with counter-questions) **[2023]**
2. Where do we stand as a nation in kabaddi? **[2023]**
3. How does kabaddi contribute to character development? **[2024]**
4. What is Budhia kabaddi and how is it different from normal kabaddi? **[2021]**
5. You play kabaddi; why are sports other than cricket not very popular in India and how can this be overcome? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. Iran has challenged India's dominance. What lessons should Indian kabaddi learn?

2. Has Pro Kabaddi League helped or hurt the traditional game?
3. Why was AKFI suspended by the international federation, and what does it say about sports governance?
4. Should kabaddi be pushed for Olympic inclusion? What are the hurdles?
5. As a district collector, how would you use kabaddi to engage rural youth?
6. Explain the super tackle and do-or-die raid rules.
7. Kabaddi is often called a game of breath and courage. How has it shaped your decision-making?
8. How do the regional variants of kabaddi reflect India's cultural diversity?

Model answer: What does the AKFI controversy tell you about sports governance in India?

It shows how administrative disputes punish athletes. AKFI was run by a court-appointed administrator and the international federation suspended it in July 2024 because there was no elected body. In February 2025 the Supreme Court had to intervene so our players could compete in the Asian Championship. Elections were finally held in June 2026. The lesson is that federations need transparent elections, athlete voices and timely dispute resolution. The National Sports Governance Act 2025, with its Sports Board and Tribunal, is meant to do that. As an officer, I would insist on clear selection criteria and grievance systems even at district level.

Model answer: Has Pro Kabaddi League commercialised and diluted an indigenous game?

I feel PKL has mostly helped. Since 2014 it has given rural players salaries, fitness support and national recognition, and India's consistent Asian Games golds, including both titles in 2026, show the talent pool has deepened. Rule changes such as the do-or-die raid made it television-friendly without losing the essence. The risk is that only the mat-based Pro format survives while variants like circle-style or Sanjeevani fade. So I would balance it: let the league grow, but use Khelo Bharat Niti's focus on traditional games to run village and school tournaments in local formats. That preserves heritage while widening opportunity.

Common traps

- Knowing only PKL teams and stars but not basic rules, variants or Asian Games history
- Saying India has never lost in kabaddi; the 2018 Asian Games loss to Iran is well known
- Speaking about rural sports without any concrete governance or policy idea

Preparation checklist

☐ Revise rules: court size, cant, baulk and bonus lines, super tackle, all out, do-or-die raid

☐ Know India's Asian Games record from 1990 to 2026 and the 2025 Women's World Cup result

☐ Read up on the AKFI administrator period, IKF suspension, the February 2025 Supreme Court order and June 2026 elections

☐ Learn regional variants (Sanjeevani, Gaminee, Amar, circle style) and your home state's local form

☐ Prepare two personal anecdotes on courage and teamwork from matches you played

HOBBY 12

Badminton

Appears in DAFs as: playing badminton, following BWF tour, PV Sindhu/Satwik-Chirag fan. Badminton is India's most successful Olympic racquet sport and an everyday neighbourhood game, so boards test both technical knowledge and sports-infrastructure thinking.

What the board is really testing

- Technical command: court dimensions, shuttle making, service and in/out rules, scoring
- Up-to-date knowledge of Indian players, results and controversies such as India Open 2026
- Thinking on sports infrastructure, rural access and getting children to play
- Ethical sensitivity, for instance animal welfare in feather shuttles
- Ability to connect the hobby with India's hosting ambitions (2030 Commonwealth Games, 2036 Olympic bid)

Basics, history and rules

- Developed by British officers in Poona (Pune) as 'Poona' in the 1870s; named after the Duke of Beaufort's **Badminton House**; BWF (founded 1934 as IBF) is based in Kuala Lumpur.
- Court 13.40 m x 6.10 m (44 x 20 ft), singles width 5.18 m (17 ft); **net** 1.55 m (5 ft 1 in) at posts, 1.524 m (5 ft) at centre.
- Service boxes: singles is long and narrow, doubles is short and wide (the back service line sits 0.76 m inside the baseline); a shuttle landing on a line is **in**.
- A shuttle has **16 feathers**, traditionally from the left wing of a goose or duck, set in a cork base and weighing 4.74–5.50 g; feathers give a stable, decelerating flight.
- Scoring: currently best of three games to 21, rally-point; BWF members approved a switch to **3x15** in April 2026, effective January 2027 (capped at 21).
- Courts use sprung wooden floors with synthetic mats for shock absorption, grip and joint safety; concrete raises injury risk and gives an uneven bounce for footwork.

India story and icons

- **Prakash Padukone** won the All England in 1980 and Pullela Gopichand in 2001; Gopichand's Hyderabad academy produced Saina and Sindhu.
- Saina Nehwal won India's first Olympic badminton medal (bronze, London 2012); **PV Sindhu** won silver at Rio 2016 and bronze at Tokyo 2020, losing the Tokyo semi-final to Tai Tzu-ying.
- Styles: Sindhu is tall and attack-first, using reach and steep smashes; Saina relied on retrieving, defence, consistency and footwork.
- India won the **Thomas Cup in 2022** in Bangkok, beating 14-time champions Indonesia 3-0 in the final; Lakshya Sen, Kidambi Srikanth, HS Prannoy and Satwik-Chirag starred.
- Satwiksairaj Rankireddy set a Guinness record for the fastest badminton hit, **565 km/h** (2023), beating Tan Boon Heong's 493 km/h; Satwik-Chirag later became world No. 1.
- Lakshya Sen finished fourth at Paris 2024 and won the Australian Open in November 2025.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Badminton Association of India (BAI)**, founded 1934, is the national federation; India Open is a BWF World Tour Super 750 event in New Delhi.
- TOPS (2014) funds elite players; Khelo India (2017–18) builds grassroots infrastructure and runs Youth, University and Para Games with badminton as a core sport.
- National Sports Governance Act 2025: federation recognition by a National Sports Board, a National Sports Tribunal for disputes, and Safe Sport and athlete-representation rules for BAI.
- National Sports Policy 2025 (Khelo Bharat Niti) and India's hosting push: Ahmedabad will host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, and India is bidding for the 2036 Olympics.
- Sport is a State subject; State sports authorities and SAI centres run most public indoor halls.

Current developments 2025–26

- India Open 2026 controversy: players flagged AQI, bird droppings halting a Prannoy match, a monkey in the stands and cleanliness; Anders Antonsen withdrew and was fined $5,000.
- BAI rejected the claims, while BWF said hygiene and animal control 'required attention' but cleared Delhi's Indira Gandhi Stadium for the August 2026 World Championships.
- BWF World Championships 2026, New Delhi (first in India since Hyderabad 2009): India's only medal was a women's doubles bronze for **Treesa Jolly–Gayatri Gopichand**.
- Thomas & Uber Cup 2026 (Horsens, Denmark): India's men won bronze, losing the semi-final to France; China won the Thomas Cup and South Korea the Uber Cup.
- BWF approved the **3x15 scoring system** on 25 April 2026, to apply from 4 January 2027, the biggest rule change since 21-point rally scoring in 2006.

Science, economics or social angle

- Physics: the shuttle is a high-drag projectile; a smash leaves the racquet very fast but loses speed quickly, and feathers flip it cork-first for stability.
- Feather versus plastic: feather shuttles leave the racquet faster and decelerate more sharply with truer flight; plastic (nylon) shuttles are cheaper, more durable and favoured for recreation.
- Animal welfare: feather supply depends on the goose and duck meat industry and bird-flu outbreaks have caused shortages; synthetic-feather shuttles are being tested.
- Urban middle-class growth: indoor courts, low equipment cost and a short game time suit cities; rural players lack halls, coaching and leisure time.
- Health: an aerobic and agility sport that improves cardiovascular fitness and reaction time, which is why it suits a Fit India push.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Multipurpose indoor halls under Khelo India or MPLADS can serve badminton, kabaddi and table tennis, which is cheaper than single-sport stadiums.
- A woman officer's priorities: safe, well-lit halls, women coaches, separate changing rooms and Safe Sport complaint mechanisms against harassment.
- Hosting credibility: venue hygiene, AQI planning and animal control are administrative tasks; India Open 2026 shows how lapses affect the 2036 Olympic bid narrative.
- Getting children to play: school inter-house leagues, subsidised shuttles, weekend coaching camps and visible local champions.

- Ethics: fair line calls, respect for opponents, anti-doping (NADA), and rejecting age fraud in junior events.

Asked in real interviews

1. Which badminton players are performing well currently? **[2024]**
2. What would you do to get children interested in badminton? **[2024]**
3. What is needed to upgrade badminton infrastructure? **[2024]**
4. Why do rural people rarely take up sports while the urban middle class does? **[2024]**
5. Why are badminton courts made of wood and not concrete? **[2024]**
6. As a woman officer, what would you prioritise in sports infrastructure? **[2024]**
7. What recent issue arose at the India Open? **[2025]**
8. Why can India host international cricket tournaments but struggle with a badminton one, and how does this affect its 2036 Olympic bid? **[2025]**
9. Why are shuttlecocks made of bird feathers: which birds, how many feathers, and is there an animal-rights concern? **[2023, 2025]**
10. Why are feathered shuttles still preferred in international tournaments? **[2025]**
11. Explain the side and back boxes on a badminton court. When is a shuttle in or out? **[2025]**
12. Which badminton player do you admire most and why? How does PV Sindhu's style differ from Saina Nehwal's? **[2025]**
13. Give the dimensions of a badminton court and the net height in feet. **[2022]**
14. Tell us about the Khelo India scheme. **[2022]**
15. Tell us about badminton. What were India's sporting achievements last year? **[2023]**
16. Who won the Thomas Cup, and who were the team members? **[2023]**
17. What was the fastest smash in that competition, who hit it, and what was the previous record? **[2023]**
18. Which travels faster, a feather shuttlecock or a plastic one? **[2023]**
19. Your state is known for wrestling, so why did you take up football and badminton? **[2023]**
20. Why did PV Sindhu lose in the semi-final? **[2020]**
21. Earlier India had good badminton players; why is it not producing similar players now? **[2024]**
22. If you are DM and an SDM beats you at badminton, how will you feel? **[2024]**
23. Which bird's feathers are used in shuttles? Why are feather shuttles still preferred internationally? **[2025]**
24. Difference between squash and badminton? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the new 3x15 scoring system? Will it help or hurt Indian players?
2. How did India perform at the 2026 World Championships in New Delhi?
3. Who are India's current top singles and doubles players, and what are their recent results?
4. As DM, a sports hall in your district is in poor shape before a national event. Your 10-day plan?
5. Should India host the 2036 Olympics when it struggles to run the India Open smoothly?
6. Why do Andhra Pradesh and Telangana produce so many badminton champions?
7. Should feather shuttles be banned on animal-welfare grounds?
8. How would you promote badminton among girls in rural areas?

Model answer: The India Open 2026 drew complaints about hygiene and pollution. How does this affect India's 2036 Olympic ambitions?

I see it as an early warning, not a verdict. Players flagged bird droppings, a monkey and Delhi's AQI; BAI disputed some claims, while BWF said hygiene needed attention yet cleared the venue for the 2026 World Championships. Olympic hosting is judged on such details. India has hosted cricket well because private bodies with deep resources run it, while public venues suffer from fragmented maintenance. As an administrator I would set venue-readiness audits, pest and bird control contracts, AQI-linked scheduling and a single nodal officer for each event, so that accountability is clear before the international spotlight arrives.

Model answer: Shuttlecocks use goose feathers. Is this ethically defensible?

It is a fair concern. A shuttle uses 16 feathers, traditionally from the left wing of a goose or duck, and supply comes largely from the poultry meat industry, so birds are not usually killed for shuttles, though welfare and bird-flu shortages remain issues. Feather shuttles are preferred at elite level because their flight is truer and decelerates consistently. I would support research into synthetic-feather shuttles and their use in schools and recreation, where cost and durability matter more. As an officer I would supply nylon shuttles for public courts, reducing cost and demand for feathers at the same time.

Common traps

- Getting court or net measurements wrong, or confusing singles and doubles service areas
- Still describing the 21-point system as permanent, unaware of the 2026 decision to move to 3x15 in 2027
- Naming only Saina and Sindhu and missing Satwik-Chirag, Lakshya Sen, Treesa-Gayatri and the 2026 results

Preparation checklist

☐ Memorise court, net and shuttle specifications in metres and feet, plus service and in/out rules

☐ Make a results card for 2022–26: 2022 Thomas Cup, Olympics 2012–2024, 2026 Thomas Cup bronze, 2026 Worlds bronze

☐ Read up on the India Open 2026 controversy and the BAI and BWF responses; prepare a hosting-readiness answer

☐ Learn the schemes: Khelo India, TOPS, Fit India, National Sports Policy 2025 and the National Sports Governance Act 2025

☐ Prepare views on feather ethics, rural access, girls' participation and the new 3x15 scoring

HOBBY 13

Table Tennis

Appears in DAFs as: playing table tennis / TT (school, college, state level), following UTT and WTT. Table tennis combines physics, diplomacy history and an Indian sport on the rise, so boards test both factual precision and analytical depth.

What the board is really testing

- Precision on equipment and rules (ball weight, net height, spin) that only a genuine player knows
- Understanding of why India lags behind China, Japan and Korea, and what can change
- Knowledge of sports diplomacy, especially the 1971 ping-pong diplomacy
- Your concentration, reflexes and composure under pressure as an individual sportsperson
- Awareness of Indian icons, recent results and federation governance

Basics, history and rules

- Originated in Victorian England as after-dinner parlour game; ITTF (now with WTT for pro events) governs globally; Olympic sport since Seoul 1988.
- Table 2.74 m by 1.525 m, 76 cm high; net 15.25 cm high; ball **40 mm, 2.7 g**, plastic since 2014 replacing celluloid.
- Games to 11 points since 2001 (earlier 21); serve rotates every two points; ball must be tossed at least 16 cm on service.
- Rubbers create spin; the ball curves through the **Magnus effect**, so a TT ball does 'swing' or dip depending on topspin or backspin.
- Speed glue banned from 2008 for health reasons; ball size raised from 38 mm to 40 mm in 2000 to slow rallies for spectators.

India story and icons

- **Sharath Kamal**: five Olympics (2004–2024), 13 Commonwealth medals including 7 golds, Paris 2024 flag-bearer; retired at WTT Star Contender Chennai, March 2025.
- Manika Batra: 2018 CWG women's singles gold; at Paris 2024 she became the first Indian to reach an Olympic singles round of 16.
- Paris 2024: Indian women's team reached its first-ever Olympic quarterfinal by beating fourth seed Romania 3–2.
- Asian Games: 2018 men's team bronze and Sharath–Manika mixed doubles bronze; 2026 mixed doubles bronze by Diya Chitale and Manush Shah.
- Rising names: Sreeja Akula, Manav Thakkar, Manush Shah, Diya Chitale, Ayhika and Sutirtha Mukherjee.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Table Tennis Federation of India** (TTFI) governs the sport; Delhi High Court suspended it and appointed a Committee of Administrators in February 2022.
- The trigger was Manika Batra's match-fixing allegation against the national coach; elections in December 2022 ended the CoA, with Meghna Ahlawat as president.

- National Sports Governance Act 2025 makes federation recognition, ethics codes, safe-sport policy and athlete commissions mandatory.
- TOPS funds elite paddlers' foreign training and coaches; Khelo India centres support grassroots TT.

Current developments 2025–26

- Sharath Kamal retired in March 2025 at WTT Star Contender Chennai, closing a two-decade era.
- Ultimate Table Tennis Season 6 (June 2025): U Mumba TT won their first title, beating Jaipur Patriots 8–4.
- Asian Games 2026: India's only TT medal was mixed doubles bronze (Diya Chitale–Manush Shah).
- Table tennis was dropped from the Glasgow 2026 Commonwealth Games, removing India's traditional TT medal haul.

Science, economics or social angle

- Reaction times under 0.2 seconds; sport trains hand-eye coordination, anticipation and cognitive speed, and is used in ageing and Parkinson's therapy research.
- Low cost and indoor play make it ideal for schools, offices and dense cities; China's mass school base explains its dominance.
- **Ping-pong diplomacy** (1971): after Nagoya World Championships, the US team visited China, paving way for Nixon's 1972 visit.
- Leagues like UTT give Indian players exposure to world-class foreign players and professional income.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Federation selection disputes show the need for transparent, merit-based criteria and athlete grievance redressal.
- Officers can place TT tables in schools, panchayat halls and police lines cheaply, widening participation.
- Sports diplomacy can use TT-like soft events to ease ties, a lesson for foreign-service aspirants.
- Individual sport teaches self-accountability and rapid adjustment, relevant to field decisions under pressure.

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the height of a table tennis net? **[2020]**
2. Name some table tennis players and Olympians. **[2020]**
3. What is the weight of a table tennis ball? **[2021]**
4. Who is the men's national champion in table tennis? **[2021]**
5. Can a table tennis ball swing? Explain the mechanism. **[2021]**
6. What was ping-pong diplomacy? **[2021]**
7. Why did you not choose sports as a career? **[2021]**
8. Why are Indian table tennis players not able to progress at the international level? (with follow-ups) **[2023]**

Expected questions

1. Why does China dominate table tennis, and what can India learn?
2. Explain topspin and backspin using physics.
3. Who are India's leading players after Sharath Kamal's retirement?
4. Glasgow 2026 dropped table tennis. Is the Commonwealth Games losing relevance?
5. Is sports diplomacy like ping-pong diplomacy possible between India and a neighbour?
6. What does the Manika Batra case say about athlete rights in federations?
7. How would you promote table tennis in government schools of your district?
8. Why was the ball size increased to 40 mm and games reduced to 11 points?

Model answer: Why have Indian paddlers struggled internationally, and is that changing?

I see three reasons. First, a narrow base: China builds from mass school participation, while Indian TT is concentrated in a few cities. Second, limited exposure to elite sparring and coaching. Third, federation disputes, which once even reached the Delhi High Court. It is changing: the women's team reached its first Olympic quarterfinal at Paris 2024 and Ultimate Table Tennis brings foreign players to India. But the single bronze at the 2026 Asian Games shows the gap remains. As an officer I would push cheap tables in schools and district leagues to widen the base, since excellence follows participation.

Model answer: What is ping-pong diplomacy, and is sport an effective diplomatic tool?

In 1971, after the World Championships in Nagoya, the US table tennis team was invited to China. That gesture softened decades of hostility and helped pave the way for President Nixon's 1972 visit. I believe sport works as a confidence-building measure because it creates people-to-people contact without political cost. But it cannot substitute for political will; India–Pakistan cricket shows sport can be held hostage to tensions. For India, hosting events like the Commonwealth Games in 2030 and an Olympic bid for 2036 can build soft power if delivered transparently. As a diplomat I would use sport as an opener, not the solution.

Common traps

- Getting basic specifications wrong (ball weight 2.7 g, diameter 40 mm, net 15.25 cm)
- Saying Sharath Kamal is still active; he retired in March 2025
- Explaining ping-pong diplomacy as India–China rather than US–China

Preparation checklist

☐ Memorise equipment and rule specifications and the reasons behind major rule changes
☐ Revise the physics of spin (Magnus effect) in simple words
☐ Know India's medal history at Olympics, Asian Games and CWG, and Paris 2024 firsts
☐ Track current national champions and UTT winners before your interview
☐ Read the TTFI governance disputes and the National Sports Governance Act 2025 provisions

HOBBY 14

Chess

Appears in DAFs as: playing chess, online chess (rapid/blitz), following world championship. India is now a chess superpower, so boards test whether the candidate knows the boom (Gukesh, Vaishali, Tamil Nadu) and can link strategic thinking to administration.

What the board is really testing

- Whether the candidate knows their own rating, the Elo system and the format basics
- Awareness of India's chess boom and the reasons behind Tamil Nadu's dominance
- Translating chess skills (planning, patience, calculation) into governance qualities without arrogance
- Mathematical and cultural trivia: the wheat-and-chessboard problem, origin in chaturanga, Go and xiangqi
- Humility, especially on questions like 'Are you among the most intelligent people?'

Basics, history and rules

- Originated in Gupta-era India as **chaturanga** (about 6th century CE), spread via Persia (shatranj) to Europe; FIDE was founded in Paris in 1924 and is now led by Arkady Dvorkovich.
- Time controls: classical (typically 90 minutes plus a 30-second increment, or longer), rapid (10–60 minutes) and blitz (under 10 minutes); Freestyle (Chess960) randomises the back rank.
- The **Elo system**, devised by physicist Arpad Elo and adopted by FIDE in 1970, predicts results from rating differences; a 400-point gap implies about a 91% expected score.
- Titles: Grandmaster needs three GM norms plus a 2500 rating; top GMs rate 2700–2800-plus, and Magnus Carlsen holds the record peak of 2882.
- Wheat-and-chessboard problem: doubling over 64 squares gives **2^64 − 1** grains, about 1.8 x 10^19, a classic lesson in exponential growth.
- Contrast: Go (weiqi) is about territory and has vastly more positions; xiangqi (Chinese chess) has a river, cannons and a confined general.

India story and icons

- **Viswanathan Anand** became India's first GM (1988) and five-time world champion; his success built the Chennai chess culture.
- **D Gukesh** became the youngest undisputed world champion at 18, beating Ding Liren in Singapore in December 2024.
- Divya Deshmukh won the FIDE Women's World Cup (Batumi, July 2025), beating Koneru Humpy, and became India's 88th GM.
- **R Vaishali** won the 2026 Women's Candidates and will challenge Ju Wenjun; her brother Praggnanandhaa and coach RB Ramesh are part of the same Chennai ecosystem.
- Aswath S became India's 98th GM in July 2026; Tamil Nadu has 38 of them, the largest share by state.
- India won double gold at the 2024 Budapest Olympiad and silver (open) and bronze (women) at Samarkand 2026, retaining the Gaprindashvili Trophy for best overall nation.

Institutions, policy and law

- The **All India Chess Federation (AICF)** is the national body; India hosted the 2022 Chess Olympiad at Mamallapuram, organised by Tamil Nadu, and the FIDE World Cup 2025 in Goa.
- Tamil Nadu's ecosystem: early clubs and coaches since the Anand era, school chess, state-backed tournaments, and players supported by corporate sponsors and the WestBridge Anand Chess Academy.
- Chess counts as a sport under the Sports Ministry; top players get TOPS-type support and awards such as the Khel Ratna (Gukesh, 2024).
- National Sports Governance Act 2025 applies to AICF: athlete representation, ethics and safe-sport policy and dispute resolution through the National Sports Tribunal.
- Fair-play issues: online cheating via engines; FIDE and platforms use statistical anti-cheating tools, and over-the-board events use scanners and broadcast delays.

Current developments 2025–26

- Uzbekistan's **Javokhir Sindarov** won the FIDE World Cup in Goa (2025) and the 2026 Candidates, earning a title match against Gukesh.
- World Championship 2026: Gukesh vs Sindarov, 24 November – 12 December 2026, at Fondation Martin Bodmer, Cologny near Geneva.
- Women's World Championship 2026: Vaishali, winner of the April 2026 Women's Candidates, challenges China's Ju Wenjun.
- 46th Chess Olympiad, Samarkand (ended 27 September 2026): Uzbekistan won the open and China the women's; India took open silver and women's bronze.
- India's GM count reached 98 by July 2026 and is nearing 100; India has several 2700-plus players including Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi and Praggnanandhaa.

Science, economics or social angle

- Cognitive science: chess trains working memory, pattern recognition and planning; evidence on wider transfer to school grades is mixed, so claims should be modest.
- AI: IBM's Deep Blue beat Kasparov in 1997, and AlphaZero (2017) learned by self-play; engines are now training partners, raising questions on cheating and creativity.
- Economics: online platforms, streaming and franchise leagues (Global Chess League) have created livelihoods beyond prize money; the cost of a chessboard is low, so it is democratic.
- Gender: separate women's titles and events persist; Divya and Vaishali show rising women's participation but the gender gap at the top remains wide.
- Social uses: chess in prisons, for elderly cognitive health and in schools; Kerala's Marottichal village is known for near-universal chess playing.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Strategic thinking: calculating consequences several moves ahead mirrors policy design, risk assessment and anticipating second-order effects.
- **Should civil servants learn chess?** It is useful for patience and decision-making under time pressure, but administration also needs empathy, consultation and field sense, which chess does not teach.
- Officers can use chess for school engagement (as in the Tamil Nadu and Kerala models), de-addiction camps and prison reform programmes at low cost.

- Ethics: fair play, accepting defeat (resigning gracefully), and anti-cheating integrity parallel probity in public office.
- Avoid elitism: being good at chess does not mean being 'most intelligent'; multiple intelligences and humility matter in public service.

Asked in real interviews

1. What qualities has chess helped you develop to improve yourself? **[2025]**
2. Chess is called the most intelligent game. Do you consider yourself among the most intelligent people? **[2025]**
3. What skills or qualities does playing chess help develop? **[2025]**
4. Why does Tamil Nadu produce so many chess Grandmasters? **[2025]**
5. Is chess just a board game for you, or more? Should civil servants be required to learn chess? **[2025]**
6. What is your chess rating? What are the Elo ratings of Grandmasters? **[2024]**
7. What have you learnt from chess for life? **[2024]**
8. You play chess; have you watched The Queen's Gambit? **[2024]**
9. One grain of wheat on the first square, doubling on each square: how much wheat across all 64 squares? **[2022]**
10. How does the approach in chess differ from a Chinese board game the member named? **[2022]**
11. Do you still play chess? What is rapid chess, how does it differ from classical, and what is the time control? **[2022]**
12. What is the Elo rating system, why and how are ratings assigned, and who was Elo? **[2021]**
13. India is doing well in chess; what significant events happened in the last year? Who has qualified for the Candidates? **[2023]**
14. Recent national awards went to R Vaishali and coach R B Ramesh; follow-up on a related player's nickname. **[2023]**
15. Why is India doing well in IT, chess, cricket, billiards and financial services? **[2023]**
16. Have you watched Searching for Bobby Fischer? What has chess taught you? How many moves can you calculate mentally? **[2024]**
17. Difference between rapid and blitz chess? **[2024]**
18. You play online chess: heard of Joshua Waitzkin? How did you learn? Which piece combination is more advantageous? **[2024]**
19. Your chess rating? What do you learn from chess in life? **[2024]**
20. Why is chess becoming popular in India? Is there a link between chess and mathematics? **[2024]**
21. How many GMs does India have? Who was the youngest FIDE-rated player recently? **[2024]**
22. How did you start chess? Your last competition? Do you know Xiangqi? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Gukesh defends his title against Sindarov in November 2026. What are his chances, and why?
2. Why is Uzbekistan suddenly a chess power, and what can India learn from it?
3. How has AI changed chess, and is it good or bad for the game?
4. Should chess be taught compulsorily in government schools?
5. Women play in separate chess events; is that fair in a mind sport?
6. As DM, how would you use chess to engage youth in a district with a drug-abuse problem?

7. Online cheating is rising. How should fair play be policed?
8. Explain exponential growth with the chessboard, and link it to a policy problem such as population or compounding debt.

Model answer: Why does Tamil Nadu produce so many Grandmasters?

It is an ecosystem effect rather than a genetic or cultural mystery. Anand's success from 1988 created role models and coaches in Chennai; clubs, school chess and dense tournaments gave children rated games early; and families and sponsors invested. Tamil Nadu now has 38 of India's 98 GMs. The state also backed events such as the 2022 Chess Olympiad at Mamallapuram, which fuelled interest further. Administratively, the lesson is replicable: a low-cost sport grows when schools, coaches, regular tournaments and recognition are combined. I would copy this through district chess leagues and teacher-coaches in government schools.

Model answer: Chess is called the most intelligent game. Are you among the most intelligent people?

Respectfully, no. Chess trains one kind of intelligence: calculation, pattern recognition and patience. Even world champions like Gukesh credit work ethic and psychology more than raw genius. Administration needs other intelligences too: emotional intelligence to listen to a grieving family, social intelligence to build consensus, and practical wisdom in the field. Chess has taught me to think about the consequences of a move and to accept defeat gracefully, which I value. As an officer I would see chess as a tool for disciplined decision-making, not as proof of being superior to anyone.

Common traps

- Not knowing your own rating, or claiming a rating or title you cannot back up
- Outdated facts: missing Gukesh vs Sindarov 2026, Vaishali's Candidates win or the current GM count
- Over-claiming: implying chess makes you smarter or a better administrator than others

Preparation checklist

☐ Know your own FIDE/online rating, preferred openings and one memorable game you can describe

☐ Learn Elo basics, time controls, title requirements and the wheat-and-chessboard calculation

☐ Make a 2024–26 timeline: Gukesh's title, Divya's World Cup, Goa World Cup, 2026 Candidates, Samarkand Olympiad, GM count

☐ Prepare the Tamil Nadu ecosystem answer and a district plan for school chess

☐ Prepare humble, balanced answers linking chess to administration, AI, gender and fair play

HOBBY 15

Athletics (Track and Field)

Appears in DAFs as: sprinting, middle/long-distance running, endurance running, marathons, jumps, throws, school/university athletics. Athletics is India's most visible Olympic success story after Neeraj Chopra, yet it is also its biggest doping and infrastructure headache, so it opens straight into sports policy.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you actually train: your event, personal best and the current Indian record for it
- Whether you can explain why India underperforms in sport beyond 'funding and infrastructure'
- Your grasp of sports governance: SAI, AFI, Khelo India, TOPS, the National Sports Governance Act 2025
- Your ethical stance on doping, age fraud and the cricket-versus-other-sports imbalance
- Discipline, resilience and mental health lessons you can carry into administration

Basics, history and rules

- **World Athletics** (founded 1912 as IAAF, renamed 2019, HQ Monaco) governs track, field, combined events, road running, race walking and cross-country.
- Track: sprints (100/200/400m), middle distance (800/1500m), long distance (5000/10,000m), hurdles, 3000m steeplechase and relays; field: four jumps and four throws.
- **Marathon** is 42.195 km, the distance fixed after the 1908 London Olympics; 'endurance running' is a broader term covering half-marathons, ultras and long-distance training.
- Combined events: decathlon (men, 10 events) and heptathlon (women, 7); scoring uses points tables, not placings.
- A false start is a reaction under 0.100 s after the gun; one false start means disqualification under current rules.
- Wind over +2.0 m/s makes sprint and horizontal-jump marks ineligible for records.

India story and icons

- **Milkha Singh** won 200m and 400m gold at the 1958 Asian Games and was fourth in the 400m at Rome 1960.
- **P.T. Usha** finished fourth in the 400m hurdles at Los Angeles 1984 by 1/100th of a second; she later became IOA president.
- Anju Bobby George won long-jump bronze at the 2003 World Championships in Paris, India's first World Championships medal.
- **Neeraj Chopra**: Olympic javelin gold at Tokyo 2020 (87.58m), world title in Budapest 2023, Olympic silver at Paris 2024.
- Neeraj broke the 90m barrier with **90.23m** at the Doha Diamond League on 16 May 2025, a national record.
- In distance running and steeplechase, Avinash Sable, Parul Chaudhary and Gulveer Singh have pushed Indian standards towards world level.

Institutions, policy and law

- The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) is the national federation; the **Sports Authority of India** (SAI, 1984) runs centres, coaching and athlete support.
- Khelo India scouts and funds grassroots talent; the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS, 2014) funds elite athletes' training, coaching and foreign exposure.
- The **National Sports Governance Act 2025** created a National Sports Board to recognise federations and a National Sports Tribunal for disputes; it partly came into force on 1 January 2026.
- Under the Act, federation executive committees have an age band of 25 to 70 (75 in exceptions), office-bearer term limits, at least four women and athlete representation.
- Recognised federations are treated as public authorities under the RTI Act, which supports transparency in selections and funding.
- The National Anti-Doping Act 2022 gave NADA a statutory basis and set up a disciplinary panel and an appeal panel.

Current developments 2025–26

- At the Tokyo 2025 World Championships India won no medals: **Sachin Yadav** placed fourth with a personal best of 86.27m and Neeraj Chopra was eighth (84.03m).
- Keshorn Walcott won the Tokyo 2025 javelin gold (88.16m). Sarvesh Kushare finished sixth (2.28m), the first Indian man in a world high-jump final.
- **Animesh Kujur** took the 100m national record to 10.18s in Greece (July 2025) and then to 10.15s in Ranchi (May 2026). He also holds the 200m record (20.32s).
- 2025 national records: Gulveer Singh 10,000m 27:00.22; Parul Chaudhary steeplechase 9:12.46 at the Asian Championships in Gumi; Mohammed Afsal 800m 1:44.93.
- WADA's 2024 testing report (reported December 2025): India had 260 adverse findings from 7,113 samples, a **3.6% positivity rate**, the highest among countries running at least 5,000 tests.

Science, economics or social angle

- Sprinters depend on **fast-twitch fibres** and the anaerobic system; distance runners depend on VO2 max, lactate threshold and running economy.
- City running comfort depends on air quality, heat and humidity, traffic, footpath availability, green cover and elevation, so a Bengaluru-versus-Thiruvananthapuram question is really about urban planning.
- Altitude training (for example at Ooty or abroad) raises haemoglobin levels; East African distance dominance reflects altitude, a running culture and economic incentive.
- India's sports economy is skewed towards cricket's media rights; athletics depends mainly on state funding, PSU jobs and armed-forces recruitment.
- Running is a cheap, mass-participation activity: city marathons, parkruns and school sports days improve public health and build social capital.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A District Collector can revive district stadiums and synthetic tracks and run talent hunts through Khelo India centres and school games.
- Doping and **age fraud** call for awareness drives in akharas and hostels, honest age verification and protection for whistle-blowers.

- Girls' participation needs safe transport, toilets, women coaches and safeguarding policies against harassment.
- City marathons need multi-department coordination (police, health, municipal bodies): a template for event management and disaster preparedness.
- Officer wellbeing: regular running helps with stress management and decision-making, and is a visible example for police and staff fitness.

Asked in real interviews

1. You seem athletic. What is your favourite sprint event, what is your best timing, and what is the Indian best at present? **[2024]**
2. As an athlete, why is India lagging in sports, and what can be done to promote sports other than cricket? **[2024]**
3. What explains the bias towards cricket over other sports, and how would you tackle it? **[2024]**
4. Are funding and infrastructure the only things lacking in sports promotion? **[2024]**
5. Running is your hobby. How does it affect mental health? What is the longest distance you have run, and your timing? **[2024]**
6. Name a famous Indian 200m runner of the past. **[2025]**
7. What does endurance running mean, and how long do you usually run? **[2025]**
8. Running feels hard in Bengaluru but soothing in Thiruvananthapuram. What could be the reason? **[2025]**
9. Give two similarities between you as a marathon runner and Sunita Williams. **[2024]**
10. What is the difference between endurance running and a marathon? **[2019]**
11. Why 10,000 steps a day? What is the history behind it? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. What is the current national record in your event, and who holds it?
2. India won no medal at the Tokyo 2025 World Championships despite Neeraj Chopra. What does that tell you about our athletics pipeline?
3. India tops WADA's doping list. As a District Magistrate, what would you do about doping in local akharas and academies?
4. What does the National Sports Governance Act 2025 change for a federation like the AFI?
5. Your DAF says you ran at university level. How would you use running to improve fitness in your district police force?
6. Should India bid for the Olympics when its athletics base is still narrow?
7. A promising tribal girl sprinter in your district has no spikes, no track and is about to drop out of school. What will you do?

Model answer: Is lack of funding the real reason India underperforms in athletics?

I don't think funding alone explains it. TOPS and Khelo India have raised spending, and in 2025 we got national records from Animesh Kujur, Gulveer Singh and Parul Chaudhary, yet India won no medal at the Tokyo 2025 World Championships. The deeper gaps are a thin school-sports base, too few qualified coaches, poor sports-science support, weak federation governance and a doping culture: WADA's 2024 report put our positivity rate at 3.6%. As an administrator I would start at the district level, with functional school tracks, coach-to-athlete ratios, nutrition support and clean-sport education, because a medal pipeline depends on a wide base.

Model answer: Why does running feel easier in some cities than in others? What can a city administrator do about it?

As a runner I feel the difference mostly through air and space. Particulate pollution and heat cut performance and raise health risks, and traffic and broken footpaths make running unsafe. A coastal city with green cover and lower traffic density can feel much easier. Elevation and humidity matter too. As an administrator I would treat runnability as an indicator of urban liveability: shaded walkable footpaths, running loops in parks, morning traffic restrictions on some stretches, AQI alerts for outdoor events and safe lighting for women. A city that is good for runners is usually healthier and more inclusive for everyone.

Common traps

- Not knowing your own personal best, or the current national record in your event, when the board can check it
- Blaming only money and infrastructure for India's sports problems while ignoring governance, coaching, school sport and doping
- Giving old records as current. For example, the 100m record moved from 10.18s to 10.15s in May 2026

Preparation checklist

☐ Write down your event, best timing, the current Indian record and the world record, and check the Indian records on AFI or World Athletics a day before the interview

☐ Revise Neeraj Chopra's timeline, the Tokyo 2025 World Championships results and the 2025–26 national records

☐ Prepare a two-minute note on the National Sports Governance Act 2025, TOPS, Khelo India, NADA and the WADA 2024 doping data

☐ Check the latest 2026 results (Glasgow Commonwealth Games, Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games) from official sites before the interview

☐ Prepare one district-level action plan for sports promotion and one answer on running and mental health

HOBBY 16

Swimming

Appears in DAFs as: swimming (recreational/competitive), open-water swimming, lifesaving. Swimming is India's most visible Olympic gap and a public-safety issue, so boards probe technique, India's under-performance and drowning prevention.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you genuinely swim: strokes, timings, training routine
- Your analysis of why India wins few swimming medals and what would fix it
- Awareness of public-health links: drowning prevention and water-borne infections
- Individual versus team sport mindset and healthy sportsmanship

- Ability to connect the hobby to disaster management and district administration

Basics, history and rules

- Four competitive strokes: freestyle, backstroke, breaststroke, butterfly; individual medley order is butterfly, backstroke, breaststroke, freestyle.
- Olympic pool is 50 m with 10 lanes; global body **World Aquatics** (renamed from FINA in December 2022).
- Synchronised swimming was renamed **artistic swimming** in 2017; it is judged on execution and artistry, unlike timed racing; men entered the Olympic team event at Paris 2024.
- Open-water marathon swimming (10 km) joined the Olympics in 2008; English Channel crossing is the classic test.
- Michael Phelps is the most decorated Olympian: 28 medals, 23 of them gold.

India story and icons

- **Mihir Sen** became the first Asian to swim the English Channel (1958); Arati Saha the first Asian woman (1959).
- **Murlikant Petkar** won India's first Paralympic gold, 50 m freestyle at Heidelberg 1972; he received the Arjuna Award for lifetime achievement in January 2025.
- Khazan Singh won 1986 Asian Games silver in 200 m butterfly; Sajan Prakash and Srihari Nataraj made Olympic 'A' qualification for Tokyo 2020.
- Paris 2024: India sent only two swimmers, Srihari Nataraj and 14-year-old Dhinidhi Desinghu, on universality places.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Swimming Federation of India** (SFI) governs aquatics and is affiliated to World Aquatics; Khelo India and TOPS fund elite swimmers.
- WHO's first Global Status Report on Drowning Prevention (2024): over 3 lakh deaths in 2021, over 90% in low- and middle-income countries.
- UN General Assembly declared 25 July as World Drowning Prevention Day (2021 resolution).
- National Sports Governance Act 2025 obliges federations to adopt safe-sport policies, important for child swimmers and coaches.

Current developments 2025–26

- Asian Aquatics Championships, Ahmedabad (September–October 2025): India's best-ever haul of 13 medals, though no gold.
- Glasgow 2026 Commonwealth Games: Indian swimmers won no medal; men's 4x200 m freestyle relay finished sixth in the final.
- Asian Games 2026, Aichi-Nagoya: India won no swimming medal while finishing 4th overall with 85 medals.
- Kerala recorded 67 cases and 18 deaths of amoebic meningoencephalitis by mid-September 2025, prompting advisories on chlorinating pools and wells.

Science, economics or social angle

- Low-impact, full-body aerobic exercise; good for asthma, joints and rehabilitation; drag reduction and stroke efficiency matter more than raw strength.
- Few heated 50 m pools, high running costs and short swimming seasons in north India restrict year-round training.
- Genetics (height, wingspan) matters, but coaching, early start and pool access explain more of the medal gap.
- Swimming in natural water bodies risks drowning, currents, pollution, leptospirosis and **Naegleria fowleri** infection.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Survival swimming for children is among WHO's proven drowning interventions; officers can link it to school curricula and disaster preparedness.
- Flood-prone districts need trained swimmers in NDRF, SDRF, police and Aapda Mitra volunteers; lifeguards at ghats and tourist spots.
- Pool safety, chlorination audits and child-protection norms for coaches are regulatory duties of local bodies.
- Inclusive access: affordable public pools and women-only sessions widen participation and safety.

Asked in real interviews

1. Which swimmer is the most successful Olympian, and how many medals did he win? **[2020]**
2. Why are we not able to win medals in swimming? Follow-up: it is said genetic reasons are also there. **[2020]**
3. What is the difference between swimming and synchronised swimming? **[2021]**
4. Which style do you practise in swimming? **[2022]**
5. Why is India not performing well, why do Western countries win so many medals, and what does India need to do? **[2022]**
6. Would you prefer a Western coach or an Indian coach, and why? **[2022]**
7. Is the absence of a career in sports discouraging parents from encouraging children's participation? **[2022]**
8. How do you practise swimming? What are the different styles? **[2024]**
9. Team sport versus individual sport? **[2024]**
10. Discussion on healthy sportsmanship and your timings in sports. **[2024]**
11. Is it safe to swim in natural water bodies? **[2025]**
12. Why is swimming not as popular as badminton in India? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What are your personal best timings, and in which stroke?
2. India won 13 medals at the 2025 Asian Aquatics Championships but none at Asian Games 2026. How do you read this?
3. Drowning kills lakhs globally each year. As a DM of a flood-prone district, what would you do?
4. Who were Mihir Sen and Murlikant Petkar?
5. What is the order of strokes in individual medley and why?
6. Should survival swimming be compulsory in schools?
7. What precautions should be taken after the amoebic meningoencephalitis cases in Kerala?

8. Is genetics or infrastructure the bigger reason for India's swimming gap?

Model answer: Why does India win so few swimming medals, and what would you change?

I think infrastructure and early access matter more than genetics. We have few heated 50 m pools, so many swimmers train only half the year, and children start late. Countries like Australia build from school swimming and club competitions. There is progress: India won a best-ever 13 medals at the 2025 Asian Aquatics Championships, but no medal at the 2026 Asian Games shows the gap. As an officer, I would push year-round public pools through smart-city and CSR funds, school swimming linked to drowning prevention, and talent scouting from coastal and riverine communities where children already swim naturally.

Model answer: As DM of a flood-prone district, how can your love of swimming help prevent drowning?

Drowning is preventable. WHO's 2024 report counts over 3 lakh deaths a year, mostly in low- and middle-income countries, often children. I would combine three measures. First, survival swimming and water-safety lessons for school children, using local ponds made safe or temporary pools. Second, train SDRF, police and Aapda Mitra volunteers, and post lifeguards at ghats and tourist spots during monsoon and festivals. Third, physical measures: fencing ponds near anganwadis and crèches for toddlers. As a swimmer I know how fast panic sets in, so I would personally champion these drives, perhaps around World Drowning Prevention Day on 25 July.

Common traps

- Listing swimming but not knowing your own stroke timings or basic training routine
- Blaming only genetics for India's medal gap, which boards then challenge
- Using the old term 'synchronised swimming' without knowing it became artistic swimming

Preparation checklist

☐ Note your personal best times, stroke and weekly routine; be ready to describe technique

☐ Revise Indian swimming milestones: Mihir Sen, Arati Saha, Khazan Singh, Petkar, Sajan Prakash, Srihari Nataraj

☐ Read WHO's 2024 drowning report highlights and India-specific drowning prevention ideas

☐ Track 2025–26 results: Asian Aquatics Ahmedabad, Glasgow 2026, Asian Games 2026

☐ Prepare a district action plan linking swimming to disaster management and public health

HOBBY 17

Yoga & Meditation

Appears in DAFs as: yoga, pranayama, Surya Namaskar, Vipassana, mindfulness, transcendental meditation, aerial/acro yoga, yoga certification course. Yoga is India's best-known soft-power export and a stated government priority, so boards test whether the candidate lives the practice or only lists it.

What the board is really testing

• Depth: can you go beyond asanas to the philosophy (Patanjali, Gita's karma-bhakti-jnana, Vipassana) and recite or interpret a text?

• Authenticity: what you practise, under whom, since when, and what measurable change it has made in you

• Scientific temper: can you explain the physiology of pranayama and meditation without exaggerated claims?

• Policy awareness: International Day of Yoga, Ministry of Ayush, WHO traditional medicine work, yoga as soft power

• Temperament: whether calm and self-regulation show up in how you handle stress and pointed questions in the room

Basics, history and texts

- **Patanjali's Yoga Sutras**: 196 sutras in four padas (Samadhi, Sadhana, Vibhuti, Kaivalya); defines yoga as 'chitta vritti nirodha' (stilling the fluctuations of mind).
- **Ashtanga (eight limbs)**: yama, niyama, asana, pranayama, pratyahara, dharana, dhyana, samadhi. The first five are external (bahiranga), the last three internal (antaranga).
- Gita's paths: karma yoga (selfless action), bhakti yoga (devotion), jnana yoga (knowledge); Vivekananda's Raja Yoga (1896) presented Patanjali's meditative path to the West.
- Hatha Yoga Pradipika (Swatmarama, c. 15th century) systematised asana, pranayama, mudra and bandha; modern postural yoga owes much to T. Krishnamacharya and his students Iyengar and Pattabhi Jois.
- **Vipassana**: Buddhist insight meditation observing breath and bodily sensations with equanimity; revived globally by S.N. Goenka (Dhamma Giri, Igatpuri, 1976) through free 10-day residential courses.
- Transcendental Meditation (Maharishi Mahesh Yogi) is mantra-based and became famous in the West after the Beatles' 1968 Rishikesh visit; mindfulness (Jon Kabat-Zinn's MBSR) is its secular clinical cousin.

India story and icons

- Paramahansa Yogananda founded the Self-Realization Fellowship (1920) and wrote 'Autobiography of a Yogi' (1946), introducing Kriya Yoga to the West.
- Gandhi is described as a karma yogi: anasakti (detached action) from the Gita guided his politics; he called the Gita his 'mother'.
- B.K.S. Iyengar (Padma Vibhushan 2014) made props-based alignment yoga global; Swami Kuvalayananda founded Kaivalyadhama, Lonavla (1924), the first scientific yoga research institute.
- **Yoga in UNESCO list**: inscribed on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2016.
- Tihar Jail's Vipassana programme (1993, under Kiran Bedi) is a well-known case study of meditation in prison reform; Goenka received the Padma Bhushan in 2012.

Institutions, policy and law

- **International Day of Yoga (21 June)**: proposed by PM Modi at the 69th UNGA (Sept 2014); resolution 69/131 adopted December 2014 with a record 177 co-sponsors; summer solstice chosen.
- Ministry of Ayush (department 2003, full ministry November 2014) runs MDNIY Delhi, the Yoga Certification Board, the Common Yoga Protocol and the National Ayush Mission.
- Yogasana was recognised as a competitive sport in December 2020 and features in Khelo India Games; Fit India Movement launched 29 August 2019.
- WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine, Jamnagar (foundation laid April 2022) is the only WHO global centre for traditional medicine; WHO mYoga app launched 2021; Y-Break app for office workers 2021.
- Santhara/sallekhana (Jain fast unto death) was held illegal by Rajasthan HC in 2015 and stayed by the Supreme Court; distinguish it from yogic samadhi and from passive euthanasia (Common Cause, 2018).

Current developments 2025–26

- **IDY 2025 (11th)**: theme 'Yoga for One Earth, One Health'; PM led the main event at Visakhapatnam; about 3 lakh people set a Guinness record for most people doing yoga at one venue.
- IDY 2025 also saw over 22,000 tribal students perform 108 Surya Namaskars in 108 minutes, a second Guinness record.
- **IDY 2026 (12th)**: theme 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing'; national event led by PM at Red Road, Kolkata, linking yoga to India's ageing population and preventive care.
- Second **WHO Global Summit on Traditional Medicine** in New Delhi (December 2025) adopted the Delhi Declaration; WHO launched the Traditional Medicine Global Library with about 1.6 million resources.
- Ayush outreach initiatives: Yoga Samavesh (chair yoga for underserved groups), Yoga Sangam events, Namaste Yoga app and disease-specific protocols for non-communicable diseases.

Science, economics and social angle

- Slow pranayama (about six breaths per minute) raises vagal tone and heart-rate variability, shifting the body towards parasympathetic 'rest and digest' and lowering stress hormones.
- Long-term evidence is moderate: yoga helps with blood pressure, low back pain, anxiety and glycaemic control as an adjunct, not a substitute for medicine. Avoid miracle-cure claims.
- India's non-communicable disease burden (diabetes, hypertension) makes low-cost preventive yoga a public-health tool; IDY 2026 tied it to the silver economy.
- Yoga is a global wellness industry worth billions; India's soft power gains, but debates on patents/copyright over asanas led to the Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) documenting postures.
- Social debates: secular framing versus religious roots (Om, Surya Namaskar), commercialisation ('McYoga'), and new fusion forms like aerial yoga and acroyoga.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Stress management for officers: meditation builds equanimity, impulse control and focus, which Gita's 'sthitaprajna' and the Second ARC's emphasis on emotional intelligence both value.

- Field use: yoga camps at Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, school wellness periods, police and jail wellness programmes, and de-addiction centres combined with counselling.
- Yama-niyama read as a code of conduct: satya (truthfulness), asteya (non-stealing), aparigraha (non-possessiveness) map directly onto integrity and probity in public life.
- Governance caution: an officer should keep yoga voluntary and inclusive, avoid religious compulsion, and insist on certified trainers and evidence-based health messaging.
- Counter-view to handle: meditation as 'passive living'. Answer that Vipassana trains awareness for better action, not withdrawal; Gandhi combined inner discipline with intense public work.

Asked in real interviews

1. What are karma yoga, bhakti yoga and jnana yoga? What is raja yoga? **[2021]**
2. Who was Paramahansa Yogananda and what did he do in the West? **[2021]**
3. What kind of yogi was Mahatma Gandhi? **[2021]**
4. You mention pranayama: name a doctor who recently spoke about its benefits. What are its immediate and long-term benefits? **[2021]**
5. What is the actual physiological process that takes place inside the body during pranayama? **[2021]**
6. Why was 21 June chosen for International Day of Yoga? **[2022]**
7. Which yoga do you practise? Why Surya Namaskar? What change have you seen in yourself? Who was your teacher? **[2022]**
8. You have a yoga certificate course; have you participated in any 21 June event? **[2022]**
9. Recite a long Sanskrit shloka from Patanjali's Yoga Sutras and interpret it. **[2022]**
10. Tell me the origin of yoga and the eight limbs of Ashtanga yoga. At which stage are you? **[2022]**
11. What is acroyoga? **[2022]**
12. Are euthanasia and samadhi in yoga the same? (with counter-questions) **[2022]**
13. What is aerial yoga? **[2022]**
14. Travelling unsettles you and meditation settles you; how did you develop both? What meditation do you do, under a guru or by yourself? **[2022]**
15. You did Vipassana, which is perceived as a way to passive living. Your take? **[2022]**
16. What is Vipassana? Then who is your real friend (breath and sensation)? **[2023]**
17. Question on Ashtanga yoga from the DAF. **[2024]**
18. Tell me unique things about Vipassana. How did it help you? **[2024]**
19. Who started Vipassana, what is its core idea, how do you practise it, and can it be practised while running? **[2024]**
20. Why transcendental meditation? Why is TM famous in the West and how is it different from other forms of meditation? **[2020]**
21. Guided meditation: what and why? The eight limbs of yoga? Do you practise Sudarshan Kriya alone or under a guide? **[2024]**
22. Surya Namaskar: how many do you do and with which mantras? Why Vipassana at a young age? **[2024]**
23. Do you practise yoga? **[2021]**
24. Differentiate meditation and Sudarshan Kriya. Disadvantages of meditation? **[2025]**
25. Who started Sudarshan Kriya? Difference between pranayama and meditation? **[2025]**
26. Is there a degree for yoga? Are you a yoga expert? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the theme of International Day of Yoga 2026 and why was Kolkata chosen for the main event?
2. Is yoga a religious practice? Should Surya Namaskar be compulsory in government schools?
3. What is the difference between dhyana, dharana and samadhi? Which have you experienced?
4. Yoga is being commercialised abroad as fitness. Has India lost ownership of yoga? What is TKDL?
5. As DM, how would you use yoga in your district's NCD and mental-health strategy without making it coercive?
6. What does the WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine at Jamnagar do, and what is the Delhi Declaration?
7. Your interview board is stressing you right now. Show me how your meditation helps here.
8. Can meditation make an officer passive or indifferent to injustice?

Model answer: Isn't meditation an escape from the world? A civil servant needs action, not withdrawal.

I see it the opposite way. Vipassana, as S.N. Goenka taught it, trains you to observe sensations without reacting, which is the gap between stimulus and response that good decisions need. The Gita's karma yoga asks for detached action, not inaction, and Gandhi meditated daily while leading the most intense public movement of his age. For an officer facing a riot, a flood or an angry delegation, that equanimity prevents knee-jerk orders. I will admit meditation can become self-absorption if practised as escape. The test is whether it makes you more responsive to people, and that is how I judge my own practice.

Model answer: Should yoga be made compulsory in government schools?

I would support making it universally available, not compulsory. The health case is real: India faces a rising burden of diabetes and hypertension, and Ayush's own IDY 2026 theme, 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', shows the preventive logic. But compulsion invites the objection that yoga carries religious elements, such as chanting Om, and that can turn a health tool into a political controversy. As an administrator, I would offer a secular Common Yoga Protocol within physical education, use certified trainers, allow opt-outs, and track outcomes such as fitness scores and attendance. Voluntary participation that children enjoy will last longer than a mandate.

Common traps

• Listing 'yoga and meditation' but being unable to name your style, teacher, routine or a single sutra, which collapses credibility when a member asks you to recite or interpret one

• Making unscientific health claims (yoga cures diabetes or cancer) instead of saying 'evidence-based adjunct to medicine'

• Getting defensive or preachy on the religion and secularism question rather than giving a balanced, constitutional answer

Preparation checklist

☐ Memorise and be able to explain 3–4 Yoga Sutras (1.2, 2.46, 2.29) and two Gita verses on

karma yoga, with your own interpretation

☐ Write a one-page note on your own practice: style, teacher, years, daily routine, certifications, IDY events attended, and one concrete change in you

☐ Learn the physiology of pranayama and meditation (vagus nerve, HRV, cortisol) in plain language, plus one or two credible studies

☐ Revise IDY facts: 2014 resolution, 177 co-sponsors, solstice logic, 2025 and 2026 themes and venues; Ayush institutions; WHO GCTM and the Delhi Declaration

☐ Prepare balanced views on secularism and yoga, commercialisation and TKDL, and the 'meditation means passivity' critique, each with an administrative application

HOBBY 18

Running, Cycling & Fitness

Appears in DAFs as: running, jogging, marathons, half marathons, endurance running, cycling, endurance cycling/randonneuring, gym, resistance training, fitness. Endurance sport signals discipline and grit, and it opens easy links to public health, urban mobility, road safety, doping and India's sporting ambitions.

What the board is really testing

• Genuineness: distances, timings, races run, how often you train, and the vocabulary (pace, splits, VO2 max) a real runner or cyclist uses

• Awareness of India's athletics story and its weak spots: middle and long-distance running, doping and grassroots infrastructure

• Urban governance lens: why Indian cities are hostile to walking and cycling, and what an administrator can fix

• Whether you connect fitness to public policy: Fit India, Khelo India, NCDs, sports governance reforms

• Mental endurance: how the loneliness and pain of long-distance training translate into resilience in service

Basics, history and rules

- **Marathon** recalls Pheidippides' run from Marathon to Athens (490 BCE); distance fixed at 42.195 km at the 1908 London Olympics and standardised in 1921.
- Pace is time per unit distance (min/km); speed is distance per unit time (km/h). Runners train by pace zones, tempo runs, intervals and long slow distance.
- Men's marathon world record: Kelvin Kiptum, 2:00:35 (Chicago 2023). Kipchoge's 1:59:40 (Vienna 2019) was unofficial, using rotating pacers.
- **Endurance cycling** includes randonneuring (BRMs of 200–1,200 km under Audax Club Parisien rules) and ultra races like Race Across America (RAAM, about 4,800 km).
- Grand Tours: Tour de France (since 1903), Giro d'Italia, Vuelta a España; India has no rider at that level and is weak in road and track cycling internationally.
- 'The Loneliness of the Long-Distance Runner' (Alan Sillitoe, 1959) is a story of a borstal boy who deliberately loses a race as rebellion: a metaphor for inner freedom.

India story and icons

- Milkha Singh ('Flying Sikh') finished fourth in the 400 m at Rome 1960; PT Usha finished fourth in the 400 m hurdles at Los Angeles 1984 and is now IOA president.
- **Gulveer Singh** set national records in 2025: 10,000 m in 27:00.22 and 5,000 m in 13:11.82; he won 10,000 m and 5,000 m gold at the 2025 Asian Championships, Gumi.
- Avinash Sable (steeplechase national record holder, 2023 Asian Games gold) and Parul Chaudhary (women's steeplechase national record holder) are India's leading distance runners.
- Fauja Singh ran marathons past age 100 and became a global symbol of ageing well; he died in a road accident in Punjab in July 2025.
- Lt Col Srinivas Gokulnath was the first Indian to complete RAAM solo (2017); Tata Mumbai Marathon is a World Athletics Gold Label race.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Fit India Movement** (29 August 2019) and its 'Sundays on Cycle' drive (December 2024); Khelo India for grassroots talent; TOPS for elite athletes.
- **National Sports Governance Act, 2025**: National Sports Board to recognise or suspend federations, National Sports Tribunal with appeals to the Supreme Court, athletes and women on executive committees.
- **National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act, 2025** amends the 2022 Act, aligns with the UNESCO Convention against Doping, and creates a National Board for Anti-Doping in Sports overseeing NADA.
- Athletics Federation of India governs running; World Athletics and its Athletics Integrity Unit (AIU) handle global rules and doping cases.
- Cycling infrastructure: India Cycles4Change Challenge (Smart Cities Mission, 2020); National Urban Transport Policy 2006 prioritises people over vehicles; World Bicycle Day is 3 June (UN, 2018).

Current developments 2025–26

- **Fit India Sundays on Cycle** reached its 82nd edition in July 2026 at over 15,000 locations, with more than 30 lakh participants since its launch.
- **Doping**: WADA's 2024 testing figures (released December 2025) show India's 260 adverse findings from 7,113 samples, a 3.6% rate, highest among major testing nations; athletics led with 76.
- Women's marathon record holder Ruth Chepngetich (2:09:56, Chicago 2024) received a three-year ban in October 2025, but her record stands because that race's sample was clean.
- **Ahmedabad was awarded the 2030 Commonwealth Games** (November 2025); India is pursuing a 2036 Olympic bid, which makes doping and governance reforms urgent.
- Tata Mumbai Marathon 2026 drew a record of about 69,000 runners on the Coastal Road and Sea Link route; Ethiopians Tadu Abate Deme and Yeshi Kalayu Chekole won the elite races.

Science, economics and social angle

- Aerobic exercise improves VO2 max, insulin sensitivity and mood (endorphins, BDNF); WHO recommends 150–300 minutes of moderate activity a week for adults.
- Physical inactivity is a major driver of India's diabetes and hypertension burden; Lancet Global Health (2024) estimated about half of Indian adults are insufficiently active.

- Cycling is cheap, zero-emission mobility, but Indian bicycle use fell as cities sprawled; India is the world's second-largest bicycle producer, centred on Ludhiana.
- Barriers: no segregated lanes, heat, unsafe roads, social status attached to motor vehicles, and fewer women cycling due to harassment risk.
- The running economy is booming: city marathons, gear and wearables, though participation is skewed towards urban middle classes.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Road safety: India records over 1.7 lakh road deaths a year; pedestrians and cyclists are the most vulnerable; cyclist helmets are not legally mandated under the Motor Vehicles Act.
- A DM can run 'Sundays on Cycle', open school grounds after hours, create car-free streets and push cycle tracks in Smart City and AMRUT projects.
- Doping is an ethics issue: win-at-all-costs culture, ignorance among rural athletes, and supplement contamination; the answer is education, testing and protecting whistle-blowers.
- Running teaches pacing and delayed gratification, useful for long projects; fitness is also an officer's duty, given long hours and disaster duty.
- Inclusion: promote safe running and cycling spaces for women, persons with disabilities (para-athletics) and elderly people in every district plan.

Asked in real interviews

1. What is 'The Loneliness of the Long Distance Runner'? **[2020]**
2. A debate with the board about India's marathon runners. **[2020]**
3. Why the name marathon? Where all have you run? What is the distance? **[2021]**
4. How would you define running? How much and how often do you run? **[2021]**
5. What is the difference between pace and speed in running? **[2021]**
6. What is endurance cycling? Where have you done endurance cycling? **[2021]**
7. Why is India not favourable to cycling? What needs to be done? **[2021]**
8. Tell me about cycle races in the world and India's position. **[2022]**
9. What are the cycling issues in our country? Why don't people wear helmets while cycling? Why are cycles costly in India? **[2022]**
10. Give two similarities between you as a marathon runner and Sunita Williams. **[2024]**
11. Can Vipassana be practised while running? **[2024]**
12. Name a famous Indian 200 m runner of the past. **[2025]**
13. What do we learn from sports in general? **[2025]**
14. Seems you are athletic: what is your favourite sprint event, your best timing, and the current Indian best? **[2024]**
15. Benefits of walking? What is the best time to walk? **[2024]**
16. How many days a week do you jog, and is it a hobby or routine? How has it benefited you? **[2024]**
17. How long does a jog take you, and what parameters do you keep in mind while jogging? **[2024]**
18. When does jogging become running? What is your pulse rate while exercising? Which CrossFit exercises do you do? **[2024]**
19. You put weight loss as a hobby. Why? **[2024]**

20. Your weight-training routine: how do you go about it? How can sudden cardiac deaths in gyms be prevented? **[2024]**
21. What is the difference between endurance running and a marathon? **[2019]**
22. Which running event is the hardest? Who from India is doing well globally in 3000m steeplechase? **[2025]**
23. What do you do for physical activity? What advice would you give someone your age? **[2025]**
24. Are you walking towards something or away from something? When did you last walk? **[2025]**
25. What is reflective walking, and how is it different from normal walking? **[2025]**
26. How often do you jog? What is the recommended diet for marathon runners? **[2025]**
27. Is there class, caste or gender bias in gyms or among trainers? **[2025]**
28. How do you stay fit? **[2025]**
29. How did you find cycling as a hobby? City rides or long journeys? What has cycling taught you? **[2025]**
30. Was it in Kota that you took up cycling? Did you commute to coaching by bicycle? **[2025]**
31. You are interested in cycling: speak for two minutes on anything about cycling. **[2025]**
32. Your hobby is endurance running: what does that mean, and how long do you usually run? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is your personal best in a 10 km, half or full marathon, and how did you train for it?
2. Why does India, a country of 1.4 billion, win so few Olympic medals in distance running?
3. India tops WADA's doping list. Is it more testing or more cheating? What should be done?
4. What are the key features of the National Sports Governance Act, 2025?
5. As Municipal Commissioner, how would you make your city safe for cyclists and pedestrians?
6. Is 'Sundays on Cycle' tokenism or a real behaviour-change campaign?
7. Has fitness become an elite hobby in India? How do we make it accessible to the poor?
8. What does a runner's 'wall' teach you about handling setbacks in service?

Model answer: India has the highest doping positivity rate among major nations. Is this a sign of better testing or a deeper rot?

Both. WADA's 2024 figures show 260 adverse findings out of 7,113 samples, a 3.6% rate, and athletics alone had 76 cases. More testing explains part of it, but that rate is far above other large testers, so a culture problem exists: coaches chasing medals, cheap supplements and poor awareness among rural athletes. The National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act, 2025 strengthens NADA's independence, and the 2030 Commonwealth Games raise the stakes. As an administrator, I would back education in district sports hostels, regulate supplement shops, and protect athletes who report coaches. Clean sport is a question of national credibility, not only medals.

Model answer: Why don't Indians cycle to work, and what would you do about it as a city administrator?

Mostly because our roads punish cyclists. There are no segregated lanes, the heat is intense, motor traffic is fast, and a bicycle is often seen as a poor man's vehicle. Yet over 1.7 lakh people die on our roads every year, many of them cyclists and pedestrians. The National Urban Transport Policy already says streets are for people first. I would start with a connected network around schools and metro stations, shaded and protected, then add public bicycle sharing, secure parking and car-free Sundays like Fit India's 'Sundays on Cycle'. Ridership follows safety, so I would track crashes and usage data.

Common traps

- Claiming 'marathons' without knowing your own timings, the 42.195 km distance, or basic terms like pace, tempo run or negative split
- Confusing Neeraj Chopra (javelin) or field events with running achievements; not knowing current distance runners like Gulveer Singh or Avinash Sable
- Treating fitness as a personal lifestyle story only and missing the governance angles of road safety, urban design, doping and sports administration

Preparation checklist

☐ Keep a factual log ready: races run, distances, personal bests, weekly mileage or cycling kilometres, injuries and how you recovered

☐ Learn athletics basics and history: marathon origin and distance, current world records, the Kiptum and Chepngetich stories, India's icons from Milkha to Gulveer

☐ Revise policy: Fit India and Sundays on Cycle, Khelo India, TOPS, the 2025 Sports Governance and Anti-Doping Acts, the CWG 2030 award and 2036 bid

☐ Prepare a 5-point district plan on cycling and pedestrian safety using NUTP 2006, Cycles4Change and road-safety data

☐ Rehearse two personal stories: one where endurance training helped you through a setback, and one on what sport taught you about teamwork or fairness

HOBBY 19

Gym and Strength Training

Appears in DAFs as: gymming, *weight training*, *strength/resistance training*, *powerlifting*, *calisthenics*, *fitness enthusiast*, *CrossFit*. Gym culture is booming among aspirants, and boards use it to probe sudden cardiac deaths, steroids and supplements, body image, social exclusion and the Fit India agenda.

What the board is really testing

- Whether you understand training science (powerlifting vs weightlifting, isometric work, progressive overload) or just 'go to the gym'
- Your awareness of public-health issues: lifestyle diseases, obesity, sudden cardiac deaths,

unregulated supplements and steroids

- Social sensitivity: class, caste and gender barriers in access to fitness spaces
- Knowledge of Indian lifters and para-athletes, and of sports governance and anti-doping
- Maturity: discipline and consistency, without arrogance about physique

Basics, history and rules

- Resistance training works on **progressive overload**, specificity and recovery; hypertrophy, strength and endurance need different load, rep and rest patterns.
- **Powerlifting** tests squat, bench press and deadlift; **Olympic weightlifting** tests snatch and clean & jerk. Only weightlifting is an Olympic sport, and para powerlifting is Paralympic.
- Bodybuilding is judged on muscle size, symmetry and conditioning. Calisthenics uses bodyweight (push-ups, pull-ups, dips, levers) and needs almost no equipment.
- **Isometric** contraction creates tension without changing muscle length (plank, wall-sit); isotonic work is concentric or eccentric movement.
- The WHO recommends 150–300 minutes of moderate aerobic activity a week, or 75–150 vigorous, plus muscle-strengthening on two or more days.
- You can measure fitness without devices: resting pulse, push-up and sit-up counts, sit-and-reach, waist-to-height ratio and the talk test for intensity.

India story and icons

- **Karnam Malleswari** won weightlifting bronze at Sydney 2000, the first Olympic medal by an Indian woman.
- **Mirabai Chanu** won Olympic silver at Tokyo 2020 (49 kg) and world gold in 2017.
- Mirabai won silver at the 2025 World Championships in Førde, Norway (48 kg), lifting 84 + 115 = 199 kg, with national records in clean & jerk and total.
- In para powerlifting, Sudhir won Commonwealth Games gold at Birmingham 2022, a sign of India's growing para-sport base.
- Indian traditions such as **akhara** wrestling, malkhamb, mudgar and gada training are indigenous forms of strength training.
- Manohar Aich, the 1952 Mr Universe (short-height category), became a symbol of discipline despite poverty.

Institutions, policy and law

- The **Fit India Movement** was launched on National Sports Day, 29 August 2019; Fit India fitness protocols give age-appropriate tests, including for people over 60.
- FSSAI regulates protein powders and supplements under its **Health Supplements and Nutraceuticals** regulations; misleading claims can be acted on under the Consumer Protection Act 2019.
- Anabolic steroids are prescription drugs under drugs law; selling them over the counter in gyms is illegal, and using them in competitive sport breaches the National Anti-Doping Act 2022.
- The Indian Weightlifting Federation governs the Olympic discipline; SAI and the Khelo India and TOPS schemes support elite lifters.

- The National Sports Governance Act 2025 sets up a National Sports Board and a Sports Tribunal and requires athlete and women representation in federations.
- Many states do not license gyms or certify trainers, a regulatory gap for safety, first aid and equipment standards.

Current developments 2025–26

- **ICMR–AIIMS** findings shared by the Health Ministry in July 2025 found no link between Covid vaccination and sudden deaths in people aged 18–45; heart attacks remain the leading cause.
- Those findings named genetic predisposition, risky lifestyles and underlying conditions as contributors to sudden deaths, which is relevant to deaths in gyms and during exertion.
- WADA's 2024 testing report (reported December 2025) found 260 adverse findings among 7,113 Indian samples, a **3.6% positivity rate**, the highest among major testing nations.
- Mirabai Chanu's 2025 world silver (199 kg, 48 kg category) revived Los Angeles 2028 hopes in weightlifting.
- The National Sports Governance Act 2025 partly came into force on 1 January 2026, reshaping federation governance, including weightlifting.

Science, economics or social angle

- Strength training improves insulin sensitivity, bone density and mental health; it helps prevent type 2 diabetes, hypertension, sarcopenia and osteoporosis.
- NFHS-5 (2019–21) found 24% of women and 22.9% of men overweight or obese, so lifestyle disease is a development issue, not just a medical one.
- Sudden gym collapses usually involve undiagnosed cardiomyopathy or coronary disease, overexertion, dehydration, stimulant pre-workouts or steroid misuse; screening and CPR-ready staff save lives.
- Private gyms are urban, costly and often male-dominated; caste, class and gender barriers appear in fees, dress norms, harassment and trainer networks.
- Social-media fitness culture can lead to body dysmorphia, unsafe supplements and eating disorders, so it needs a positive body-image counter-narrative.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- **Open-air gyms** in parks and panchayats, built through municipal or MPLADS funds, make fitness free and inclusive; women-only time slots improve access.
- A District Magistrate can push gym safety norms: an AED and CPR-trained staff, trainer certification, and checks against over-the-counter steroid sales.
- Police and paramilitary fitness drives, along with regular health screening, reduce lifestyle disease and stress among frontline staff.
- Ethics: you should neither promote nor quietly ignore steroid use. Honest advice on supplements matters, especially to impressionable youth.
- For an officer, a gym routine models discipline and resilience, but it should not turn into vanity or social-media self-promotion.

Asked in real interviews

1. You do powerlifting. How is it different from weightlifting, why not weightlifting, and which one is in the Olympics? **[2025]**
2. Indian athletes are doing well in para-lifting. Name some. Who are para-athletes? **[2025]**

3. Why are so many youngsters dying in gyms? **[2025]**
4. Is there class, caste or gender bias in gyms? Is there caste bias in the trainers' community? **[2025]**
5. Describe your strength-training experience and process. **[2025]**
6. A player died at a stadium in Haryana. Do you know the incident? How should sports be promoted? **[2025]**
7. What is calisthenics? How did you learn it? Do you practise daily, and did you today? **[2025]**
8. You are into fitness. What are lifestyle diseases, how can they be prevented, and what is the role of a balanced diet? **[2025]**
9. Describe your weight-training routine. What causes sudden cardiac deaths in gyms, and how can they be prevented? **[2024]**
10. You are a fitness enthusiast. What would you suggest a 62-year-old like me should do? **[2024]**
11. How can fitness be measured without a device? What is isometric exercise? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Should protein supplements be regulated as food or as drugs? What does FSSAI do?
2. India has the highest doping positivity among major nations. Is gym culture partly responsible?
3. Is going to the gym enough to make India fit? What is missing in the Fit India Movement?
4. As a Collector, how would you make fitness accessible to women and poor households in your district?
5. Your DAF mentions powerlifting. Name Indian weightlifters and para powerlifters, and their latest medals.
6. A trainer in a local gym is found selling steroids to college students. What will you do?
7. Does a muscular physique help or hurt an officer's image?

Model answer: Why are young people collapsing in gyms, and what should the state do?

From my own training I see three overlapping causes: undiagnosed heart conditions or a family history, overexertion without warm-up or hydration, and the misuse of stimulants and steroids. The ICMR–AIIMS findings released in July 2025 found no Covid-vaccine link and pointed to heart attacks, genetics and lifestyle. I would not frighten people away from exercise. Instead, as an administrator I would push minimum gym standards: CPR-trained staff, an AED on site, certified trainers, pre-participation screening for high-risk members and a crackdown on over-the-counter steroid sales, along with awareness drives in colleges.

Model answer: Are gyms socially exclusive spaces?

Often, yes. Private gyms are mostly urban and fee-based, and many women find them intimidating because of harassment or dress norms. Hiring through trainer networks can also reflect caste and class networks. Fitness is a public-health good, though: NFHS-5 shows nearly a quarter of adults are overweight or obese. So the answer is to widen access, not to criticise gyms. Open-air gyms in parks and panchayats, women-only slots in municipal facilities, school strength programmes and Fit India protocols for the elderly can democratise fitness. As an officer I would track usage data by gender and locality to see who is still left out.

Common traps

- Mixing up powerlifting and weightlifting, or not knowing that only weightlifting (and para

powerlifting) is at the Olympics and Paralympics

• Dismissing gym deaths as 'vaccine effects' or rumours instead of citing evidence and prevention steps

• Talking only about physique and personal routine, and missing public health, access and regulation

Preparation checklist

☐ Be ready to describe your weekly split, your main lifts and their numbers, and to explain progressive overload, isometrics and recovery simply

☐ Learn the Indian lifters: Karnam Malleswari, Mirabai Chanu (including the 2025 world silver) and key para powerlifters

☐ Revise the Fit India Movement, FSSAI supplement rules, the National Anti-Doping Act 2022, the WADA 2024 data and the National Sports Governance Act 2025

☐ Prepare a health note: lifestyle diseases, NFHS-5 obesity figures, the WHO activity guidelines, CPR/AED basics and the July 2025 ICMR–AIIMS findings

☐ Prepare one answer each on social exclusion in gyms, and on a district plan for inclusive fitness (open gyms, women's slots, school programmes)

HOBBY 20

Trekking & Mountaineering

Appears in DAFs as: trekking, hiking, mountaineering, rock climbing, Himalayan treks, camping, basic/advanced mountaineering course (NIM, HMI). Mountains combine personal courage with geography, ecology, border strategy and disaster governance, so boards can probe both character and knowledge in one thread.

What the board is really testing

• Authenticity: exact treks, altitudes, routes, villages, gear and whether you used oxygen; boards cross-check numbers

• Conceptual clarity: hiking versus trekking versus mountaineering; the role of IMF and liaison officers; acclimatisation and safety protocols

• Ethical reflection on adventure: Everest queues, deaths, commercialisation, Sherpa labour and the 'conquest' narrative

• Himalayan governance: fragile ecology, overtourism, waste, GLOFs, disaster response and border-area development

• Risk judgement and leadership: when to turn back, how you managed a team, stay and local communities on the trail

Basics, history and rules

- Hiking is a day walk on trails; trekking is a multi-day walk, often at altitude, without technical gear; mountaineering involves ropes, ice axes and crampons on snow, ice or rock.

- **Acute Mountain Sickness** can progress to HAPE (fluid in lungs) or HACE (brain swelling); rule: 'climb high, sleep low', gain under about 500 m sleeping altitude a day above 3,000 m.
- Mount Everest's height was jointly re-announced by Nepal and China as 8,848.86 m in December 2020; first ascent by Tenzing Norgay and Edmund Hillary, 29 May 1953.
- Bachendri Pal became the first Indian woman to summit Everest (1984); Arunima Sinha became the first woman amputee to summit (2013).
- Popular Indian treks: Triund (Dhauladhar, Kangra), Nag Tibba (about 3,022 m, Tehri), Dodital (Uttarkashi, source of the Assi Ganga), Kedarkantha, Roopkund and Hampta Pass.
- Leave No Trace principles: carry out all waste, stay on trails, avoid camping on fragile meadows, respect wildlife and local cultures.

India story and icons

- Himalayan Mountaineering Institute, Darjeeling was set up in 1954 after the Everest ascent, with Tenzing Norgay as its first field director.
- Key institutes: NIM Uttarkashi (1965), ABVIMAS Manali, JIM&WS Pahalgam, and NIMAS Dirang in Arunachal Pradesh under the Ministry of Defence.
- Dashrath Manjhi, the 'Mountain Man' of Gaya, Bihar, cut a path through a hill with hammer and chisel over 22 years: a story of perseverance, not mountaineering.
- Draupadi ka Danda-II avalanche (October 2022) killed 27 or more NIM trainees and instructors, the deadliest accident in Indian mountaineering training.
- Sahastra Tal tragedy (June 2024): nine members of a 22-member Karnataka trekking group died in a blizzard in Uttarkashi, exposing weak regulation of commercial trek operators.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Indian Mountaineering Foundation (IMF, 1961)** issues peak permissions; for foreign expeditions it appoints a liaison officer to accompany the team for safety and border compliance.
- Many Himalayan areas need Inner Line or Protected Area Permits; climbing in national parks and sanctuaries requires forest department permission under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.
- Ministry of Tourism issued Indian Adventure Tourism Guidelines (2018) and a National Strategy for Adventure Tourism (2022) covering safety standards, accreditation and rescue.
- In 2018 Uttarakhand High Court restricted overnight camping on alpine meadows (bugyals) to protect them; the Supreme Court has pressed for carrying-capacity studies of Himalayan states.
- Nepal's Everest royalty for foreigners rose from US$11,000 to US$15,000 (spring) from 1 September 2025; a bill proposing a 7,000 m climbing prerequisite was still pending.

Current developments 2025–26

- **Uttarakhand opened 83 Himalayan peaks** (5,700–7,756 m, including Kamet, Nanda Devi East, Shivling, Changabang) in February 2026, waiving state fees for Indian climbers and launching an online UKMPS single window.
- **Record Everest day**: on 20 May 2026, 274 climbers (150 Nepali Sherpas among them) summited from Nepal's side in one day, beating 2019's 223; Nepal issued 502 permits that spring.

- Nepal opened 97 lesser-known peaks with no permit fee for two years (2025) to spread climbers away from Everest, and made at least one guide mandatory for every two climbers on 8,000 m peaks.
- Climate stress: glacial retreat and GLOF risk (South Lhonak, Sikkim, October 2023) make glacier lakes and moraine routes more dangerous for trekkers each season.
- Vibrant Villages Programme (2023) develops border villages in Arunachal, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Himachal and Ladakh, with homestays and treks as a livelihood pillar.

Science, economics and social angle

- At about 5,500 m air holds roughly half the oxygen of sea level; most Everest climbers use bottled oxygen above 7,000 m, and few climb without it.
- Adventure tourism sustains porters, guides, mule-owners and homestays in remote villages, reducing distress migration from Himalayan districts.
- Costs of overtourism: plastic waste, sewage at camps, trampled meadows, human-wildlife encounters and crowding on popular routes like Kedarkantha and Triund.
- Critique of 'conquest' language: colonial-era expeditions treated peaks as trophies and locals as porters; today's debate covers Sherpa risk, pay and recognition.
- Mountains are sacred to many communities, and some peaks (Kanchenjunga's summit in Sikkim, Kailash) are left unclimbed or restricted out of respect.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District role: register trek operators, mandate certified guides, health checks, weather alerts and GPS tracking, and pre-position SDRF and ITBP rescue teams.
- Carrying capacity: permit caps per day on fragile trails, eco-fees used for waste collection, and community-run trail management on the Sikkim and Ladakh model.
- Leadership lesson: the best mountaineering decision is often turning back; 'summit fever' is a classic case of sunk-cost bias that officers must also resist.
- Ethical dilemma: should rescuers risk lives for climbers who ignored rules? Answer: duty to rescue remains, but recover costs and enforce insurance requirements.
- Strategic link: trekking routes on the LAC and border passes need coordination with ITBP and the Army, and adventure tourism can support border-area presence.

Asked in real interviews

1. What do you see when you look at a mountain or rock face? **[2019]**
2. Why not mountaineering (as a pursuit)? **[2019]**
3. What places have you visited in Ladakh? What is the highest road in Ladakh? **[2020]**
4. There are queues and deaths on Mount Everest; what drives people to climb mountains? **[2021]**
5. Do you think the sport of mountaineering is an example of white supremacy? **[2021]**
6. What is the maximum height you have climbed? Did you use oxygen? **[2021]**
7. Who appoints the liaison officer for mountaineering expeditions? **[2021]**
8. Which places did you trek? Where is Triund and how was it? Are you still trekking after college? **[2021]**
9. What preparation is required before going on a trek? **[2021]**
10. What is the highest altitude you have trekked, and which places? **[2022]**
11. Are mountaineering and trekking the same thing? **[2022]**

12. What kind of travelling do you like? What is the difference between hiking, mountaineering and trekking? **[2022]**
13. What pleasure do you get from trekking? What is the height of Nag Tibba? **[2023]**
14. What is the difference between trekking and hiking? **[2023]**
15. Which peaks are you planning to trek next? What safety protocols are needed for trekking? **[2024]**
16. Aren't trekking training institutes too few in India? What should be done to promote trekking among school and college students? **[2024]**
17. What trekking equipment do you use? (with counter-questions) **[2024]**
18. Which treks have you done? Name a village on the Dodital route. How did you manage stay? Any wildlife conflict? What gear do you have? **[2025]**
19. What is waterfall trekking? Been to Dudhsagar? How many treks, the longest, and any night stays? Isn't it hiking? **[2024]**
20. Which peaks will you trek next? Safety protocols needed? Are trekking institutes too few? **[2024]**
21. How can trekking be promoted among school and college students? **[2024]**
22. How did you develop interest in mountaineering? Ten things you'd teach young mountaineers on day one? **[2024]**
23. Trekking: what equipment do you use? **[2024]**
24. Have you gone trekking? Name some famous trekking routes. **[2024]**
25. Which is your most memorable trek and why? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the difference between AMS, HAPE and HACE, and how do you prevent them?
2. After the Sahastra Tal tragedy, how should trek operators be regulated?
3. Uttarakhand has opened 83 peaks free for Indian climbers. Good for adventure tourism or a threat to fragile ecology?
4. Is commercial Everest climbing exploitative of Sherpas?
5. As DM of Uttarkashi, how would you manage overtourism on popular treks like Kedarkantha or Dayara Bugyal?
6. What role does the Indian Mountaineering Foundation play, and why do foreign expeditions need a liaison officer?
7. Tell us about a time on a trek when you had to turn back or change plans.
8. How is climate change making Himalayan trekking more dangerous?

Model answer: Hundreds queue on Everest and people die every year. Is this courage or vanity?

It can be either; the mountain does not decide, the climber does. Commercialisation has made Everest accessible to people with money but limited experience, and on 20 May 2026 a record 274 climbers summited from Nepal in a single day. Crowding at high altitude means more time in the death zone, which explains many fatalities. Courage includes the humility to turn back. Nepal's fee rise to US$15,000 and the proposed 7,000 m prerequisite show regulators trying to put competence before ego. As an administrator in a Himalayan district, I would apply the same logic on our treks: certify operators, cap numbers and treat safety as non-negotiable.

Model answer: Should the state promote adventure tourism in fragile Himalayan areas?

Yes, but on the mountains' terms. Adventure tourism gives livelihoods to guides, porters and homestays in border villages, which supports the Vibrant Villages Programme and reduces out-migration. Uttarakhand's February 2026 decision to open 83 peaks and waive fees for Indian climbers can nurture a new generation of mountaineers. The risks are real too: waste, trampled bugyals and accidents like Sahastra Tal in 2024, where nine trekkers died. I would pair promotion with carrying-capacity limits, online registration, certified guides, mandatory insurance and eco-fees spent locally on waste and rescue. Growth that degrades the trail is a loss for everyone.

Common traps

- Inflating altitudes or difficulty; boards ask exact heights (Nag Tibba, Triund, your highest point) and whether you used oxygen, so wrong numbers expose you quickly
- Using 'trekking', 'hiking' and 'mountaineering' interchangeably, a distinction asked repeatedly across years
- Romanticising adventure while ignoring local communities, waste, Sherpa and porter safety, and the regulatory failures behind tragedies

Preparation checklist

☐ Make a trek sheet: name, region, district, maximum altitude, days, route villages, operator or self-guided, stay arrangements, gear list and one incident from each trek

☐ Learn high-altitude physiology (AMS, HAPE, HACE, acclimatisation rules) and a safety protocol you can recite in five points

☐ Revise institutions and rules: IMF and liaison officers, HMI, NIM, JIM&WS, NIMAS, ILP/PAP permits, Adventure Tourism Guidelines 2018 and the 2022 strategy

☐ Track current facts: Uttarakhand's 83 peaks, Nepal's Everest fee and rules, the record summit day of 2026, Sahastra Tal and Draupadi ka Danda-II lessons

☐ Prepare views on overtourism, the 'conquest' and Sherpa debate, GLOF risk, and promoting trekking among students, each ending with a district-level action

PART III

Knowledge, Communication and Technology

Quizzing, debating, languages, collecting, podcasts, gaming, coding

HOBBY 21

Quizzing

Appears in DAFs as: participating in quizzes, hosting/conducting quizzes, quiz club president, GK competitions, college quiz fests. A quizzer claims broad general knowledge, so boards test that claim directly and ask whether trivia translates into judgement.

What the board is really testing

- Depth of the claim: Indian quizmasters, formats, famous quiz shows
- Whether you understand the difference between hosting and competing, and between quizzing and rote contests like spelling bees
- Lateral thinking and calm under pressure, often through rapid factual questions
- Whether you see the limits of information versus wisdom, and how quizzing builds curiosity
- Use of quizzes as a tool for awareness, education and citizen engagement

Basics, history and rules

- Common formats: a written preliminary round, stage finals, buzzer rounds, **pounce and bounce** (infinite bounce), connect rounds, and audio-visual rounds.
- Good quiz questions are **workable**: they reward reasoning from clues, not just recall. That is the quizzer's key distinction from a GK test.
- **Mastermind** (BBC, from 1972, hosted first by Magnus Magnusson) pairs a specialist subject round with a general knowledge round; contestants sit in the famous black chair.
- A spelling bee tests orthography, etymology and memorised word lists; quizzing tests breadth, connections and inference across domains.
- Hosting needs research, fact-checking, fair difficulty curves, clear phrasing and crowd management; competing needs recall, teamwork and risk-taking.
- Formats such as University Challenge, Jeopardy! and Who Wants to Be a Millionaire (the basis of KBC) shaped global quiz culture.

India story and icons

- **Neil O'Brien** is regarded as the father of Indian quizzing; he conducted a pioneering formal quiz in Kolkata in 1967.
- **Derek O'Brien** became a household name with the Bournvita Quiz Contest, and later entered politics as a Rajya Sabha MP.
- **Siddhartha Basu** hosted Quiz Time on Doordarshan in the 1980s and Mastermind India, and is credited with shaping India's TV quiz industry, including KBC.
- Kaun Banega Crorepati, hosted by Amitabh Bachchan since 2000, is India's adaptation of Who Wants to Be a Millionaire.
- Kolkata, Bengaluru and Chennai have strong quiz-club cultures; campus fests and corporate quizzes such as Tata Crucible sustain the circuit.
- Many civil servants and toppers came from quiz societies, which shows the overlap between curiosity and administrative aptitude.

Institutions, policy and law

- **MyGov** hosts national quizzes on schemes, the Constitution and heritage, using quizzes for citizen engagement and awareness.
- MEA's **Bharat Ko Jano** quiz connects diaspora youth with Indian culture; it is a public-diplomacy use of quizzing.
- NEP 2020 emphasises experiential, inquiry-based learning and less rote learning, which suits quiz clubs in schools.

- Quizzes are used in awareness drives: voter awareness (SVEEP), financial literacy, road safety and health campaigns.
- Intellectual property: quiz-show formats are licensed internationally, as with KBC's licensed format, and questions must respect copyright when they use media clips.
- Fair play: competitive quizzes need clear rules on ambiguous answers, and neutral, published adjudication.

Current developments 2025–26

- Interview boards are testing quizzers on the culture itself: a CSE 2024 candidate was asked to name Indian quizmasters.
- Generative AI and search make pure recall less valuable, so quizzing is moving towards **workable, connect-style** questions that reward inference over memory.
- Online quiz leagues and app-based quizzes grew after the pandemic, widening access beyond metro clubs and elite campuses.
- Sports records are standard quiz material for 2025–26: Neeraj Chopra's 90.23m (May 2025) and Animesh Kujur's 10.15s 100m national record (May 2026).
- Governance quiz staples for 2025–26 include the National Sports Governance Act 2025, which partly came into force on 1 January 2026.

Science, economics or social angle

- Cognitive science: **retrieval practice** and spaced repetition strengthen memory, and quizzing is a form of active recall that improves learning retention.
- Quizzing builds crystallised intelligence (accumulated knowledge) and trains pattern recognition and lateral connections.
- Socially, quiz culture has been urban, English-medium and elite; regional-language quizzes and rural school quizzes democratise it.
- TV quiz shows such as KBC turned knowledge into aspiration, highlighting small-town contestants and creating a 'knowledge as mobility' story.
- The limit: knowing facts is not the same as understanding causes. Boards may probe whether a quizzer can reason about issues.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District officers can run quiz campaigns on schemes, the Constitution, elections and health to raise awareness and test grassroots understanding.
- Quizzing teaches quick retrieval under pressure, useful in meetings, crisis briefings and field inspections.
- Hosting teaches neutrality, fact-checking and clear communication; one ambiguous question can undermine trust in the result.
- Quiz clubs in Navodaya and Kendriya Vidyalayas and in government schools can reduce the urban-rural gap in exposure.
- Ethics: verify before asserting. A quizzer's habit of checking sources protects an officer from misinformation.

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the difference between hosting quizzes and participating in them? **[2022]**
2. How does the skill set for quizzes differ from that for a spelling bee? **[2022]**

3. With your background in debating and quizzing, is India a debating society or a compliant society? **[2021]**
4. Did you conduct quizzes or only participate? **[2020]**
5. Do you know about Mastermind? **[2020]**
6. You have done quizzing. Name a few quizmasters from India. **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Who is called the father of Indian quizzing? What did Siddhartha Basu contribute?
2. In the age of Google and AI, is quizzing still relevant?
3. Does knowing facts make a good administrator? What does quizzing not teach you?
4. Ask us one interesting question from your quizzes, and explain how it is workable.
5. How would you use quizzes for awareness campaigns in your district?
6. Quiz culture is largely urban and English-medium. How would you democratise it?
7. You are hosting a quiz and a team disputes an answer the audience supports. What will you do?

Model answer: Is quizzing relevant when every fact is a search away?

I think it matters more now, not less. Good quizzing was never about memorising trivia. It rewards workable questions, where you connect clues across history, science and culture to reach an answer. Search gives you information, but quizzing builds the habit of making connections and checking facts, which is what we need when misinformation spreads fast. Neil O'Brien and Siddhartha Basu built Indian quizzing around curiosity, not rote learning. As an administrator I would use quizzes on schemes, voting or health as engagement tools, because people remember what they actively recall far better than what they are told.

Model answer: How is hosting a quiz different from competing in one?

Competing tests recall, teamwork and the nerve to take risks in pounce rounds. Hosting is closer to administration. I have to research widely, fact-check every answer, set a fair difficulty curve, phrase questions so they cannot be read two ways, and handle disputes neutrally in front of an audience. One ambiguous question can damage confidence in the whole result. When I hosted inter-college quizzes I learnt to publish rules in advance and to keep a second source for each answer. That is the same discipline I would apply to transparent procedures and grievance redress in public office.

Common traps

- Not being able to name Indian quizmasters or famous formats when the hobby claims depth
- Treating quizzing as rote GK and not explaining workability, connections or inference
- Overclaiming knowledge, then failing simple rapid-fire factual questions the board throws in

Preparation checklist

☐ Learn the history: Neil O'Brien, Derek O'Brien and the Bournvita Quiz Contest, Siddhartha Basu, Quiz Time, Mastermind, KBC

☐ Be able to explain the formats (pounce and bounce, buzzer, connect, written preliminaries)

and the hosting-versus-competing difference

☐ Keep three of your own workable questions ready to put to the board

☐ Revise high-yield 2025–26 facts (sports records, new laws, awards), checked against official sources

☐ Prepare answers on quizzing in the AI age and on quizzes as a tool for citizen engagement (MyGov, SVEEP, Bharat Ko Jano)

HOBBY 22

Debating and Public Speaking

Appears in DAFs as: debating society president, parliamentary debate, MUN, youth parliament, elocution, extempore, public speaking, anchoring. Debaters claim they can argue and persuade, so boards make them perform on the spot and ask about the falling quality of debate in Parliament and public life.

What the board is really testing

- Live performance: a two-minute speech on a topic set on the spot, structured and balanced
- Your view of democratic discourse: parliamentary decorum, disruption, civility and dissent
- Whether you can hold an argument without arrogance, and accept a counterpoint
- Knowledge of formats, great speeches and orators, and constitutional free-speech law
- How persuasion and listening would help in public consultation, grievance hearings and crisis communication

Basics, history and rules

- **British Parliamentary** debate (four teams of two: Opening and Closing Government, Opening and Closing Opposition) is the World Universities Debating Championship format.
- Asian Parliamentary debate is three against three; Points of Information (POIs) let opponents interject during protected-time rules.
- Elocution is a prepared speech judged on delivery; extempore gives short preparation time; Just a Minute tests fluency without hesitation or repetition.
- Aristotle's modes of persuasion: **ethos** (credibility), **pathos** (emotion), **logos** (logic). A good speech balances all three.
- Model United Nations simulates UN committees: position papers, caucuses, resolutions and diplomacy-based consensus.
- A simple two-minute structure: hook, define the motion, two or three arguments with examples, a counterpoint, and a balanced conclusion.

India story and icons

- India's **shastrartha** tradition of structured philosophical debate includes the Shankara–Mandana Mishra debate, with Ubhaya Bharati as judge.
- Akbar's **Ibadat Khana** at Fatehpur Sikri (from 1575) hosted debates among religious scholars; Buddhist councils also settled doctrine through debate.

- Swami Vivekananda's address in Chicago on 11 September 1893 and Nehru's 'Tryst with Destiny' speech on 14–15 August 1947 are landmarks of Indian oratory.
- The Constituent Assembly debated for about three years (two years, 11 months, 18 days), a model of reasoned disagreement.
- Atal Bihari Vajpayee's 1977 Hindi address at the UN General Assembly and his parliamentary wit are often cited as examples of civil debate.
- Amartya Sen's idea of the 'argumentative Indian' frames dissent and debate as part of India's democratic heritage.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Article 19(1)(a)** guarantees free speech, subject to reasonable restrictions under Article 19(2), such as public order, defamation and India's sovereignty.
- **Article 105** gives MPs freedom of speech in Parliament, and Article 194 gives the same to state legislators; Article 121 bars discussing a judge's conduct except during removal proceedings.
- In *Sita Soren v Union of India* (2024) the Supreme Court held that legislative privilege does not protect bribery, overruling the 1998 P.V. Narasimha Rao ruling.
- In *Shreya Singhal* (2015) the Court struck down Section 66A of the IT Act as vague, protecting online speech.
- Parliamentary tools such as Question Hour, Zero Hour (a convention since 1962), adjournment motions and calling-attention motions structure debate.
- The Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs' **Youth Parliament** scheme and the National Youth Parliament Festival build debate culture among students.

Current developments 2025–26

- The Waqf (Amendment) Bill 2025 was debated late into the night in both Houses in April 2025 before it was passed.
- In the 2025 Monsoon Session Parliament held a special discussion on **Operation Sindoor**, a prominent long debate on national security.
- The Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill 2025, on removing ministers held in custody for 30 days, was referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee amid protests.
- Interview boards in CSE 2024 asked debaters about falling debate quality and civility in Parliament, citing the Nehru–Vajpayee era.
- AI debate tools, from IBM's Project Debater (2019) to today's chatbots, raise questions about persuasion, deepfakes and authentic speech.

Science, economics or social angle

- Fear of public speaking (**glossophobia**) is among the most common social fears; structured practice and exposure reduce anxiety.
- The idea of **steelmanning** (stating the strongest version of the other side's argument) reduces polarisation and improves decisions.
- Echo chambers and algorithmic feeds reward outrage over argument, which threatens deliberative democracy.
- Deliberative tools such as citizens' assemblies and gram sabhas turn debate into participatory decision-making.

- Language and access: English-medium debating circuits exclude many people; vernacular debating and elocution contests widen participation.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers persuade constantly: in gram sabhas, public hearings for environmental clearance, land acquisition consultations and inter-departmental meetings.
- **Crisis communication** during floods, riots or epidemics needs clarity, calm and credibility, all of which come from public-speaking practice.
- Debating teaches seeing both sides, which matters for quasi-judicial roles (Revenue Courts, Executive Magistracy) and for natural justice.
- Ethical speech: civil servants must stay politically neutral under the Conduct Rules and must not use oratory for partisan ends.
- Listening is the other half of debating: grievance redress depends on hearing citizens patiently before responding.

Asked in real interviews

1. You were president of the debating society. Why is debating important? **[2024]**
2. What is the point of students debating when debate quality is declining at the highest levels of the country? **[2024]**
3. Parliamentary debates once had civility (Nehru, Vajpayee). How can that culture be restored? **[2024]**
4. Will the nature of debates and democracy change in the future? **[2024]**
5. You debate. Give us a two-minute speech on 'Make India Great Again' so we can vote for you. **[2024]**
6. Your hobby is public speaking. Speak for two minutes on 'Justice delayed is justice denied'. **[2024]**
7. You do elocution. What qualities are necessary, and whom do you admire as a speaker? **[2024]**
8. Do you participate in debates? **[2021]**
9. With your debating and quizzing background, is India a debating society or a compliant society? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. Speak for two minutes on 'Social media has made us louder but not wiser'.
2. Should there be a code of conduct to reduce disruptions in Parliament? Who should enforce it?
3. Who, in your view, is the best orator in Indian history, and why?
4. Can a civil servant who is a strong debater stay politically neutral?
5. What is the difference between debate and argument, and between persuasion and manipulation?
6. You are at a public hearing for a project and the crowd is hostile. How will you speak to them?
7. Does MUN or youth parliament experience actually improve democratic culture?

Model answer: Why should students debate when debate quality is falling in Parliament?

That is exactly why students should debate. Debate trains people to argue with evidence, listen to the other side and accept a counterpoint, which is what is missing when disruption replaces discussion. Our tradition, from shastrartha to the Constituent Assembly's three years of deliberation, shows that disagreement can be productive. The Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs' Youth Parliament scheme exists for this reason. As an administrator I would use the same habits in gram sabhas and public hearings: letting people state their concerns fully, responding with facts and recording dissent. A generation trained in civil debate is the long-term fix for our legislatures.

Model answer: Speak for two minutes on 'Justice delayed is justice denied'.

Justice works only if it arrives in time. An undertrial who spends years in jail for a minor offence is punished before being judged. Delays come from vacancies, frequent adjournments, the state as the biggest litigant and weak case management. But speed is not everything: justice hurried is justice buried, because fair hearing and due process take time. The answer is efficiency without shortcuts: e-courts, Lok Adalats, plea bargaining for petty cases and better prosecution. As a District Magistrate I would use under-trial review committees and cut the government's own appeals. Timely justice protects both rights and trust in institutions.

Common traps

- Making a one-sided, combative speech on the spot instead of a structured, balanced one with a clear conclusion
- Sounding arrogant or argumentative with the board, and treating the interview itself as a debate to win
- Taking partisan political positions on parliamentary disruption instead of focusing on institutions and reforms

Preparation checklist

☐ Practise ten two-minute speeches on governance topics (judicial delay, social media, federalism, slogans like MIGA) using hook, arguments, counterpoint and conclusion

☐ Revise formats (BP, AP, MUN, elocution, extempore), Aristotle's ethos, pathos and logos, and three great Indian speeches with their dates

☐ Revise Articles 19, 105, 118, 121 and 194, the Sita Soren (2024) and Shreya Singhal (2015) rulings, and parliamentary procedures

☐ Prepare a balanced view on parliamentary disruption and civility, with data from PRS session reports checked shortly before the interview

☐ Prepare examples of using persuasion and listening as an officer: public hearings, crisis communication, grievance redress

HOBBY 23

Learning Languages

Appears in DAFs as: learning foreign languages (French, German, Japanese, Spanish), learning Indian languages and dialects, reading Urdu/Sanskrit texts, K-drama-led Korean. Language sits at the junction of identity, federalism, education policy and diplomacy, so one DAF line opens the three-language debate, cadre postings and soft power.

What the board is really testing

- Real proficiency: can you actually speak, read or explain a phrase on demand?
- Your stand on language politics (Hindi, three-language formula, mother-tongue education) without being partisan
- Whether you see language as a governance tool for last-mile communication and grievance redressal
- Cultural depth: literature, idioms and society behind the language, not just apps and certificates
- Consistency between the hobby and your schooling, optional subject and home-state background

Basics, history and rules

- **Critical period hypothesis** (Lenneberg, 1967): native-like accent is easier before puberty, but adults learn grammar and vocabulary efficiently through structured study.
- **CEFR** grades proficiency A1–C2; tests include DELF/DALF (French), Goethe-Zertifikat (German), JLPT N5–N1 (Japanese), DELE (Spanish), TOPIK (Korean), HSK (Mandarin).
- Teaching bodies in India: Alliance Française, Goethe-Institut/Max Mueller Bhavan, Japan Foundation, Instituto Cervantes, King Sejong Institute; JNU and EFLU Hyderabad offer degrees.
- Methods: spaced repetition, comprehensible input (Krashen), immersion, shadowing and language exchange; apps such as Duolingo gamify vocabulary but rarely deliver speaking fluency alone.
- Language versus dialect is often political, not linguistic: 'a language is a dialect with an army and a navy' (Max Weinreich).

India story and icons

- Census 2011 rationalised over 19,500 raw mother-tongue returns into **121 languages** (22 scheduled, 99 non-scheduled) with 10,000-plus speakers each.
- People's Linguistic Survey of India (Ganesh Devy) counted about 780 living languages and estimated roughly 220 lost in fifty years.
- Linguistic reorganisation: Potti Sriramulu's 1952 fast led to Andhra State; Fazl Ali Commission and the States Reorganisation Act, 1956 followed.
- **Classical languages**: Tamil (2004), Sanskrit, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Odia; Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali added in October 2024, making 11.
- Polyglot icons often cited: P.V. Narasimha Rao (reportedly over a dozen languages), Rahul Sankrityayan, and grammarians Panini and Tolkappiyar in the classical tradition.

Institutions, policy and law

- Articles 343–351: Hindi in Devanagari as Union official language, Official Languages Act 1963 continues English; Article 351 directs spread of Hindi.
- **Article 350A** urges primary instruction in mother tongue; Article 350B creates the Special Officer (Commissioner) for Linguistic Minorities, headquartered at Prayagraj.
- Eighth Schedule began with 14 languages; the 92nd Amendment (2003) added Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali, taking it to 22.
- **NEP 2020**: home language as medium at least till Grade 5, preferably Grade 8; flexible three-language formula, two of them native Indian languages, none imposed.
- Bhashini (National Language Translation Mission, MeitY, 2022) builds open AI translation; CIIL Mysuru runs SPPEL for endangered languages; Supreme Court translates judgments into regional languages.
- UPSC permits the interview in English, Hindi or any Eighth Schedule language; IAS probationers must pass a cadre-language exam, and IFS officers learn a compulsory foreign language.

Current developments 2025–26

- Maharashtra's 2025 orders making Hindi a third language from Class 1 drew protests and were withdrawn in June 2025, with an expert committee set up to re-examine.
- Tamil Nadu and the Centre clashed in 2025 over the three-language formula and withheld Samagra Shiksha funds linked to PM SHRI and NEP adoption.
- October 2024 classical-language additions expanded funding for centres of excellence, translation and research in Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali.
- AI translation (Bhashini, large language models) is shifting debate from 'which link language' to 'translation-first' service delivery in courts, Parliament and e-governance.
- UNESCO's International Decade of Indigenous Languages (2022–2032) frames India's tribal-language documentation; 21 February is International Mother Language Day.

Science, economics or social angle

- Bilingualism builds **cognitive reserve**: a 2013 Hyderabad study (Alladi et al., Neurology) found dementia onset about 4.5 years later in bilinguals.
- English carries a measurable wage premium in India's labour market, which drives parental demand for English-medium schooling over mother-tongue instruction.
- Children learn concepts best in the home language; foundational literacy gaps (NIPUN Bharat, ASER data) widen when school language differs from home language.
- Language death follows economic migration and stigma; intergenerational transmission, not dictionaries, decides survival.
- Foreign-language skills feed export services: Japanese for IT and manufacturing tie-ups, German for nursing and skilled-migration pacts, French for Africa-facing trade.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A collector who speaks the local dialect hears grievances directly, reduces intermediary capture and builds trust in tribal and border districts.
- Linguistic minorities' rights (Articles 29, 30, 347, 350A) must be protected in schooling, signage and recruitment exams.

- Public communication should be multilingual: forms, helplines, court orders and disaster alerts in local languages improve compliance and access to justice.
- Ethical restraint: officers must avoid partisan language politics and respect every language equally, whatever their personal preference.
- Diplomacy and investment: language skills help in Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat, Kashi Tamil Sangamam-type outreach, and handling foreign investors or delegations.

Asked in real interviews

1. Your hobby is learning different languages and dialects: how many languages do you know?
2. Can you speak, read and write Bengali? **[2024]**
3. Why is there a trend nowadays of children learning languages other than their mother tongue? **[2024]**
4. How feasible is it to teach multiple languages to children? **[2023]**
5. Are you comfortable in Hindi? **[2023]**
6. Foreign schools in India teach foreign languages; is that right when we cannot focus on our own native languages?
7. Which language did you learn in at primary level, and could you grasp subjects well in it?
8. Mother tongue–English–Hindi or mother tongue–Hindi–English: which order should schools follow?
9. You studied Sanskrit in Class 10; do you remember it? Complete the shloka 'Vidya dadati vinayam'. **[2021]**
10. Do you read Urdu? Do you read Ghalib? What does 'Bazicha-e-atfal' mean? **[2025]**
11. From your K-drama interest: do you read Korean literature, and what is 'nunchi' in Korean society? **[2024]**
12. After asking the candidate's native language, the chairperson conversed with them in Tamil for about a minute. **[2021]**
13. Chairman asked the candidate to answer in Hindi, saying they must surely know Hindi. **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Say a few sentences about yourself in the foreign language you are learning, and translate them for us.
2. Which proficiency level have you reached, and how do you measure it?
3. Is the three-language formula a unifying policy or an imposition? Give both sides.
4. With AI translation like Bhashini, why should anyone learn a new language?
5. As DM of a tribal district where you do not know the dialect, how will you communicate with people?
6. Should English remain the language of the higher judiciary under Article 348?
7. Why are Indian languages dying, and what can a district administration do about it?
8. You learn German or Japanese: what does India gain from those countries, and what is their language policy?

Model answer: If AI translation tools like Bhashini can translate instantly, isn't learning languages an outdated hobby?

I don't think so. Translation tools are excellent for forms, court orders and quick service delivery, and Bhashini is already being used across government apps. But a language carries tone, idiom and trust, which machines still miss. When a tribal woman explains a land grievance in her dialect, an officer who understands her directly catches nuance and avoids middlemen distorting her case. So I see AI as a force multiplier: it handles volume, while human language skills handle empathy and judgement. As an administrator I would use both, and I would also push for local-language datasets so smaller languages are not left out.

Model answer: Is the three-language formula a tool of national integration or of Hindi imposition?

The formula, from the 1968 education policy and retained flexibly in NEP 2020, aims at multilingual citizens and mobility. Its integrative value is real: learning another Indian language builds empathy across regions. However, implementation matters. When states feel a third language is mandated without choice, resistance follows, as Maharashtra's 2025 rollback showed. NEP itself says no language will be imposed. I would favour state choice, quality teachers and mother-tongue foundation first. As an officer, my duty would be to implement the policy sensitively, protect linguistic minorities under Article 350A, and keep personal language preferences out of public work.

Common traps

- Listing a language you cannot speak a sentence in; boards test proficiency on the spot or switch to that language.
- Taking a partisan side on Hindi or Tamil language politics instead of citing constitutional provisions and balanced arguments.
- Knowing only app streaks and certificates, but nothing about the country's culture, literature, or India's relations with it.

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare a two-minute self-introduction and a district description in each language listed, and be ready to translate.

☐ Revise Articles 343–351, the Eighth Schedule, the Official Languages Act 1963, NEP 2020 language provisions and the 11 classical languages.

☐ Know one author, one film, one idiom and current India relations for each foreign language you study.

☐ Prepare balanced views on the three-language formula, English in courts, and AI translation (Bhashini).

☐ Link the hobby to administration: cadre-language exam, grievance hearings, tribal outreach and multilingual public communication.

HOBBY 24

Stamp & Coin Collecting

Appears in DAFs as: philately, stamp collection, numismatics, coin collection, currency notes, first-day covers. Stamps and coins are miniature records of history, economy and state symbolism, so boards jump from your oldest coin to the RBI, crypto and India Post.

What the board is really testing

- Genuine engagement: size, oldest item, how the collection began and how it is catalogued
- Historical depth: punch-marked coins to Gupta dinars, Scinde Dawk to the first stamp of free India
- Monetary and postal institutions: who issues coins and notes, RBI's role, India Post's relevance
- Views on the digital shift: UPI, crypto, CBDC, email replacing letters and stamps
- Legal and ethical awareness: antiquities law, treasure finds, fakes and illicit trade

Basics, history and rules

- **Numismatics** studies coins, tokens, notes and medals; grading considers condition, mint mark, die variety and rarity. **Philately** studies stamps, covers, postmarks and postal history.
- The world's first adhesive stamp, the Penny Black, was issued in Britain in 1840 under Rowland Hill's uniform penny-post reform.
- Lydian electrum coins (about 7th century BCE) are among the earliest; India's silver **punch-marked coins** (karshapana) date to roughly the 6th century BCE Mahajanapadas.
- Collector terms: first-day cover, miniature sheet, se-tenant, cancellation, overprint, error/variety; for coins, proof, uncirculated, commemorative, legend, obverse and reverse.
- Care: acid-free albums, stamp tongs, low humidity; never clean old coins chemically, as patina affects value and historical evidence.

India story and icons

- **Scinde Dawk** (1852, Karachi, under Bartle Frere) was Asia's first postage stamp; the first all-India stamps bearing Queen Victoria followed in 1854.
- First stamp of independent India, 'Jai Hind' (21 November 1947), showed the national flag; Gandhi stamps of August 1948 are among India's most valuable issues.
- Coin milestones: Indo-Greek portrait coins, Kushana gold, **Gupta dinars** (Samudragupta's veena-player type), Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency, Sher Shah Suri's silver rupiya.
- Decimal coinage began on 1 April 1957 (naya paisa); the ₹ symbol, designed by D. Udaya Kumar, was adopted in July 2010.
- The National Philatelic Museum is at Dak Bhawan, Sansad Marg, New Delhi; the RBI Monetary Museum in Mumbai displays India's currency history.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Coinage Act, 2011**: the Government of India alone designs and mints coins; RBI only distributes them (RBI Act, Section 38). RBI issues notes under Section 22; ₹1 notes are issued by the government.

- SPMCIL runs the four mints (Mumbai, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Noida) and security presses; India Security Press, Nashik prints postage stamps.
- **Antiquities and Art Treasures Act, 1972**: coins over 100 years old are antiquities; export needs permission, and ASI registers notified items. Indian Treasure Trove Act, 1878 requires finds be reported.
- **Post Office Act, 2023** replaced the Indian Post Office Act, 1898, effective June 2024; India is a Universal Postal Union member since 1876, and World Post Day is 9 October.
- Collector schemes: Philatelic Deposit Account (about ₹200 minimum), My Stamp personalised sheets (2011), and **Deen Dayal SPARSH** scholarships for philatelist students in Classes VI–IX.

Current developments 2025–26

- October 2025: a commemorative ₹100 coin and postage stamp marked the RSS centenary, with the coin reported to carry Bharat Mata imagery.
- India Post launched **DIGIPIN** (2025), a geo-coded digital address grid, and has been merging services such as registered post into Speed Post as letter volumes fall.
- ₹2000 notes, withdrawn from circulation in May 2023, remain legal tender; most have returned to RBI, a recurring question on demonetisation versus withdrawal.
- Crypto stays unbanned but taxed at 30% plus 1% TDS since 2022, with exchanges registered with FIU-IND under PMLA; the RBI pilots e₹ (CBDC) since late 2022.
- El Salvador made bitcoin acceptance voluntary in 2025 under an IMF programme, a useful counterpoint when boards ask about crypto as legal tender.

Science, economics or social angle

- Coins are durable, low-denomination currency: a coin lasts decades while low-value notes wear out fast, which is why ₹10 and ₹20 shifted towards coins.
- Metal content matters: when metal value exceeds face value, coins get melted, so mints adopt cheaper alloys such as ferritic stainless steel.
- Accessibility design: distinct sizes and edges help visually impaired users; the ₹20 coin (2019) is 12-sided, and RBI's MANI app identifies notes.
- Philately as soft power: stamps narrate national priorities, from yoga and freedom fighters to joint issues with foreign countries.
- Digital payments (UPI) reduce cash use for small transactions, threatening coin circulation and letter mail, yet both remain vital for financial inclusion and the offline poor.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Collectors handle treasure-trove finds and antiquities seizures; officers must prevent illegal sale of hoards and route finds to ASI and museums.
- Counterfeit currency (FICN) links to terror financing; NIA and district police depend on detection training and bank reporting.
- Post offices are last-mile government outlets: India Post Payments Bank, DBT, Aadhaar services and savings schemes in remote villages.
- Ethics: buy only provenance-documented items, avoid looted antiquities, and refuse gifts of rare coins or stamps under conduct rules.
- District heritage: local museums, coin exhibitions and philatelic clubs can drive school heritage education under initiatives like Dhai Akhar letter-writing.

Asked in real interviews

1. Tell me the history of philately. **[2023]**
2. Where exactly is the philately museum in Delhi? **[2023]**
3. From numismatics, explain one unique thing you have learned. **[2021]**
4. Linked to numismatics: what about cryptocurrency and its regulation? Who issues coins in India? **[2021]**
5. You collect coins: how did you develop interest in that? **[2023]**
6. With respect to coins, what else do you learn from them? **[2023]**
7. Tell me the oldest coins in your collection. **[2023]**
8. Which is your favourite coin in history? **[2024]**
9. Why does India not widely print currency notes above ₹100, unlike the widespread US $100 note? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Who designs and mints coins in India, and how is that different from note issuance?
2. Is collecting stamps relevant when hardly anyone writes letters now?
3. Tell us about India's first stamp and the first stamp of independent India.
4. What does a Gupta gold coin tell a historian about the economy of that time?
5. Should India give crypto legal-tender status? What did El Salvador's experience show?
6. As DM, villagers find a pot of old coins while digging. What will you do?
7. What does the Post Office Act 2023 change, and why was it criticised?
8. Which commemorative coin or stamp released recently stood out to you, and why?

Model answer: In the age of UPI and email, isn't collecting coins and stamps a dying, irrelevant hobby?

Their use as payment and postage is shrinking, but their value as historical records is not. A punch-marked coin or a Gupta dinar tells us about trade, metallurgy and political authority; a 1947 Jai Hind stamp captures how a new nation chose to present itself. The hobby also keeps institutions alive: India Post still reaches remote villages, and philately supports schemes like Deen Dayal SPARSH for school students. As an administrator I would use collections in district museums and school heritage clubs, and I would handle treasure-trove finds under the 1878 Act so that history reaches the public rather than private markets.

Model answer: Villagers digging a pond under MGNREGA find a pot of old coins. As District Collector, what will you do?

First, secure the site and the hoard with police and revenue staff, list the items before witnesses, and stop any private distribution. Under the Indian Treasure Trove Act, 1878, the Collector decides on the find, and since coins over a hundred years old are antiquities under the 1972 Act, I would inform the Archaeological Survey of India and state archaeology department for assessment. I would recognise the finders, since the law allows reward or compensation, so that future finds are reported rather than sold. Finally, the coins should go to a museum, ideally with a local display, turning a legal process into community heritage.

Common traps

• Over-preparing coin trivia while ignoring institutions; boards ask who mints coins, RBI's role, crypto and antiquities law more than rare varieties.

• Confusing the Coinage Act (government mints coins) with the RBI Act (RBI issues notes), or calling ₹2000 withdrawal a demonetisation.

• Not knowing your own collection: count, oldest item, its period and metal, and how you acquired it.

Preparation checklist

☐ Memorise your collection: number of items, oldest coin or stamp, its ruler or year, metal or printing, and source.

☐ Revise the coin timeline (punch-marked to Sher Shah to decimal) and the stamp timeline (Scinde Dawk 1852 to Jai Hind 1947).

☐ Learn the Coinage Act 2011, RBI Act Sections 22 and 38, Antiquities Act 1972, Treasure Trove Act 1878 and Post Office Act 2023.

☐ Track recent commemorative coins and stamps, CBDC pilots, crypto taxation and India Post reforms such as DIGIPIN.

☐ Prepare situational answers on treasure finds, counterfeit currency and gifts of rare items under conduct rules.

HOBBY 25

Podcasts & Documentaries

Appears in DAFs as: listening to podcasts, audiobooks, watching documentaries (wildlife, environment, social, space), true-crime and history podcasts. It shows how a candidate consumes information, so boards test what you last heard or watched, its social message, and your views on media regulation and misinformation.

What the board is really testing

• Recall and specificity: the last podcast or documentary, its maker, argument and your takeaway

• Critical thinking: can you separate facts, framing and bias in persuasive media?

• Views on media ethics: trial by media, crime coverage, glorification, obscenity and free speech

• Awareness of regulation: IT Rules 2021, Cinematograph Act, CBFC, OTT self-regulation

• Whether passive consumption converts into action, writing or public communication skills

Basics, history and rules

- John Grierson coined 'documentary' (1926), defining it as the 'creative treatment of actuality'; Robert Flaherty's Nanook of the North (1922) is an early landmark.
- Bill Nichols' six modes: poetic, expository, observational, participatory, reflexive and performative; each makes different truth claims.
- 'Podcast' (iPod plus broadcast) was coined in 2004; formats include interviews, narrative non-fiction, explainers, true crime and daily news briefs.

- Audiobooks are narrated books; podcasts are episodic and serialised. Both depend on RSS feeds or platform apps such as Spotify, Apple Podcasts, Audible and YouTube.
- Evaluate any documentary by funding, access, editing choices, missing voices and whether claims are sourced.

India story and icons

- Films Division (1948) produced newsreels and documentaries; in 2022 it merged into NFDC along with the Directorate of Film Festivals, NFAI and CFSI.
- **The Elephant Whisperers** (Kartiki Gonsalves) won the 2023 Oscar for Best Documentary Short; Period. End of Sentence (2019) also won in that category.
- All That Breathes (Shaunak Sen) won Cannes' L'Œil d'or (2022) and an Oscar nomination; Writing with Fire and To Kill a Tiger were also Oscar-nominated.
- Anand Patwardhan (Ram ke Naam, Reason) is India's best-known political documentarian; the Mumbai International Film Festival (MIFF) showcases documentaries.
- Government audio: **Mann Ki Baat** began on All India Radio in October 2014 and crossed its 100th episode in April 2023.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Cinematograph Act, 1952**: CBFC certification is needed for public exhibition; the 2023 amendment added anti-piracy penalties and UA 7+, 13+, 16+ age ratings.
- **IT Rules 2021**, Part III: Code of Ethics for OTT and digital news publishers, self-classification and a three-tier grievance system under MIB.
- Section 69A of the IT Act allows blocking content for sovereignty, security or public order; Shreya Singhal (2015) upheld it with procedural safeguards.
- The draft Broadcasting Services (Regulation) Bill (2023) proposed bringing OTT and online creators under regulation; a revised 2024 draft was withdrawn for wider consultation.
- Courts restrain 'trial by media' through sub judice contempt and privacy rulings (Puttaswamy, 2017); crime reporting must protect victims, minors and the accused's presumption of innocence.

Current developments 2025–26

- February 2025: the India's Got Latent row led the Supreme Court to question obscenity online and ask for guidelines; MIB advised OTT platforms to follow the Code of Ethics.
- WAVES summit (Mumbai, May 2025) promoted the creator economy, announcing a creator fund and the Indian Institute of Creative Technology.
- Prasar Bharati launched its OTT platform WAVES (November 2024), carrying Doordarshan and AIR archives, documentaries and podcasts.
- No Other Land, a Palestinian–Israeli collective documentary, won Best Documentary Feature at the March 2025 Oscars, renewing debate on documentary as activism.
- Generative AI voice cloning now produces podcasts and narration, raising consent, deepfake and copyright concerns for voice artists and platforms.

Science, economics or social angle

- **Parasocial relationships** (Horton and Wohl, 1956): listeners feel intimacy with hosts, which builds trust but can spread unverified claims.

- Audio suits multitasking and low-literacy audiences, so podcasts and community radio reach people print cannot; India has hundreds of licensed community radio stations.
- Industry reports often rank India among the largest podcast-listening markets, driven by cheap data, regional-language shows and YouTube video podcasts.
- Documentaries can shift policy: wildlife films build conservation support, while exposés on caste, gender or pollution spark public debate and litigation.
- Echo chambers: recommendation algorithms favour engagement, so balanced consumption needs deliberate diversity of sources.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers can use short audio and video for public outreach: vaccination drives, Swachh Bharat, disaster alerts, and grievance-redress explainers in local dialects.
- Documentaries are training tools at academies for case studies on disasters, conflicts and service delivery failures.
- Content regulation must balance Article 19(1)(a) with 19(2) restrictions; officers should apply blocking powers narrowly, with reasons and proportionality.
- Misinformation management: district fact-check cells, rapid rebuttals and trusted local voices work better than blanket internet shutdowns.
- Ethics: officers appearing on podcasts must follow conduct rules, avoid political commentary and protect confidential information.

Asked in real interviews

1. What kind of podcasts do you listen to, and which one did you last listen to? (Follow-ups on true crime and the Aarushi Talwar case) **[2022]**
2. What is the media's role in covering crime, and what are Supreme Court guidelines on crime coverage? **[2022]**
3. You listen to a space podcast: do you believe in alien civilisation? **[2024]**
4. From the Carl Sagan series: he mentions a Rigveda connection with the Big Bang; what is it? **[2024]**
5. Are you a reader or a listener? Which app do you use for audiobooks, and what is its subscription rate? **[2024]**
6. Can AI replace voice artistry, given so many songs and YouTube videos now use AI voices? **[2024]**
7. Which audiobooks have you listened to? Why not read instead? **[2020]**
8. Why do you like audiobooks rather than reading? Which books have you gone through recently? **[2022]**
9. Which documentaries have you seen recently? Name a few documentaries with social underpinnings. **[2024]**
10. What type of documentaries do you watch? **[2020]**
11. Which documentary did you watch recently? **[2021]**
12. Which documentaries do you watch? Which was the recent one?
13. We have movies and documentaries highlighting war heroes; isn't that glorification of war? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Name the last documentary you watched, its director, and one point you disagreed with.

2. Should podcasts and YouTube creators be regulated like broadcasters? Who should do it?
3. Is listening to a podcast as good as reading a book for learning?
4. Documentaries are often one-sided. How do you guard against bias?
5. As DM, a viral podcast spreads false claims about a vaccination drive in your district. What will you do?
6. What is India's Code of Ethics for OTT platforms under the IT Rules 2021?
7. Which Indian documentary deserves a global audience, and why?
8. If you had to make a documentary on your home district, what would it show?

Model answer: Should podcasts and online creators be regulated like TV broadcasters?

Some regulation is needed, but it should be proportionate. Creators reach millions, and episodes such as the 2025 India's Got Latent controversy showed real harms from obscenity and misinformation. Yet podcasts are also cheap platforms for independent and regional voices, and Article 19(1)(a) protects them, with restrictions only under 19(2). I would prefer a graded model: platform-level self-regulation, transparent age ratings, quick grievance redress under the IT Rules 2021, and criminal law only for clear offences. As an administrator I would act through reasoned, narrow orders and build media literacy, rather than blanket takedowns that chill legitimate speech.

Model answer: Documentaries claim to show truth but are often one-sided. How do you watch them critically, and what would you do as an officer if a documentary criticised your district?

I treat a documentary as an argument, not a verdict. I check who funded it, whose voices are missing and whether claims are sourced; Bill Nichols' idea that every documentary has a mode and a viewpoint helps me here. A film like The Elephant Whisperers shows how persuasive storytelling can build support for conservation, but persuasion and accuracy are different things. If a documentary criticised my district, I would first verify the facts. Where it is right, I would correct the failure openly. Where it is wrong, I would respond with data through official channels, never by seeking to suppress it, because public trust depends on transparency.

Common traps

• Naming a podcast or documentary but not knowing its host, director, central argument or a counter-view; boards follow up on content, as in the true-crime case question.

• Claiming 'learning' from audio while being unable to justify why audiobooks or podcasts and not reading; prepare an honest, specific answer.

• Taking extreme positions on content regulation, either 'ban harmful content' or 'no regulation at all', without citing Article 19(2), the IT Rules or due process.

Preparation checklist

☐ Keep a log of your last five podcasts and documentaries: maker, year, thesis, one fact, one criticism and one policy link.

☐ Revise the IT Rules 2021 Code of Ethics, Cinematograph Act amendments (2023), Section 69A IT Act and Shreya Singhal.

☐ Know Indian documentary milestones: The Elephant Whisperers, All That Breathes, Writing with Fire, Films Division's merger into NFDC.

☐ Prepare balanced views on creator regulation, AI voice cloning, trial by media and misinformation.

☐ Draft one administrative use case: a district podcast or short documentary for a welfare scheme in the local dialect.

HOBBY 26

Gaming & Esports

Appears in DAFs as: playing video/mobile games, online games, esports tournaments, virtual football management, Wordle/puzzle apps, following esports. Gaming sits where youth culture, a booming digital economy, addiction concerns and a brand-new central law collide, so boards use it to test whether a candidate can see policy behind play.

What the board is really testing

• Whether you know the legal architecture: the 2025 Online Gaming Act, the 2026 Rules, and the skill-versus-chance jurisprudence

• Whether you can separate esports and social games from real-money gaming and gambling without moralising

• Maturity on addiction, child safety, financial loss and mental health, and what a district officer can actually do

• Awareness of India's economic opportunity: AVGC-XR, game development, jobs, exports and soft power

• Self-awareness: how many hours you play, what the hobby has taught you, and whether you play responsibly

Basics, genres and the skill-chance divide

- Genres: casual/puzzle (Wordle, Candy Crush), battle royale (BGMI, Free Fire), MOBA (League of Legends, Pokemon Unite), sports sims (eFootball, EA FC), strategy and management games.
- **Esports** means organised competitive video gaming with leagues, teams, coaches and prize pools; it is distinct from casual gaming and from betting on outcomes.
- **Game of skill** vs **game of chance**: the test is 'preponderance of skill'. Skill games were historically exempt from the Public Gambling Act, 1867 and state gaming laws.
- SC in State of AP v K Satyanarayana (1968) held rummy mainly a game of skill; Dr K R Lakshmanan (1996) held horse-race betting skill-based.
- Punjab & Haryana HC (Varun Gumber, 2017) held Dream11-style fantasy sports skill-based; the SC dismissed the SLP. Courts repeatedly upheld the skill exemption until the 2025 Act changed the frame.
- Free-to-play economics: revenue comes from in-app purchases, loot boxes, battle passes and ads, which raise consumer-protection and child-spending concerns.

India story and icons

- India is one of the world's largest gamer bases by downloads, driven by cheap data post-2016 and low-cost smartphones; mobile dominates over PC and console.
- PUBG Mobile was blocked in September 2020 among 118 apps under **Section 69A** of the IT Act; its Indian version BGMI was blocked in 2022 and allowed back in 2023.
- Esports debuted as a medal sport at the Hangzhou Asian Games (held 2023); India competed in DOTA 2, FIFA Online 4, Street Fighter V and League of Legends.
- For Aichi-Nagoya 2026 (19 Sep to 4 Oct), OCA expanded esports to 11 medal events; MYAS approved a 15-athlete Indian esports contingent on 22 August 2026.
- India's 2026 contingent played League of Legends, Pokemon Unite, Puyo Puyo Champions and eFootball; media reports indicate the esports squad returned without a medal.
- Prime Minister met top Indian gamers in April 2024 and said over-regulating the industry was not ideal, signalling support for creators and esports.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025** (passed August 2025): bans online money games whether skill or chance, bars their ads and bank/payment facilitation, and promotes esports and social games.
- Penalties under the Act: offering money games can attract up to 3 years' jail and/or Rs 1 crore fine; advertising them up to 2 years and/or Rs 50 lakh.
- **Online Gaming Rules, 2026** notified 22 April 2026, in force 1 May 2026; they set up the **Online Gaming Authority** chaired by a MeitY Additional Secretary with MHA, MIB, MYAS, DFS and Legal Affairs members.
- Rules: registration is mandatory for games offered as esports, certificates valid up to 10 years; grievance path runs provider, then Authority, then appeal to the MeitY Secretary.
- Allocation of Business (Dec 2022): MeitY is nodal for online gaming, MYAS for esports as part of multi-sport events; betting and gambling remain Entry 34, State List.
- Supreme Court has taken up all challenges to the 2025 Act; in August 2026 a bench led by CJI Surya Kant agreed to a final hearing on issues including Parliament's legislative competence.

Current developments 2025–26

- Real-money gaming firms shut or pivoted their money formats after August 2025, shifting to free-to-play, esports and overseas markets; job losses became a key criticism.
- Rules 2026 define how to determine an 'online money game' using factors such as stake, expectation of winnings, revenue model and redeemability of in-game assets.
- GST: 28% on full deposit value applied to online gaming from October 2023; under GST rationalisation in 2025, betting, gambling and online money gaming moved to the 40% slab.
- Esports at Asian Games 2026 had 11 titles including Street Fighter 6, Honor of Kings, PUBG (Asian Games version), Gran Turismo 7 and Naraka: Bladepoint.
- A PIL seeking action against gambling platforms disguised as social or esports games is also being heard with the Act challenges.

Science, economics and social angle

- WHO's ICD-11 recognises **gaming disorder** (code 6C51), effective 2022: impaired control, priority over other activities, and continuation despite harm for at least 12 months.

- Positive evidence: action games improve visual attention and reaction time; strategy games aid planning; gamified learning improves engagement when tied to curricula.
- Dark patterns such as loot boxes, variable rewards and pay-to-win exploit dopamine-driven reward loops, which is why consumer and child-protection lenses apply.
- **AVGC-XR** sector: a national Centre of Excellence, the Indian Institute of Creative Technology in Mumbai, was announced and launched around WAVES 2025 to build animation, gaming and XR talent.
- Social angle: gaming is a stigma-laden career choice for many families, gender gaps persist in esports, and online harassment and toxic chats are widespread.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District role: cyber cells and police act on illegal betting apps, mule bank accounts and loan-app links; banks are barred from processing money-game payments.
- Schools and parents: digital-wellbeing sessions, screen-time norms and counselling via Tele-MANAS (14416) can address problem gaming among adolescents.
- Gamification in governance: quizzes on MyGov, simulation-based disaster drills and gamified financial-literacy modules can raise citizen engagement.
- Ethical tensions: paternalism vs individual liberty, revenue vs harm, and innovation vs child protection; proportionality (Puttaswamy, 2017) is the test for restrictions.
- Officers can use esports events and gaming cafes as youth-outreach platforms for drug awareness, cyber-hygiene and voter-registration campaigns.

Asked in real interviews

1. What is the government's view on online games? **[2022]**
2. Is there any Act for regulating games, and are there rules under it? **[2022]**
3. Is there any authority that oversees these gaming regulations? **[2022]**
4. Is rummy a game of skill or a game of chance? **[2022]**
5. What is the difference between a game of skill and a game of chance? **[2022]**
6. Chairman's follow-up: is life a game of skill or a game of chance? **[2022]**
7. What is the government's stance on online gaming? **[2023]**
8. How would you make parents aware about allowing their children to play games? **[2023]**
9. What are the benefits of online gaming for India? **[2023]**
10. What yardstick should decide which online games are allowed and which are not? **[2023]**
11. Discussion on real-money online games (summarised by the candidate). **[2023]**
12. Link between Gandhi's views and gaming (summarised by the candidate). **[2023]**
13. You participate in online virtual football management tournaments. Elaborate. Do you play football in real life? **[2022]**
14. You list sudoku as a hobby; why is Wordle becoming so popular? **[2021]**

Expected questions

1. What is the difference between esports, online social games and online money games under the 2025 Act?
2. Should India have banned real-money gaming outright, or regulated it like many other countries do?
3. Is gaming addiction a disease? What does WHO say, and what would you do about it as a DM?

4. Name India's esports titles at the 2026 Asian Games. Why has India not won esports medals yet?
5. Betting is a State subject. How then could Parliament pass the Online Gaming Act?
6. How many hours a week do you play? Has gaming ever affected your preparation?
7. As SP, you find students losing money on an offshore betting app disguised as a game. What steps will you take?
8. How can India become a game-development hub rather than just a consumer market?

Model answer: Was banning all online money games, including skill-based ones, the right decision?

I see merit on both sides. The Act of 2025 responded to real harm: debt, addiction and even suicides linked to money games, along with money laundering through offshore platforms. Courts had long called rummy a skill game, but stakes, not skill alone, drive the harm. Still, a blanket ban risks pushing users to illegal offshore sites and has cost jobs. As an administrator, I would enforce the law firmly through cyber cells and bank coordination, while supporting evidence-based review, so that legitimate esports and game development grow and the Online Gaming Authority's decisions stay transparent.

Model answer: You are a gamer. How would you convince a parent that gaming is not a waste of time?

I would not deny the parent's worry; WHO recognises gaming disorder, and excess screen time does harm sleep and studies. But I would distinguish between compulsive use and structured play. Strategy and team games taught me planning, quick decision-making and coordination. India now sends esports athletes to the Asian Games with MYAS approval, and the AVGC sector offers careers. I would suggest agreed time limits, no money-based games, and playing together. As an officer, I would back school digital-wellbeing programmes so that families get guidance rather than blanket bans or blind permission.

Common traps

• Saying rummy or fantasy sports are 'legal because they are skill games' without knowing the 2025 Act now bans all online money games regardless of skill

• Treating esports and gambling as the same thing, or defending loot boxes and betting apps as harmless fun

• Overclaiming: listing gaming but being unable to name titles you play, India's Asian Games esports titles, or hours you actually spend

Preparation checklist

☐ Read the Online Gaming Act 2025 and Rules 2026 summary: three categories, penalties, Online Gaming Authority composition, effective date 1 May 2026

☐ Learn three cases: K Satyanarayana (1968), Dr K R Lakshmanan (1996), Varun Gumber (2017), plus the pending Supreme Court challenge

☐ Know India's esports record: Hangzhou titles, the 11 titles and Indian contingent at Aichi-Nagoya 2026, and the Esports Federation of India

☐ Prepare a 60-second answer on what your game taught you, with one concrete incident, and

an honest answer on weekly hours

☐ Revise WHO gaming disorder, GST on online gaming, Section 69A app blocking, AVGC-XR and IICT Mumbai

HOBBY 27

Coding & Technology

Appears in DAFs as: programming, competitive coding, building apps/websites, hackathons, robotics, electronics repair, tech tinkering. Coding lets boards test whether a candidate's technical skill translates into judgement about AI, data, jobs and digital governance, India's defining administrative frontier.

What the board is really testing

- Depth: can you explain your languages, projects and a technical concept simply to a layperson
- Judgement on AI: jobs, ethics, bias, deepfakes and regulation, not just enthusiasm
- Understanding of India's digital public infrastructure and how technology reaches the last mile
- Whether you see technology as a tool for citizens rather than an end in itself
- Why you are leaving a tech career or hobby for civil services, and how you will use the skill

Basics and concepts you must explain simply

- Compiled vs interpreted: C++ compiles to machine code; Java compiles to bytecode run on the JVM ('write once, run anywhere'); Python is interpreted and dynamically typed.
- Core ideas: algorithm, data structure, time complexity (Big-O), open source, version control (Git), APIs, cloud computing and databases.
- **AI vs ML**: AI is the broad goal of machine intelligence; machine learning learns patterns from data; deep learning uses multi-layer neural networks; LLMs are trained on large text corpora.
- Competitive programming (Codeforces, CodeChef, ICPC) builds problem decomposition and speed; hackathons build teamwork and prototyping under deadlines.
- Hardware tinkering: sensors, microcontrollers (Arduino, Raspberry Pi), IoT; Li-Fi transmits data through modulated light and is hard to intercept beyond line of sight.
- Security basics: encryption, two-factor authentication, phishing, ransomware and bots; quantum computing threatens current public-key encryption.

India story and icons

- India's IT-BPM sector, led by clusters in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune and Chennai, grew from 1990s offshoring; Infosys, TCS and Wipro became global brands.
- Clusters thrived on engineering colleges, STPI policy, airports, venture capital and network effects; tier-2 cities now attract GCCs (global capability centres).
- **India Stack**: Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, eSign and DEPA; UPI handles the majority of India's digital retail payments and has been offered to other countries.
- Icons: Nandan Nilekani (Aadhaar), Sam Pitroda (telecom), F C Kohli (father of Indian IT), and engineers behind ISRO's software and the CoWIN platform.

- India has one of the world's largest and fastest-growing developer communities on GitHub, with strong open-source contribution.

Institutions, policy and law

- **IT Act, 2000**: Sec 43A, 66 (computer offences), 69A (blocking), 79 (intermediary safe harbour); IT Rules 2021 impose due-diligence and grievance duties on platforms.
- **Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023**: consent-based processing, data fiduciary duties, Data Protection Board; DPDP Rules were notified in November 2025 with phased implementation.
- **IndiaAI Mission** (Rs 10,372 crore, approved March 2024): subsidised GPU compute, foundation models, datasets platform (AIKosh), skilling and safe-and-trusted AI pillars.
- Other bodies: MeitY, CERT-In (incident reporting within 6 hours), NIC, C-DAC, NASSCOM; PM WANI for public Wi-Fi; National Quantum Mission (2023).
- Shreya Singhal (2015) struck down Sec 66A; Puttaswamy (2017) made privacy a fundamental right, framing all data and surveillance policy.

Current developments 2025–26

- India hosted the **AI Impact Summit** in New Delhi in February 2026, the first such global AI summit in the Global South, themed on people, planet and progress.
- MeitY amended IT Rules in early 2026 to require labelling of synthetically generated content and faster takedown of deepfakes by platforms.
- DPDP Rules 2025 began phased rollout: the Data Protection Board first, with full consent-manager and fiduciary obligations later.
- Generative AI is reshaping IT services hiring; firms report fewer entry-level roles and more demand for AI, cloud and cybersecurity skills.
- India Semiconductor Mission: first commercial chips from domestic units began rolling out in 2025, alongside several approved fab and ATMP projects.

Science, economics and social angle

- Automation risk: routine coding, testing and support jobs are most exposed; complementary skills like problem framing, domain knowledge and ethics gain value.
- **Digital divide**: gaps by gender, rural-urban location and language; Indic-language AI (Bhashini) and low-cost devices are key to inclusion.
- Bots and algorithms can manipulate discourse through fake engagement, echo chambers and filter bubbles; platform transparency and bot labelling are countermeasures.
- Right to repair: use-and-throw electronics add to e-waste; India launched a Right to Repair portal (2022), and E-Waste Rules 2022 set producer responsibility.
- Brain drain vs brain circulation: Indian engineers abroad create remittances, diaspora networks and returning startup founders.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers who code can build dashboards, automate MIS, clean beneficiary data and spot leakages; examples include e-Office, PFMS and district-level data analytics.
- Tech-for-tourism and service delivery: geo-tagged asset monitoring, chatbots in local languages, QR-based grievance systems and open data portals.

- Ethical issues: algorithmic bias, exclusion errors from Aadhaar authentication failures, surveillance creep, and accountability when AI assists decisions.
- Cyber hygiene for administration: secure handling of citizen data under DPDP, phishing awareness for staff, and CERT-In reporting duties.
- Principle: technology must be assisted, not automated, for vulnerable citizens; keep offline fallbacks, human review and grievance redress.

Asked in real interviews

1. After ChatGPT, will coding still be required? **[2022]**
2. How have competitive coding and puzzle-solving helped you develop yourself? **[2022]**
3. Bots are spamming online platforms; how can we counter them? **[2022]**
4. Is it ethical to use bots to force one's own views on others? **[2022]**
5. Will India continue to lead the IT sector? **[2022]**
6. What is the difference between Java and C++? **[2021]**
7. Why are some cities, like Pune and Bengaluru, good at IT? **[2021]**
8. What would you do to improve the IT industry in other cities and states? **[2021]**
9. How will you use technology to improve tourism? **[2020]**
10. You did a hackathon on automatic irrigation. Explain it. Which sensors did you use? **[2022]**
11. Have you replicated your automatic irrigation project anywhere other than the field? **[2022]**
12. What is Li-Fi technology, and how is it secure? **[2025]**
13. How has electronics shaped the music industry? What technology will we see in the next ten years? **[2025]**
14. People don't repair gadgets nowadays; it is mostly use and throw. Why? **[2025]**
15. What exactly did you do in the electronics repair camp, and did it really have any impact? **[2025]**
16. What did you do as coordinator of the robotics club? Follow-ups on your projects.
17. What is the relevance of nanotechnology today?

Expected questions

1. Explain to a layperson what an algorithm is, using an example from your district or village.
2. What is the IndiaAI Mission, and what did the AI Impact Summit 2026 achieve?
3. Should India regulate AI through a dedicated law like the EU AI Act or through sectoral guidelines?
4. How does UPI work, and why could it not be built by the private sector alone?
5. Will AI take away jobs in Indian IT? What should the government do?
6. You coded projects in college; build me, in two minutes, an app idea for a problem in your home state.
7. A deepfake of you as DM goes viral before an election. What will you do in the first 24 hours?
8. Why leave a technology career, where you could build at scale, to join the civil services?

Model answer: With generative AI writing code, is coding still a useful skill?

I believe coding is changing, not disappearing. AI tools now generate routine code, and IT firms are hiring fewer entry-level programmers, so rote syntax knowledge matters less. But someone must frame the problem, check the output, secure it and take responsibility for it. Coding taught me logical decomposition and debugging, which is valuable even when AI writes lines. For an administrator, this means being able to judge vendor claims, read a data pipeline and spot bias. Under the IndiaAI Mission, government itself will deploy AI; officers who understand code will ask better questions and protect citizens from opaque systems.

Model answer: How would you use your coding skills as a District Collector without compromising citizens' privacy?

I would use coding to make data work for citizens: dashboards for scheme saturation, simple scripts to find duplicate or ineligible beneficiaries, and a local-language WhatsApp grievance tracker. But the DPDP Act, 2023 and the Puttaswamy judgment set limits, so I would follow purpose limitation, collect minimum data, restrict access and log every query. Analysis would flag cases for human verification, never cut benefits automatically, because exclusion errors fall on the poorest. I would work with NIC and CERT-In for security audits, and publish anonymised data so that citizens and researchers can hold the administration accountable.

Common traps

- Listing coding but fumbling basics such as Java vs C++, what an API is, or the logic of your own project, which boards do probe
- Uncritical techno-optimism: claiming AI or apps will solve governance without addressing exclusion, privacy, bias and the digital divide
- Using heavy jargon instead of explaining simply, or being unable to justify leaving a tech job for civil services

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare a one-minute plain-language explanation of each project, language and hackathon in your DAF, including sensors, stack and outcome

☐ Revise IT Act key sections, DPDP Act and Rules, IT Rules 2021 and the 2026 deepfake-labelling amendments, Shreya Singhal and Puttaswamy

☐ Know IndiaAI Mission pillars and outlay, the February 2026 AI Impact Summit, India Semiconductor Mission and National Quantum Mission

☐ Be ready to explain UPI, Aadhaar, Li-Fi, blockchain, AI vs ML and quantum encryption risk in under 60 seconds each

☐ Build three district-level examples where you would use code or data analytics, each with a privacy safeguard

PART IV

Life, Nature and Service

Travel, cooking, gardening, social work, astronomy, birding

HOBBY 28

Travelling

Appears in DAFs as: travelling, solo travel, backpacking, exploring new places, visiting historical sites, travel vlogging/blogging, travel documentaries. Travel claims invite instant cross-examination on places visited and open the whole tourism economy, heritage, infrastructure and overtourism debate.

What the board is really testing

• Observation: did you learn the history, people, economy and problems of the places you visited, or only take photographs?

• Recall under pressure: your last trip, what you saw at a monument, its museum, emblem or local story

• Tourism economics: why India underperforms on foreign arrivals despite its assets; medical, religious, rural and eco-tourism potential

• Governance of tourism: carrying capacity, overtourism protests, sustainability of air travel, infrastructure status and schemes

• Values: openness, adaptability and respect for diversity, plus the ability to compare India with other countries without cynicism

Basics, types and concepts

- Forms: cultural/heritage, religious, eco, adventure, rural, medical and wellness, MICE (meetings, incentives, conferences, exhibitions), cruise and film tourism.
- **Carrying capacity**: the maximum visitors a place can host without degrading ecology, infrastructure or residents' quality of life; overtourism is its breach.
- Responsible tourism: minimise negative impacts, maximise local benefit; Kerala's Responsible Tourism Mission (2017), built on the Kumarakom model (2008), is a global reference.
- A blog is written content; a vlog is video content. Travel influencers shape demand, but 'Instagram tourism' can concentrate crowds at viral spots.
- Tourism Satellite Accounts estimate tourism's share of India's GDP at about 5% and a large share of jobs, much of it informal.

India story and heritage

- **Sarnath became India's 45th World Heritage Site** (July 2026, 48th WHC session, Busan) as a serial property including Dhamekh and Chaukhandi stupas and the Ashokan pillar.
- The Sarnath Lion Capital (four lions, Dharma Chakra of 24 spokes) is India's national emblem, adopted on 26 January 1950; it sits in ASI's Sarnath Museum, India's oldest site museum (1910).
- Maratha Military Landscapes (12 forts) became India's 44th site in July 2025; India now has 37 cultural, 7 natural and 1 mixed (Khangchendzonga) World Heritage Sites.

- Lohagarh Fort, Bharatpur: the 'iron fort' with mud ramparts that withstood British sieges in 1805; Keoladeo National Park nearby is a World Heritage Site.
- Mussoorie hosts LBSNAA (1959), the hill climate and the former Charleville Hotel estate made it a natural campus; Ladakh's high passes and roads attract motor tourists.

Institutions, policy and schemes

- Ministry of Tourism schemes: **Swadesh Darshan 2.0** (destination-centric sustainable tourism), PRASHAD (pilgrimage), Dekho Apna Desh and the Incredible India campaign.
- Union Budget 2025-26: develop 50 top destinations with states in challenge mode; hotels at these sites placed in the infrastructure Harmonised Master List; 'Heal in India' medical tourism push.
- Infrastructure status gives cheaper long-term credit and longer loan tenure, which helps hotels with high capital costs and long payback periods.
- e-Tourist Visa (2014) and later e-Medical visas eased entry; UDAN regional connectivity (2016) opened smaller airports; PRASHAD and Swadesh Darshan fund last-mile facilities.
- Heritage law: Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958 (100 m prohibited and 200 m regulated zones); Adopt a Heritage 2.0 for private amenities.

Current developments 2025–26

- **2025 data**: foreign tourist arrivals fell 8.1% to 91.49 lakh; foreign exchange earnings dropped 9.5% to US$31.69 billion; arrivals from Bangladesh fell 73%.
- Domestic tourist visits rose 45.5% to 428.55 crore in 2025, with Uttar Pradesh (155.74 crore, boosted by the Maha Kumbh) accounting for most of the increase.
- **WEF Travel and Tourism Development Index 2026**: India rose nine places to 31st; Japan ranked first. India scores well on price competitiveness and cultural and natural resources.
- Pahalgam terror attack (22 April 2025) hit Kashmir tourism hard and showed how security shocks hurt tourism-dependent economies.
- Overtourism protests in Spain and other European hotspots (2024–25), and crowding at Himalayan hill stations and char dham sites, have pushed carrying-capacity rules onto India's agenda.

Science, economics and social angle

- Tourism has a high employment multiplier and supports women, artisans and homestay owners; it is a key source of foreign exchange.
- Why foreign arrivals lag: image and safety concerns, especially for women; poor last-mile infrastructure and sanitation; visa and tax complexity; weak global marketing compared with Thailand or Turkey.
- Aviation emissions are a sustainability concern; rail, buses and longer, slower trips reduce footprint. Air connectivity still matters for the North-East and islands.
- Medical tourism draws patients from South Asia, West Asia and Africa for cost-effective quality care; about 4.5 lakh foreigners came for medical purposes in January–November 2025.
- Lessons from abroad: Switzerland's rail-linked mountain tourism and strict zoning offer J&K and Himachal a model of high-value, low-volume tourism.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A district collector manages tourism through destination plans, solid waste and sewage capacity, permit caps, crowd management at fairs and coordination with ASI and forest departments.
- Travel builds empathy for diversity and the 'unity in diversity' outlook needed in All India Services, where officers serve far from home cadres.
- Ethical traveller: respect local customs and sacred sites, avoid exploitative voluntourism and wildlife selfies, and pay fairly for local services.
- Tourism can drive rural renewal: Best Tourism Villages (UN Tourism) and community homestays spread benefits beyond hotspots; renewable energy and connectivity unlock remote destinations.
- Overtourism protests show that residents' consent matters; tourism plans must include local communities, not just visitors and investors.

Asked in real interviews

1. You like exploring new places; where do you like to explore, mountains? What about the costs? **[2021]**
2. Where all have you travelled? **[2022]**
3. What can J&K learn from Switzerland in tourism development? How can we increase the number of foreign tourists? **[2022]**
4. What kind of travelling do you like? You like travelling, so where all have you been? **[2022]**
5. What is the difference between a blog and a vlog? **[2022]**
6. Travelling unsettles you and meditation settles you; how did you develop both? What did you learn from a place? Where did you travel last? **[2022]**
7. What steps did the government take for tourism in the budget? What will happen if tourism is given infrastructure status? **[2022]**
8. We are building new airports and promoting air travel. Is it sustainable? **[2022]**
9. What is tourism's share in Kerala's GDP and what is its potential for development? **[2023]**
10. Travelling to rural areas: what is the potential of renewable energy in rural areas? **[2023]**
11. What do you think about travelling: is it only for photos, videos and show-off, without caring about a place's history and importance? **[2024]**
12. Why have we been unable to achieve our potential in foreign tourist arrivals? What are the opportunities in medical and religious tourism? **[2024]**
13. Places to visit in Bharatpur apart from Lohagarh Fort and Keoladeo? Why do Lohagarh's 'mud fort' walls look like stone? **[2024]**
14. Why is Mussoorie called Mussoorie, and why was LBSNAA set up there? **[2024]**
15. Where did you travel last? You visited Sarnath; did you see the museum? Tell me about the Sarnath lion (capital). **[2025]**
16. Why are we seeing protests against the overflow of tourists at tourist sites? **[2025]**
17. How can Kerala's tourism success be emulated by other states? Why are foreign tourists declining, as in Goa, and how can we improve? **[2025]**
18. Where all have you travelled? Which place is more tourist-friendly and where would you revisit? **[2024]**
19. Which country would you like to visit and why? **[2024]**
20. Where did you travel in Gujarat? What is parasailing and where did you do it? **[2024]**
21. Tell me one place we should surely visit and why. **[2024]**

22. How does travelling help you? **[2021]**
23. Where did you travel last? **[2025]**
24. Your hobby is talking to people from different cultures: how can it help in IFS? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. Tell us about the last place you visited: its history, economy and one problem you noticed there.
2. Sarnath is now a World Heritage Site. What does that status bring, and what are its obligations?
3. Domestic tourism is booming but foreign arrivals fell in 2025. Why, and what should be done?
4. As DM of a hill district, how would you handle overtourism and residents' protests?
5. Is travel a privilege of the rich? How can tourism benefit local communities and not just hotel chains?
6. Compare tourism in India with a country you have visited or studied. What can we learn?
7. How do social media influencers affect tourism, safety and heritage sites?
8. What is carrying capacity and how would you calculate it for a destination?

Model answer: India has world-class heritage, yet foreign tourist arrivals fell in 2025. Why do we underperform?

Our assets are not the problem; the experience around them is. In 2025, foreign arrivals fell 8.1% to about 91.5 lakh, partly because Bangladesh arrivals collapsed, but long-standing issues remain: safety perceptions, especially for women, poor last-mile connectivity and sanitation, touts at monuments, and weak global marketing. The WEF's 2026 index, where India rose to 31st, shows the strengths are real. As an administrator, I would focus on what a district can fix: clean, signposted sites, trained local guides, tourist police, digital ticketing and homestays. Sarnath's new World Heritage status is exactly the kind of place where that work can show results quickly.

Model answer: Residents in many tourist towns are protesting against tourists. Should we limit tourism?

We should manage it, which sometimes means limiting it. Protests in Spain and crowding in our own hill towns arise when visitors' gains go to outsiders while residents bear the costs: traffic, water shortages, garbage and rising rents. Carrying capacity is the key concept: what roads, sewage and ecology can actually sustain. Kerala's Responsible Tourism Mission shows the alternative, where local groups supply food, crafts and experiences, so residents become stakeholders. As DM, I would use daily permit caps at fragile sites, staggered entry, eco-fees spent locally and planned parking at town edges. Tourism that residents resent is not sustainable over time.

Common traps

• Naming places without knowing their history, monuments, museums, emblems or local issues; boards test recall of what you actually saw, as with the Sarnath lion capital

• Presenting travel as a photo or Instagram pursuit, which boards challenge directly, instead of learning about people, economy and governance

• Giving generic tourism answers with no data: not knowing 2025 FTAs, the WEF 2026 rank, key

schemes or the latest World Heritage additions

Preparation checklist

☐ Build a travel log of 8–10 places: state and district, monuments, museum, history, local economy, one problem and one administrative fix for each

☐ Revise heritage facts: India's 45 World Heritage Sites with the 2025 and 2026 additions, national emblem and Sarnath, the AMASR Act and Adopt a Heritage

☐ Learn tourism data and policy: 2025 FTAs, earnings and domestic visits, WEF TTDI 2026, Swadesh Darshan 2.0, PRASHAD, Budget 2025-26 measures and infrastructure status

☐ Prepare comparative examples: Switzerland, Bhutan's high-value low-volume model, Kerala's responsible tourism, and overtourism responses in Venice or Barcelona

☐ Prepare views on sustainable air travel, medical and religious tourism, carrying capacity and safety for women travellers, each with a district-level action

HOBBY 29

Cooking

Appears in DAFs as: cooking, regional/millet cooking, baking, experimenting with traditional recipes. Cooking opens easy doors into nutrition, food security, agriculture prices, regional culture and climate, letting the board test whether a domestic skill has public-policy depth.

What the board is really testing

• Whether the hobby is genuine: what you cook, how often, and the method behind a signature dish

• Awareness of India's food diversity: regional cuisines, GI-tagged foods and the ingredients behind them

• Ability to link the kitchen to policy: food inflation, crop seasons, millets, nutrition and food safety

• Balanced views on contested food questions such as vegetarianism, meat bans and dietary choice

• Practical sense of how food habits connect to health, climate and administration

Basics, history and techniques

- Core methods: dry heat (roasting, tandoor, baking), moist heat (boiling, steaming, **dum** slow-cooking in sealed pots) and fat-based (tadka, deep-frying); each changes texture, nutrients and fuel use.
- **Dum pukht** biryani layers par-cooked rice over marinated meat and seals the handi with dough; 'normal' or kachchi/pakki styles differ in whether meat is raw or pre-cooked.
- Indian cooking rests on the spice tempering (tadka/chhaunk), regional fats (mustard oil in the east, coconut oil in Kerala, ghee in the north) and souring agents like tamarind, kokum and amchur.

- Ayurveda classifies food by taste (shad-rasa) and effect; modern nutrition counts macronutrients, micronutrients and fibre, so a cook should know both vocabularies.
- Food chemistry basics: Maillard browning, fermentation (idli, dhokla, kanji), and that pressure cooking raises water's boiling point to about 120 degrees C, saving fuel.

India story and regional cuisines

- Broad zones: wheat-and-dairy north, rice-fish-mustard east, rice-coconut-tamarind south, millet-pulse west; within each, sub-regions like **Malwa** (dal bafla), Awadh, Chettinad and Kashmiri Wazwan.
- Rajasthan's **ker-sangri** uses desert berries and Khejri beans, dried for storage: a classic drought-adapted cuisine built on scarcity.
- Hyderabadi Haleem (GI), Dharwad Pedha, Bikaneri Bhujia, Odisha Rasagola and Darjeeling Tea (India's first GI, 2004) show food as protected intellectual property.
- India had 822 registered GIs after 125 were added in 2025-26; Uttar Pradesh (79) and Tamil Nadu (74) lead the cumulative tally.
- **Deepavali** became India's 16th UNESCO intangible heritage element in December 2025, at the committee session hosted at Red Fort, New Delhi; festival foods are part of that living heritage.

Institutions, policy and law

- **FSSAI** was set up under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006; it runs Eat Right India, Eat Right Campus, hygiene ratings and labelling rules.
- National Food Security Act, 2013 covers up to 75% rural and 50% urban population; PMGKAY gives free foodgrains to about 81 crore people.
- **PM POSHAN** (school meals) and Mission Poshan 2.0 target child and maternal nutrition; millets and fortified rice are being added to menus.
- India led the UN **International Year of Millets 2023**; millets were rebranded 'Shree Anna' in Budget 2023-24, with IIMR Hyderabad as the Global Centre of Excellence.
- ICMR-NIN's Dietary Guidelines for Indians (2024) advise limiting salt, sugar, ultra-processed food and protein supplements, and recommend diverse plant-based diets.

Current developments 2025-26

- PM's call to cut cooking-oil use by 10% to fight **obesity**; FSSAI asked states/UTs in May 2025 to scale up awareness and measures.
- In August 2025 FSSAI was reported to be preparing a voluntary advisory for restaurants to display **sugar and oil boards** showing content in dishes.
- A Lancet study projects more than 440 million Indians will be overweight or obese by 2050, shifting focus from hunger alone to the double burden of malnutrition.
- Food inflation swings in tomatoes, onions and potatoes (the 'TOP' crops) remain politically sensitive; potato is mainly a **rabi** crop in the Indo-Gangetic plains.
- GI registrations surged with 125 new tags in 2025-26, Madhya Pradesh topping additions (26), reflecting a push to market regional foods.

Science, economics and social angle

- Food systems cause roughly a third of global greenhouse emissions; **rice paddies** emit methane, ruminant meat has the highest footprint, millets need little water.

- Food is a caste, community and gender marker: unpaid cooking falls mostly on women, and meat or beef bans raise questions of choice, livelihood and Article 21 privacy.
- UNEP's Food Waste Index 2024 estimates about 55 kg of household food waste per Indian per year; cold-chain gaps also cause large post-harvest losses.
- The food-processing sector qualifies for **PLI** support and PMKSY; street food sustains millions of informal livelihoods under the PM SVANidhi scheme.
- Fermented and traditional foods support gut health; ultra-processed foods with high fat, sugar and salt drive diabetes and hypertension.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A collector who cooks understands the **mid-day meal** kitchen: hygiene, menu cost norms, fuel, and why food-poisoning incidents need audits, not just suspensions.
- Food safety enforcement: Designated Officers under FSSA 2006, sampling during festivals, and adulteration of milk, sweets and spices.
- Promoting millets through PDS, anganwadis and self-help group cafes links nutrition with farmer incomes and water conservation.
- Disaster and relief management depends on community kitchens; COVID-era kitchens showed the importance of quick, nutritious and culturally acceptable meals.
- Ethically, an officer must respect diverse food choices and avoid imposing personal dietary preferences in public institutions.

Asked in real interviews

1. Should we make the whole country vegan? **[2025]**
2. Just like gambling and alcoholism, should non-vegetarian food also be banned? Can the government do this? **[2025]**
3. Which dish do you like? **[2025]**
4. What inspires you to cook? Is cooking a hobby for you or a compulsion? **[2025]**
5. Compare the carbon footprint of Hyderabadi cuisine and Chennai cuisine. Why the difference? **[2025]**
6. You like cooking; what is the price of potatoes these days? Is potato a kharif or rabi crop? **[2025]**
7. You cook; what are the different Indian cuisines? **[2024]**
8. If someone says they know cooking, what would you ask them to cook? **[2024]**
9. Tell me about the cuisine of Malwa. What is dal bafla? **[2024]**
10. What do you cook? What is the difference between normal and dum biryani, and why is dum special? **[2022]**
11. Some say it is biryani only if it is mutton biryani. What do you say? **[2022]**
12. How is cooking your hobby? What are famous vegetable dishes of the Barmer region, and what is special about ker and sangri? **[2021]**
13. Why are millets not popular? How will you popularise millets? **[2020]**
14. Tell us something about cooking. What do you cook? **[2020]**
15. Do you cook only dal bafla? What is Malwa cuisine and how will you promote it? Know a book on it? **[2024]**
16. Don't you think cooking is a woman's job? Why IAS when you have such a great cooking hobby? **[2024]**

17. Whom did you learn cooking from? South Indian vs Rajasthani cuisine; is Rajasthani food healthy? What is a Michelin chef? **[2024]**
18. Name ten world cuisines, three top Indian dishes and three sweets. **[2024]**
19. How did you get interested in cooking? Why desserts? Are men now adopting cooking? **[2024]**
20. Such an open hobby: can you answer anything about cuisines around the world? **[2025]**
21. You like cooking: what is the price of potatoes these days? **[2025]**
22. Your Maharashtrian cooking speciality? **[2025]**
23. Why does food cook faster in a pressure cooker? **[2025]**
24. Recommend something to try in Mangalorean cuisine. **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the Eat Right India movement and how is FSSAI enforcing food safety in street food?
2. Why is India's obesity rate rising, and is a 10% cut in cooking oil a realistic target?
3. Which dishes of your home state have GI tags, and how does a GI help producers?
4. Should the State regulate what people eat, for example through meat bans on festival days?
5. As collector, a mid-day meal poisoning case is reported in your district. What will you do?
6. How can millets be made part of the daily urban diet rather than a niche health food?
7. How does your cooking hobby connect with your academic background or optional subject?
8. Why do onion, tomato and potato prices fluctuate so sharply, and what can the government do?

Model answer: Should the government ban non-vegetarian food, the way it restricts alcohol or gambling?

I would respectfully disagree. Alcohol and gambling are regulated because of proven social harm, whereas diet is part of personal liberty, culture and livelihood; the Supreme Court's Puttaswamy judgment places such choices within privacy. Meat and fish are also affordable protein for many poor households and coastal communities. The State's legitimate role is in food safety, animal welfare under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, and hygienic slaughter. As an administrator I would ensure licensed, clean meat shops and FSSAI compliance rather than prohibition, while encouraging balanced, plant-rich diets through awareness.

Model answer: Compare the carbon footprint of a meat-heavy cuisine with a rice-based one. Which is greener?

Both have costs, so it depends on the plate. Ruminant meat has the highest emissions per kilogram, but flooded rice paddies emit methane and need heavy irrigation; food systems overall cause about a third of global emissions. A cuisine using millets, pulses, seasonal vegetables and local fish is generally the most sustainable. As a cook I see that pressure cooking and soaking also cut fuel use. As an administrator I would promote millets in PDS and mid-day meals, support direct-seeded rice, and reduce food waste, which UNEP estimates at about 55 kg per Indian household member every year.

Common traps

- Listing cooking but being unable to explain the method, ingredients or regional origin of the dishes you claim to cook
- Ignoring the policy side: not knowing current vegetable prices, crop seasons, FSSAI or millet

initiatives

• Taking an extreme or moralising position on vegetarianism, veganism or meat bans instead of a balanced, rights-based view

Preparation checklist

☐ Master 3-4 signature dishes fully: ingredients, method, regional history and nutrition profile

☐ Learn the cuisine, GI-tagged foods and key crops of your home state and district

☐ Track current retail prices of staples (atta, rice, dal, onion, tomato, potato, edible oil) before the interview

☐ Revise FSSAI, NFSA, PM POSHAN, Poshan 2.0, millets/Shree Anna and the 2025 anti-obesity push

☐ Prepare balanced answers on food choice and the State, food waste, and the carbon footprint of diets

HOBBY 30

Gardening & Kitchen Gardening

Appears in DAFs as: kitchen gardening, terrace/balcony gardening, fruit gardening, potted plants, organic/vegetable farming. Gardening lets the board move quickly from your terrace pots to agriculture, horticulture, soil health, food security and climate, testing both practical knowledge and policy depth.

What the board is really testing

• Whether you actually garden: what you grow, which season, which inputs and what goes wrong

• Scientific grasp of soil, composting, fertilisers, pests and plant biology

• Ability to scale up from a kitchen garden to urban food security, nutrition and waste management

• Informed views on agricultural debates: GM crops, organic and natural farming, cropping patterns

• Administrative imagination: how a collector would use horticulture and nutri-gardens for development

Basics, science and practice

- Plants need light, water, air and nutrients; macronutrients are **N, P, K** (plus Ca, Mg, S), and most vegetables prefer soil pH of about 6 to 7.
- **Vermicompost** is made by feeding kitchen and farm waste to earthworms such as Eisenia fetida in shaded beds; castings are ready in roughly 45 to 60 days.
- Systemic pesticides and fertilisers are absorbed and moved through plant tissues, unlike contact products that act only on surfaces; systemic insecticides like neonicotinoids harm pollinators.

- Good practices: crop rotation, companion planting (marigold with tomato), mulching, drip irrigation, and neem-based or biological pest control.
- Season planning: kharif (monsoon), rabi (winter) and zaid (summer) crops apply to kitchen gardens too; leafy greens, tomato, chilli and brinjal suit most Indian terraces.

India story: horticulture and pioneers

- India is the world's second-largest producer of fruits and vegetables; horticulture output was a final 3,707 lakh tonnes in 2024-25, exceeding foodgrains.
- 2025-26 first advance estimates put horticulture at about 3,708 lakh tonnes, with fruits near 1,187 lakh tonnes and vegetables about 2,162 lakh tonnes.
- **Sikkim** became India's first fully organic state in 2016; Subhash Palekar's Zero Budget Natural Farming inspired Andhra Pradesh's community-managed natural farming.
- Exotic crops such as avocado, dragon fruit (kamalam) and kiwi are spreading in Kerala, Karnataka and the North-East as farmers diversify.
- Average operational landholding is about 1.08 hectares (Agriculture Census 2015-16); over 86% of holdings are small and marginal.

Institutions, policy and law

- **MIDH** (Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture) and the National Horticulture Board support nurseries, protected cultivation and post-harvest infrastructure.
- The **Clean Plant Programme** (approved 2024, about Rs 1,766 crore) aims to provide virus-free planting material for fruit crops.
- Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers' Rights Act, 2001 lets farmers save and sell seed; GI Act, 1999 protects regional produce through the Chennai GI Registry.
- GM crops need GEAC approval under Environment Protection Act rules; Bt cotton is the only commercial GM crop; GM mustard remains before the Supreme Court.
- **Terminator seeds** (genetic use restriction technology) produce sterile seed; India's PPV&FR Act bars registration of varieties containing such technology.

Current developments 2025-26

- The **National Mission on Natural Farming** (November 2024, Rs 2,481 crore) targets 1 crore farmers on 7.5 lakh hectares through 15,000 clusters and 30,000 Krishi Sakhis.
- In May 2025 India released the world's first **genome-edited rice** varieties, DRR Dhan 100 (Kamala) and Pusa DST Rice 1, developed by ICAR using SDN-1/2 editing.
- Horticulture final estimates for 2024-25 and first advance estimates for 2025-26 were released in March 2026, both above 3,700 lakh tonnes.
- India registered 125 new GIs in 2025-26, taking the total to 822, many of them fruits, vegetables and spices.
- Kitchen and nutri-gardens (Poshan Vatika) are promoted in anganwadis and schools under Poshan 2.0 and PM POSHAN to diversify diets.

Science, economics and social angle

- Home and community gardens cut food miles, divert wet waste from landfills and offer fresh, pesticide-free produce to urban households.
- About 40% of food is lost or wasted across the chain in some estimates; cold storage gaps hurt perishable fruits and vegetables most.

- Punjab's **paddy-wheat cycle** has driven groundwater depletion and stubble burning; crop diversification needs MSP, procurement and market support for alternatives.
- India's share of world agri exports is only about 2 to 2.5%, limited by small holdings, quality standards, residue limits and weak branding.
- Gardening has proven mental-health benefits (horticultural therapy) and is used in prisons, hospitals and old-age homes.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A collector can scale kitchen gardens through MGNREGA works, self-help groups and anganwadi nutri-gardens to fight anaemia and stunting.
- Urban local bodies can link terrace farming with **decentralised composting** under Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) 2.0 and bulk waste generator rules.
- Extension matters: Krishi Vigyan Kendras, Krishi Sakhis and soil health cards help farmers cut chemical overuse.
- Officers must balance farmer income with sustainability, for example when convincing Punjab farmers to shift away from water-intensive paddy.
- Ethical angle: honest labelling of organic produce, preventing spurious seeds and pesticides, and protecting farmers' seed rights.

Asked in real interviews

1. What are you growing? Do you use fertilisers or go organic? What are the benefits of growing your own fruits and vegetables? **[2020]**
2. How can kitchen gardening be a model to tackle shortage of fruits and vegetables in urban areas? How is it different from conventional farming? **[2020]**
3. What can be done with day-to-day kitchen waste? **[2020]**
4. Explain farm to fork. About 40% of food is wasted; why, and how can it be tackled? **[2020]**
5. Our share of global agricultural exports is only about 2%; why? What is the average landholding in India? **[2020]**
6. Since you do fruit gardening, what can be done in horticulture given the state of Indian agriculture? **[2023]**
7. Which exotic fruit crop has become popular in Kerala recently? Are you aware of different avocado varieties? **[2023]**
8. You do gardening. How is vermicompost made? **[2022]**
9. Name two GI-tagged agricultural products from Jammu and Kashmir. Who grants GI tags and where is the office? **[2023]**
10. How do you do kitchen gardening, and which plants do you cultivate? **[2021]**
11. What are systemic fertilisers? **[2021]**
12. What do you grow? What is your view on GM crops and on terminator seeds? **[2019]**
13. Your hobby is organic farming. Where did organic farming start in India and what is happening now? **[2019]**
14. Should the government pass a law to stop rice cultivation in Punjab? As collector, how would you convince farmers not to sow rice? **[2022]**
15. Factors for a successful plantation drive? Success rate of such drives, and yours? **[2025]**
16. About your gardening (discussion moved to Manipur riots). **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the difference between organic farming and natural farming? Which suits India better?
2. How would you promote terrace gardening in a city like yours?
3. What is the National Mission on Natural Farming and what are its targets?
4. Are genome-edited crops different from GM crops? Should India adopt them?
5. What is the role of earthworms and microbes in soil health?
6. As collector, how would you use nutri-gardens to reduce malnutrition in tribal blocks?
7. Which crops in your kitchen garden fail most often and why?
8. How does your gardening hobby relate to your optional subject or home state's agriculture?

Model answer: Can kitchen gardening really address urban food and nutrition problems, or is it just a hobby?

It cannot replace farms, but it is more than a hobby. A few square metres of terrace can supply leafy greens and herbs year-round, improving dietary diversity cheaply. In my own garden, composting kitchen waste cuts what goes to the landfill. At scale, community and school gardens build awareness, as Poshan Vatikas in anganwadis show. As an administrator I would link terrace gardening with decentralised composting under Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban 2.0, offer seed kits through horticulture departments, and use resident welfare associations, while being realistic that staple supply still depends on farmers and markets.

Model answer: What is your view on GM and genome-edited crops?

I take an evidence-based, cautious view. Bt cotton raised yields but also showed pest resistance and seed-price issues. Genome editing without foreign DNA is different: in May 2025 India released DRR Dhan 100 (Kamala) and Pusa DST Rice 1, which promise higher yield and stress tolerance. I support such research, with strong biosafety review by GEAC, transparent field data, and protection of farmers' seed rights under the PPV&FR Act. As an administrator I would focus on honest extension through KVKs so farmers adopt new seeds based on local trials, not hype or fear.

Common traps

- Claiming a kitchen garden but not knowing the basics of soil, compost, pests or which season your plants grow in
- Romanticising organic farming without acknowledging yield, certification and cost challenges
- Confusing natural, organic and genome-edited or GM concepts, or giving outdated figures on schemes and production

Preparation checklist

☐ List every plant you grow with its season, inputs, pests and last harvest

☐ Learn composting and vermicomposting steps, NPK basics and the difference between systemic and contact inputs

☐ Revise MIDH, NMNF 2024, Clean Plant Programme, PPV&FR Act, GI Act and GEAC's role

☐ Note the latest horticulture production estimates and India's GI tally

☐ Prepare views on GM and genome-edited crops, Punjab's cropping pattern and urban farming

HOBBY 31

Social Work & Teaching Kids

Appears in DAFs as: teaching underprivileged children, volunteering with NGOs, NSS/NCC service, mentoring, relief work, community service. Boards treat it as a rehearsal for public service and probe whether the candidate has really worked on the ground and understands India's learning and welfare gaps.

What the board is really testing

- Is the work real: who, where, how often, what changed, and can you give specifics?
- Do you understand the education system behind your classroom (RTE, NEP, ASER, UDISE+, NIPUN)?
- Empathy without saviour complex: do you see children as rights-holders or as charity cases?
- Can you scale personal effort into policy, convergence and institutional design as a DM?
- Ethical sensitivity: safeguarding of minors, consent, NGO accountability and fund transparency

Basics, history and rules

- Indian voluntarism runs from **seva** and dana traditions to reform bodies: Brahmo Samaj, Servants of India Society (Gokhale, 1905), Ramakrishna Mission (1897) and Gandhian constructive work.
- **National Service Scheme** began on 24 September 1969 (Gandhi centenary) under the Youth Affairs Ministry; motto 'Not Me But You'.
- **MY Bharat** (Mera Yuva Bharat), launched 31 October 2023, is an autonomous body and phygital platform for youth volunteering and experiential learning.
- Good practice in teaching volunteers: diagnose with **Teaching at the Right Level** (Pratham's TaRL), group by level not age, track attendance and learning, and avoid one-off visits.
- Distinguish charity, service and empowerment: sustainable work builds community ownership (SMCs, parents) rather than volunteer dependency.

India story and icons

- **Kailash Satyarthi** founded Bachpan Bachao Andolan (1980) against child labour and trafficking; shared the 2014 Nobel Peace Prize with Malala Yousafzai.
- Savitribai and Jyotirao Phule opened a girls' school at Bhide Wada, Pune, in 1848: India's founding moment for teaching the excluded.
- Baba Amte's Anandwan and Prakash Amte's **Hemalkasa** (Lok Biradari Prakalp) model serve Madia Gond tribals with health, school and wildlife care.
- Pratham (ASER, TaRL), Akshaya Patra (mid-day meals), Teach For India, CRY and SEWA show varied NGO models: research, delivery, fellowship, rights and collective organising.

- Anand Kumar's Super 30 and community libraries show how one committed educator can shift outcomes for poor students.

Institutions, policy and law

- **Article 21A** (86th Amendment, 2002) and the RTE Act 2009 make education free and compulsory for ages 6–14; Section 12(1)(c) reserves 25% private-school seats for disadvantaged children.
- NEP 2020 targets universal foundational literacy and numeracy; **NIPUN Bharat** (2021) aims for every child to read and do basic maths by end of Grade 3.
- Juvenile Justice Act 2015, POCSO Act 2012 and the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Amendment Act 2016 frame child protection; Mission Vatsalya funds child care institutions.
- Companies Act 2013 **Section 135** mandates 2% CSR spending for qualifying companies; education is the largest CSR head.
- FCRA 2010 (amended 2020) caps admin spending of foreign funds at 20% and mandates an SBI New Delhi account; NGO Darpan registers voluntary organisations with NITI Aayog.
- Vidyanjali portal (2021) lets volunteers and CSR donors contribute services or assets to government schools.

Current developments 2025–26

- **ASER 2024** (released 28 January 2025): in rural government schools, 23.4% of Class 3 children read a Class 2 text, up from 16.3% in 2022 (27.1% across all schools).
- ASER 2024 arithmetic: Class 3 subtraction 33.7% and Class 5 division 30.7%, both above 2018 levels. ASER is biennial; ASER 2026 is being conducted.
- **PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024** (4 December 2024, results July 2025) tested about 21 lakh students; only 53% of Class 6 knew tables up to 10.
- UDISE+ 2024–25: enrolment fell to 24.69 crore; teachers crossed one crore for the first time; secondary dropout fell to 8.2% from 10.9%.
- Secondary retention is only about 47%, so the drop-out problem shifts to Classes 9–12, exactly where volunteer mentoring helps most.

Science, economics or social angle

- Learning poverty compounds: a child who cannot read by Grade 3 falls further behind every year, so **foundational learning** has the highest returns.
- Mid-day meals (PM POSHAN) raise attendance and nutrition; hunger, child marriage, migration and child labour are major dropout drivers.
- Caste, gender and the digital divide shape who drops out; first-generation learners lack home support, which volunteers can partly fill.
- Volunteering builds social capital (Putnam) and civic trust; poorly designed 'voluntourism' can instead create dependency and disrupt children's routines.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- DMs replicate volunteer models at scale: adopt-a-school, community reading campaigns, Anganwadi–school convergence, and Mission Shiksha-type drives using SMCs and self-help groups.
- Ethics: **safeguarding** of minors (background checks, two-adult rule, no photos without consent) and respecting children's dignity in publicity.

- Officers must treat NGOs as partners yet audit them: social audits, outcome contracts and transparent fund use prevent capture and fraud.
- Disaster relief volunteering (cyclones, floods) shows that inclusion of the most vulnerable (elderly, disabled, Dalit hamlets) must be planned, not left to chance.

Asked in real interviews

1. What do you mean by underprivileged children? **[2021]**
2. Do you know a Nobel laureate who works for underprivileged children? What kind of children does he work for, and what is his organisation called? **[2021]**
3. How did you make sure the children you taught did not drop out of school? **[2021]**
4. What do you learn from teaching children? **[2021]**
5. What do you teach, whom do you teach, and how does it help you? **[2021]**
6. Whom do you teach? **[2022]**
7. You list teaching as a hobby. How do you pursue teaching nowadays? **[2023]**
8. Are we teaching children too many things in schools while they still cannot read and write properly? **[2023]**
9. In Gujarat, ministers and secretaries visit villages and teach. Can the Maharashtra government do something similar, and why hasn't it? **[2023]**
10. What are the issues in school education and what steps would you take? **[2023]**
11. Tell me about Anganwadis. How are they different from primary schools? **[2024]**
12. What is your work in the NGO, and which classes did you teach? **[2024]**
13. Can you give a popular example of a community-driven social healthcare model? Explain the Hemalkasa model. **[2024]**
14. What did you do as a police mitra? Police volunteers now also help senior citizens; what sensitivities must they keep in mind? **[2024]**
15. What did you do in Cyclone Fani relief work, and how can we avoid the problems underprivileged people face during calamities? **[2024]**
16. Why did you found a social service group, and what has the group done? **[2024]**
17. How do you teach? Give details about your NGO. **[2024]**
18. What did you learn while working against child labour and while raising funds from companies? **[2024]**
19. Why did you join NSS and what activities were you involved in? **[2025]**
20. You mentor students at an academy. What do you do there, and how would you advise them on the Personality Test? **[2025]**
21. How do you define underprivileged kids? **[2024]**
22. Elderly care: what problems do they face? Visited an old-age home? What can be done? **[2024]**
23. You train underprivileged children: do you know Teach for India? **[2024]**
24. While teaching, what differences do you see between Gen-Z kids and your generation? What do you learn from children? **[2025]**
25. What did you observe while teaching in slums? **[2025]**
26. You teach tuitions: why only biology? **[2025]**
27. Volunteering with transgender community: why are they on roads and how can we help? **[2025]**
28. Explain your village library initiative. **[2025]**
29. You taught underprivileged children in NSS: what has NSS taught you? **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. ASER 2024 shows learning recovery. Is it real, and what should the next phase focus on?
2. Should RTE be extended to ages 3–6 and 14–18?
3. Is the 25% RTE quota in private schools working? What has gone wrong?
4. Your DAF says you taught slum children. If you are DM, how will you scale that to 2,000 schools?
5. Are NGOs partners of the state or substitutes for it? Should FCRA be tightened or relaxed?
6. A volunteer in your NGO is accused of misbehaving with a child. What do you do?
7. Is CSR in education crowding out public spending or complementing it?
8. Does charity perpetuate inequality? Comment, citing Ambedkar or Gandhi.

Model answer: If government schools are improving, why do volunteers like you still need to teach children?

I see volunteers as a supplement, not a substitute. ASER 2024 shows real recovery: in rural government schools, 23.4% of Class 3 children can read a Class 2 text, up from 16.3% in 2022. That still leaves three in four behind, mostly first-generation learners without help at home. In my sessions I grouped children by level, not age, which teachers with crowded classrooms find hard. As an administrator I would formalise this: community reading volunteers through SMCs and MY Bharat, linked to NIPUN targets, with safeguarding rules and simple learning tracking, so that goodwill strengthens the public system rather than bypassing it.

Model answer: Is NGO work a form of charity that lets the state escape responsibility?

It can be if NGOs become permanent substitutes, but the best ones are pathfinders. Pratham's Teaching at the Right Level began as an NGO method and is now used in many state programmes, which shows how civil society can innovate and the state can scale. Education is a right under Article 21A, so the duty stays with government. As an officer I would use NGOs for innovation, community mobilisation and independent monitoring, while insisting on transparency through NGO Darpan and social audits. Partnership with accountability, not outsourcing, is my position.

Common traps

• Calling it a hobby while unable to name a single child's progress, the NGO's registration, or the number of sessions; vagueness signals DAF padding.

• Saviour tone ('I uplifted poor children'); the board prefers rights language and humility about what one volunteer can achieve.

• Not knowing the basic data (ASER, UDISE+ dropout, RTE provisions) behind the cause you claim to care about.

Preparation checklist

☐ Write a one-page fact sheet of your own work: NGO name, place, years, hours a week, age group, method, one measurable result and one failure.

☐ Memorise headline numbers from ASER 2024, PARAKH 2024 and UDISE+ 2024–25, with release dates.

☐ Revise Article 21A, RTE Act sections (12(1)(c), 16, 29), NEP 2020 FLN goals, NIPUN Bharat, PM POSHAN, POCSO and the JJ Act.

☐ Prepare views on NGO accountability: FCRA 2020 amendments, CSR Section 135, NGO Darpan and social audits.

☐ Rehearse two situational answers: child-safety complaint against a volunteer, and scaling a volunteer model across a district.

HOBBY 32

Astronomy & Stargazing

Appears in DAFs as: stargazing, amateur astronomy, sky watching, astrophotography, interest in space and the universe. It lets the board test scientific temper and depth in physics, and link the night sky to India's heritage, the space programme and light-pollution governance.

What the board is really testing

- Do you actually observe: what, where, with what equipment, and under what conditions?
- Conceptual depth: black holes, event horizon, stellar evolution, the Big Bang, explained simply
- Scientific temper: astronomy versus astrology, myth versus evidence (Article 51A(h))
- Awareness of India's space and observatory ecosystem and the latest missions
- Governance sense: light pollution, dark-sky tourism, space commercialisation and debris

Basics, history and rules

- Naked-eye basics: constellations, planets, Milky Way and meteor showers (Perseids August, Geminids December); the **Bortle scale** (1–9) grades sky darkness.
- **Saptarishi** is the Big Dipper in Ursa Major; its pointer stars lead to Dhruva (Polaris). Vasishtha and Arundhati are the Mizar–Alcor pair.
- Visibility hindrances: light pollution, aerosols and smog, humidity, moonlight, atmospheric turbulence ('seeing') and low horizons in cities.
- **Event horizon**: the boundary of a black hole beyond which no light escapes; its radius for non-rotating holes is the **Schwarzschild radius**, $2GM/c^2$.
- Stellar life: nebula to main sequence to red giant; remnants are white dwarf, neutron star or black hole depending on mass.

India story and icons

- Vedanga Jyotisha, **Aryabhata** (Aryabhatiya, 499 CE: rotating Earth, eclipse explanation), Varahamihira and Bhaskara II built a strong mathematical-astronomy tradition.
- Sawai Jai Singh II built five Jantar Mantars; Jaipur's became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2010.
- **S. Chandrasekhar**'s white-dwarf mass limit (about 1.4 solar masses) won the 1983 Physics Nobel; Meghnad Saha gave the ionisation equation.
- Key facilities: 3.6 m Devasthal Optical Telescope (ARIES, Nainital), GMRT near Pune, Indian Astronomical Observatory at Hanle (about 4,500 m), and AstroSat (2015).

- LIGO-India, a gravitational-wave detector in Hingoli, Maharashtra, received Cabinet approval in 2023.

Institutions, policy and law

- Department of Space and ISRO; IN-SPACe (2020) authorises private players; **Indian Space Policy 2023** defines roles for ISRO, NSIL and the private sector.
- Research bodies: Indian Institute of Astrophysics (Bengaluru), ARIES, PRL, IUCAA, NCRA-TIFR; Astronomical Society of India supports outreach.
- **Hanle Dark Sky Reserve** (Ladakh, 2022) was India's first; Pench Tiger Reserve (Maharashtra) became India's first certified Dark Sky Park in 2024.
- Tamil Nadu has opened its first dark sky park in Ariyur Shola, Kolli Hills; states are linking dark skies to astro-tourism.
- UN Outer Space Treaty 1967 bars national sovereignty claims; India signed the Artemis Accords in 2023.

Current developments 2025–26

- **Shubhanshu Shukla** flew Axiom-4 (June–July 2025), the first Indian aboard the ISS; the crew undocked on 14 July and splashed down on 15 July 2025.
- ISRO's SpaDeX docked two satellites in January 2025, making India the fourth nation to dock in orbit.
- Gaganyaan G1, the uncrewed test flight with Vyommitra, has slipped repeatedly; as of mid-2026 ISRO expects it in Q4 2026 after a crew-module air-drop test in April 2026.
- A total lunar eclipse on 7–8 September 2025 was visible across India; Vera Rubin Observatory released first images in June 2025.
- Interstellar comet **3I/ATLAS**, discovered in July 2025, is only the third known interstellar object after 'Oumuamua and Borisov.

Science, economics or social angle

- **Light pollution** harms astronomy, migratory birds, insects and human sleep; full-cutoff LED fixtures and warm colour temperatures are cheap fixes.
- Mega-constellations (Starlink and others) streak telescope images and raise radio interference; space commercialisation needs coordination with observatories.
- Astronomy versus astrology: astronomy is testable science; astrology lacks predictive validity. Article 51A(h) asks citizens to develop **scientific temper**.
- Astro-tourism (Hanle's trained local 'astro-ambassadors', homestays) creates rural livelihoods while giving communities a stake in keeping skies dark.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A DM can notify dark-sky zones, regulate outdoor lighting in bylaws and promote astro-tourism in tribal or hill districts.
- Public outreach (telescope nights, eclipse viewing with safe filters) counters superstition, such as eclipse-time food taboos for pregnant women.
- Satellite and space data aid governance: NISAR, Bhuvan and IMD imagery for floods, crops and disaster planning.
- Ethics: space debris, militarisation (ASAT test 2019, Mission Shakti) and equitable access to orbital slots for developing countries.

Asked in real interviews

1. What type of stargazing do you do, and what do you see? **[2022]**
2. Where do you live, since stargazing is difficult in Delhi? What are the possible hindrances to visibility? **[2022]**
3. Have you seen the Saptarishi? Name the seven rishis and their importance. **[2022]**
4. What is the event horizon of a black hole? **[2022]**
5. What is the event horizon, and why is it called the event horizon? **[2020]**
6. What is the Schwarzschild radius? **[2020]**
7. How do you practise your hobby? (asked of an astronomy-hobby candidate) **[2020]**
8. What is the difference between astronomy and astrology? Is there any scientific basis for astrology? **[2021]**
9. How does space commercialisation affect astronomical observation, and what can be done about it? **[2021]**
10. Do you believe in alien civilisations? (DAF interest: space and universe) **[2024]**
11. Question on Carl Sagan's link between the Big Bang and the Rigveda; what happened before the Big Bang? **[2024]**
12. Do you believe in alien civilisations? Why do movies imagine aliens so differently? **[2024]**
13. Carl Sagan mentions a Rigveda connection with the Big Bang: what is it? What happened before the Big Bang? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. What did you last observe, and with what equipment? Name three constellations visible this season.
2. Why does Pluto no longer count as a planet?
3. Explain a black hole to a Class 8 student.
4. Is India's space programme a luxury for a poor country?
5. How will you reduce light pollution in your district without compromising safety?
6. Aryabhata knew the Earth rotates. Why did Indian science not sustain that lead?
7. What is the significance of Shubhanshu Shukla's Axiom-4 flight for Gaganyaan?
8. Villagers in your district refuse to step out during an eclipse. Will you intervene?

Model answer: Is astrology a science? Many people in your district will consult it before every decision.

Astrology is not a science in the sense astronomy is: it makes predictions that have not held up under controlled tests. Astronomy explains eclipses through orbital mechanics, which Aryabhata already did in the fifth century. Still, I would not mock people's beliefs; for many it is cultural comfort. As an officer my approach would follow Article 51A(h): avoid endorsing astrology in official work, but build scientific temper through outreach such as public eclipse-viewing camps with safe filters. That shows people that nothing harmful happens, which persuades better than lectures.

Model answer: Stargazing is a niche hobby. What public value does it have?

It has more value than it appears. The Hanle Dark Sky Reserve in Ladakh trained local residents as astro-ambassadors and created homestay income while protecting the night sky for India's high-altitude observatory. Light pollution also disrupts migratory birds, insects and human sleep, so dark skies are an environmental issue. As a district officer I could add shielded street lighting to municipal bylaws, promote astro-tourism in hill or tribal blocks, and run school telescope nights. A personal hobby can thus support livelihoods, ecology and scientific temper together.

Common traps

- Claiming astronomy as a hobby but faltering on basics such as the Saptarishi, Polaris, phases of the Moon, or why stars twinkle.
- Muddling astronomy with astrology, or giving a dismissive, sneering answer about astrology instead of a balanced one.
- Quoting outdated mission status (for example, saying Gaganyaan has already flown) without checking current timelines.

Preparation checklist

☐ Keep an observation log: dates, locations, Bortle class, objects seen, equipment; be ready to describe one memorable night.

☐ Revise concepts with one-line explanations: event horizon, Schwarzschild radius, Chandrasekhar limit, redshift, dark matter, exoplanets, gravitational waves.

☐ Learn Indian heritage: Aryabhata, Varahamihira, Jantar Mantar, nakshatras and Saptarishi names (Marichi, Atri, Angiras, Pulastya, Pulaha, Kratu, Vasishtha).

☐ Update space-programme status: Chandrayaan-3, Aditya-L1, SpaDeX, Axiom-4, NISAR, Gaganyaan G1 timeline, Bharatiya Antariksh Station.

☐ Prepare a governance note on light pollution, dark-sky reserves (Hanle, Pench, Kolli Hills) and satellite constellations.

HOBBY 33

Bird Watching & Wildlife

Appears in DAFs as: birding, bird photography, wildlife watching, nature walks, trekking, watching wildlife documentaries. Boards use it to test ecological literacy and local knowledge, then pivot quickly to sanctuaries, conservation law and the development-versus-environment dilemma.

What the board is really testing

- Field reality: which birds you have logged, where, which season, and with what method (eBird, counts)
- Local knowledge of your home district and state: sanctuaries, state bird and animal, Ramsar sites
- Grasp of conservation law and institutions (WPA 1972, CAMPA, NTCA, Ramsar, CMS)

• Balance on development versus ecology: renewable power lines versus the Great Indian Bustard

• Ability to use citizen science and communities in administration

Basics, history and rules

- India records about 1,350 bird species; the **Central Asian Flyway** brings winter migrants such as bar-headed geese, Amur falcons and shorebirds.
- Birding ethics: no nest photography or playback near breeding birds, keep distance, stay on trails, and never bait or disturb roosts.
- **Citizen science**: eBird checklists, Great Backyard Bird Count (February), Asian Waterbird Census (January, run in India by BNHS and Wetlands International) and the Big Bird Day.
- Habitats to know: wetlands, grasslands, Western Ghats and North-East forests, mangroves, and the Thar desert.

India story and icons

- **Salim Ali** (1896–1987), the 'Birdman of India', wrote The Book of Indian Birds; his birthday, 12 November, is observed as National Bird Day in India.
- Bombay Natural History Society (1883), Salim Ali Centre for Ornithology and Natural History (SACON, Coimbatore) and Nature Conservation Foundation anchor bird research.
- Keoladeo National Park, Bharatpur, is a Ramsar site and UNESCO World Heritage Site; Chilika is India's first Ramsar site (with Keoladeo, 1981).
- Pangti, Nagaland, turned from Amur falcon hunting to protection after community campaigns from 2012–13, a model of community conservation.
- Nature photographers and filmmakers often cited: Sudhir Shivaram, Dhritiman Mukherjee, and Mike Pandey (Green Oscars).

Institutions, policy and law

- **Wildlife (Protection) Act 1972**, amended in 2022, cut schedules to four and added CITES provisions; Article 48A and 51A(g) give constitutional backing.
- Ramsar Convention 1971; Convention on Migratory Species (India hosted CMS COP13 at Gandhinagar, 2020); National Action Plan for the Central Asian Flyway.
- Vulture crisis: veterinary diclofenac banned 2006; ketoprofen and aceclofenac banned for animals in 2023; Vulture Action Plan 2020–25.
- **M.K. Ranjitsinh v Union of India**: the Supreme Court links the Great Indian Bustard to the right to be free from climate change effects (March 2024).
- Forest Conservation Amendment Act 2023 (Van Sanrakshan evam Samvardhan Adhiniyam) and Biological Diversity Amendment Act 2023 reshape forest and biodiversity governance.

Current developments 2025–26

- On 19 December 2025 the Supreme Court set GIB **priority areas** at 14,013 sq km in Rajasthan and 740 sq km in Gujarat, with undergrounding of critical power lines within two years.
- India's Ramsar sites reached 103 by October 2026 with Sukhna Wetland (Chandigarh) and Sauj Jheel (UP); Tamil Nadu leads with 20.

- Great Backyard Bird Count 2026 (13–16 February): about 7,300 Indian participants logged nearly 65,000 checklists and about 1,092 species; India ranked second globally in checklists.
- The Delhi Bird Atlas 2025 recorded 471 species, calling Delhi the world's second most bird-diverse capital.
- **State of India's Birds 2023** remains the key benchmark: 178 species of high conservation concern; grassland, wetland and specialist insectivore birds decline fastest.

Science, economics or social angle

- Birds are **indicator species**: declines signal habitat loss, pesticide load, wetland drainage and climate shifts.
- Ecosystem services: pollination, seed dispersal, pest control and carcass disposal by vultures; the vulture crash raised rabies and public-health costs.
- **Invasive species** (Lantana, Senna spectabilis in Wayanad, Prosopis juliflora) degrade habitats, cut fodder for herbivores and push wildlife into farms.
- Bird tourism and festivals (Chilika, Mangalajodi, Thol) give boatmen and ex-poachers guide jobs, aligning livelihoods with conservation.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District officers can use **wetland mitras**, eco-development committees and waterbird census data for planning.
- Human–wildlife conflict needs quick compensation, early-warning systems, invasive species removal and corridor protection.
- Development projects require bird-safe design: bird diverters on power lines, wind-farm siting outside flyways, and wetlands kept out of urban zoning.
- Ethical issue: balancing renewable-energy targets with endangered species, and livelihoods of fishers and graziers with protected-area rules.

Asked in real interviews

1. What is citizen science? (asked of a bird-photography candidate) **[2023]**
2. Tell us about nature photography. Who are some famous nature photographers in India? **[2023]**
3. What is the state animal of Madhya Pradesh and where is it found? Which special species is found in Kanha National Park? **[2023]**
4. How many wildlife sanctuaries are there in Tamil Nadu? (hobby: watching wildlife) **[2024]**
5. What issues do invasive species cause? Which invasive species is behind human–wildlife conflict in Wayanad? **[2025]**
6. What is the status of Sariska Tiger Reserve and how has the government rehabilitated tigers there? **[2021]**
7. Is India doing enough for the environment? How does development threaten the environment, in layman's terms? **[2021]**
8. Tell us about a famous bird sanctuary in your area. **[2022]**
9. What is waterfall trekking? Have you been to Dudhsagar? Which is the longest trek you have done? **[2024]**
10. Who is the most renowned ornithologist from India? **[2025]**
11. Any wildlife photographer you know of? **[2025]**
12. What animals do you rescue, and how? Name some NGOs in Delhi working in this field. **[2025]**

13. You take care of street dogs: what do you do? **[2024]**

Expected questions

1. Name five birds you have seen in your home district and one winter migrant. Where does it come from?
2. Why are vultures disappearing, and what has the government done?
3. Should renewable-energy transmission lines be stopped to save the Great Indian Bustard?
4. What is the Central Asian Flyway and why does it matter to India?
5. How many Ramsar sites does India have? Name the ones in your state.
6. As DM, how would you resolve conflict between fishers and a bird sanctuary on a wetland?
7. Is eBird data reliable enough for policy?
8. A wind-power company wants land in a bustard habitat in your district. What will you do?

Model answer: Renewable energy or the Great Indian Bustard: which should India prioritise?

I don't think it has to be either-or. Only about 150 bustards survive, and overhead power lines are a leading cause of their deaths. In December 2025 the Supreme Court set revised priority areas of about 14,013 sq km in Rajasthan and ordered critical lines undergrounded within two years, while allowing clean energy outside them. That is a sensible balance. As an administrator I would map habitats into land-allocation decisions, move power corridors early, fit bird diverters where undergrounding is not possible, and involve local Bishnoi and grazier communities in monitoring.

Model answer: How can a bird watcher's hobby help district administration?

Birds are cheap indicators of ecosystem health. Data from citizen-science platforms such as eBird and the Great Backyard Bird Count, where India ranked second in checklists in 2026, can show which wetlands are degrading. As a collector I would use Asian Waterbird Census results to prioritise wetland restoration under the Amrit Dharohar approach, train local youth as bird guides, and enlist wetland mitras to report encroachment. Pangti in Nagaland shows that when communities earn from birds, former hunters become protectors. So the hobby gives me data and also a model of participation.

Common traps

• Listing birding but unable to name common birds of your own district, the state bird, or the nearest sanctuary and Ramsar site.

• Taking an absolutist 'stop all development' stance; boards want a balanced, solution-oriented view.

• Confusing national parks, sanctuaries, tiger reserves and Ramsar sites, or quoting stale Ramsar counts.

Preparation checklist

☐ Make a personal checklist of 25 birds you have actually seen, with locations and seasons; know one migrant's route.

☐ List your home state's national parks, sanctuaries, Ramsar sites, state bird and state animal.

☐ Revise WPA 1972 (2022 amendment), Ramsar, CMS, the GIB judgments (2021, March 2024, December 2025) and vulture drug bans.

☐ Read State of India's Birds 2023 highlights and the latest GBBC and Asian Waterbird Census results.

☐ Prepare views on invasive species, human–wildlife conflict compensation and bird-safe infrastructure.

PART V

Extra-curricular Activities and Achievements

NCC, NSS, sports medals, leadership roles, awards and competitions

ACTIVITY 1

NCC

Appears in DAFs as: NCC 'A/B/C' certificate, Army/Naval/Air Wing cadet, RDC, Thal/Vayu/Nau Sainik camp, Senior Under Officer. NCC is the one ECA that boards can test like a subject: motto, wings, certificates and camps are checkable, and a 'C' certificate invites the sharp follow-up of why not the Armed Forces.

What the board is really testing

• Authenticity: wing, unit, directorate, camps attended and certificate grade, with a concrete experience behind each

• Values internalised: discipline, punctuality, teamwork and 'Unity and Discipline' as lived practice, not slogans

• Career logic: why a 'C' certificate holder chose civil services over the officer entries reserved for cadets

• Critical maturity: honest view of NCC's weaknesses (drill-heavy training, instructor shortage, uneven reach) and reforms

• Policy awareness: compulsory NCC debate, expansion to border and coastal areas, NCC's role in disasters and nation-building

Origins, structure and identity

- Lineage: University Corps under the Indian Defence Act 1917, University Training Corps (1920) and UOTC (1942); the **H.N. Kunzru Committee** (1946) recommended a national cadet organisation.
- **NCC Act, 1948** created the corps, raised on 15 July 1948 under the Ministry of Defence; Girls Division followed in 1949, Air Wing in 1950 and Naval Wing in 1952.
- Motto **'Ekta aur Anushasan' (Unity and Discipline)**; NCC Day falls on the fourth Sunday of November; the flag's red, dark blue and light blue stand for Army, Navy and Air Force.
- Aims: develop character, comradeship, discipline, leadership and selfless service; create a trained youth reserve; encourage careers in the Armed Forces.

- Cardinal principles taught to cadets: obey with a smile, be punctual, work hard without fuss, make no excuses and tell no lies.
- Headed by a **Director General (Lt Gen rank)** in Delhi; 17 State Directorates, then Group HQs and units; Junior Division/Wing in schools and Senior Division/Wing in colleges.

Certificates, camps and ranks

- **'A' certificate**: Junior Division, 75% attendance over two years plus one Annual Training Camp; 'B': Senior Division, two years, 75% attendance and one ATC or NIC.
- **'C' certificate**: must hold 'B', be in third-year SD/SW with 75% attendance, and attend two ATCs or one ATC plus RDC, a central camp or an adventure course.
- Grades: A (80% plus), B (65–79%), C (50–64%); a pass needs 45% in each paper and 50% overall. Know your own grade and year.
- Central camps: **Republic Day Camp** in Delhi (culminating in the Prime Minister's Rally), Thal Sainik, Vayu Sainik and Nau Sainik camps, National Integration and Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat camps.
- Cadet ranks run Lance Corporal, Corporal, Sergeant, CQMS, CSM, Under Officer and **Senior Under Officer**, the highest cadet rank; Associate NCC Officers are teachers commissioned to lead units.
- Other activities: Youth Exchange Programme with friendly countries, adventure courses, Puneet Sagar Abhiyan (cleaning water bodies), blood donation, Swachhta and Yoga Day drives.

Career benefits and the 'why not Army' question

- 'C' certificate holders get reserved officer vacancies: 64 a year at IMA (via UPSC and SSB), 100 a year at OTA through **NCC Special Entry** without a written exam.
- Navy reserves 6 vacancies per course and the Air Force 10% of course seats for 'C' holders (SSB only); bonus marks apply for soldier, sailor and airman recruitment.
- Paramilitary and some State police recruitments give bonus marks; several States prefer NCC holders; Agniveer recruitment also awards NCC bonus marks by certificate level.
- A sound answer to 'why not the Army' respects the uniform, then shows that the same service motive found a wider canvas in civil administration, without running down either.

Policy, law and expansion

- NCC is voluntary; the **Kunzru Committee** and later debates weighed compulsory training, but cost, instructor shortage and the voluntary spirit argued against making it universal.
- Independence Day 2020: PM announced NCC expansion to 173 **border and coastal districts**, adding about 1 lakh cadets, with Army, Navy and Air Force training support.
- Sanctioned strength stood near 17 lakh, with long waiting lists in many States; in 2025 the Defence Ministry cleared a further expansion of about 3 lakh cadets, towards 20 lakh.
- The Self-Financing Scheme lets schools and private institutions on the waiting list raise NCC units by bearing costs, easing the reach gap in private and rural institutions.
- NCC cadets assist civil authorities in floods, Covid-19 ('Exercise NCC Yogdan', 2020), elections and civil defence, under State direction and without arms.

Critiques and the social angle

- Common criticisms: drill-heavy, repetitive training; few ANOs and Permanent Instructor staff; certificate chasing for bonus marks; uneven quality between urban and rural units.

- Gender: girls now form well over a third of cadets; safe camp facilities, women instructors and grievance systems are needed to retain them.
- Incidents of harsh punishment or ragging in camps (reported from time to time) raise questions of safeguarding and civilian oversight of youth training.
- NCC's value is social as much as military: national integration camps put cadets from different States together, building a shared civic identity early.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- District administrations use NCC cadets for disaster relief, traffic and crowd management at melas, voter awareness and plantation drives, a ready-trained volunteer pool.
- NCC habits map onto **civil service values**: punctuality, chain of command with moral courage, care of subordinates, and calm under pressure in law-and-order duty.
- Ethics of obedience: 'obey with a smile' must not become blind obedience; an officer follows lawful orders and records dissent when orders are unlawful or harmful.
- As DM or SP, an officer can push NCC units in government schools, link them with Aapda Mitra and civil defence, and ensure safe and fair camp selection.

Asked in real interviews

1. NCC: what is the criterion for getting the 'C' certificate? **[2024]**
2. You have an NCC 'C' certificate; why did you not try to join the Armed Forces? **[2024]**
3. Which ethics and values are important in NCC, and what have you learnt from NCC? Did you find anything wrong in NCC? **[2024]**
4. Asked about NCC from the DAF: what did you learn, and should NCC be made compulsory? **[2023]**
5. As part of NCC, what did you learn? Did you do marching? **[2023]**
6. How many members are there in Bharat Scouts and Guides; what share of students are in NCC and NSS? **[2023]**
7. What are the wings of NCC, when was it formed, and what is its motto? What is the issue about NCC in the news? **[2022]**
8. NCC: what did you learn? **[2021]**
9. Which NCC wing were you in (Air Wing)? Why did you not pursue the 'B' certificate?
10. Enquired about NCC; did you ever consider joining the Army Medical Corps?

Expected questions

1. What is the NCC motto and when was NCC raised? Name its wings and the law behind it.
2. Which camps did you attend? Describe one day at the RDC or an Annual Training Camp.
3. Your 'C' certificate gives you a direct route to OTA. Why civil services instead?
4. Should NCC be made compulsory in all colleges? What would it cost and who would train cadets?
5. What are the weaknesses of NCC today and how would you reform it?
6. Cadets in your district are asked to manage crowds at a fair and one is injured. Who is accountable?
7. How can NCC strengthen border and coastal districts, and what is the Vibrant Villages link?
8. 'Obey with a smile': is obedience a virtue for a civil servant?

Model answer: Should NCC be made compulsory for all college students?

I would not make it compulsory, though I would make it universally available. NCC already has long waiting lists, and its sanctioned strength of roughly 17 lakh is small against over four crore students in higher education, so compulsion would dilute training quality without enough instructors or camps. Its value also comes from voluntary commitment; forced drill breeds certificate-chasing. As an administrator I would expand units in government and rural colleges through the Self-Financing Scheme and district funds, give credits under NEP 2020, and link cadets with Aapda Mitra so that willing students get real service experience, not just parades.

Model answer: You hold a 'C' certificate. Is choosing the civil services over the Army a loss for the nation?

I see it as the same commitment on a different front. NCC reserves officer vacancies for cadets, such as 100 a year at OTA, and I respect those who take that path. My NCC camps, especially working with cadets from other States, showed me that discipline and teamwork are needed equally in districts, where floods, elections and law and order test administrators. As a civil servant I will work closely with the forces in disaster response and border-area development, and I would actively promote NCC units in my district, so the values I learnt keep producing both soldiers and citizens.

Common traps

- Claiming a 'C' certificate but fumbling the motto, wing, directorate, camp names or grade; boards treat that as padding.
- Answering 'why not the Army' by implying the Army is a lesser or harder option, or giving a purely career-security reason.
- Defending NCC uncritically; boards often ask what is wrong with it and expect a balanced, reform-minded answer.

Preparation checklist

☐ Write down your unit number, wing, directorate, ANO's role, certificate grade and year, and every camp with dates and one story each.

☐ Memorise basics: NCC Act 1948, raising date, motto, cardinal principles, flag colours, 17 directorates, certificate eligibility and C-certificate benefits.

☐ Prepare a 60-second 'why civil services and not the Armed Forces' answer that respects both careers.

☐ Read up on NCC expansion to border and coastal districts, the Self-Financing Scheme and NCC's disaster and Covid roles.

☐ Prepare views on compulsory NCC, NCC versus NSS, and two reforms you would suggest.

ACTIVITY 2

NSS and Volunteering

Appears in DAFs as: NSS volunteer, NSS special camp, NGO volunteer, disaster relief, Rotaract, Bharat Scouts and Guides, MY Bharat. Volunteering entries let boards check whether a candidate's empathy is real: they ask what exactly you did, in which village, for how many hours, and whether anything changed.

What the board is really testing

- Specificity: the village or slum adopted, the problem found, the hours and the measurable outcome of your work
- Reflection: what volunteering taught you about people, poverty and the limits of goodwill
- Knowledge of NSS and youth institutions: motto, history, programmes and the newer MY Bharat platform
- Policy sense: how volunteers can strengthen, not bypass, public systems in health, sanitation, elections and disasters
- Ethics of service: consent, dignity, safeguarding and avoiding 'voluntourism' or photo-op service

NSS basics and history

- **National Service Scheme** launched on 24 September 1969, Gandhi's birth centenary year, by Education Minister V.K.R.V. Rao in 37 universities; 24 September is NSS Day.
- Motto **'Not Me But You'**; the symbol is the Konark Sun Temple wheel, standing for continuity and change; the badge's red and navy blue signify energy and the cosmos.
- Run by the Department of Youth Affairs, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, through university programme coordinators and college Programme Officers.
- Regular activities: **240 hours over two years** (120 a year); plus a seven-day residential special camp in an adopted village or slum.
- National NSS Awards are presented by the President, usually on NSS Day; an NSS contingent marches in the Republic Day Parade after a Delhi camp.

Wider volunteering ecosystem

- **Nehru Yuva Kendra Sangathan** (1972) works with rural youth clubs; **MY Bharat** (Mera Yuva Bharat), launched 31 October 2023, is an autonomous phygital platform for youth volunteering and experiential learning.
- **Bharat Scouts and Guides** formed on 7 November 1950 by merging Indian scout bodies; world scouting was founded by Lord Baden-Powell in 1907; motto 'Be Prepared'.
- NDMA's **Aapda Mitra** trains community disaster volunteers, scaled to 350 disaster-prone districts; Civil Defence Act 1968 governs civil defence volunteers.
- Rotaract (Rotary-sponsored clubs for ages 18–30), Red Cross Youth, Police Mitra and Electoral Literacy Clubs are other common DAF entries.
- NGO governance: NGO Darpan registration with NITI Aayog; FCRA 2010 (amended 2020) for foreign funds; CSR under Section 135 of the Companies Act 2013.

Government programmes NSS supports

- NSS volunteers have been mobilised for Swachh Bharat, Fit India, blood donation, Covid-19 awareness and vaccination, Har Ghar Tiranga and Meri Mati Mera Desh (2023).
- Electoral participation: NSS and Electoral Literacy Clubs support the Election Commission's **SVEEP** programme and National Voters' Day (25 January) drives.
- Disaster relief: volunteers helped in the 2018 Kerala floods and Cyclone Fani (2019) with relief camps, food distribution and cleaning.
- Digital literacy, nutrition (Poshan Maah), anti-drug (Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan) and plantation drives are routine NSS campaigns.

Current developments 2025–26

- The UN General Assembly proclaimed **2026 the International Volunteer Year for Sustainable Development**; International Volunteer Day falls on 5 December.
- MY Bharat is being used as the single youth platform for NSS, NYKS and other volunteer drives, with programmes such as the Viksit Bharat Young Leaders Dialogue (January, National Youth Day).
- **ASER 2024**: only 23.4% of Class 3 children in rural government schools read a Class 2 text, so teaching volunteers have a real gap to fill.
- Volunteer roles keep widening: civic, disaster and digital literacy drives through MY Bharat and Aapda Mitra, with States using volunteers for elder care and road safety.

Social angle and critiques

- Critiques of NSS: certificate-oriented participation, thin funding per volunteer, camps reduced to cleaning photo-ops, and little follow-up in adopted villages.
- The 'NSS quota' (admission or job weightage) can reward box-ticking; quality improves when outcomes, not hours, are recorded.
- Kerala's Haritha Karma Sena and Kudumbashree show how organised volunteers and SHGs can sustain waste segregation and collection, beyond one-off drives.
- Good Samaritan protection (SaveLIFE Foundation judgment 2016, Section 134A Motor Vehicles Act) shows law can encourage citizens to help without fear.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers rely on volunteers in floods, epidemics, elections and census work; registering them in advance (Aapda Mitra, MY Bharat) beats ad hoc appeals.
- **Dignity and consent**: photographing beneficiaries, entering homes or collecting data needs consent and privacy safeguards.
- Volunteers should strengthen public institutions, for example through School Management Committees and Vidyanjali, rather than run parallel systems.
- Safeguarding: police or elder-care volunteers need background checks, training, a code of conduct and clear limits on powers.

Asked in real interviews

1. For how many years and hours does one work under NSS? What did you learn in NSS? **[2021]**
2. Name the villages where you held NSS camps and the problems people face there. What is the motto of NSS? **[2021]**

3. Can you name two Government of India programmes in which NSS has played a prominent role? Do you know about NSS youth mobilisation for elections? **[2021]**
4. What work did you do in NSS? Did you bring any change through your NSS work? **[2023]**
5. What did you do during the Kerala floods? Which NGO did you collaborate with? **[2023]**
6. Why are scouts and guides declining? What did you do in Engineers Without Borders? **[2023]**
7. What did you do in NSS, and which disaster did you work on? What is the objective of Bharat Scouts and Guides, and who founded it? **[2024]**
8. What is the relevance of NSS today? About the NSS quota: how to promote it when only 10–20% get chances? **[2024]**
9. You worked in Cyclone Fani relief work. Tell me what all you did. **[2024]**
10. What did you do as a Police Mitra? Such volunteers now help senior citizens; what sensitivities should they keep in mind? **[2024]**
11. You were resource mobilisation lead in an NGO against child labour. How did it change you, and what did you learn negotiating with company heads? **[2024]**
12. What is the Million Plantation Drive? What was your participation, and what plants did you plant? **[2024]**
13. Why did you participate in NSS and what activities were you involved in? How is the waste management strategy of volunteer groups in Kerala working? **[2025]**
14. You were part of a panchayat-level digital literacy drive. Tell me more. What did you do in this camp; did you really have any impact? **[2025]**
15. What were your lessons from organising a cricket tournament for visually impaired women? **[2025]**
16. What animals do you rescue and how? Name some NGOs in Delhi in this field. **[2025]**

Expected questions

1. What is the NSS motto and symbol, and when and why was NSS started?
2. What exactly did your NSS special camp achieve, and what happened in that village after you left?
3. Is NSS still relevant now that MY Bharat exists? How are the two different?
4. Volunteering often becomes a photo opportunity. How would you make it meaningful?
5. As DM in a flood, how would you organise and protect thousands of spontaneous volunteers?
6. Should community service be made compulsory for college students?
7. Are NGOs partners of the state or watchdogs? What is your view of FCRA restrictions?
8. 2026 is the International Volunteer Year. What would you do in your district to mark it meaningfully?

Model answer: Your NSS camp lasted seven days. Did you really change anything?

Honestly, the change in me was larger than the change in the village. We surveyed households, ran a health and hygiene camp and found several anaemic women whom we referred to the PHC, but without follow-up the impact fades. That taught me why sustained systems matter more than events. NSS already requires 240 hours over two years; I would make the special camp part of a two-year adoption, tracked by outcomes like referrals completed. As an administrator I would link NSS units with ASHAs, School Management Committees and panchayats, so that student energy feeds into institutions that stay in the village after the volunteers leave.

Model answer: Is volunteering a substitute for an effective state?

No; it complements the state but cannot replace it. Volunteers bring local trust, speed and energy, as Aapda Mitra volunteers and student groups showed in the Kerala floods, but rights such as education under Article 21A and health care need permanent, accountable institutions. When volunteers run parallel systems, the state can retreat and quality becomes uneven. As an officer I would register and train volunteers in advance, give them defined roles within government programmes, for example reading support under NIPUN Bharat, and insist on safeguarding and data privacy, so that civic goodwill strengthens public delivery rather than masking its gaps.

Common traps

- Listing NSS or NGO work without names, places, dates or outcomes; boards ask exactly which village, which NGO and what changed.
- Overclaiming impact; boards respect an honest 'it changed me more than them' with lessons learnt.
- Not knowing NSS basics (1969, 'Not Me But You', 240 hours) or confusing NSS with NCC, NYKS and scouts.

Preparation checklist

☐ Prepare a STAR note (situation, task, action, result) for each volunteering entry, with names, numbers and one honest limitation.

☐ Memorise NSS facts: 24 September 1969, V.K.R.V. Rao, motto, Konark wheel, 240 hours, special camp, National NSS Awards.

☐ Revise the ecosystem: NYKS, MY Bharat, Bharat Scouts and Guides, Aapda Mitra, Civil Defence, Electoral Literacy Clubs, NGO Darpan, FCRA, CSR.

☐ Know two current links: International Volunteer Year 2026 and ASER 2024 learning gaps, plus your State's volunteer models.

☐ Prepare views on compulsory community service, NGOs and the state, and safeguarding of beneficiaries.

ACTIVITY 3

Sports Achievements

Appears in DAFs as: school/university/state-level medals, team captain, inter-college champion, Khelo India participant, athletics best timing. A medal in the DAF lets boards test both the person (timings, positions, captaincy decisions) and the policy mind (why India wins so few Olympic medals and how a district can change that).

What the board is really testing

- Genuineness: event, level, year, your best timing or score, position played, coach and the record you are chasing
- Character: discipline, handling defeat, team versus individual ethic, and decisions taken as

captain

• Sports-policy grasp: Khelo India, TOPS, the 2025 governance law and the reasons behind India's Olympic underperformance

• Regional insight: why some States (Haryana, Manipur, Punjab) produce medallists and others do not

• Administrative imagination: what you would do as sports secretary or DM to raise participation and medal counts

Levels, bodies and pathways

- School sport runs through the **School Games Federation of India (SGFI)** and CBSE/State boards; university sport through the Association of Indian Universities (AIU) and Khelo India University Games.
- National federations (NSFs), the Indian Olympic Association and the Sports Authority of India (SAI, 1984) handle elite pathways; SAI runs National Centres of Excellence.
- **Khelo India** (2017–18) merged earlier schemes; it runs Youth, University, Para, Winter and Beach Games, Khelo India Centres and accredited academies.
- **TOPS** (Target Olympic Podium Scheme, 2014) funds elite athletes' training abroad, coaches and a monthly allowance; a Mission Olympic Cell selects athletes.
- Sport is a **State subject** (Entry 33, List II), so stadiums, district coaches and most school sport depend on States and districts.

India's record and benchmarks

- **Paris 2024**: 6 medals (1 silver, Neeraj Chopra; 5 bronze), no gold; Tokyo 2020 had 7 including Chopra's gold. Paris Paralympics brought a record 29 medals (7 gold).
- Hangzhou Asian Games 2023: a record 107 medals (28 gold); Khelo India athletes formed a large share of the squads.
- Regional clusters: Haryana (wrestling, boxing), Manipur (weightlifting, boxing), Punjab (hockey), Kerala (athletics), Odisha (hockey under State sponsorship).
- Know the national record and your State record in your own event, and how your best timing compares; boards ask both.

Institutions, law and awards

- **National Sports Governance Act 2025** (assent 18 August 2025): National Sports Board for recognition, National Sports Tribunal, Election Panel; partly in force from 31 December 2025.
- Federations need 15-member executives with at least two outstanding sportspersons and four women, plus ethics, dispute and athletes' committees; RTI applies where government grants flow.
- **National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act 2025** aligns with the UNESCO Convention and creates a National Board for Anti-Doping in Sports over NADA.
- **National Sports Policy 2025 (Khelo Bharat Niti)**, approved July 2025, replaces the 2001 policy, linking sport with education, economy, social development and global excellence.
- Awards: **Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna** (renamed 2021), Arjuna, Dronacharya, Arjuna (Lifetime), MAKA Trophy, Rashtriya Khel Protsahan Puraskar; 2024 Khel Ratna: Gukesh, Harmanpreet, Praveen Kumar, Manu Bhaker.

Current developments 2025–26

- **Ahmedabad will host the 2030 Commonwealth Games** (awarded November 2025); India is pursuing a bid for the 2036 Olympics.
- WADA's 2024 figures (released December 2025) put India top for adverse findings: 260 from 7,113 samples, a 3.6% rate, with athletics leading.
- The Sports Governance Act's bodies are being set up, putting federations such as wrestling and football under recognition and election norms.
- Cricket returns at the LA28 Olympics; India won the 2025 women's ODI World Cup and the 2026 men's T20 World Cup.
- Fit India's 'Sundays on Cycle' reached over 15,000 locations by July 2026, part of a push to make fitness a mass habit.

Why India underperforms: the social angle

- Causes: low school sport hours, few playgrounds and coaches, academic pressure, poverty and nutrition, and weak talent identification outside a few States.
- Governance: federation politics, age fraud, doping and the 2023 wrestlers' protest exposed weak athlete safeguards and accountability.
- Cricket's commercial pull dominates media and sponsorship; other sports rely on government funding and leagues of uneven viability.
- Positives: Khelo India, TOPS, corporate academies (JSW, Reliance, OGQ) and State models like Odisha hockey and Haryana's cash-plus-job incentives.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Sportspersons can enter government service through sports-quota recruitment; several States appoint top medallists directly as DSPs or officers.
- A DM can use DMF, CSR, MGNREGA and MPLADS funds for playgrounds, open gyms and Khelo India Centres, and revive district leagues and school sports days.
- Captaincy translates to administration: selecting on merit, backing an out-of-form player, and taking responsibility for defeat.
- Ethics: fair play, anti-doping, honest age certificates and safe sport for girls; officers must act on harassment complaints in sports bodies.

Asked in real interviews

1. You seem athletic. What is your favourite sprint event, what is your best timing, and what is the Indian best time at present? **[2024]**
2. You are an athlete, so tell me why India is lacking in sports, and what can be done to promote other sports. **[2024]**
3. Why is your sports column blank? Are you a nerd? **[2024]**
4. You are cricket team captain, not performing well, and the team is going for a series. Will you step down as captain or player? **[2024]**
5. What is India's rank in the Olympics? Why are countries like Belgium and New Zealand above India? Is the Olympics a business? **[2024]**
6. India with 1.4 billion people did not win one gold at the last Olympics. How do you explain that? **[2024]**
7. At which position did you play kabaddi? **[2024]**
8. How does kabaddi contribute to character development? **[2024]**

9. If you were made sports secretary, what steps would you take to improve medal counts, given Haryana wins many and Gujarat few? **[2023]**
10. You play cricket: what life lessons have you learnt from cricket, and what have you learnt as a captain? **[2023]**
11. Is your sports hobby for recreation or at a professional level? **[2021]**
12. Which civil servant won gold at the Paralympics? **[2025]**
13. You were part of the IIT Madras cricket team. Do you know cricketers from there who won international fame? **[2025]**
14. How can sports infrastructure be improved? What is the relevance of sports in life? **[2025]**
15. Your DAF shows a cricket team: what is the difference between a team and a group?
16. What did sports teach you, and how will you use it in administration?

Expected questions

1. What was your toughest match or race, and what did you do differently afterwards?
2. What is the national record in your event, and how far are you from it?
3. Why does India win so few Olympic medals despite its population?
4. Should sports-quota recruitment exist in civil services and the police?
5. India tops WADA's adverse findings list. Is it more testing or more cheating? What would you do?
6. As DM of a district with no stadium, how would you build a sports culture in three years?
7. What changes does the National Sports Governance Act 2025 bring for athletes?
8. As captain, would you drop your best friend from the team if he was out of form?

Model answer: India won no gold at Paris 2024. What is wrong with Indian sport?

The problem is the base of the pyramid more than the peak. Paris gave us six medals and the Paralympics a record 29, so elite support through TOPS works; but few schools have daily sport, trained coaches or playgrounds, and talent outside Haryana, Manipur or Punjab rarely gets spotted. Governance disputes and doping, where India topped WADA's 2024 adverse-findings list, also hurt. The 2025 Sports Governance Act and Khelo Bharat Niti address federations and policy. As an administrator I would focus on district-level basics: school sports periods, Khelo India Centres using CSR and DMF funds, and local leagues that let children compete regularly.

Model answer: You captained your team. As captain, would you drop yourself if you were out of form?

Yes, if the team's interest required it, and I would say so openly. As captain of my college team, I learnt that authority comes from being seen as fair; a captain who protects his own place loses the dressing room. I would first talk to the coach, accept data on my performance and, if needed, step aside or bat lower. The same principle applies in administration: an officer must hold himself to the standard he applies to subordinates. Accountability starting at the top, as in the Integrity Pledge, is what makes a team, or a district office, trust its leader.

Common traps

- Listing a medal but not knowing your own best timing, the national record or the year and venue of the event.
- Blaming only 'lack of sports culture' or cricket for India's Olympic record, without specifics or

solutions.

• Leaving the sports column blank and then sounding defensive; a calm answer about your fitness routine or one sport you follow is better.

Preparation checklist

☐ Write a fact card for each achievement: event, level, year, venue, score or timing, coach, team role and one defining moment.

☐ Learn your event's rules, national and world records, and India's top current athletes in it.

☐ Revise policy: SGFI, AIU, SAI, Khelo India, TOPS, Khelo Bharat Niti 2025, Sports Governance Act and Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act 2025.

☐ Know India's Paris 2024, Paralympics and Asian Games figures, the 2030 CWG award and the 2036 Olympic bid.

☐ Prepare a five-point district sports plan and a captaincy-dilemma answer.

ACTIVITY 4

Positions of Responsibility

Appears in DAFs as: student union president, class representative, hostel secretary, club head, fest/event organiser, debating society president, mentor. Positions of responsibility are the closest thing to administrative experience a fresh candidate has, so boards probe decisions, conflicts, dilemmas and how you dealt with authority.

What the board is really testing

• What you actually decided: budget, team, conflict, crisis, and what you would do differently

• Ethical judgement: dilemmas faced as a representative, fairness to rivals, handling pressure from peers and administration

• Understanding of campus governance: student unions, the Lyngdoh Committee, grievance and anti-ragging rules

• Balanced views on student politics: its democratic value versus violence, money and partisanship

• Transfer of skills: how organising a fest or running a hostel translates into running a district office

Types of roles and what boards look for

- Elected roles (union president, class representative) test representation and negotiation; appointed roles (club head, hostel secretary) test management and delivery.
- Event organisation (fests, conferences, marathons) tests budgeting, sponsorship, permissions, safety and teamwork under deadlines.
- Mentorship roles test empathy and patience; boards ask how you handled a struggling first-year student.

- For each role, be ready with one decision, one conflict, one failure and one measurable result; boards dislike titles without content.

Student union governance and the Lyngdoh Committee

- The Supreme Court, in **University of Kerala v Council of Principals of Colleges**, set up a committee under ex-CEC **J.M. Lyngdoh** (2005); its 2006 report was ordered into force.
- Age limits: undergraduates 17–22, postgraduates up to 24–25, research students up to 28; candidates need minimum attendance (75%) and no academic arrears.
- Spending cap of **Rs 5,000** per candidate, audited accounts within two weeks, only hand-made posters, and no funds from political parties or outside bodies.
- No criminal record or disciplinary action; one chance to contest for office-bearer posts; elections within six to eight weeks of session start; a grievance cell for disputes.
- Compliance is uneven: some States suspend union elections, others hold direct polls; parties' student wings still dominate campuses such as DU, JNU and Hyderabad.

Campus law and institutions

- Article 19(1)(a) and (c) protect speech and association, subject to reasonable restrictions; universities can regulate campus conduct but not bar ideas.
- **UGC anti-ragging regulations 2009** followed the Raghavan Committee and the Aman Kachroo case; colleges need anti-ragging committees, squads and affidavits.
- UGC (Redress of Grievances of Students) Regulations 2023 require Student Grievance Redressal Committees and an Ombudsperson in each university.
- Electoral Literacy Clubs (Election Commission, SVEEP) and the National Youth Parliament Festival build civic skills; NEP 2020 encourages student participation in governance.

Debates and current issues

- Student politics produced leaders from the JP movement to today's Parliament, but also violence, money power and class disruptions.
- JNU (2016) and later campus rows show how protest, sedition charges and police action on campuses become national controversies.
- Arguments for depoliticised unions (Kerala HC view on campus politics) contrast with arguments that partisan politics trains democratic citizens.
- Debating and MUN culture: boards ask why student debate matters when parliamentary debate quality is seen as declining.

Leadership concepts worth knowing

- Transformational versus transactional leadership (Burns); servant leadership (Greenleaf); situational leadership adapts style to followers' readiness.
- Team versus group: a team shares a goal and accountability; a group may only share space or a task.
- Delegation, consensus-building and conflict resolution are the core skills; a good representative carries bad news to both sides honestly.
- Parade or event coordination teaches the logic of drill and ceremony: rehearsal, timing, symbolism and public trust.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- A student union president negotiating with college authorities mirrors an SDM negotiating with protesters: listen, document, separate demands from positions.
- **Ethical dilemmas**: favouring friends, using office for personal benefit, or keeping silent on ragging; transparency and conflict-of-interest rules apply equally to officers.
- Fest budgeting and sponsorship relate to public procurement: competitive quotes, receipts, audit and no kickbacks.
- Pressuring administration lawfully (petitions, RTI, representation) versus coercion (gheraos, violence) shows whether a candidate respects due process.

Asked in real interviews

1. You were in the student union: is it only for personality development or is there something negative too? **[2024]**
2. When you were student union president, was the Lyngdoh Committee recommendation implemented? What challenges did you face? **[2024]**
3. What strategy did you use to pressurise the administration to get work done while in the student union? **[2024]**
4. You were president of the debating society: why is debating important, when at the highest levels we see a decline in quality? **[2024]**
5. What was your role as Student Representative? What ethical dilemmas did you face? **[2024]**
6. You were secretary of the hostel. What was your work? **[2024]**
7. What was your role as a mentor? How did you handle your first-year mentee? **[2024]**
8. Since you were part of the Electoral Literacy Club, (followed by questions on electoral bonds). **[2024]**
9. You were Activity Head of a Women in Data Science conference. Tell us about it. Why specifically women in data science? **[2024]**
10. What learnings did you get as an event organiser? **[2024]**
11. You were president of the Civil Engineering Students' Association and coordinator of a national conference (questions followed). **[2024]**
12. You were parade coordinator at school; tell me the significance of the parade. **[2023]**
13. How will organising a marathon help educate a city on environmental concerns? **[2023]**
14. Which university is mostly in the news for student politics? What happened in JNU some years back? Is student politics right, and what should be its limit? **[2021]**
15. What is this HRA you formed in school, based on the old one? **[2025]**
16. What activities did you do under Rotaract? What is the age group of members? What was the topic of the symposium you organised, and why? **[2019]**
17. What did you do as coordinator of the robotics club?

Expected questions

1. What was the hardest decision you took in that role, and who opposed it?
2. Should student union elections be allowed on party lines?
3. What are the main Lyngdoh Committee recommendations, and are they still relevant?
4. A friend in your council misused fest funds. What did you, or would you, do?
5. How did you handle a ragging complaint or a hostel food protest?
6. Leaders are born or made? Answer from your own experience.
7. What is the difference between a manager and a leader in a district office?

8. Your fest needed police and fire permissions. What did that teach you about government?

Model answer: Should student politics be banned on campuses?

No, though it must be regulated. Campus politics trains young people in representation, negotiation and dissent, and many national leaders began there. The problems are money, violence and outside party control, which is why the Lyngdoh Committee in 2006 set age limits, a Rs 5,000 spending cap and a ban on outside funding. The answer is enforcing those rules, holding regular elections and strong grievance systems under the 2023 UGC regulations, not a ban that pushes politics underground. As an administrator I would work with university authorities on peaceful election conduct and quick, fair responses to protests.

Model answer: What ethical dilemma did you face as a student representative?

My hardest moment was when classmates, including friends, wanted me to back a demand to postpone exams that I felt was unjustified for most students. I chose to present both views honestly to the faculty and suggested a smaller concession for students affected by a genuine clash with a university event. Some friends were upset, but the class trusted me more later. It taught me that representation is not echoing the loudest voice. An officer faces the same pressure from lobbies; transparency about reasons, consultation with those affected and consistency, as the Second ARC recommends, help build legitimacy.

Common traps

- Listing grand titles (president, head, secretary) without a single concrete decision, number or outcome.
- Speaking against all student politics or defending disruptive protest; both sound immature to a board.
- Not knowing the Lyngdoh Committee or UGC anti-ragging and grievance rules after claiming a union or council post.

Preparation checklist

☐ For each role, prepare one decision, one conflict, one failure, one result and one administrative parallel.

☐ Memorise Lyngdoh Committee basics: SC case, 2006 report, age limits, attendance, Rs 5,000 cap, no outside funds.

☐ Revise campus law: Article 19 rights, UGC anti-ragging 2009, grievance regulations 2023, Electoral Literacy Clubs.

☐ Prepare a balanced view on student politics and examples such as JNU 2016 or your own campus.

☐ Practise one ethical dilemma story told in 60 seconds, ending with a lesson for civil service.

ACTIVITY 5

Awards and Competitions

Appears in DAFs as: NTSE/KVPY/INSPIRE scholar, olympiad medallist, MUN delegate, hackathon winner, debate/essay prize, best speaker, excellence award. Every award in the DAF is a hook: boards ask who gave it, why you got it and what it is worth, then pivot to the policy behind scholarships, olympiads or the theme of your prize.

What the board is really testing

- Authenticity and detail: awarding body, year, amount, selection process and your exact contribution
- Depth on the theme: a debate prize on free markets or an essay prize leads to questions on that topic itself
- Policy knowledge: scholarship schemes, NTSE and KVPY's discontinuation, olympiad programmes, innovation drives
- Humility and perspective: what an award means beyond the certificate, and how you handled failure in competitions
- Transfer to service: how research, coding or public speaking skills will help in administration

Talent-search exams and scholarships

- **NTSE** (NCERT, origins 1963, renamed 1977) gave Rs 1,250 a month in Classes 11–12 and Rs 2,000 for UG/PG; it has not been held since 2021, pending a revamp.
- **KVPY** (DST, 1999, run from IISc Bengaluru) was discontinued in 2022 and merged into DST's **INSPIRE-SHE** scholarship for top science students.
- INSPIRE (DST, 2008): SHE scholarship of Rs 80,000 a year (Rs 60,000 plus Rs 20,000 mentorship grant); INSPIRE-MANAK rewards school students' ideas.
- **PM's Scholarship Scheme** (Kendriya Sainik Board) for wards of ex-servicemen and CAPF personnel pays Rs 2,500 a month for boys and Rs 3,000 for girls since 2019.
- Others: National Means-cum-Merit Scholarship (Class 9–12), Post-matric SC/ST scholarships, **PM-YASASVI** for OBC, EBC and DNT students, all via the National Scholarship Portal.

Olympiads and competitions

- The **Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education** (HBCSE-TIFR) runs India's olympiad programme in maths, physics, chemistry, biology, astronomy and junior science.
- India has competed at the International Mathematical Olympiad since 1989; at IMO 2024 in Bath, India placed fourth with four gold medals, its best result.
- **Smart India Hackathon** (since 2017, Ministry of Education and AICTE) has students solve problem statements set by ministries and industry.
- Model United Nations simulates UN bodies; know the UN Charter basics, Security Council reform debates and India's eight non-permanent terms.
- Google Summer of Code and competitive coding show open-source and problem-solving skills; boards ask why you stopped or what you built.

National awards and honours

- **Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar** honours children for bravery, innovation, sports, arts and social service; from 2024 it is presented around Veer Baal Diwas (26 December).
- **Rashtriya Vigyan Puraskar** (first given 2024) replaced the Shanti Swarup Bhatnagar Prize and other science awards; categories include Vigyan Ratna and Vigyan Yuva-SSB.
- Maths prizes compared to the Nobel: Fields Medal and Abel Prize; Indian-linked ones include the SASTRA Ramanujan Prize and the Infosys Prize.
- Sachin Tendulkar (2014) is the only sportsperson to receive the Bharat Ratna; National Youth Awards are given around National Youth Day (12 January).

Current developments 2025–26

- **PM Vidyalaxmi** (approved November 2024) offers collateral-free education loans for students in about 860 top institutions, with 3% interest subvention for family incomes up to Rs 8 lakh.
- Discontinued NTSE and KVPY mean fewer school-level talent signals; INSPIRE-SHE and State olympiads are now the main science-talent routes.
- NEP 2020 pushes recognition of extracurricular achievement through the Academic Bank of Credits and holistic report cards (PARAKH).
- Scholarship delivery has moved to DBT on the National Scholarship Portal, with Aadhaar seeding and institute verification to curb fraud.

Social angle and debates

- Talent exams reward coaching access; urban, English-medium students dominate, so scholarships need outreach to rural and first-generation learners.
- Scholarship delays and fraud (fake institutions and beneficiaries, uncovered in several States) undermine trust; timely DBT matters more than headline amounts.
- Competition culture builds excellence but can breed anxiety; Kota-type stress shows the cost of a single-metric view of merit.
- Debates and MUNs build reasoning and empathy for opposing views, skills directly useful in policy drafting and negotiation.

Administrative and ethical linkages

- Officers run scholarship verification, district talent searches and science fairs; ensuring timely disbursal is an administrative test.
- Hackathon and coding skills help in e-governance, grievance dashboards and data-driven monitoring of schemes.
- Ethics: claim only what you earned; group awards should be presented as team efforts. Boards punish exaggeration more than modest achievements.
- A public speaking award can be linked to communication duties: explaining policy, handling media and consulting gram sabhas.

Asked in real interviews

1. You are an NTSE scholar: which body gives it, how much do they pay, till what time, and did you submit any proofs periodically? **[2023]**
2. What did you learn from MUN? **[2023]**
3. What kind of scholarship did you get through PMSS? **[2023]**

4. You mentioned you participated in a talent exam (olympiad-style, in DAF); tell me about it. **[2024]**
5. Tell me about your essay mentioned in the DAF. **[2024]**
6. Why did they give you the excellence award? **[2024]**
7. You also got the Rani Jhansi award; what is inspiring about her? **[2024]**
8. Your DAF lists an olympiad in 'superlative English'. What is that? **[2024]**
9. Which sportsperson should get the next Bharat Ratna? **[2024]**
10. Tell me about the prize in mathematics comparable to the Nobel. Is there any such prize in India? **[2024]**
11. What is a skit? (DAF entry on a skit competition) **[2024]**
12. On your free-market debate prize: what is a free market, and does it need regulation? **[2025]**
13. What did you represent at Rashtrapati Bhavan? **[2025]**
14. What is the NMR award and why did they give it to you? **[2025]**
15. You have a best speaker award. What are three qualities of a best speaker? **[2025]**
16. You got an award in a plantation drive. What factors make a plantation drive successful, and what was your success rate? **[2025]**
17. About Google Summer of Code: why did you discontinue it?

Expected questions

1. NTSE and KVPY were discontinued. Was that a good decision?
2. What was the problem statement at your hackathon, and has your solution been used anywhere?
3. In your MUN you represented a country. Argue that country's position on Security Council reform.
4. Do olympiads and talent exams favour children who can afford coaching?
5. Scholarships often reach students late. As DM, how would you fix this?
6. What is the Rashtriya Vigyan Puraskar, and which award did it replace?
7. Your essay prize was on an environmental theme. What has changed on that issue since you wrote it?
8. Which award would you most like to win as a civil servant, and why?

Model answer: NTSE and KVPY have been discontinued. Is India losing a way to find young talent?

Partly, yes. NTSE, run by NCERT, and KVPY, run by DST through IISc, gave early recognition and stipends; KVPY has been merged into INSPIRE-SHE, and NTSE has not been held since 2021. But both were dominated by coached urban students, so a revamp could be fairer if it reaches rural and government-school children. INSPIRE-MANAK and State olympiads partly fill the gap. As an administrator I would run district talent searches in government schools, link winners to HBCSE olympiad camps and Atal Tinkering Labs, and ensure scholarship money arrives on time through DBT, which often matters more than the amount.

Model answer: You won a debate prize arguing for free markets. Does India need more state or more market?

India needs a capable state and freer markets together, not one or the other. Reforms since 1991 show that freeing markets lifted growth and cut poverty, yet markets alone did not deliver health, nutrition or learning, as ASER data on foundational reading show. In debate I argued that regulation should correct market failures such as monopoly, pollution and information gaps, not protect incumbents. In administration this means simplifying licences and compliance under ease of doing business, while strengthening regulators and public services. The real goal is a state that steers rather than rows, with clear rules and accountability.

Common traps

- Not knowing the awarding body, year, amount or selection criteria of your own scholarship or prize.
- Claiming a team award as personal, or exaggerating a participation certificate as an achievement.
- Ignoring the content behind the prize: a debate or essay award invites questions on that very topic.

Preparation checklist

☐ Make a card for each award: body, year, criteria, amount, your contribution, and one line on its theme.

☐ Revise scholarship schemes: NTSE, KVPY to INSPIRE-SHE, PMSS, NMMSS, Post-matric, PM-YASASVI, PM Vidyalaxmi, National Scholarship Portal.

☐ Know competition ecosystems: HBCSE olympiads, IMO record, Smart India Hackathon, MUN basics and UNSC reform.

☐ Learn national honours: PM Rashtriya Bal Puraskar, Rashtriya Vigyan Puraskar, National Youth Awards, Bharat Ratna for sport.

☐ Re-read your essay, debate or project topic and prepare a current, balanced view on it.

PART VI

When Hobbies Meet Your DAF

Real combination questions and how to answer them

HOBBY + DAF

Combination questions

Boards often join a hobby to your degree, job, home state, optional or another hobby. The question tests whether your DAF tells **one coherent story**. Below are real combinations, what each probes, and a model approach.

Principles

Find the genuine bridge, not a forced one. Link the hobby to your degree, job or state only through something you have actually experienced; the board probes any connection you invent.

Know the region behind the hobby. If a hobby has a geographic or cultural root (a cuisine, folk form, sport), expect your home state or district to be layered on, and prepare its ecology, history and current schemes.

Convert the hobby into an officer's lens. When asked how it helps administration, name one concrete quality (team trust, crisis calm, local language) and one practical initiative you would run.

Defend your choices without disparaging the alternative. For NSS vs NCC, AMC vs IAS, or politics vs service, explain why your path fits you while respecting the other.

Accept the challenge in the question. If the board suggests your hobby hurt your studies or is impractical, concede what is fair, then show balance with evidence.

Be ready to perform. Boards may ask you to sing, anchor or demonstrate; doing it briefly and with composure says more than any explanation.

Mechanical engineer + Formula 1 (district officer)

Asked

1. Drawing on your hobby and your engineering education, what new vehicle technologies are coming up in India? **[2021]**
2. How would your interest in Formula 1 help you in administration? **[2021]**

Probe: Whether the hobby is engaged with technically and whether the candidate can carry it into a public-policy frame.

Model approach

My engineering training is why Formula 1 interests me: it is a lab for energy recovery, aerodynamics and safety systems. Hybrid recovery tech has reached road cars, and India's EV push, FAME subsidies and battery-swapping policy face the same efficiency questions. For administration, F1 teaches data-driven decisions under pressure and pit-crew coordination. As a district officer I value the same thing: clear roles, rehearsed procedures and quick review after every operation.

Doctor + NCC

Asked

1. You were in NCC and you are medically trained; did you ever consider joining the Army Medical Corps? **[2021]**

Probe: Whether the candidate's choice of civil services over a uniformed medical career was a considered one.

Model approach

Yes, I did consider it seriously. NCC gave me discipline and respect for the forces, and the AMC would have used my medical degree directly. But in clinical work I kept seeing that most of my patients' problems began outside the hospital: sanitation, nutrition, delays in referral. I chose civil services to work on those determinants at scale. The NCC ethos of service before self is what links both paths for me.

IIT engineer + cricket and extracurriculars

Asked

1. Isn't inadequate attention given to the primary discipline, civil engineering, because of the other activities students do in college? **[2021]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can defend balance without dismissing academic rigour, and stay calm under a mildly accusatory frame.

Model approach

There is some truth in it. I have seen classmates let grades slip because of fests and sports. But in my case cricket complemented civil engineering: team captaincy taught me planning and accountability, the same skills a site engineer needs. The answer is prioritisation, not elimination. I kept my core courses first and played within that. Recruiters and our own faculty also look for graduates who can work in teams, not only solve problem sets.

Doctor in service + doodling

Asked

1. You doodle abstract emotional constructs; how can this be used in administration? **[2021]**

Probe: Whether an unusual, introspective hobby has a practical value the candidate can explain without overclaiming.

Model approach

Doodling helps me make my own thinking visible. As a doctor I used it to map a patient's history before deciding. In administration the same habit works as visual problem-structuring: sketching a grievance or a scheme as a flowchart shows where the bottleneck is. It also keeps me emotionally aware, which matters when dealing with distressed citizens. I would not claim it is a governance tool, but it makes me a clearer thinker.

Sports hobby + gender lens

Asked

1. As a woman officer, what would you focus on as far as sports infrastructure is concerned? **[2023]**
2. What are the achievements of Indian women cricketers? **[2021]**
3. Should there be pay parity between men and women cricketers? **[2024]**
4. Name three women mountaineers who have summitted Everest. **[2024]**

5. Have you heard of the recent weightlifting accident involving a girl? What do you make of it? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate's interest in a sport extends to its gender dimension and to the policy fixes it needs.

> **Model approach**
>
> As a woman who plays badminton, I know the barriers are rarely talent: they are safe courts, toilets, timings, women coaches and families' fears about travel. As an officer I would prioritise lit, secure facilities near schools, women coaches under Khelo India, and safe transport for competitions. Saina, Sindhu and our women's cricket team show what access does. On pay, BCCI's equal match fees are a good start; parity in contracts should follow revenue growth.

Sports hobby + home district/state

Asked

1. You have to select two athletes from your district (Ghazipur). What would you do? **[2023]**
2. Haryana wins many medals while Gujarat lags; as sports secretary, what would you do to improve the medal count? **[2023]**

Probe: Whether the candidate knows the sporting ecosystem of their own region and can design a fair, transparent selection or development process.

> **Model approach**
>
> I would not pick on reputation. I would hold open district trials at block level, with standard timing and fitness tests, include school and rural girls through outreach, and use a panel with an external coach. On Haryana, its edge comes from akharas, a sporting culture, cash awards and jobs for medallists. Gujarat can replicate the system parts: talent scouting through Khel Mahakumbh, sports hostels and assured careers, not just stadiums.

Cooking + home region

Asked

1. What is the difference between South Indian and Rajasthani cuisines? Are Rajasthani cuisines really healthy? **[2024]**
2. How did you get into cooking? What are the regional dishes of Rajasthan? **[2024]**
3. Which North Karnataka dishes do you prepare as part of your cooking hobby? **[2019]**
4. What are the famous vegetable dishes of the Barmer region? What is special about ker-sangri? **[2021]**
5. Tell us about Malwa cuisine; what is daal bafla? **[2023]**

Probe: Whether the candidate cooks for real and understands food as geography, ecology and culture.

Model approach

Rajasthani food is a response to the desert: little water and few green vegetables, so it relies on preserved items like ker-sangri, gram flour, millets and ghee. Bajra and ker-sangri are genuinely nutritious and drought-hardy. The heavy ghee and fried dishes made sense for hard physical work but need moderation for sedentary lifestyles. South Indian food, by contrast, is rice and coconut based because of the wetter climate. Cooking both taught me how geography shapes diet.

Folk-culture hobby + home state

Asked

1. Tell us about Bihu: what are its types and how is it celebrated? **[2019]**
2. You sing Punjabi folk songs; sing your favourite one. **[2024]**

Probe: Whether a culture-linked hobby is authentic, and whether the candidate can perform or explain it on the spot.

Model approach

I am happy to. Bihu has three forms tied to the agricultural cycle: Rongali in April with sowing and the new year, Kongali in October when granaries are empty, and Bhogali in January after harvest, with community feasts and meji bonfires. For me it is a living link between farming, music and community. If asked to sing, I sing a short verse confidently. The board is testing ease, not voice quality.

Tennis + taekwondo (two sports)

Asked

1. How can sports like tennis and taekwondo contribute to youth development? **[2024]**
2. What lessons can public administration draw from the Barcelona football club's economic crisis? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can find a common thread in two different pursuits and extend it to policy.

Model approach

The two teach complementary things. Tennis is individual and cerebral: managing pressure point by point, with no one to blame. Taekwondo teaches discipline, respect and controlled force, and gives girls self-defence confidence. Together they build resilience and self-regulation, which helps against addiction and screen dependence among youth. Taekwondo is also cheap to scale in schools. From Barcelona, I take a governance lesson: chasing short-term glory through debt destroys long-term institutional health.

Weightlifting vs powerlifting; NSS vs NCC

Asked

1. What is the difference between weightlifting and powerlifting? Which do you do? **[2024]**

2. Why NSS and not NCC? What did you learn? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate understands the precise difference between related activities and can justify a personal choice without disparaging the other.

Model approach

Weightlifting is the Olympic sport: snatch and clean-and-jerk, where speed and technique matter. Powerlifting tests maximal strength in squat, bench press and deadlift. I do powerlifting because it suits my training goals and needs less technical coaching. I chose NSS over NCC because I wanted community work: blood camps and literacy drives in villages. NCC builds discipline through drill; NSS built my understanding of people. Both instil service.

Anchoring + fitness (two hobbies)

Asked

1. The chairman set a task: anchor a fitness event on a TV news channel, using both hobbies. **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can perform under pressure and combine two hobbies spontaneously.

Model approach

I would treat it as a real task and start immediately. For example: 'Good morning! Today, on the Fit India stage, we have school children, a 70-year-old marathoner and a gym-trainer who took up running at forty. Fitness is not a luxury; it is a habit, and 30 minutes a day is enough.' The trick is to stay in character briefly, keep it crisp, and end by thanking the board with a smile.

Literature optional + film hobby

Asked

1. What are your favourite Marathi movies, and why are they not doing as well as South Indian films? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can connect their literature optional with a popular cultural interest and analyse an industry critically.

Model approach

Marathi cinema has strong content: Court, Sairat, Natsamrat draw on our literary and theatre tradition. It lags South cinema in scale because of smaller budgets, competition from Hindi films in the same market, fewer screens and weak dubbing and pan-India distribution. South industries invested in spectacle and star ecosystems. Marathi films could use state screen quotas wisely, OTT partnerships and dubbing to reach wider audiences while keeping their literary depth.

Civil engineer + analysing TV advertisements

Asked

1. What changes have occurred in advertisements on parameters like gender and family? **[2024]**

2. If you were head of marketing for your firm and had to advertise your product, how would you do it? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether an analytical hobby gives real social insight and can be applied to a practical, ethical task.

> **Model approach**
>
> Ads have moved from showing women only in kitchens to showing them as professionals, and men sharing chores, like the 'Share the Load' campaign. Family ads now include single parents and interfaith couples, though the backlash to some ads shows society is uneven. As an engineer I enjoy decoding how ads are built. For my firm's product, I would sell real performance claims, avoid stereotypes, and follow ASCI norms against misleading advertising.

Language-learning hobby + service posting

Asked

1. You learn languages and dialects; it would be great if you were posted in Nagaland. **[2021]**

Probe: Whether the candidate sees how a personal hobby becomes an administrative asset in a culturally diverse posting.

> **Model approach**
>
> I would welcome it. In the Northeast, language is a bridge of trust: many communities feel distant from Delhi, and an officer who speaks Nagamese or greets people in their tongue is heard differently. I already learn dialects through music and conversation, and I would start Nagamese before joining. As an IRTS officer I saw the value of local language in passenger grievances; in Nagaland it would matter even more.

Hip-hop + bureaucrat lens

Asked

1. You follow hip-hop. Have you watched Gully Boy? As a bureaucrat, what would you observe in the movie? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can read a hobby through a governance lens, not just as entertainment.

> **Model approach**
>
> Gully Boy shows Dharavi's youth with talent but no pathways: cramped housing, informal jobs, class barriers and drug-peddling as easy money. As a bureaucrat I would notice the gaps it reveals: few community spaces, weak skill programmes linked to creative industries, and poor slum redevelopment. Hip-hop itself is a protest art that voices urban marginalisation. I would see such youth as assets: create public studios, open mics and cultural incubators.

Doctor + HIIT fitness, as a collector

Asked

1. Will you promote HIIT as a collector? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can scale a personal fitness habit into a public-health initiative without imposing it.

Model approach

Not HIIT itself, because it is intense and not for everyone. As a doctor I know physical inactivity drives diabetes and hypertension. As collector I would promote a range: walking groups, yoga, school sports and open gyms in parks, under Fit India. HIIT suits young people and busy staff, so I might offer short sessions for district employees. The goal is a district culture of movement, matched to each age and health status.

Teaching hobby + corporate job (CSR)

Asked

1. What was your core motivational message to slum children when you taught them as part of L&T's CSR activities? **[2019]**

Probe: Whether the hobby is genuine and lived, and how the candidate links private-sector work with social commitment.

Model approach

My core message was that their circumstances did not decide their future. I told them about our engineers who came from small towns and used examples from the cranes and bridges they saw every day to teach mathematics. My job at L&T gave me the platform, and teaching gave me purpose. That experience is why I want public service: CSR helped dozens of children, but policy can reach millions.

Sports hobby + sports career and sports-administration job

Asked

1. Gopichand commented that the middle class should refrain from making sports a career option. Do you agree? **[2023]**
2. If Elon Musk says SAI should be scrapped because it failed to deliver in the Olympics, how would you respond? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can defend the sporting system they belong to while acknowledging its real weaknesses.

Model approach

I understand Gopichand's point: without assured income, sport is a risky career for middle-class families. I would not discourage them; I would reduce the risk with scholarships, sports quotas in jobs and insurance. On SAI, I would not scrap it, because it runs national centres and TOPS, which helped our Tokyo medallists. But it needs reform: athlete-centred governance, professional coaches and accountable federations. Medals follow decades of grassroots work.

Debating + career choice (politics)

Asked

1. You are good at debate; have you thought about going into politics? **[2023]**

Probe: Whether the candidate understands the difference between political and administrative roles and why they chose the latter.

> **Model approach**
>
> I respect politics; it is the most direct form of representation. But debating taught me to argue both sides, while a politician must take a side and mobilise for it. I am more suited to implementing well: listening to all stakeholders and giving impartial advice. Civil service uses the same skill differently, to present options to the minister and to explain decisions to citizens. So my debating serves neutrality, not partisanship.

Sports hobby + administration

Asked

1. How would you use your understanding of sports and experience in administration? **[2022]**
2. How can sports be useful in administration? **[2019]**
3. What did sports teach you, and how will you use it in administration? **[2021]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can turn a sporting experience into concrete administrative qualities and ideas, not clichés.

> **Model approach**
>
> Football taught me that results come from a team that trusts each other and a plan everyone understands. In administration, that means giving field staff clear roles and backing them. It also taught me to accept losing and to review the match honestly, which is what a good after-action review does. Practically, I would use sport for youth engagement in difficult districts, as Bastar's leagues and Mission Olympic programmes have shown.

Age + fitness

Asked

1. The board asked about his age, fitness routine and personal strengths. **[2025]**

Probe: Whether the candidate's fitness habit is real and whether it supports the stamina a demanding field career needs.

> **Model approach**
>
> I am twenty-six, and I train daily: running, bodyweight work and stretching for about an hour. I started during preparation because I found long study hours were draining me. Fitness keeps me calm and alert, which are my main strengths. A field posting with long hours, disaster response or night duty needs physical stamina, so I see training not as vanity but as preparation for the job.

Mechanical engineer + online gaming

Asked

1. What about the exposure of gaming in academics? **[2024]**

Probe: Whether the candidate can see the educational use and the risks of a hobby that is often seen as a distraction.

Model approach

Games build problem-solving, strategy and quick decision-making, and simulation games are already used to teach engineering and flight training. As a mechanical engineer I enjoyed physics-based games that made me think about forces and design. In schools, gamified learning can improve engagement, as DIKSHA modules try to do. But exposure needs limits: screen time, age-appropriate content, and safeguards against addiction and real-money gaming, which the Online Gaming Act now regulates.

PART VII

Night-before Revision Sheets

Ten facts, five likely questions and one officer link for every hobby and activity

QUICK REVISION

Revision sheets

Reading Books: ten facts

1. Bibliophile loves and collects books; bookworm reads compulsively; wordsmith is skilled with words.
2. Poirot uses psychology and 'little grey cells'; Sherlock Holmes relies on forensic observation and deduction.
3. Sen wrote The Argumentative Indian; Huntington, Clash of Civilizations; Sanjaya Baru, The Accidental Prime Minister.
4. Girish Karnad's plays: Tughlaq, Hayavadana. Tagore won the Nobel in 1913 for Gitanjali.
5. 59th Jnanpith: Vinod Kumar Shukla, first from Chhattisgarh; died in Raipur, 23 December 2025.
6. 58th Jnanpith shared by Gulzar and Jagadguru Rambhadracharya.
7. International Booker 2025: Banu Mushtaq's Kannada Heart Lamp, translated by Deepa Bhasthi; first Kannada winner.
8. Sahitya Akademi (1954) awards 24 languages; 2025 awards delayed from December 2025 to 16 March 2026.
9. Libraries are State List Entry 12; NBT runs Rashtriya e-Pustakalaya, a free digital library for children.
10. ASER 2024: only 27.1% of Std III children could read a Std II text.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the last book you read, and what did you learn from it?

Q2. What kind of books do you read: fiction or non-fiction, classical or contemporary? Name contemporary writers.

Q3. Do you read in print or on Kindle? Which is better and why?

Q4. Who won the 59th Jnanpith Award, and what is distinctive about his writing?

Q5. As District Collector, how would you build a reading culture among rural youth?

Officer link: Reading builds the empathy, judgement and clear drafting an administrator needs, and an officer can spread it through village and school libraries.

Creative Writing & Poetry: ten facts

1. Free verse drops fixed metre and rhyme (Whitman, Eliot); Vikram Seth's The Golden Gate uses rhymed sonnets.
2. Ghazal parts: sher, matla, maqta, radif, qafiya.
3. Chhayavad poets: Prasad, Pant, Nirala, Mahadevi Verma; Agyeya's Tar Saptak (1943) launched Prayogvad.
4. Dinkar's Rashmirathi (1952) retells Karna's life: 'charioteer of the sun's rays'. Dinkar won Jnanpith for Urvashi.
5. Thirukkural has 1,330 couplets on virtue, wealth and love; Andal's Thiruppavai has 30 Margazhi verses.
6. Mahadevi Verma, the 'modern Meera', won Jnanpith in 1982; wrote Shrinkhala ki Kadiyan.
7. Shreya Singhal (2015) struck down IT Act Section 66A but upheld Section 69A blocking powers.
8. BNS 2023: Section 196 promoting enmity, 299 outraging religious feelings, 356 defamation.
9. Imran Pratapgadhi case (March 2025): SC quashed FIR over a poem, applying the reasonable-person standard.
10. Copyright for literary works lasts the author's life plus 60 years; DPDP Rules notified November 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Who are your favourite poets? Have you read any contemporary poets?

Q2. Why is Rashmirathi named so? Tell us something special about Mahadevi Verma and Chhayavad.

Q3. What types of blogs do you write, and why that name? How many people read them?

Q4. Can a poem be a crime? Where should the line between creative freedom and public order lie?

Q5. Should civil servants publish poetry or blogs? What limits do the Conduct Rules impose?

Officer link: Writing trains the clarity an officer needs for notes, orders and press releases, and storytelling makes public campaigns reach people in their own dialect.

Movies & Cinema: ten facts

1. Raja Harishchandra (1913) was India's first feature; Alam Ara (1931) the first talkie.
2. Oscars 2023: Naatu Naatu and The Elephant Whisperers; Cannes Grand Prix 2024: All We Imagine As Light.
3. 71st National Film Awards: 12th Fail best feature; Mohanlal received the Dadasaheb Phalke Award.
4. 72nd National Awards: Article 370 best feature; Kartik Aaryan and Mammootty shared best actor; Yami Gautam best actress.
5. 72nd awards ceremony held at Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, on 22 September 2026; Anant Nag named Phalke awardee.
6. CBFC certifies under Cinematograph Act 1952; Film Certification Appellate Tribunal abolished 2021, appeals go to High Courts.
7. Cinematograph Amendment Act 2023: UA 7+, 13+, 16+ categories; piracy jail up to three years.
8. OTT is governed by IT Rules 2021 Part III: code of ethics, self-classification, three-tier grievance system.
9. Homebound, India's Oscar entry, made the December 2025 shortlist but missed the January 2026 nomination.
10. WAVES 2025 Mumbai: Rs 391 crore Indian Institute of Creative Technology and USD 1 billion creator fund.

Five likely questions

Q1. How is society influenced by social movies? Name films dealing with social issues.

Q2. Have you watched 12th Fail? What do you think of it?

Q3. Are violent films like Animal a concern? Would you censor such films?

Q4. OTT content is uncensored. Should it be brought under CBFC-type control?

Q5. Why are National Award-winning films not doing well at the box office?

Officer link: Cinema helps an officer read society, run IEC campaigns and protect lawful screenings, balancing free expression with public order.

Music & Indian Classical: ten facts

1. Seven swaras Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Dha Ni give 12 semitones; Sa and Pa are fixed (achal).

2. Hindustani uses 10 thaats (Bhatkhande); Carnatic uses 72 melakarta ragas (Venkatamakhin).

3. Carnatic Trinity: Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar, Syama Sastri; Purandara Dasa is the 'Pitamaha'.

4. Gharanas include Gwalior (oldest khayal), Agra, Kirana, Jaipur-Atrauli, Patiala and Mewati.

5. Natya Shastra classes instruments as tata, sushira, avanaddha and ghana; harmonium is a European free-reed instrument.

6. All India Radio banned the harmonium 1940–1971; minister B.V. Keskar barred film songs in the 1950s.

7. Copyright Amendment Act 2012 gave lyricists and composers a non-waivable right to royalties.

8. Grammys 2026: Amjad Ali Khan with sons Amaan and Ayaan won for the Dalai Lama's Meditations.

9. Zubeen Garg died September 2025; Pt. Chhannulal Mishra died October 2025; Zakir Hussain died December 2024.

10. SC 2005 order: no loudspeakers 10 pm–6 am; Noise Pollution Rules date from 2000.

Five likely questions

Q1. Who is your favourite singer? Are old songs better than new ones?

Q2. What is the difference between Hindustani and Carnatic music? Name two Carnatic proponents.

Q3. What is sur? How many surs are there, and how do Bollywood and classical sur differ?

Q4. Why was the harmonium banned on All India Radio, and which minister was involved?

Q5. Folk artists of your home state are struggling. What would you do as Collector?

Officer link: Music teaches riyaz, patience and listening, and lets an officer reach citizens through folk forms while preserving dying traditions and artists' livelihoods.

Painting, Sketching & Art: ten facts

1. Oil dries slowly with rich blending; acrylic is water-based and fast-drying.

2. Cubism (Picasso and Braque, c. 1907-14) used geometric planes; Gaganendranath Tagore experimented with it.

3. V.S. Wakankar identified Bhimbetka rock shelters (MP) in 1957; UNESCO site since 2003.

4. Abanindranath Tagore founded the Bengal School ('Bharat Mata'); Nandalal Bose illustrated the Constitution.

5. Progressive Artists' Group (Bombay, 1947): Souza, Raza, Husain, Ara, Bakre, Gade.

6. Kalamkari (Andhra) styles: Srikalahasti freehand pen and Machilipatnam block-printed, GI-tagged.

7. Antiquities and Art Treasures Act 1972 bars export of national art treasures by nine artists.

8. Lalit Kala Akademi and National Gallery of Modern Art were both founded in 1954.

9. April 2026: Ravi Varma's Yashoda and Krishna sold for Rs 167.2 crore, an Indian auction record.

10. FM wore Madhubani saree by Padma Shri Dulari Devi on Budget day, 1 February 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Which painter do you like? What themes do you paint, and in which medium?

Q2. What is cubism in art, and whom did it inspire?

Q3. Middlemen take most Madhubani profits. What is the government doing?

Q4. How can traditional arts like Madhubani and Kalamkari be promoted among children?

Q5. You do pencil sketching; isn't it just copying?

Officer link: Painting sharpens observation and visual communication, letting an officer use murals for public campaigns and link folk artists to fair markets.

Photography: ten facts

1. Niépce made the earliest surviving photograph (c. 1826-27); World Photography Day is 19 August.

2. Exposure triangle: aperture controls depth of field, shutter speed motion, ISO sensitivity and noise.

3. Bokeh is aesthetic out-of-focus blur from wide apertures like f/1.8.

4. Bird photography needs telephoto lenses of about 400-600 mm and fast shutter speeds.

5. Homai Vyarawalla, India's first woman photojournalist, received the Padma Vibhushan in 2011.

6. Raghu Rai, famed for Bhopal and Bangladesh war images, died on 26 April 2026 aged 83.

7. Danish Siddiqui won Pulitzers (2018, 2022); killed covering Afghanistan in 2021.

8. Under the Copyright Act 1957, the photographer is author; protection lasts 60 years from publication.

9. IT Amendment Rules 2026 require labels on AI-generated images; some takedowns within three hours.

10. Camera traps underpin tiger census: about 3,682 tigers in 2022, around 75% of world's wild tigers.

Five likely questions

Q1. Which camera and lens do you use? Which lens is preferred for bird photography?

Q2. Name famous photographers, including Indian nature photographers. What type of photography do they do?

Q3. What is bokeh? What is street photography?

Q4. Street photography tells a story. How can storytelling benefit administration?

Q5. As collector, how will you stop fake geo-tagged photographs being used to claim scheme payments?

Officer link: Photography helps an officer verify works through geo-tagged evidence and tell development stories honestly, while respecting the privacy of victims and children.

Dance (Classical & Folk): ten facts

1. Natyashastra's four abhinayas: angika, vachika, aharya and sattvika.

2. Dance has three elements: nritta (pure rhythm), nritya (expressive) and natya (drama).

3. Sangeet Natak Akademi recognises eight classical forms; the Culture Ministry also lists Chhau.

4. Kathak gharanas: Lucknow (expressive), Jaipur (footwork), Banaras; Raigarh developed in Chhattisgarh.

5. Rukmini Devi Arundale founded Kalakshetra (1936), reframing Sadir as Bharatanatyam.

6. Vallathol founded Kerala Kalamandalam (1930); Sattriya gained classical status in 2000.

7. Madras Devadasis (Prevention of Dedication) Act 1947 ended temple dedication.

8. Copyright Act 1957 protects original choreography as dramatic work; traditional forms are public domain.

9. Natyashastra and Gita manuscripts entered UNESCO's Memory of the World Register in April 2025.

10. Garba was inscribed in December 2023; Deepavali became India's 16th element at Red Fort, December 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Bharatanatyam needs three elements. Can a dancer do well with only two?

Q2. Who are the main proponents of Bharatanatyam, and what is its social significance?

Q3. Do traditional art forms inadvertently reinforce social stratification?

Q4. Why do South Indian states have more classical dance forms?

Q5. Which form of intellectual property right applies to Kathak?

Officer link: Dance teaches discipline and expression, and folk forms let an officer carry welfare messages to communities while ensuring artists are paid fairly.

Cricket: ten facts

1. MCC (1787) is custodian of the Laws; ICC (1909) is headquartered in Dubai.

2. Chucking means straightening the elbow beyond 15 degrees; pink ball is used for day-night Tests.

3. India women won their maiden ODI World Cup on 2 November 2025, beating South Africa by 52 runs.

4. India men won the 2026 T20 World Cup, beating New Zealand by 96 runs on 8 March 2026.

5. RCB won IPL 2026, beating Gujarat Titans at Ahmedabad, a second straight title after 2025.

6. Vaibhav Suryavanshi became the youngest IPL centurion at 14 in 2025.

7. Zee Telefilms (2005): BCCI is not 'State' under Article 12 but amenable to Article 226 writs.

8. National Sports Governance Act 2025 creates a National Sports Board and Tribunal; BCCI stays outside RTI.

9. Online Gaming Act 2025 banned real-money games; Apollo Tyres replaced Dream11 as Team India sponsor till 2027.

10. Cricket returns at LA28: six-team men's and women's T20 events at Pomona.

Five likely questions

Q1. Should men and women cricketers get equal pay?

Q2. Why was 2 November 2025 a notable day for Indian cricket?

Q3. Which cricketer inspires you most and why? Compare captaincy of Dhoni, Kohli and Ganguly.

Q4. Should India play cricket with Pakistan? Why?

Q5. What watershed moment made cricket popular in India? Why can't football be promoted similarly?

Officer link: Cricket teaches teamwork and composure under pressure, and its stadium crowds remind an officer that event management and SOPs are core administrative duties.

Football: ten facts

1. FA codified rules in 1863; IFAB (1886) makes the Laws; FIFA was founded in 1904 in Paris.
2. Syed Abdul Rahim era: Asian Games golds 1951 and 1962; fourth at 1956 Melbourne Olympics.
3. India qualified for the 1950 World Cup but did not travel; the barefoot story is largely a myth.
4. Sunil Chhetri, record scorer with 90-plus goals, retired in 2024 and returned in March 2025.
5. Khalid Jamil became, in August 2025, the first Indian men's head coach in 13 years.
6. FIFA suspended AIFF in August 2022 for third-party influence; lifted after about 11 days.
7. SC AIFF judgment (19 September 2025): eminent players on bodies, 70-year age cap, promotion-relegation mandatory.
8. Spain won the 2026 World Cup, beating Argentina 1-0 after extra time on 19 July 2026.
9. East Bengal won the shortened 2025–26 ISL, their first top-flight title in 22 years.
10. India fell to 142nd in FIFA rankings after losing to Bangladesh; missed the 2027 Asian Cup.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why is Indian football in a poor state, and why can't it be promoted like cricket?

Q2. What was the recent issue involving the AIFF, and its implications for Indian football?

Q3. Is it justified that footballers earn far more than doctors and engineers?

Q4. What steps would you take to improve Indian football?

Q5. Who is the greatest footballer of all time? Name today's top three players.

Officer link: Football shows an officer how grassroots leagues engage youth in tribal and border districts, and why federation governance and crowd safety need firm oversight.

Hockey: ten facts

1. FIH founded 1924, headquartered in Lausanne; 11-a-side on synthetic turf, four 15-minute quarters.
2. India: 8 Olympic golds (six straight 1928–1956, 1964, 1980) and the 1975 World Cup in Kuala Lumpur.
3. Astroturf at Montreal 1976 favoured fitness and speed, eroding India's dribbling-based advantage.
4. Dhyan Chand: golds 1928, 1932, 1936; his birthday, 29 August, is National Sports Day.
5. Balbir Singh Sr's five goals in the 1952 Olympic final remain a record.
6. Tokyo 2020 bronze ended a 41-year drought; Paris 2024 bronze (beat Spain 2–1) gave back-to-back medals.
7. No sport is officially India's 'national game', per Sports Ministry RTI replies.
8. Odisha sponsors national teams since 2018, extended to 2036; hosted 2018 and 2023 men's World Cups.
9. 2026 World Cup: men 8th, women 5th; Asian Games 2026: both teams won gold, qualifying for LA 2028.
10. National Sports Governance Act 2025: National Sports Board and Tribunal; key provisions in force 1 January 2026.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why does India lag in Olympic medals, and what can be done to improve the tally?

Q2. What is the future of hockey in India after back-to-back Olympic bronzes?

Q3. Why should other sports be promoted instead of focusing only on cricket?

Q4. Why did India finish only 8th at the 2026 World Cup despite Olympic medals?

Q5. As DM of a tribal district, how would you build a hockey pipeline?

Officer link: Hockey teaches role clarity and collective responsibility; an officer applies the same to lead a district team and build inclusive sports pipelines.

Kabaddi: ten facts

1. Seven players per side; the raider chants 'kabaddi' in one breath while tagging defenders and returning.
2. Super tackle: fewer than four defenders stop the raider; PKL adds the do-or-die raid.
3. Demonstration sport at 1936 Berlin Olympics; in the Asian Games since Beijing 1990.
4. India won all seven men's Asian Games golds 1990–2014; Iran beat India in 2018 (bronze).
5. Asian Games 2026: India won both golds, beating Iran 40–34 (men) and 37–34 (women).
6. Indian women retained the Kabaddi World Cup in Dhaka, November 2025, beating Chinese Taipei 35–28.
7. Pro Kabaddi League began July 2014; Season 12 (2025) won by Dabang Delhi KC over Puneri Paltan.
8. AKFI founded 1973; IKF suspended it in July 2024 for lacking an elected body.
9. AKFI elections at Ranchi, June 2026: Punit Balan elected unopposed as president for 2026–30.
10. Traditional games revival is a Khelo Bharat Niti 2025 pillar; kabaddi needs only a mat or mud court.

Five likely questions

Q1. What have you learnt from playing kabaddi?

Q2. Where do we stand as a nation in kabaddi?

Q3. How does kabaddi contribute to character development?

Q4. Has the Pro Kabaddi League helped or hurt the traditional game?

Q5. As a district collector, how would you use kabaddi to engage rural youth?

Officer link: Kabaddi teaches tackling as a unit and knowing when to retreat, skills an administrator needs in crisis management and team leadership.

Badminton: ten facts

1. Developed by British officers in Poona in the 1870s; BWF (1934, as IBF) is based in Kuala Lumpur.
2. Court is 13.40 m x 6.10 m; net is 1.55 m at posts, 1.524 m at centre.
3. A shuttle has 16 feathers from a goose or duck's left wing, weighing 4.74–5.50 g.
4. BWF approved 3x15 scoring on 25 April 2026, effective 4 January 2027.
5. Saina won bronze at London 2012; Sindhu won silver at Rio 2016 and bronze at Tokyo 2020.
6. India won the 2022 Thomas Cup in Bangkok, beating 14-time champions Indonesia 3-0.
7. Satwik Rankireddy holds the Guinness record for the fastest hit: 565 km/h in 2023.
8. India Open 2026 row: AQI, bird droppings, a monkey; Anders Antonsen withdrew and was fined $5,000.
9. 2026 World Championships, New Delhi: India's only medal was Treesa Jolly–Gayatri Gopichand's doubles bronze.
10. Ahmedabad hosts the 2030 Commonwealth Games; India is bidding for the 2036 Olympics.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why are shuttlecocks made of feathers? Which birds, how many feathers, any animal-rights concern?

Q2. What recent issue arose at the India Open, and how does it affect India's 2036 Olympic bid?

Q3. Which badminton player do you admire? How does Sindhu's style differ from Saina's?

Q4. What would you do to get children, especially rural girls, interested in badminton?

Q5. Give the dimensions of a badminton court and the net height.

Officer link: Badminton's India Open lessons show an officer that hygiene, safety and infrastructure upkeep decide a nation's credibility as a host.

Table Tennis: ten facts

1. Net height 15.25 cm; table 2.74 m by 1.525 m, 76 cm high.
2. Ball is 40 mm and 2.7 g; plastic since 2014, size raised from 38 mm in 2000.
3. Games to 11 points since 2001; Olympic sport since Seoul 1988.
4. Topspin and backspin make the ball dip or 'swing' through the Magnus effect.
5. Ping-pong diplomacy (1971): after Nagoya Worlds, US team visited China, paving way for Nixon's 1972 visit.
6. Sharath Kamal: five Olympics, 7 CWG golds; retired at WTT Star Contender Chennai, March 2025.
7. Manika Batra: 2018 CWG singles gold; first Indian in an Olympic singles round of 16 (Paris 2024).
8. Paris 2024: Indian women reached their first Olympic team quarterfinal, beating Romania 3–2.
9. Delhi High Court suspended TTFI and appointed a Committee of Administrators, February 2022.
10. Asian Games 2026: only medal was mixed doubles bronze (Diya Chitale–Manush Shah); TT dropped from Glasgow 2026.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the height of the net and the weight of a table tennis ball?

Q2. Can a table tennis ball swing? Explain the mechanism.

Q3. What was ping-pong diplomacy?

Q4. Why are Indian table tennis players unable to progress at the international level?

Q5. Why does China dominate table tennis, and what can India learn?

Officer link: Table tennis builds split-second judgement and self-accountability, qualities an administrator needs when making field decisions under pressure.

Chess: ten facts

1. Chess originated as chaturanga in Gupta-era India; FIDE was founded in Paris in 1924.
2. Elo system, by physicist Arpad Elo, adopted by FIDE in 1970; Carlsen's peak is a record 2882.
3. Grandmaster title needs three GM norms plus a 2500 rating.
4. Wheat on 64 doubling squares totals 2^64 − 1 grains, about 1.8 x 10^19.
5. Anand became India's first GM in 1988 and was five-time world champion.
6. Gukesh became youngest undisputed world champion at 18, beating Ding Liren in Singapore, December 2024.
7. Divya Deshmukh won the 2025 Women's World Cup in Batumi, becoming India's 88th GM.
8. Aswath S became India's 98th GM in July 2026; Tamil Nadu has 38 GMs.

9. World Championship 2026: Gukesh vs Sindarov, 24 November–12 December, near Geneva.

10. Vaishali won the 2026 Women's Candidates and challenges China's Ju Wenjun.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why does Tamil Nadu produce so many chess Grandmasters?

Q2. What qualities and life skills has chess helped you develop?

Q3. What is the Elo rating system? What is your rating, and Grandmasters' ratings?

Q4. Should civil servants be required to learn chess?

Q5. Chess is called the most intelligent game. Do you consider yourself among the most intelligent?

Officer link: Chess trains an officer to think several moves ahead and anticipate second-order effects, though administration also needs empathy and consultation chess cannot teach.

Athletics (Track and Field): ten facts

1. World Athletics founded 1912 as IAAF, renamed 2019, headquartered in Monaco.

2. Marathon is 42.195 km, fixed after the 1908 London Olympics; endurance running is broader.

3. Milkha Singh won 1958 Asian Games 200m and 400m gold; fourth at Rome 1960.

4. P.T. Usha missed 1984 400m hurdles bronze by 1/100th second; later became IOA president.

5. Neeraj Chopra: Tokyo 2020 gold (87.58m), 2023 world title, Paris 2024 silver; 90.23m at Doha, May 2025.

6. Tokyo 2025 Worlds: no Indian medal; Sachin Yadav fourth (86.27m), Neeraj eighth.

7. Animesh Kujur holds 100m record 10.15s (Ranchi, May 2026) and 200m record 20.32s.

8. WADA 2024 report: India 260 adverse findings in 7,113 samples, 3.6% positivity, highest among major testers.

9. Sports Governance Act 2025: executive age band 25–70, at least four women, athlete representation, RTI applicable.

10. Khelo India funds grassroots talent; TOPS (2014) funds elite training; NADA statutory under 2022 Act.

Five likely questions

Q1. As an athlete, why is India lagging in sports, and how can sports other than cricket be promoted?

Q2. Running is your hobby. How does it affect mental health? What is your longest run?

Q3. What does endurance running mean, and how does it differ from a marathon?

Q4. Why does running feel hard in Bengaluru but soothing in Thiruvananthapuram?

Q5. India tops WADA's doping list. As DM, what would you do about doping locally?

Officer link: Running builds endurance and calm under stress; an administrator can extend it to district talent hunts, clean sport and staff fitness.

Swimming: ten facts

1. Individual medley order: butterfly, backstroke, breaststroke, freestyle; Olympic pool is 50 m with 10 lanes.

2. FINA was renamed World Aquatics in December 2022.

3. Synchronised swimming renamed artistic swimming in 2017; judged on execution and artistry, not time.

4. Michael Phelps is the most decorated Olympian: 28 medals, 23 of them gold.

5. Mihir Sen first Asian to swim the English Channel (1958); Arati Saha first Asian woman (1959).

6. Murlikant Petkar won India's first Paralympic gold, 50 m freestyle, Heidelberg 1972.

7. Paris 2024: only two Indian swimmers, Srihari Nataraj and 14-year-old Dhinidhi Desinghu.

8. 2025 Asian Aquatics Championships, Ahmedabad: India's best-ever 13 medals; no swimming medal at Asian Games 2026.

9. WHO 2024 drowning report: over 3 lakh deaths in 2021; 25 July is World Drowning Prevention Day.

10. Kerala: 67 amoebic meningoencephalitis cases and 18 deaths by mid-September 2025 (Naegleria fowleri).

Five likely questions

Q1. Why are we not able to win medals in swimming? Is genetics a reason?

Q2. What is the difference between swimming and synchronised (artistic) swimming?

Q3. Which swimmer is the most successful Olympian, and how many medals did he win?

Q4. Is it safe to swim in natural water bodies?

Q5. As DM of a flood-prone district, what would you do to prevent drowning?

Officer link: Swimming links to disaster preparedness: an administrator can promote survival swimming, trained rescuers and pool safety to save lives in flood-prone districts.

Yoga & Meditation: ten facts

1. Patanjali's Yoga Sutras: 196 sutras in four padas; yoga is 'chitta vritti nirodha'.

2. Ashtanga's eight limbs: yama, niyama, asana, pranayama, pratyahara, dharana, dhyana, samadhi.

3. Gita's paths: karma, bhakti, jnana yoga; Vivekananda's Raja Yoga (1896) took Patanjali to the West.

4. Yogananda founded Self-Realization Fellowship (1920); wrote Autobiography of a Yogi (1946).

5. S.N. Goenka revived Vipassana at Dhamma Giri, Igatpuri (1976); Tihar's Vipassana programme began 1993.

6. IDY proposed at 69th UNGA (2014); resolution 69/131 had record 177 co-sponsors; 21 June is summer solstice.

7. Yoga inscribed on UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage list in 2016; yogasana recognised as sport in 2020.

8. IDY 2025: 'Yoga for One Earth, One Health' at Visakhapatnam, about 3 lakh people, Guinness record.

9. IDY 2026: 'Yoga for Healthy Ageing', national event at Red Road, Kolkata.

10. WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine is at Jamnagar; Delhi Declaration adopted December 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is Vipassana, who started it, and how has it helped you?

Q2. Explain the origin of yoga and Ashtanga's eight limbs. At which stage are you?

Q3. What are karma, bhakti, jnana and raja yoga? What kind of yogi was Gandhi?

Q4. Why was 21 June chosen for International Day of Yoga?

Q5. What physiological process happens during pranayama? What are its immediate and long-term benefits?

Officer link: Meditation builds the equanimity and impulse control an officer needs, while yama-niyama values like satya and asteya mirror integrity in public life.

Running, Cycling & Fitness: ten facts

1. Marathon distance of 42.195 km was fixed at the 1908 London Olympics, standardised 1921.
2. Pace is time per distance (min/km); speed is distance per time (km/h).
3. Kelvin Kiptum's 2:00:35 (Chicago 2023) is the men's marathon world record.
4. Randonneuring BRMs run 200–1,200 km; RAAM is about 4,800 km; Srinivas Gokulnath first Indian solo finisher (2017).
5. Gulveer Singh set 2025 national records: 10,000 m in 27:00.22, 5,000 m in 13:11.82.
6. Fauja Singh, marathoner past 100, died in a road accident in Punjab in July 2025.
7. Fit India launched 29 August 2019; 'Sundays on Cycle' began December 2024; World Bicycle Day is 3 June.
8. WADA 2024 data: India had 260 adverse findings from 7,113 samples, a 3.6% rate, highest.
9. National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act 2025 creates a National Board for Anti-Doping overseeing NADA.
10. WHO recommends 150–300 minutes of moderate activity weekly; India sees over 1.7 lakh road deaths yearly.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why the name marathon? What is its distance, and where all have you run?

Q2. What is the difference between pace and speed in running?

Q3. Why is India not favourable to cycling? What needs to be done?

Q4. India tops WADA's doping list. Is it more testing or more cheating? What should be done?

Q5. As Municipal Commissioner, how would you make your city safe for cyclists and pedestrians?

Officer link: Endurance sport teaches an officer pacing and delayed gratification for long projects, and the road-safety and doping issues it raises are governance responsibilities.

Gym and Strength Training: ten facts

1. Powerlifting: squat, bench, deadlift; Olympic weightlifting: snatch, clean & jerk. Only weightlifting is Olympic; para powerlifting Paralympic.
2. Isometric contraction creates tension without changing muscle length, as in a plank or wall-sit.
3. WHO: 150–300 minutes moderate aerobic activity weekly, plus muscle-strengthening on two or more days.
4. Karnam Malleswari's Sydney 2000 bronze was the first Olympic medal by an Indian woman.
5. Mirabai Chanu: Tokyo 2020 silver; 2025 World Championships silver, Førde, 199 kg in 48 kg.
6. Sudhir won para powerlifting gold at the Birmingham 2022 Commonwealth Games.
7. Fit India Movement launched on National Sports Day, 29 August 2019.
8. FSSAI regulates supplements under Health Supplements and Nutraceuticals regulations; over-the-counter steroid sales are illegal.
9. ICMR–AIIMS (July 2025): no link between Covid vaccination and sudden deaths in 18–45 year olds.
10. NFHS-5: 24% of women and 22.9% of men overweight or obese.

Five likely questions

Q1. How is powerlifting different from weightlifting, and which one is in the Olympics?

Q2. Why are so many youngsters dying in gyms, and how can it be prevented?

Q3. Is there class, caste or gender bias in gyms?

Q4. What are lifestyle diseases, and how can they be prevented?

Q5. How can fitness be measured without a device? What is isometric exercise?

Officer link: Gym discipline models resilience; an administrator can make fitness inclusive through open-air gyms and enforce safety against steroids and unsafe supplements.

Trekking & Mountaineering: ten facts

1. Hiking is a day walk; trekking is multi-day without technical gear; mountaineering uses ropes, axes, crampons.
2. AMS can progress to HAPE (lungs) or HACE (brain); rule: 'climb high, sleep low'.
3. Everest re-announced at 8,848.86 m (2020); first ascent by Tenzing and Hillary, 29 May 1953.
4. Bachendri Pal: first Indian woman on Everest (1984); Arunima Sinha: first woman amputee (2013).
5. Nag Tibba is about 3,022 m (Tehri); Triund is in the Dhauladhar, Kangra.
6. HMI Darjeeling (1954) had Tenzing as first field director; NIM Uttarkashi founded 1965.
7. IMF (1961) issues peak permissions and appoints liaison officers for foreign expeditions.
8. Sahastra Tal (June 2024): nine of a 22-member Karnataka group died in an Uttarkashi blizzard.
9. Uttarakhand opened 83 peaks in February 2026, waiving fees for Indian climbers.
10. Record 274 climbers summited Everest from Nepal on 20 May 2026; Nepal royalty now US$15,000.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the difference between hiking, trekking and mountaineering?

Q2. Which treks have you done, and what is the highest altitude you reached?

Q3. What preparation and safety protocols are required before going on a trek?

Q4. Queues and deaths occur on Everest; what drives people to climb mountains?

Q5. Who appoints the liaison officer for mountaineering expeditions?

Officer link: The mountaineer's wisdom of turning back against summit fever teaches an officer to resist sunk-cost bias and put safety before targets.

Quizzing: ten facts

1. Good quiz questions are workable: they reward reasoning from clues, not mere recall.
2. Formats include pounce and bounce, buzzer, connect and audio-visual rounds.
3. BBC's Mastermind began 1972, hosted first by Magnus Magnusson; specialist and general rounds, black chair.
4. Neil O'Brien, father of Indian quizzing, conducted a pioneering formal quiz in Kolkata in 1967.
5. Derek O'Brien hosted the Bournvita Quiz Contest; later became a Rajya Sabha MP.
6. Siddhartha Basu hosted Doordarshan's Quiz Time and Mastermind India; shaped India's TV quiz industry, including KBC.
7. KBC, hosted by Amitabh Bachchan since 2000, adapts Who Wants to Be a Millionaire.
8. Spelling bee tests orthography and etymology; quizzing tests breadth, connections and inference.
9. MEA's Bharat Ko Jano quiz connects diaspora youth with Indian culture; MyGov runs national quizzes.
10. Retrieval practice and spaced repetition strengthen memory; quizzing is active recall.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the difference between hosting quizzes and participating in them?

Q2. How does the skill set for quizzes differ from that for a spelling bee?

Q3. Name a few quizmasters from India. Who is the father of Indian quizzing?

Q4. Do you know about Mastermind?

Q5. In the age of Google and AI, is quizzing still relevant?

Officer link: Quizzing trains quick retrieval and a habit of verifying before asserting, protecting an administrator from misinformation in briefings and crises.

Debating and Public Speaking: ten facts

1. British Parliamentary format: four teams of two; used at the World Universities Debating Championship.
2. Aristotle's modes of persuasion: ethos (credibility), pathos (emotion), logos (logic).
3. Shastrartha tradition: Shankara–Mandana Mishra debate, with Ubhaya Bharati as judge.
4. Akbar's Ibadat Khana at Fatehpur Sikri hosted religious debates from 1575.
5. Constituent Assembly debated two years, 11 months, 18 days, a model of reasoned disagreement.
6. Article 19(1)(a) guarantees free speech; Article 105 gives MPs freedom of speech in Parliament.
7. Sita Soren (2024): legislative privilege does not protect bribery, overruling the 1998 Narasimha Rao ruling.
8. Shreya Singhal (2015) struck down Section 66A of the IT Act as vague.
9. Zero Hour is a parliamentary convention since 1962.
10. 2025 Monsoon Session held a special discussion on Operation Sindoor; Waqf (Amendment) Bill debated April 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Why is debating important when debate quality is declining at the highest levels?

Q2. Parliamentary debates once had civility (Nehru, Vajpayee). How can that culture be restored?

Q3. Give a two-minute speech on 'Justice delayed is justice denied'.

Q4. Is India a debating society or a compliant society?

Q5. What qualities are necessary for elocution, and whom do you admire as a speaker?

Officer link: Debating teaches seeing both sides and persuading calmly, vital for gram sabhas, crisis communication and quasi-judicial fairness, while staying politically neutral.

Learning Languages: ten facts

1. CEFR grades proficiency A1–C2; tests include DELF, Goethe-Zertifikat, JLPT N5–N1, DELE, TOPIK, HSK.
2. Census 2011: 121 languages (22 scheduled, 99 non-scheduled) from over 19,500 mother-tongue returns.
3. People's Linguistic Survey (Ganesh Devy): about 780 living languages; roughly 220 lost in fifty years.
4. Eleven classical languages; Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bengali added in October 2024.
5. 92nd Amendment (2003) added Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali, taking the Eighth Schedule to 22.
6. Article 350A urges mother-tongue primary instruction; 350B creates the Commissioner for Linguistic Minorities.

7. NEP 2020: home language medium till Grade 5, preferably 8; flexible three-language formula.

8. Bhashini (MeitY, 2022) builds open AI translation; CIIL Mysuru runs SPPEL for endangered languages.

9. Maharashtra withdrew Hindi-from-Class-1 orders in June 2025 after protests.

10. Hyderabad study (2013): dementia onset about 4.5 years later in bilinguals.

Five likely questions

Q1. How many languages do you know, and can you speak, read and write them?

Q2. How feasible is it to teach multiple languages to children?

Q3. Mother tongue–English–Hindi or mother tongue–Hindi–English: which order should schools follow?

Q4. Is the three-language formula a unifying policy or an imposition?

Q5. With AI translation like Bhashini, why should anyone learn a new language?

Officer link: An administrator who speaks the local language hears grievances directly, reduces intermediaries and builds trust, especially in tribal and border districts.

Stamp & Coin Collecting: ten facts

1. Penny Black, world's first adhesive stamp, issued in Britain in 1840 under Rowland Hill's reform.

2. Scinde Dawk (1852, Karachi) was Asia's first stamp; first all-India stamps followed in 1854.

3. Independent India's first stamp, 'Jai Hind', issued 21 November 1947, showed the national flag.

4. National Philatelic Museum is at Dak Bhawan, Sansad Marg, New Delhi.

5. Punch-marked karshapana coins date to the 6th century BCE; Gupta dinars include Samudragupta's veena-player type.

6. Decimal coinage began 1 April 1957; ₹ symbol by D. Udaya Kumar adopted July 2010.

7. Coinage Act 2011: Government designs and mints coins; RBI distributes them and issues notes.

8. Antiquities Act 1972: coins over 100 years are antiquities; Treasure Trove Act 1878 requires reporting finds.

9. Post Office Act 2023 replaced the 1898 Act, effective June 2024; World Post Day is 9 October.

10. Crypto taxed at 30% plus 1% TDS; El Salvador made bitcoin acceptance voluntary in 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Tell me the history of philately. Where exactly is the philately museum in Delhi?

Q2. Which is your favourite coin in history, and what do coins teach you?

Q3. What about cryptocurrency and its regulation? Who issues coins in India?

Q4. Why does India not widely print currency notes above ₹100, unlike the US?

Q5. As DM, villagers find a pot of old coins while digging. What will you do?

Officer link: Collecting builds respect for provenance and heritage, guiding an administrator in handling treasure finds, curbing counterfeits and refusing valuable gifts.

Podcasts & Documentaries: ten facts

1. John Grierson coined 'documentary' (1926): 'creative treatment of actuality'; Nanook of the North (1922) an early

landmark.

2. Bill Nichols' six modes: poetic, expository, observational, participatory, reflexive, performative.

3. 'Podcast' (iPod plus broadcast) was coined in 2004.

4. The Elephant Whisperers (Kartiki Gonsalves) won the 2023 Oscar for Best Documentary Short.

5. All That Breathes (Shaunak Sen) won Cannes' L'Œil d'or (2022) and an Oscar nomination.

6. Films Division (1948) merged into NFDC in 2022.

7. Mann Ki Baat began on All India Radio in October 2014; 100th episode April 2023.

8. IT Rules 2021 Part III: Code of Ethics for OTT, three-tier grievance system under MIB.

9. Cinematograph Act amended 2023: anti-piracy penalties and UA 7+, 13+, 16+ ratings.

10. Prasar Bharati launched OTT platform WAVES (November 2024); WAVES summit held in Mumbai, May 2025.

Five likely questions

Q1. Which documentaries have you seen recently? Name a few with social underpinnings.

Q2. What kind of podcasts do you listen to, and which one did you last listen to?

Q3. Why do you prefer audiobooks or podcasts rather than reading?

Q4. What is the media's role in covering crime, and what are Supreme Court guidelines?

Q5. Can AI replace voice artistry, given rising AI-generated voices?

Officer link: Podcasts and documentaries teach an administrator to weigh sources, spot bias and use local-language audio for outreach and countering misinformation.

Gaming & Esports: ten facts

1. Skill versus chance turns on 'preponderance of skill'; Satyanarayana (1968) held rummy mainly a game of skill.

2. Varun Gumber (2017, Punjab & Haryana HC) held fantasy sports skill-based; SC dismissed the SLP.

3. PUBG Mobile blocked September 2020 among 118 apps under Section 69A; BGMI blocked 2022, restored 2023.

4. Esports debuted as a medal sport at Hangzhou Asian Games (held 2023).

5. Aichi-Nagoya 2026 had 11 esports events; India's 15-member contingent reportedly won no medal.

6. Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act 2025 bans online money games and promotes esports and social games.

7. Offering money games: up to 3 years' jail and/or ₹1 crore fine; advertising: 2 years and/or ₹50 lakh.

8. Online Gaming Rules 2026 in force 1 May 2026; created the Online Gaming Authority under MeitY.

9. Betting and gambling are Entry 34, State List; Supreme Court is hearing challenges to the 2025 Act.

10. WHO's ICD-11 recognises gaming disorder (code 6C51), effective 2022.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the difference between a game of skill and a game of chance? Is rummy skill?

Q2. What is the government's stance on online gaming? Is there an Act and authority?

Q3. How would you make parents aware about allowing their children to play games?

Q4. What yardstick should decide which online games are allowed and which are not?

Q5. Betting is a State subject. How could Parliament pass the Online Gaming Act?

Officer link: Gaming teaches strategy under pressure; an administrator must balance innovation and liberty against addiction, fraud and child protection.

Coding & Technology: ten facts

1. C++ compiles to machine code; Java compiles to bytecode on the JVM; Python is interpreted.
2. AI is the broad goal; machine learning learns from data; deep learning uses multi-layer neural networks.
3. Li-Fi transmits data through modulated light, hard to intercept beyond line of sight.
4. India Stack: Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, eSign and DEPA; F C Kohli is called father of Indian IT.
5. IT Act 2000: Sec 66 offences, 69A blocking, 79 safe harbour; Shreya Singhal struck down 66A.
6. DPDP Act 2023 set up a Data Protection Board; DPDP Rules notified November 2025, phased rollout.
7. IndiaAI Mission: ₹10,372 crore, approved March 2024; includes GPU compute and AIKosh datasets.
8. CERT-In requires cyber-incident reporting within 6 hours; National Quantum Mission launched 2023.
9. India hosted the AI Impact Summit, New Delhi, February 2026, first in the Global South.
10. 2026 IT Rules amendments mandate labelling of synthetic content and faster deepfake takedowns.

Five likely questions

Q1. After ChatGPT, will coding still be required?

Q2. What is the difference between Java and C++?

Q3. Why are cities like Pune and Bengaluru good at IT, and how would you spread it?

Q4. Bots are spamming online platforms; how can we counter them, and is it ethical?

Q5. Will India continue to lead the IT sector? Will AI take away IT jobs?

Officer link: Coding lets an administrator build dashboards and spot leakages, but technology must assist, not replace, human review for vulnerable citizens.

Travelling: ten facts

1. Carrying capacity is the maximum visitors a place can host without degradation; overtourism is its breach.
2. Kerala's Responsible Tourism Mission (2017) built on the Kumarakom model (2008).
3. Sarnath became India's 45th World Heritage Site in July 2026 at the Busan session.
4. Sarnath Lion Capital, with a 24-spoke Dharma Chakra, became the national emblem on 26 January 1950.
5. Maratha Military Landscapes (12 forts) became the 44th site in July 2025.
6. India has 37 cultural, 7 natural and 1 mixed (Khangchendzonga) World Heritage Sites.
7. 2025: foreign tourist arrivals fell 8.1% to 91.49 lakh; domestic visits rose 45.5% to 428.55 crore.
8. WEF Travel and Tourism Development Index 2026: India rose nine places to 31st.
9. Budget 2025-26: 50 top destinations developed in challenge mode; their hotels get infrastructure status.
10. Ancient Monuments Act 1958 sets 100 m prohibited and 200 m regulated zones.

Five likely questions

Q1. Where did you travel last, and what did you learn from that place?

Q2. Why are foreign tourist arrivals below potential, and how can we increase them?

Q3. Why are there protests against overtourism at popular sites?

Q4. How can Kerala's tourism success be emulated by other states?

Q5. What can J&K learn from Switzerland in tourism development?

Officer link: Travel builds the empathy for India's diversity that an All India Services officer needs when serving far from home among unfamiliar communities.

Cooking: ten facts

1. Dum pukht biryani layers par-cooked rice over marinated meat in a dough-sealed handi.
2. Pressure cooking raises water's boiling point to about 120 degrees C, saving fuel.
3. Rajasthan's ker-sangri uses desert berries and Khejri beans: a drought-adapted cuisine.
4. Darjeeling Tea was India's first GI (2004); India had 822 GIs after 125 added in 2025-26.
5. Deepavali became India's 16th UNESCO intangible heritage element in December 2025, at Red Fort.
6. FSSAI was set up under the Food Safety and Standards Act 2006; runs Eat Right India.
7. NFSA 2013 covers up to 75% rural and 50% urban population; PMGKAY feeds about 81 crore.
8. India led International Year of Millets 2023; millets rebranded 'Shree Anna'; IIMR Hyderabad is Centre of Excellence.
9. PM called for a 10% cut in cooking-oil use to fight obesity; FSSAI acted in May 2025.
10. Lancet projects over 440 million overweight or obese Indians by 2050.

Five likely questions

Q1. What are the different Indian cuisines? Describe one regional cuisine in detail.

Q2. What is the difference between normal and dum biryani, and why is dum special?

Q3. Should non-vegetarian food be banned, or the whole country made vegan? Can the government do this?

Q4. Why are millets not popular, and how will you popularise them?

Q5. As collector, a mid-day meal poisoning case is reported in your district. What will you do?

Officer link: A cooking officer understands mid-day meal kitchens, food safety and nutrition firsthand, while respecting citizens' diverse food choices in public institutions.

Gardening & Kitchen Gardening: ten facts

1. Macronutrients are N, P, K; most vegetables prefer soil pH of about 6 to 7.
2. Vermicompost uses earthworms like Eisenia fetida; castings are ready in about 45 to 60 days.
3. Systemic products move through plant tissue; systemic neonicotinoids harm pollinators.
4. Horticulture output was 3,707 lakh tonnes in 2024-25, exceeding foodgrains.
5. Sikkim became India's first fully organic state in 2016.
6. Average operational landholding is about 1.08 hectares; over 86% of holdings are small and marginal.
7. PPV&FR Act 2001 protects farmers' seed rights and bars terminator-seed varieties.
8. GI tags are granted by the GI Registry in Chennai under the GI Act 1999.

9. National Mission on Natural Farming (2024, Rs 2,481 crore) targets 1 crore farmers, 7.5 lakh hectares.

10. May 2025: India released world's first genome-edited rice, DRR Dhan 100 (Kamala) and Pusa DST Rice 1.

Five likely questions

Q1. What are you growing? Do you use fertilisers or go organic, and why?

Q2. How is vermicompost made, and what can be done with kitchen waste?

Q3. What is your view on GM crops and terminator seeds?

Q4. How can kitchen gardening tackle urban shortages of fruits and vegetables?

Q5. As collector, how would you convince Punjab farmers not to sow rice?

Officer link: Gardening teaches patience and soil-level understanding of agriculture, helping an officer scale nutri-gardens and composting while balancing farm incomes with sustainability.

Social Work & Teaching Kids: ten facts

1. NSS began 24 September 1969 (Gandhi centenary); motto 'Not Me But You'.

2. MY Bharat (Mera Yuva Bharat), launched 31 October 2023, is a youth-volunteering platform.

3. Kailash Satyarthi founded Bachpan Bachao Andolan (1980); shared the 2014 Nobel Peace Prize with Malala.

4. Savitribai and Jyotirao Phule opened a girls' school at Bhide Wada, Pune, in 1848.

5. Prakash Amte's Hemalkasa (Lok Biradari Prakalp) serves Madia Gond tribals with health and schooling.

6. Article 21A (86th Amendment, 2002) and RTE Act 2009 guarantee free education for ages 6–14.

7. RTE Section 12(1)(c) reserves 25% private-school seats for disadvantaged children.

8. NIPUN Bharat (2021) targets reading and basic maths for every child by end of Grade 3.

9. ASER 2024: 23.4% of Class 3 children in rural government schools read a Class 2 text (up from 16.3%).

10. UDISE+ 2024–25: teachers crossed one crore; secondary dropout fell to 8.2% from 10.9%.

Five likely questions

Q1. Whom do you teach, what do you teach, and what have you learnt from teaching children?

Q2. How did you make sure the children you taught did not drop out of school?

Q3. Name a Nobel laureate working for underprivileged children. What is his organisation called?

Q4. What are the issues in school education, and what steps would you take?

Q5. Your DAF says you taught slum children. As DM, how will you scale that?

Officer link: Teaching and social work give an officer ground-level empathy for the excluded and show how to build community ownership rather than dependency.

Astronomy & Stargazing: ten facts

1. Saptarishi is the Big Dipper in Ursa Major; its pointers lead to Dhruva (Polaris).

2. Vasishtha and Arundhati form the Mizar–Alcor pair; Bortle scale (1–9) grades sky darkness.

3. Schwarzschild radius, $2GM/c^2$, is the event horizon of a non-rotating black hole.

4. Aryabhatiya (499 CE) described a rotating Earth and explained eclipses.

5. Chandrasekhar limit (about 1.4 solar masses) won the 1983 Physics Nobel.

6. Jaipur's Jantar Mantar, built by Sawai Jai Singh II, became a UNESCO site in 2010.

7. Hanle (Ladakh, 2022) is India's first Dark Sky Reserve; Pench became first Dark Sky Park (2024).

8. Shubhanshu Shukla flew Axiom-4 in 2025, first Indian aboard the ISS; splashdown 15 July 2025.

9. SpaDeX docking in January 2025 made India the fourth nation to dock in orbit.

10. Interstellar comet 3I/ATLAS (July 2025) is the third known interstellar object.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is the event horizon of a black hole, and what is the Schwarzschild radius?

Q2. What hindrances affect visibility while stargazing, especially in cities like Delhi?

Q3. Have you seen the Saptarishi? Name the seven rishis and their importance.

Q4. What is the difference between astronomy and astrology? Does astrology have any scientific basis?

Q5. How does space commercialisation affect astronomical observation, and what can be done?

Officer link: Stargazing nurtures the scientific temper of Article 51A(h), equipping an officer to counter superstition and use space data for governance.

Bird Watching & Wildlife: ten facts

1. India records about 1,350 bird species; Central Asian Flyway brings winter migrants like Amur falcons.

2. Salim Ali, 'Birdman of India', wrote The Book of Indian Birds; 12 November is National Bird Day.

3. BNHS was founded in 1883; SACON is in Coimbatore.

4. Chilika and Keoladeo became India's first Ramsar sites in 1981.

5. India had 103 Ramsar sites by October 2026; Tamil Nadu leads with 20.

6. Pangti, Nagaland, turned from Amur falcon hunting to protection from 2012–13.

7. Wildlife (Protection) Amendment 2022 cut schedules to four and added CITES provisions.

8. Veterinary diclofenac banned 2006; ketoprofen and aceclofenac banned for animals in 2023.

9. SC (19 December 2025) set GIB priority areas: 14,013 sq km Rajasthan, 740 sq km Gujarat.

10. State of India's Birds 2023: 178 species of high conservation concern.

Five likely questions

Q1. What is citizen science, and how do platforms like eBird use birders' data?

Q2. Tell us about a famous bird sanctuary in your area.

Q3. What issues do invasive species cause? Which species drives human–wildlife conflict in Wayanad?

Q4. Why are vultures disappearing, and what has the government done?

Q5. Should renewable-energy transmission lines be stopped to save the Great Indian Bustard?

Officer link: Birds are indicator species, so a birder-officer reads ecological distress early and balances development, livelihoods and conservation on the ground.

NCC: ten facts

1. H.N. Kunzru Committee (1946) recommended a national cadet organisation.
2. NCC Act, 1948; raised 15 July 1948 under Ministry of Defence; Girls Division 1949.
3. Air Wing 1950, Naval Wing 1952; flag red, dark blue, light blue for Army, Navy, Air Force.
4. Motto 'Ekta aur Anushasan' (Unity and Discipline); NCC Day on the fourth Sunday of November.
5. Headed by a Director General (Lt Gen rank) in Delhi; 17 State Directorates.
6. 'C' certificate: hold 'B', third-year SD/SW, 75% attendance, two ATCs or ATC plus RDC/central camp.
7. Grades: A 80%+, B 65–79%, C 50–64%; pass needs 45% per paper, 50% overall.
8. 'C' holders: 64 IMA vacancies a year; 100 at OTA via NCC Special Entry, no written exam.
9. Senior Under Officer is the highest cadet rank; Republic Day Camp ends with Prime Minister's Rally.
10. 2020 expansion to 173 border and coastal districts; 2025 clearance of about 3 lakh more cadets.

Five likely questions

Q1. You hold an NCC 'C' certificate; why did you not join the Armed Forces?

Q2. What did you learn from NCC, and should NCC be made compulsory?

Q3. What is the criterion for getting the NCC 'C' certificate?

Q4. What are NCC's wings, when was it formed, and what is its motto?

Q5. Which values are important in NCC? Did you find anything wrong in NCC?

Officer link: NCC's discipline, chain of command and disaster duty prepare an officer to lead calmly under pressure while obeying only lawful orders.

NSS and Volunteering: ten facts

1. National Service Scheme launched 24 September 1969 by V.K.R.V. Rao in 37 universities.
2. Motto 'Not Me But You'; symbol is the Konark Sun Temple wheel; 24 September is NSS Day.
3. Run by Department of Youth Affairs, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports.
4. 240 hours over two years (120 a year) plus a seven-day residential special camp.
5. National NSS Awards presented by the President, usually on NSS Day.
6. MY Bharat (Mera Yuva Bharat) launched 31 October 2023; Nehru Yuva Kendra Sangathan founded 1972.
7. Bharat Scouts and Guides formed 7 November 1950; Baden-Powell founded world scouting in 1907.
8. NDMA's Aapda Mitra scaled to 350 disaster-prone districts; Civil Defence Act 1968.
9. UN proclaimed 2026 International Volunteer Year for Sustainable Development; Volunteer Day 5 December.
10. NGO Darpan with NITI Aayog; FCRA 2010 (amended 2020); CSR under Section 135, Companies Act 2013.

Five likely questions

Q1. What did you do in NSS, and did your work bring any real change?

Q2. For how many years and hours does one work under NSS? What is its motto?

Q3. Which disaster relief did you work in, and what exactly did you do?

Q4. What is the relevance of NSS today, and how would you promote it?

Q5. Name government programmes where NSS played a prominent role, including election youth mobilisation.

Officer link: Volunteering teaches an officer to mobilise citizens in floods and elections while strengthening institutions, protecting dignity and avoiding parallel systems.

Sports Achievements: ten facts

1. Sport is a State subject (Entry 33, List II); SAI set up in 1984.
2. Khelo India launched 2017–18; TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme) launched 2014.
3. Paris 2024: 6 medals (1 silver Neeraj Chopra, 5 bronze); Tokyo 2020: 7 medals.
4. Paris Paralympics: record 29 medals (7 gold); Hangzhou Asian Games 2023: record 107 medals (28 gold).
5. National Sports Governance Act 2025 (assent 18 August 2025): National Sports Board, Tribunal, Election Panel.
6. Federations need 15-member executives with at least two outstanding sportspersons and four women.
7. National Sports Policy 2025 (Khelo Bharat Niti), approved July 2025, replaces the 2001 policy.
8. Khel Ratna renamed Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna in 2021; 2024 awardees include Gukesh, Manu Bhaker.
9. Ahmedabad will host 2030 Commonwealth Games (awarded November 2025); India pursuing 2036 Olympics bid.
10. WADA 2024 data: India top for adverse findings, 260 from 7,113 samples (3.6%).

Five likely questions

Q1. Why does India, with 1.4 billion people, win so few Olympic medals, especially gold?

Q2. What did sports teach you, and how will you use it in administration?

Q3. As an out-of-form captain before a series, would you step down as captain or player?

Q4. As sports secretary, what would you do to improve medal counts across States?

Q5. What is your best timing in your event, and what is the Indian best?

Officer link: Sport trains an administrator in fair play, merit-based selection and owning defeat, the same accountability a district team expects from its leader.

Positions of Responsibility: ten facts

1. Lyngdoh Committee set up by SC in University of Kerala v Council of Principals of Colleges (2005).
2. Lyngdoh report (2006) ordered into force; chaired by ex-CEC J.M. Lyngdoh.
3. Age limits: UG 17–22, PG up to 24–25, research students up to 28.
4. Candidates need 75% attendance, no arrears, no criminal record; one chance to contest office-bearer posts.
5. Spending cap Rs 5,000 per candidate; audited accounts within two weeks; no party or outside funds.
6. UGC anti-ragging regulations 2009 followed the Raghavan Committee and the Aman Kachroo case.
7. UGC Redress of Grievances Regulations 2023: Grievance Redressal Committees and an Ombudsperson per university.
8. Article 19(1)(a) and (c) protect speech and association, subject to reasonable restrictions.
9. Burns: transformational vs transactional leadership; Greenleaf: servant leadership.
10. Team shares goal and accountability; a group may only share space or a task.

Five likely questions

Q1. Was the Lyngdoh Committee implemented when you were in the union? What challenges did you face?

Q2. Is student union only for personality development, or is there something negative too?

Q3. What was your role as Student Representative, and what ethical dilemmas did you face?

Q4. Is student politics right, what should be its limit, and what happened at JNU?

Q5. What learnings did you get as an event organiser?

Officer link: Campus leadership mirrors district administration: negotiating with protesters, transparent budgeting, resisting favouritism and pursuing demands only through lawful due process.

Awards and Competitions: ten facts

1. NTSE (NCERT, origins 1963, renamed 1977): Rs 1,250/month Classes 11–12, Rs 2,000 UG/PG; not held since 2021.
2. KVPY (DST, 1999, IISc Bengaluru) discontinued 2022, merged into INSPIRE-SHE.
3. INSPIRE (DST, 2008): SHE scholarship Rs 80,000 a year; INSPIRE-MANAK rewards school students' ideas.
4. PM's Scholarship Scheme (Kendriya Sainik Board): Rs 2,500/month boys, Rs 3,000 girls since 2019.
5. HBCSE-TIFR runs India's olympiad programme in maths, sciences, astronomy and junior science.
6. India at IMO since 1989; IMO 2024 in Bath: fourth place, four golds, best result.
7. Smart India Hackathon since 2017, run by Ministry of Education and AICTE.
8. Rashtriya Vigyan Puraskar (first given 2024) replaced the Shanti Swarup Bhatnagar Prize.
9. Fields Medal and Abel Prize compare to the Nobel; Indian-linked: SASTRA Ramanujan and Infosys Prize.
10. Sachin Tendulkar (2014) is the only sportsperson awarded the Bharat Ratna.

Five likely questions

Q1. As an NTSE scholar: which body gives it, how much, till when, and with what proofs?

Q2. What did you learn from MUN?

Q3. Tell me about the mathematics prize comparable to the Nobel. Is there an Indian one?

Q4. Why did you get this award, and what are the qualities it recognises?

Q5. NTSE and KVPY were discontinued. Was that a good decision?

Officer link: Awards matter in administration only when honestly claimed; officers must likewise ensure fair talent searches and timely scholarship disbursal to deserving students.

Sources

569 web sources were used, mainly: forumias.com (202), t.me (181), pwonlyias.com (16), newsonair.gov.in (13), en.wikipedia.org (12), thebridge.in (10), outlookindia.com (8), drishtiias.com (7), nextias.com (7), tribuneindia.com (7). Questions are paraphrased from candidate-shared transcripts; facts on current developments were checked in October 2026.

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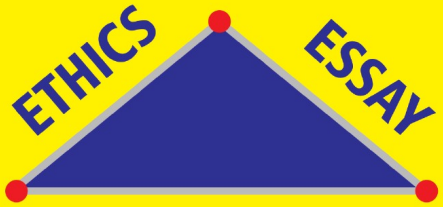
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Yashaswi Raj Vardhan (AIR 11): Secured highest rank for **Public Administration optional (291 marks, top score).** Enrolled in Public Admin Foundation 2023, Crash Course 2025, and Ethics Crash Course 2025. Achieved in second attempt through discipline and consistency.

Akansh Dhull (AIR 3): Scored 1057 total marks in fourth attempt. Courses: Ethics Test Series 2023, Case Studies 2023, Essay Mock Test 2023, IGP. Standout scores: **Ethics 134, Essay 119, Interview 193.** B.Com from SRCC (DU); from Chandigarh/Haryana; optional Commerce & Accountancy.

Rajeshwari Suve M (AIR 2): Enrolled in Ethics Test Series 2023 & 2025. From Vadipatti, Madurai (TN); B.E. Electrical & Electronics from Anna University; optional Sociology. Serving as Deputy Collector (Training) in TN govt post-TNPSC Group 1.

Ishan Bhatnagar (AIR 5): From Lucknow (UP), resides in Bhopal (MP); born 2001. Courses: GS Mains Test Series 2023, Essay & Ethics Test Series 2025. Son of Amitabh Bhatnagar (Good Governance Institute) and Prof. Vinita Bhatnagar.

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